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by ezmatron

Summary

The initial introductions over, Catra finds herself now betrothed to a mysterious warrior woman from across the seas: her promised soul-mate as ordained by her dreams.

Adora and Catra must now move to cement their alliance and, perhaps, bond more fully under the full moon, in accordance with Adora's people's cultures. But Catra also knows her own people need to be informed of these formidable new allies. And that will bring a whole host of new challenges in the sunken, subterranean court of the magicats - the hidden nation of vampires.

Notes

You asked for it, so I have begun part 2!

I will be providing a fade to black at some stage and provide the SPICY stuff in a separate standalone chapter ;))

So, yes, MOAR of these two blatant warrior women. We're gonna have a chance to see Catra show off more of her skills soon as well.

Preparations

Catra wasn't quite sure *what* to feel. Not horror, no; mirth? That came closer. Satisfaction? *Very* close. She felt a sense of shame, but then again she wasn't sure *why*. Perhaps it was the societal norm that she shouldn't take satisfaction in what appeared a brutal act?

The post battle clean-up hadn't taken too long - the corpses of the Horde had been piled into hastily dug pits, then burned by Glimmer's magic - fae fire ensured their remains could not be repurposed again. The villagers had returned to watch, slack jawed, as the Seafarers had easily hauled bodies in and tossed them atop the pyre.

Catra had marshalled her troops to secure the hiding villagers and to reassure them that all was well. With Pan in control of things, she'd returned to the village fringes to watch the disposal and found Adora with Kyle, Shadow Weaver's disembodied head clutched by the hair.

The blonde warrior turned, a grin on her face. Her troops had found some coverings for the woman, to Catra (And, it appeared, *Adora's)* disappointment. Her torso was now covered by a shift, while a loose set of britches preserved the rest of her modesty. The shift, however, was not exactly the warrior's size, which was to Catra's benefit, as it helped to show off the blonde werewolf's forearms and biceps *very* nicely. The britches also only came down to about mid calf. The warrior's greatsword was planted in the soil next to her, the remnants of Adora's armour draped over the crossguard.

"Ah, *sjelevenn* . All is to your satisfaction?"

That smirk made Catra want to slap the woman and also to leap into her arms.

It was disconcerting. Catra had *never* felt like this - this *off balance* ; this *happy* about being off balance.

"Well enough. Turns out your people are actually good at manual labour. Not just hauling sails and singing around a campfire."

"High praise indeed,"Adora chuckled, "So, I thought you might want to bear witness.we wanted to teach your ghoul an object lesson."

Catra arched an eyebrow, "Adora, your skald tore her *head* off. Not sure she can learn more."

Adora shrugged, "I'm feeling in a vengeful mood. She tried to *hurt* you,"the ice in the blonde' s voice made Catra shiver. In a very pleased way, which should have troubled her. She didnt *get* like this over her dalliances.

But after their conversation, she knew Adora wasn't going to be a *dalliance* . And that scared her a little - this was *it* .

She stared into the grey-blue eyes of the warrior and smirked right back at her, to hide her sudden flutter of nerves, "Alright, consider my interest piqued."

Adora's cold demeanour vanished into a grin. She hoisted Weaver's head up to eye level and tutted, "Watch. See how we dealt with Keldor. And will soon deal with your own Master."

Weaver's jaw worked and her voice came out as a wheezing, slurred, rasp, "Mon-grel. I will"…

Adora rolled her eyes, then plucked a scrap of cloth from Kyle's hand and stuffed it into the head's open mouth. She then turned her head as another pair of Seafarers carried a new body towards the firepit and Catra couldn't help but grin as she realised it was *Weaver's* corpse. She watched with that strange mix of shame and satisfaction as the body was tossed into the blue and pink-fringed flames.

Weaver squealed through her gag, unable to turn away as Adora held her up, making her watch. Catra's gaze flitted to the warrior . She expected something, some expression of glee, perhaps a savage snarl. But Adora's face was impassive. There was no pleasure there. In a small way, that pleased Catra - this wasn't an act she relished - it was a *lesson* .

Again, a flutter drifted through Catra's belly - Adora was doing this *because* Weaver had harmed her, or intended to do so. Ever since the campfire, the day prior, the blonde had stood ready to *end* anyone who said a cross word to her. It was smothering.

And wonderful.

It was an alien feeling. But one she wanted to get used to.

Her gaze tracked back to the smouldering body as it flared with greenish flame. The dark magics within writhed, trying to escape, but the fae-flame held it, burning the taint away. Weaver howled, then went slacked jawed, whimpering. Adora pulled the head back, keeping Weaver's gaze facing forwards. Her voice was low, level.

"I know. I know you intended to take my *sjelevenn* from this world. I know you wished her harm. Your kind wishes to consume the world, that is a given. You did so with *malice*. This I do not out of hate of you, but to show you the consequence of a life of darkness. Now and forever you will be beholden to others. This is a consequence of your decisions. We will let you exist," a small smile quirked at Adora's mouth, "You are *welcome*."

She turned the head and stared into Weaver's vacant eyes, the former witch now stunned into silence. Catra stared as Adora nodded slowly. The blonde handed Weaver's head to Kyle, who bagged it up. Catra exhaled, a sense of peace settling upon her. She'd kept Weaver alive and chained for many reasons, but mostly a

strange sense of *nostalgia* . The woman had been a tutor for years, a trusted member of their kingdom. And she was wise. But also dangerous.

Her mother had kept her around after that betrayal as a lesson and *responsibility* for Catra. A lesson that revenge and immediate actions werent always the best long term solution. Of course, there was always the *option* to remove her permanently. And that had been *another* lesson - how far do you risk things?

There was *always* a risk that Weaver could escape, or manipulate things to her advantage.

Catra sighed: Magicat politics were an ever moving, whimsical and capricious game. That was the problem when most of the court were near-immortal and nigh unkillable. Every choice felt like a win *and* lose proposition.

It was why she preferred to be out in the moonlight - somewhere her actions had impact, where she could *see* the results. Oh she was great at politicking and manoeuvring. None in the court dared challenge her, dared to chance their arm. A few had tried, thinking to curry favour or to put the *princess* in her place;but they'd found themselves arriving in their offices to find her sitting there, feet on whatever desk it was, a note in hand, information at her fingertips.

And that was perhaps why she found Adora refreshing. Yes the woman was subtle in her own way, but she was direct. A

sledgehammer to a complex lock. There was a problem: show the Magicats the value of the Seafarers. And Adora had solved it by simply chasing down the nearest threat and *utterly* brutalising it.

Oh and marrying Catra in the same battle.

That was a fact that both excited and confused Catra. It felt sudden but *right* .

And she knew her mother would likely be positively apoplectic about it.

She realised that Adora was watching her, a small frown on that beautiful face. Catra shook herself and glanced up at the sun, her body feeling the lethargic pull of its presence. Quite how she'd kept going she wasn't sure. She regarded Adora, "What?"

"You did not approve? Ah she is *yours* I should have asked, I apologise!" The blonde bit her lip and winced. It was endearing. Catra rolled her eyes.

"Your kill, your decision. I think you earned it, stopping her from… well, whatever she was going to do."

The smile that broke across the blonde's face was worth it as she squared her shoulders. Catra's tail swished as Adora placed both

hands behind her head and nodded, "Well.then you approve? And you are welcome."

Catra shrugged, "Theatrical and made the hag shut up. Yeah, it was good. So"…

She gazed at the blonde whose smile shifted back to an eyebrow-quirked grin, "Yes?"

"Next steps?"

Adora shrugged, "Well, I would like to perform the ceremony" she inhaled and looked to one side, then met Catra's gaze, "But.would you wish to"…

"Ma'am!" A shout from across the field interrupted the pair and Catra clenched her fist. She turned and forced a neutral expression onto her face as one of her soldiers jogged over. The man had a small messenger vial in his hand, "Massage from the Queen."

That caused Catra to arch an eyebrow and she held a hand out. The soldier passed the small tube over then glanced nervously up at Adora. Catra gave him a side glance and snorted, "What, don't trust the people who saved our village, soldier?"

"No, ma'am, princess um…just.. It's…it's from the *Queen* ."

"So you don't trust me," Adora smirked at the man, "It is understandable. We are scary," she leaned forwards and bared her teeth, "Maybe we come to steal your secrets? I am trying to steal your princess after all." she winked at Catra, then stepped back, "I will rally my people. I have a feeling we will be marching soon, no?"

Catra had to bite back her smile as the soldier blanched. Not many had gotten a good view of Adora in her… *other* form. But they'd all followed the trail of destruction and had a fair idea of just *how* formidable the Seafarers were. Catra regarded the magicat then dismissed him with a wave, "Go fetch Pan. I take it the raven is still here?"

"Uh, yes ma'am."

"Excellent. Feed it and be ready to dispatch."

The soldier saluted and dashed off, while Catra popped the cap on the tube and fished out a flimsy, thin piece of parchment. She read it and snorted, then rolled her eyes. It had a single word on it:

Report .

"Wow mom, to the point as ever," she whispered the words without malice, more wry amusement. She loved her mother, truly, but when it came to politics, she was nothing if not *direct* . And honestly, a

message needed to be succinct, in case a Horde archer took down a messenger.

She crumpled the note and shook her head, then strode to where Adora was conversing quietly with Teela. The blonde and the redhead nodded to one another, then clasped forearms, before Teela jogged away, yelling out in the Seafarer's native tongue. Adora turned to smile at Catra, "We are going?"

Catra narrowed her eyes, "You can read from that distance?"

Adora scoffed, "Tsch, no. Just a reasonable assumption. I assume you wish for me to meet your court before," Adora waved her hands in the air, as she sought the words, "Before. Well, we are bonded properly."

The magicat licked at one of her prominent fangs, then cocked a hip, "Properly, huh?"

Adora nodded stiffly, jaw suddenly tense, "Well, the full moon is it is only a few days away. For us to be bonded in the eyes of my people it must be done under the moon at its fullest."

"So, we're on a deadline, huh?" Catra smirked. Adora blinked and then rubbed the back of her head.

"Well, we could wait for another month, if...if you are still uncertain. And, well, I am in no way wishing to press-"

Catra stalked closer and grasped Adora's britches by the hem and tugged her closer. Her head came to just beneath Adora' s chin and she stared up into Adora's eyes. Eyes that had haunted her dreams for months.

"Adora. I stabbed you. And you think that makes me *marriage* material. I have no *clue* what all this is about but"...her eyes searched Adora's, still seeking any guile, any trickery there. A lifetime of being tutored by a resentful Weaver and juggling the demands of a court of vampires meant she always tried to see everyone's angle.

But all she saw there was *love* .

It was terrifying.

It was exhilarating.

It was inevitable.

Adora reached up and cupped Catra's face, "This is good. But...I believe it still would be good to meet with your court. To clarify to

them that you are committed to this action, to confirm our alliance?"

Catra snorted, "Our alliance huh?"

Adora shrugged, "Of course, you can admit to them you like me. I know most political unions in your lands are...not always so blessed, you know?"

"...what makes you think I like you?" Catra smirked, trying to maintain the cool facade. Adora's eyebrow raised once more and her easy smile spread across her face.

"You can admit it, you know?"

"Get over yourself, just because you can go all big and scary , psh."

Adora shrugged and rolled a shoulder, "Bigger you mean?"

"Does your head naturally stay that big or did you have to work at it?"

Adora stared at her then barked a laugh and shoved Catra. The magicat stumbled and growled as her tail fluffed. She leapt at Adora who caught her, but tumbled to the ground as she did so. They rolled

about until Catra was straddled on Adora, with the blonde's wrists in her grip. Adora smiled up at the magicat as Catra blinked in surprise. She glanced up to see half her soldiers staring in confusion. A few had their hands on swords, clearly worried the fight was *genuine* ?

"You wish me to yield?" Adora breathed. Catra stared back down, suddenly very uncertain. She swallowed and her nostrils flared as Adora flexed her chin up to reveal her neck. All while maintaining that cocky smile, blue eyes boring into Catra, "I am not so easy , princess."

Catra yelped as Adora rolled her then gasped as Adora's mouth locked onto her neck. She felt the pressure of teeth - not quite like a vampire bite - different but still primal. She couldn't help the whimper that escaped her throat. And then the pressure was gone. She blinked rapidly and looked up as Adora moved to prop herself above Catra. The blonde's eyes twinkled with mischief.

"Hey," breathed Catra, "I'll..."

Adora leaned down and placed a soft kiss against Catra's lips, a mere brush, before she pulled away, cheeks flushed, "We have time, Catra. But your lieutenant is staring and I would not wish to embarrass you in front of your soldiers," she winked and leaned back in, voice serious, "Or... share you. I am a little bit possessive. It is something I have learned about myself."

"Adora"...

“Hmm?” The blonde’s eyes kept tracing to Catra’s lips.

“Shut up.”

Adora actually let out a squeak as Catra pushed off the ground and planted a kiss of her own against the blonde’s mouth. She traced the tip of her tongue across Adora’s lips, then broke away with a gasp. Adora blinked and then chuckled softly. She exhaled slowly, eyes full of promise.

And then the blonde was upright, pushing into a squat, then hopping up. She leaned down and pulled Catra to her feet, the action yanking Catra until she was flush with the tall warrior. Part of Catra was irked at being manhandled like some common tavern wench.

Another part of her revelled in it.

And yet another part was planning on ways to return the favour.

With a throaty cough she pushed away from Adora, but the lashing of her tail betrayed her. SHe didnt miss the matching flush on Adora’s own cheeks, though. She turned and motioned to Pan, who she spotted waiting at the village edge. The magicat approached, a faintly amused expression on his face, “Your orders ma’am?”

"We've been requested to update her majesty . Send a raven back saying we are en route. Nothing more. Get the men ready , leave a contingent here to observe the village in case there is another incursion," she glanced at Adora, then back at Pan, "The Seafarers will be accompanying us. At least a contingent?"

Adora nodded, suddenly serious, "I, Kyle and Duncan, along with four others, will join you. Teela will remain with the boats, but I have asked her to ensure a battle-pair will remain here to assist you in case."

Pan bowed slightly, "As you command, ma'am. And thank you, Adora Moondaughter."

The blonde regarded the dark-furred magicat, "And you are well?"

He looked abashed, "My head is clear , now that damnable leash is off. I I am embarrassed she was able to subvert."

Catra huffed, "We weren't aware she could do that. The runes *should* be only one way. A lesson learned. Prepare the horses and we will leave within the hour."

Pan saluted and turned to carry out his Princess' orders. Catra blew a breath out her nose and glanced up at Adora, "So ready to meet

the parents?

Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

A walk in the woods and some quiet discussions.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The group left the village in the late afternoon, eager to make time during the night, when the burden of the sun wouldn't dull senses and leave the Magicat's more vulnerable. It was a strange menagerie that made up the caravan: Pan and his troop in the lead, to scout ahead, with Catra behind, Adora strolling alongside the Princess' horse, with Bow and Glimmer just behind them, walking in quiet conversation. The Seafarers followed behind them, acting as a sort of impromptu honour guard cum minstrel band, as the Skald, Kyle, sang jaunty tunes about their victory.

Behind that came the rest of the Magicat entourage, along with some of the Faerie troops. Glimmer and Bow had elected to journey part way, to a nearby henge, where they would make their way direct to Brightmoon.

This had piqued Adora's interest briefly, and Glimmer had explained the interconnectedness of the henges. Adora's response was both one of fascinated wonder and militaristic curiosity.

"So, these are choke points?"

Glimmer had frowned and shrugged, "They are nexus for magic but allow for low-cost, longer range teleportation. I can do that easily over short distances, a lot of Faeries can."

"Alright for some!" Bow had chuckled, with an amused look, "It's handy if she wants to avoid discussions."

That had gotten him a gentle elbow to the ribs. But Adora had pressed on, "We have similar in our lands. Fallen now, broken. Druids used them but the Horde captured them."

Glimmer had nodded sadly, "Aye, the ones to the North are lost to us. We had to sever the connections, lest the corruption infected the magical lay lines."

"So... they are targets? Are they not defended?" Adora had been alarmed, but Glimmer had just laughed.

"To corrupt a Henge you need a *lot* of undead and a whole load of Necromancers and a long ritual. The Henges are resistant to such things, but they are still just tools. And, well, we'd detect such corruption and would be able to react. If The Horde made it to one of these Henges, well, the power needed means that they'd have likely already conquered the surrounding land."

Adora had seemed placated, but had fallen into quiet contemplation as they all marched through the forest. Catra, who was composing another note as she rode, glanced down at her. fiancee? Mate?

The words still sent a thrill through her.

She noted the woman's expression and leaned down to flick a claw against the side of the Adora's head, "Hey , you still with us?"

The blonde blinked then glanced up at Catra with a well-practiced grin, "So desperate for my attention you resort to physical violence, hmm?"

Catra rolled her eyes, "That is *weak* . You'd know if I wanted your attention. Such a *dog* , preening."

That drew an actual *bark* of a laugh out of Adora, "And you are such a cat, pretending to be aloof when all you wish is a scritch between the ears," she winked at Catra, whose tail lashed with a mix of irritation and amusement, "But. I am pondering."

"Oh this should be good," mused Catra. She of fered a smile of her own, to show it was mere banter, not a barb, "So, talk."

"This land has many vulnerabilities. Many avenues for the Horde to assault via. Glimmer is confident of security, but"…

"But the Faerie haven't exactly been proactive. Or are they really *warriors*?" Catra supplied. She adjusted herself in the saddle and peered up at the setting sun. She sighed happily, "Yeah…it's been mostly a stalemate. Our alliance has held them back and cutting off those stone circles bought the members time."

Adora nodded, "So Halfmoon does not make use of the ley lines?" she probed. Catra glanced at her, then shrugged.

"No need. Our abilities are internal. Not many magi among us who do the whole showy magic. We use runes, we bind, we use more ritual stuff," she glanced down at the short missive in her hand, then rolled it up and slid it into a message tube. With a whistle she summoned one of her guards and handed him the note, "For a raven. Now."

"Yes'm," the soldier reached up, plucked the tube, then dashed back down the column towards the baggage train and the raven cages. Adora watched him go, then looked back at Catra.

"As we thought, innate magic, but different from the Fey folk."

"You got *that* right," snorted Catra, "Can you imagine me coughing up *glittery sparks*, eugh."

Adora chuckled, "Hardly . It would not fit your aura."

"Now you sound like the dryads," scoffed the Magicat, "You produce some magic crystal as a wedding present, this whole thing is *off* ."

Adora grinned at her, "I would not dream of risking *this* before we have a chance to swap stories in more detail." the tall woman waggled her eyebrows at Catra. It should have been stupid, or goofy. But the Magicat swallowed and coughed.

It was probably just the way Adora's voice had dropped into a husky growl as she spoke. Caught her off guard, that was it.

In an effort to regain some control, Catra coughed, "So, yeah we don't use the magic around us. Not anymore. Apparently we *used* to - we were more druidic, apparently. But"…

"The curse, yes?"

"Yep," Catra popped the p of the word. She glanced back at Glimmer, who offered a wave before she returned to her conversation with Bow. They were walking, having eschewed the offer of a ride on one of the carts. Idly, Catra wondered what they were discussing. Cute, married couple things, no doubt. Or affairs of court. Or both.

"I am looking forward to seeing your home," mused Adora. Her voice drew Catra's attention back and she watched as Adora continued, "A city beneath the earth. Such a thing must be wondrous. We mine and dig, but we have not built an entire citadel beneath a mountain."

"What *is* your home like?" Catra asked, "I mean, you're here, we're supposedly" she gestured between them and shrugged. Adora chuckled.

"Bonded? Betrothed?"

"Yeah, that," Catra huffed and glanced away, mildly frustrated at her sudden feeling of fluster. Court assassins and intrigue she could handle; necromancers were fine. Flirting with *meaning*?

That was difficult.

Adora seemed happy to breeze past it, "Our lands are mostly mountain and steppe, with vast fields of orange grass and red wheat. In the winter months the snow is so deep you can dig down and not find the soil. Silence fills the land. Much of it was reduced to grey desert by the Horde, but we are rebuilding. Our homes many live a life close to the earth, in tune with the ebb and flow of the rivers and winds. But our cities, grand places of glass and stone, where the halls of the Moon and the Star watchers dwell."

The look on Adora's face was that of quiet nostalgia, with a hint of longing. Catra felt a momentary pang of uncertainty? She coughed, "So, you seem eager to return, then?"

Adora glanced at her. Her smile was soft, not cocky, "And why would I want that? I have seen all that, I remember it. I may visit. But I hope to have company if I do."

They shared another glance and Catra found herself smiling back at the buff blonde, "Well in the interest of diplomatic relations, it'd be good to experience those things."

"Indeed," Adora's smile became smug once more, "And it would be my duty and *pleasure* to ensure such an envoy experienced all the best things my people have to offer. Personally." Catra stared at the woman, at a loss for words. Adora's expression shifted minutely and she winced a bit, "That is, should said envoy w-"

"Said envoy is incredibly keen," Catra rushed out before she coughed again and turned in the saddle to stare straight ahead.

Adora's expression shifted to gleeful amusement, "Ahhh. Good! You do like me"…

"I did not say that!" Catra hummed, but she shrugged with a smile, "I just said I was *keen*."

"Mhhm. So…tell me, what should we expect in your city?" Adora asked, shifting the subject.

Catra sighed, "Honestly…questions. Most notably , why did you rip *her* head off," she patted the sack that was hung from her saddle. A muffled curse came from within, "And then…well, I imagine my mother will want to know *details* about our arrangement."

"That was the missive you sent?" Adora asked. Catra nodded.

"A brief update that we are returning. With guests."

"W ell I look forward to meeting the woman who…" Adora paused as she saw Catra's mouth twist a little. She mused, "Influenced your… ah upbringing."

Catra glanced at Adora and chuckled, "Oh she influenced. Mostly for the good. But she is not as friendly as I am."

"Y ou're *friendly* ?" came Glimmer 's voice from behind them, "Since *when* ?"

"Unless you want me to boot you through your henge portal, consider your words *carefully* , Sparkles," Catra called back. She just got a melodramatic huff in response.

"I did have another question," Adora asked. Catra nodded.

"Something about our city , our culture, our way of life?"

"Oh no, we have some understanding if it." Adora saw Catra's eyebrow raise, "We are *explorers* . And explorers who travel without some form of reconnaissance are dead explorers."

"Fair. Ask away ," huf fed Catra.

"Oh, no. It's not about the city. Glimmer mentioned. your people fought *giants* ?"

Catra blinked, "Uhhh"…

"And, second question. can I fight one?"

The column paused at Catra's raucous belly laugh, with one of her guards riding up to ensure she was ok. She was trying not to fall out of her saddle, while Adora sheepishly held her in place by her hips, at an awkward angle. After a few moments, Catra sat up and wiped her eyes after gasping out an: "Oh gods you were *serious* ,"

Adora huffed, "Dont see what is so funny , I just wish to." which set Catra off to cackling again. After a moment, she leaned down to put a hand on Adora's shoulder.

"I have *no* idea why..but that was adorable. Never change, mkay?"

A few hours later and night had fallen fully. The impact was noticeable, with the Magicats parking up and becoming more alert. Their movement was less forced, more fluid and they seemed less cautious. Pan had the scouts out ahead to double check the route. Adora likewise had her people prowling the flanks, albeit it seemed more a token gesture - these were Magicat lands, after all and, supposedly, safe.

Or rather, *safer* than the border regions with the Horde lands.

The disposition changed as the group reached the forests proper. The woodlands they moved through were thick, with heavy ferns underfoot if they went off the road. The branches hung low overhead and the air was silent. The Magicats grumbled and were forced to dismount while the Faeries fluttered up to drift among the trees. Except Bow. Bow was left standing on the ground as he shook a fist at his wife in mock frustration.

Adora and her ilk on the other hand, seemed ecstatic. While Pan and his men struggled to chart a path, Adora volunteered Duncan to scout.

Catra's second pursed his lips, "You dont know this land. I wouldnt want you to fall afoul of our other patrols."

Duncan chuckled, his bristly moustache wrinkling as he smiled, "Fear not, lad. They wont even know Im there. Mlady?" He turned to Adora with a questioning glance. She pursed her lips, then grinned and nodded.

"Run free, my friend."

The caravan had stopped while they discussed the scouting concern and now all watched as Duncan stripped away his armour. After a few moments he had his woollen hauberk and chainmail off and folded, with his boots and swordbelt laid atop them. His broad helm he handed to Kyle, "Be a good lad and dont scuf f these, aye?"

The Skald snorted, "Try not to pick up too many ticks!"

Duncan, naked, laughed and clapped Kyle on the shoulder. He turned and hunched forward. Then *continued* to hunch as his whole body changed.

The Seafarers seemed completely unselfconscious. Catra had expected them to maybe hide, or look for somewhere private. She'd expected…what? Cracking joints? Howls of pain?

But no, Duncan just moved between two shapes. One moment man, then a sense of motion, then…

Wolf.

But not what Catra had been expecting. Duncan was now a wolf, yes. But a Wolf that stood shoulder to shoulder with *Grimmer*. Grey fur covered its body and muscles rippled underneath.

Duncan looked different from how Adora had transformed - there was nothing *human* here, just a large beast. Save the eyes, of course - those glittered with intelligence.

Duncan gave a low rumbling growl, which Adora responded to. And then off Duncan bounded, his sleek, muscular form vanishing amidst the ferns and brush. Catra watched him go and exhaled. She looked at Adora, "And you can *all* do that, huh?"

Adora nodded and smiled, "Yes. To one extreme or another, with practice. Much like a muscle, failure to stretch it leaves a person… less able."

Bow, who had been standing nearby while his wife buzzed about the branches above;she had yelled down she was trying to get a better vantage to identify the henge. Catra believed it was actually because she was bored walking. Bow,meanwhile, just whistled, "So.you mean some of your kind cant do *that* ?

That got a laugh from Adora, "Many just.partially transform. Think.a human with strength and hairy hands," her smirk was cocksure, "And others are gifted enough to achieve what Duncan could do."

"But you.?" Catra led with a smirk of her own, "Miss oh-so-amazing warrior?"

Adora tapped the back of Catra's leg, where she still sat atop her horse, "Hush you. Dont make me drag you down of f there."

"Promises promises. I dont hear a *denial* though."

The blonde cocked her head to one side and shrugged, "Our most practised warriors can adopt the form I take - the beserker rage."

"But you can turn into a dog too?" chuckled Catra. Adora rolled her eyes and looked at the Magicat.

"No bats for you? Jealous, hmmm?"

"Eugh, no. If I could shapeshift, why would I choose a *bat* ? Seriously, those things share a cavern with them for a few hundred years, see how much you like 'em." scoffed the princess. Adora laughed and shook her head, then turned back to the road.

"We should press on. Duncan will follow up with us and your scouts can check shorter distances. As you say, you wish to make headway."

Catra did. And yet she also *didn't* . Because getting back to Halfmoon meant a *discussion* and, most likely, an argument. And weirdly she didn't want that. A day or so ago, the idea of some arranged marriage would have made her spit nails. But now? Now she was amenable.

Of course it didn't hurt that Adora was at great pains to say it wasn't *compulsory* . That she had a choice. And, honestly, even with her pampered upbringing (Relatively speaking) choice was something of a rigged game a lot of the time.

The group continued through the night, until they reached a clearing as dawn's first rays broke through the branches. Visible through a break in the trees was the peak of a vast mountain, jagged and split. Adora whistled low as the party filed into the clearing and began to setup a temporary camp, "Home?"

"Yeah, that's the Halfmoon peak. All busted up where the Faerie dropped *something* on it."

"What did they drop?" Adora quized.

"Another mountain," Catra shrugged, smiled, then swung off the back of her horse. Adora sputtered for a moment, then sighed.

"Magic. So unpredictable."

"Oh, no, we predicted they'd do it. Which was why my ancestors warded the mountain. Blew up the *other* mountain, just as it hit. Took two generations before any trees would grow around her," she delivered this in a lazy drawl, while focused on tying her horse to a low hanging branch. Adora watched her then scoffed.

"That is madness. You jest?"

,

"Nope, why would I? Go ask Sparkles. It was a *bad* time."

The warrior woman sighed and leaned against the tree Catra was busy securing her horse to, "I would like to hear your learnings of it."

Catra stared at the bark, then at Adora, "Oh? It's dull as hell."

"History is not dull. It is vital to teaching us our mistakes," Adora riposted.

"It's dusty and dull and all about which King tried to murder which brother," groused Catra.

"You are immortal, you live history, you will learn. Others need to understand the mistakes of their forebears...and their successes," Adora shrugged, "It was our hubris in such things that led to the Horde in our lands, after all."

That caught Catra's attention, "Oh? You're, um...not immortal?" the Magicat chided herself for the faint note of worry in her voice.

Adora saw the deflection, but went with it, "No one has tested our… lifespan. But my magic...well, it is a strong, even for my people. How long I will live? That depends on you, hmmm, shield wife?"

"Hey, calm down. We aren't married *yet*," Catra huffed. Adora leaned forwards and grinned.

"Soon enough. But it...feels right," she actually blushed for a moment, before coughing and shrugging, "We are bonded that way at least. A cherished memory."

"What, of breaking a death-knight and tossing a load of corpses around?"

"Yes. And our betrothal," Adora's smile widened, but she stepped back, "Let me help with the tent."

"We're just here one evening, no tents," Catra responded. She turned to the wider group and raised her voice, to reiterate the command: "Pan, remind the men - no tents tonight, campfires and bedding only. Need to make good time next evening."

After an affirmative from her second, Catra and Adora carefully removed the saddle from Catra's horse. The blonde warriors eemed adept with the fittings, which prompted a question from the Magicat. Adora had arched an eyebrow, "Do we have horses?"

"Yeah, I mean...you know what to do with the straps."

Adora laughed, "We have them...but mostly for hauling carts or as pets. We have little need to *ride* as you can likely tell from what we are. But...we have no real need. That said, I do like them...a graceful beast."

It was interesting, watching the barbarian woman caress and brush at Catra's horse. It was endearing.

They were interrupted by a shout from one of the posted Sentries and turned to see Duncan bound into the clearing. Adora dashed forwards and crouched in front of the huge wolf. The beast spat something onto the ground, then shifted. Catra noticed the stains around the beast's maw even as Duncan shifted. Her eyes tracked to the thing he'd dropped - a severed arm.

The old man sat back on his haunches, unperturbed by his nakedness. He grinned up at Adora, who flopped the discarded limb about curiously, "T rouble, old one?"

"A ye..well...not quite. Ranged out a fair way and thought it best to check yonder standing stones. Found some of the undead there.."

Glimmer gasped as she approached, her hand to her mouth, "What!? They were...corrupting it?"

Duncan frowned and shook his head, "N...no, mostly they were just..standing there. Only five, all told, along with a robed bugger . He went down easy. N...no, they were just scouts. But they seemed… lost," he looked up at Adora and grinned, "Think maybe our little punch up had an impact?"

Adora studied the arm a little bit longer, then tossed it away, "Mayhap. Killing that Commander may have disrupted their connection. Or they were waiting"…

The old soldier nodded, then beckoned to Kyle, "Give a man some clothes, Ill catch my death!" he chuckled.

Catra approached and furrowed her brow, "Still, that' s a *long* way from the front. Incursions against villages, now we have deep scouts? T roubling. Mother will want to know."

"Should we press on?" Adora asked, eyebrow raised. That fact she'd *asked* and hadnt demanded was reassuring. It reinforced that this woman wouldnt browbeat or challenge for the sake of it - it was a discussion. Catra shook her head.

"No, we need to spend a few hours recuperating. A day of fighting in the sun, followed by a march, well need the rest."

Adora nodded, then turned to her folks, "W e take watch while the others rest." The Sefarers chorused their assent back and Adora turn to face Catra again, her smile soft, "Let' s get you ready then."

A few scant moments later and Catra's bedding was ready - little more than an unfurled, padded sheet, along with a makeshift canopy fashioned from a cloak. Not entirely necessary , but it helped keep the suns rays off of the Magicat. The other soldiers had done similar, hunkering in the shade where they could doze.

Duncan was speaking quietly to Glimmer and Bow, reassuring them, while Adora moved about with purpose, ensuring the camp was secure. Catra felt a sense of peace, of reassurance. She allowed herself to relax, safe beneath her canopy, surrounded by soldiers

and, surprisingly for her, her.what was it Adora had said? *Self-inny yell in?* She chuckled to herself and then exhaled, as the lethargy began to creep up her skin - the weight of the sun pressing down upon her.

As she drifted off, she saw Adora watching her, sword planted in the dirt, gaze soft and a small smile on her chiseled face.

Catra exhaled and closed her eyes, content.

What felt like moments later, her eyes snapped open. Her day-dreams flittered away, a mess of strange and intense visuals, mingled with alluring smells and a coppery taste she wanted *more* of. With a hiss, Catra leaned out from under her shelter and checked the sky - the sun was still high, indicating she'd slept for only the morning most likely. And yet she felt buoyant, excited.

Around the camp, most of the other Magicats slept, whilst the Faerie stood watch. They'd left most of the non-vampiric Magicats back at the village, figuring a more mixed band of soldiers could handle whatever the Horde decided to try next.

Catra huffed and dragged herself out from the shelter, then stood on shaky legs. Her nose sniffed the air and she caught a faint whiff of something *familiar* . She felt awake and yet tired as well.

She spotted Bow who was quietly whittling away at a branch. The man glanced up and smiled as she approached, "Your highness, still a bit early. What ails you?"

"Nothing. Just anxious to be home/ Where's our tall and mysterious woman?"

"You mean your *fiancee*?" Bow grinned. Catra scoffed and waved a hand.

"That remains to be seen. And depends on my *mother*."

Bow just shrugged, "We haven't known each other that long Catra, but something tells me that, well, you wouldn't let a little thing like that stop you if you really wanted something."

Catra just chuckled and glanced about. Her nose twitched again as that scent tickled it one more. She made an idle goodbye to Bow, who just waved her away and continued with his woodwork. She checked Pan, but he was out like a light, so she paused by one of the Faerie guards who pointed out of the camp and gave a shrug. With a nod, Catra returned to her bedroll.

She bent down and buckled her sword belt on, then checked her armour, before heading out into the brush. She wasn't sure *why* or *what for*, but she wanted to find Adora. The scent was her, that was definite - but she wasn't in the camp. She stalked into the ferns and

found a small trail: clearly where Adora had pushed through the undergrowth.

After a few minutes, Catra broke through to a sight she had *not* expected.

Ahead of her was a small pool, with a small, maybe only twenty feet tall, waterfall next to it. A small stream led out of the pond and vanished into the thick undergrowth.

But Catra's attention was drawn to the figure *in* the pool.

Adora was naked, waist deep in the water. Her armour, clothes and weapon lay on a rock near the water's edge. Catra watched as the tall blonde scooped a handful of water and doused her face with it,then went back for more, only to pour it over her head.

Catra was entranced, eyes picking up the trail of water as it cascaded down Adora's toned back. She felt rooted to the spot, unable to turn away but also weirdly mortified she'd intruded.

In the pool Adora paused and half turned, a grin on her face, "So, are you going to join me, or have you caught your own tongue, hmm?"

The Magicat swallowed as Adora turned fully, completely unashamed. She managed a quick, "I uh…didn't know where you were and with the undead this far south I…"

Adora rolled her eyes, "Are you pining me or?"

Catra swallowed and stared at the water, "I'm not…great with… uh…water…"

The blonde glanced down, then back up. She nodded slowly, then began to wade towards shore, before stepping out and towards Catra. The Magicat squeaked as Adora was revealed. She'd seen it all before, post transformation. But that felt much more controlled - a fact of battle.

Here? Here it meant something else.

Adora paused at Catra's expression, her own face switching from smug anticipation to cautious approach, "Ah, was this…I believed you wished for more, hence your seeking me out?"

Catra forced her gaze up. She was mostly embarrassed at how *attracted* she was to this beautiful woman. She'd had plenty of admirers, maybe even a dalliance here or there. But *no one* had caught her attention as much as this woman. She swallowed.

"I uh.well, just"…

Adora cocked her head and folded her arms, which did *things* that made Catra very enamoured. Her cool eyes shone with a mixture of caution and mirth, "I am flattered you find me so.alluring that your brain ceases to work.but I fear this is not equal."

Catra coughed rolled her shoulders, asserting her entire *princess* attitude back to the fore, "You want me, the heiress to the throne of Halfmoon.to strip?"

Adora bit her lip, cocked her head and then nodded, "It would be a start."

"What happened to waiting?"

That made Adora shrug, "And I will, should you need it. But".Adora glanced to one side then back at Catra, then heaved a sigh, "I am naturally impatient. And.I.crave you."

That sent a jolt through Catra' s whole form. She swallowed thickly and licked her lips. The motion dragged Adora's eyes down for a moment, before those grey-blue eyes fixed right back on Catra's own eyes. The Magicat shook her head and heaved a sigh, "I can smell you. Even from.far away ."

Adora nodded, "The bond is forming, slowly . As I said, we are sword-wed, at the least. Always able to find one another. Unless you force the bond broken. I will always be able to find you. And you, I."

That was a revelation. Catra blinked, "I thought it was just a symbol?"

Adora shook her head, "You have drunk my blood. Then you proposed."

Catra bristled a little, "If I'd known taking your blood would… would." Adora frowned at that.

"By itself, that would have done nothing. You must drink from others." there was a strange tension as Adora said that. As if she were jealous?

"Are.. .are you *envious* of my food?" Catra smirked, suddenly back in control. Adora huffed and adjusted her stance. Catra fought to keep her gaze at eye level. Frankly , she felt she deserved a *medal* .

"I.it is more intimate than I expected, alright?" Adora gave a shrug, "And it felt special. To me. That is where the bond comes from. Feelings;intent;desire. If you did not want *me* it would not have worked."

Catra chuckled, "You want me to drink from you, right?"

"Did you. I. am explaining the *bond* Catra!"

"Yeah, yeah, mystical connection based on emotions or something. All I'm *really* hearing is that you want me. to bite you."

Adora's eyes narrowed and her arms dropped to her sides, "Mayhap. But. I. am no wilting farm girl eager for your faint desire."

"Awww, why struggle? Makes it harder ," Catra laughed.

"But it makes the blood. sweeter , no?" Adora' s eyebrow arched, "And we both know you would not be happy with some waif."

"Oh I dunno, something appealing about someone just wanting to give it all up."

Adora snorted, "Then go find your milkmaid," she waved Catra of f and turned away.. As she did so, she tilted her head, revealing the expanse of pale flesh that was her neck. The action made the Magicat blink in surprise. It triggered something, The fact it was daytime, the smell of Adora, the sudden exposure of a vulnerable *back*

Catra lunged forwards, propelled by a desire to *grab* Adora and tell her what she thought. It wasn't just a jump to grab the arm" move, though. No. Catra launched herself, a hunter looking to fix her prey: arms outstretched, claws out.

Adora spun and caught Catra's wrists mid flight. She continued to move, spinning the Magicat until she had Catra pinned against a tree, face an inch away from the Magicat's. Adora smiled, "Nice try ."

"You knew?"

"I guessed you might try . I mean, I'm barely holding back. Why do you think I needed to bathe?" Adora leaned in and nuzzled along Catra's jaw , taking a deep breath, "Just walking next to you"…

This close, Catra could hear Adora's heart - powerful, rhythmic, steady. She groaned at the smell of the woman, "Adora," she whined, entirely uncaring of her tone.

"Yes, *sjelevenn?* "

Catra swallowed, and managed to make eye contact, "What… about the the ceremony? The bonding?"

"Do you wish to wait for your mother 's view?" Adora was breathing heavily, naked form flexing with each breath. Her skin was flushed as

she swallowed, "The bond is reinforced if..if we..um" she looked Catra up and down, "do *this* at the moon. But" and now her smile was wicked, "Practicing can't hurt."

Catra stared at her. She wanted this woman. Needed her. Those eyes, her smell, her whole demeanour. She knew, she just *knew*, this was it. This was *her*. The eyes from her dreams, the person who was just *hers*.

Damn the consequences. She'd handle those later.

Catra took a breath, flicked her eyes down to Adora's lips, then hooked her legs around the woman's waist. She took advantage of Adora's momentary surprise and yanked her hands free from Adora's grip to then wrap them around the woman's neck. She stared into Adora's eyes, breathing heavily, "I'm going to bite you. And you're gonna let me. But you're gonna do so much more to *me*."

Adora stared into her eyes and grinned, "I can work with that."

Chapter End Notes

PHEW - sorry for the delay folks - this one took some editing and my brain has been a bit of a fog this week - wanted this up 2 days ago! If you spot any errors or flow issues, please do flag!

AWAY, as you can see, we're a bit spicier. And the chapter was a tad longer than I expected. I COULD have split it, but there's no easy break point. Other than Catra sleeping, buuuut eh.

OK! NOW! Do you guys W AN spice? Or fade to black!

AND! Addendum to that - do you want the spice in a standalone chapter I can keep separate so you can pick / choose to read it? Happy to keep this just "Mature" and then have the sexy stuf f off to one side.

Chapter 3

Chapter Summary

A romantic and sensual interlude

Chapter Notes

THE SPICE IS UPON US. Be warned:

Blood play (minor)
Roughish sex
They're pretty much switches.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra felt lost in those icy-blue eyes. Her dreams reared up in the back of her mind, assailing her with sense memories from years of nights where she'd jolted awake, tasting the breath of an unfamiliar *other* . She was not *inexperienced* - a Princess can command a lot of discrete attention when she is bored, after all. And, given her particular *leanings* , the risk of some illegitimate heir was nonexistent. She was expecting a sudden, worshipful sucking on her neck, or a deferential drop-to-knees initiation.

She did not expect a kiss that felt like her soul was both aflame *and* being sucked from her being. It was insistent, but gentle, Adora's tongue tracing across her lips. And whilst it lasted for what seemed like hours, it was over far too soon. Adora leaned back and bared her throat, "I am yours, Catra. But you are mine. You will want no other."

That smug tone drew Catra in -a challenge. And, while in her gut she could acknowledge the *possibility* , she also wanted to ensure Adora knew that *no one else* would be good enough for her, either - that Catra would be *it* and that Catra was the one in control.

She lunged, still wrapped around the naked blonde. Her fangs extended, her eyes dilated to slits: she sank her teeth into Adora's neck. She heard a gasp, followed by a sensual moan;or rather she *felt* the moan through her mouth.

Adora's blood pooled into Catra's mouth: thick, salty, and addictive. It forced a cascade of sense memories behind Catra's tightly shut eyes: scampering through the fields;a stick duel with a lady' s maid when Catra was a but a wee slip of a girl;riding her horse through the woods during a storm. Exhilaration, fondness, *safety* . The blood was *strong* and she felt herself groaning at the taste.

Fingers corded through Catra's hair and she felt herself being held in place. She *felt* Adora's voice more than heard it, a low guttural purr, "Drink, my love. T ake from me."

Catra bucked at that and ground her crotch against Adora's firm abdominal muscles, suddenly desperate for purchase. The blonde's chuckle reverberated into Catra's suckling mouth and the Magicat growled. She felt Adora's grip tighten and suddenly her feast was removed. Icy blue eyes regarded her with fondness and list. Catra panted and licked at her stained fangs, feeling the warm drip of blood from her lips. Adora's eyes flicked down and suddenly she pulled Catra in for a searing kiss. Blood mingled with saliva as their tongues twined and battled, the pair lost in one another.

The grip on Catra's hair vanished, to be replaced by both of Adora's hands firmly gripping her bottom. Adora broke the kiss, panting slightly. Her voice was a low growl as she spoke, "Y ou are still clothed. Unacceptable."

"What're you gonna do about it?" goaded Catra. She felt Adora' s grip tighten on the seat of her britches. And then she heard a tearing sound as Adora yanked the material apart. Before she could say another word she felt the bark of the tree against the back of her shift and then Adora hoisted her up. The ease and speed shocked Catra and her head tilted down. Adora's flushed face gaze up at her from between Catra's thighs, the tatters of her britches dangling from her

waist and down her legs. Adora's face was smeared with blood, but the wound at her throat seemed to have healed entirely. The blonde met her gaze with lust filled eyes and grinned.

"Do you want the wolf or the woman?"

Catra swallowed, suddenly very *very* out of her depth. But her response was automatic, "Both. Both is…is good."

Adora's smile was open and genuine as she planted a soft kiss against Catra's inner thigh, "Then both you shall have *sjelevenn.* "

The response Catra was about to fire back morphed into a whimper as Adora gently bit and nipped at Catra's furred skin. A purr rumbled from within the Princess' throat and her head fell back against the bark of the tree as she felt Adora's tongue dance across her thigh. Her core was exposed to the air and she felt the ghost of Adora's breath. It made her hips twitch and drew a chuckle from the muscular woman beneath her.

"T ease."

"Always," Adora hummed back. She kissed eithe r side of Catra' s centre, then paused to draw a deep breath, "MM…and I havent eaten today"…

Catra lolled her head forwards and snorted, "Seriously , that's"…but *again* Adora interrupted her as she laid the flat of her tongue against Catra's wetness and dragged up, flicking Catra's clit as she did so. The Magicat thudded back against the tree, one hand above her, claws sunken into the wood. Her other hand snaked into Adora's hair and gripped, "Dont…st…st"…

Coherent thought became a little fuzzy at that point. Adora held Catra up with one hand and pushed the other up, under Catra's shirt, to knead at the petite woman's chest. She massaged and tweaked at Catra's breasts, pulling gently at her nipples to pebble them to hardness. Catra's breathing was ragged and little mewls escaped as

Adora licked and suckled at Catra's lower lips. She drew them in, then released the with a pop.

It was a sensory overload, not *quite* enough to get Catra all the way, but continuous and rigorous to keep her coasting *just* at the right point. Catra bucked her hips, desperate for that little more, but Adora tongued expertly around her pussy without touching Catra's now-throbbing clit. Adora chuckled, the vibrations making Catra twitch again, before she did another broad tongue and then, suddenly, clamped her lips around the Magicat's clit. She sucked and flicked her tongue across it, then released it to continue flicking the tip of her tongue across the sensitive bundle of nerves.

Catra shredded the bark above her and bent forwards, practically curling around Adora's head. She yowled and bucked in Adora's grip, hands tightly wound into the blonde's hair. She pressed her crotch into Adora's eager mouth, desperate for more purchase until it became too much and she tried to pull away. Adora held her in place for long enough for another wave to crash through Catra's body, sucking hard on Catra's clit and drinking down her release, until the Magicat's whimpers became ragged gasps.

Adora gently lowered the limp woman down. Catra managed to focus her hetero-chromatic gaze on the blonde as she was cradled in Adora's grasp, "I said..I..was gonna bite you..then"…

The taller woman quirked an eyebrow and leaned in to silence the protesting Princess. Catra tasted herself and opened her mouth to tangle her tongue with Adora's once more. Her purr grew stronger as she sighed into the kiss. Adora pulled away and smirked, "It was only proper I show you all the skills I possess. And I look forward to your..demonstration. But first, you wished for the wolf.."

Before Catra could speak, Adora flipped her over in her grasp and pushed her back against the tree. Catra instinctively reached out to grab at it as she lost her balance for a moment. She shivered as warm breath brushed past her ear, which twitched in response. Adora's large hands gripped her shoulders then slowly trailed down

Catra's sides. Fingertips traced featherlike touches across her as Adora growled in approval. The Magicat sighed happily and arched her back instinctively, then looked over her shoulder with a faint glare. She made to push away from the tree, but one of Adora's hands gripped her hip and held her in place. The other reached up and traced Catra's jaw gently.

Catra shuddered and tried to maintain her glare, "I want to"…

"You will have a moment, love," Adora's voice was husky with lust, but her eyes were soft, her smile gentle, "Let me love you first. Please?"

The entreaty made Catra huff; coupled with Adora's insistent grip and the fact she knew that it was more a polite *command*, she felt conflicted. She was the Princess of the Magicats! A powerful Warrior! Not some…some…maiden on her knees for…

And yet…and *yet*…it felt good to surrender control for a moment; to let go and allow this warrior to just play her like an instrument.

She relaxed and Adora leaned forwards, pressing her naked form against Catra's back, "Good girl. I am sure you will make me dance to your tune. We are battle bonded, love-linked. I…the ritual will cement it but Catra…" Adora's forehead rested between Catra's shoulder blades, before she planted a kiss there. Catra's tail whipped from side to side, excitedly, "I am yours. I cannot be otherwise. Let me make you mine."

Adora's voice seemed to deepen. The arm at Catra's hip slid back over the curve of her rear, to dip down between her things from behind. Adora's fingers spread and played over Catra's entrance, massaging and squeezing. Catra slumped forwards with a groan, but found Adora's other arm holding her up. As she did, Adora pushed first one finger, then two into the needy woman. Catra's purr ratcheted up a notch and she gurgled happily before biting gently into her own arm to muffle the groan of pleasure that threatened to tear out.

And then she felt her feet lift from the grassy floor. Adora's arms shifted and seemed to grow, the muscle cording. Fur grew out, not as dense as before, but clearly there. Catra felt the sensation of fullness increase as Adoras fingers became larger and her pussy was stretched further. Her legs spasmed and kicked as she blindly sought for purchase, her body reveling in the helplessness of it, whilst also comforted by the support of Adora's arm. Her hands raked at her bark and her head lolled for side to side as Adora pistoned her fingers slowly and firmly in and out, her now-larger thumb playing across Catra's clit in small circular motions.

"Whawhat are youughh, doingdoing to me?" Catra manage to grunt out.

Adoras breath was now hot against her ear, her voice ragged and deep, more a growl, "Ruining you."

Catra turned her head, her eyes focusing slowly on the blonde as she spoke. Adora Had shifted partway. She was not as wolf like as her full form, but there was a definite hint of *beast* there - golden fur stretched across her body, almost like a Magicat. Her face had a more muzzle-like shape, her teeth now sharper . Her long hair now looked more like a mane and her muscles were more pronounced. She looked like a forest goddess come to life.

Catra start and felt a lazy grin stretch across her face. She pushed back against the fingers inside her and arched her back, bending herself to lean back. She wasnt flexible enough to go all the way , but her intent was clear. Adora leaned in as Catra twisted her torso, her hands now gripping Adora's forearm. Their mouths met in another searing kiss. Adora still tasted the same, but her tongue felt larger, more insistent. Catra pulled away, eyes hazy and happy , "Fuck… me"…

"As you wish."

Adora's fingers picked up speed as she pulled Catra back against her chest. She held her there, withdrawing for a moment to

reposition her hand. Catra grunted and mewled at the loss, face flushed at how needy she felt. Her tail coiled around Adora's bicep and she sighed happil as the wolf-woman cupped her mons and reinserted her fingers once more. Adora set to it with a punishing and regular pace, palm slapping wetly against Catra's core. Her other hand mauled at the Magicat's chest, while her mouth suckled at Catra's neck.

The Magicat bucked reached up and back to hand on to Adora's neck as she rode Adora's fingers. Her legs kicked and spasmed as she let out a shriek of pleasure, her pussy tightening around Adora's thick fingers. A sudden pressure at her shoulder made Catra's eyes fly open, as Adora latched on and bit down, just hard enough to hold her in place. It sent a jolt of pleasure right down Catra' s spine and the forest floor was splashed by a sudden excess of her excitement.

Catra yelped again as she suddenly found herself being hauled up and turned. She found herself upside down, a frankly amazing view of Adora's thick legs before her, along the heady scent of Adora's arousal. She swung forwards and wrapped her arounds around Adora's thighs and pulled herself in. She was not quite conscious of her actions, her mind still a little drunk on her release. That state of mind was suddenly compounded as she felt Adora's now-shifted tongue delving into her core.Catra groaned and shuddered, but managed a breath of her own and adjusted herself. She saw Adora' s own pussy, lips engorged with arousal, clitoris peeking out from its hood, right in front of her. She smelled divine.

Catra's tongue darted out and she laid her own assault on the warrior-woman. She gripped Adora's ass and set to, sucking and licking, and was rewarded as Adora's stance buckled for a moment. The blonde's tongue seemed to stutter and pause, followed by a whimper from above. A grin spread across Catra's face, gratified to hear that she wasnt the only person who was going to be putty at the end of this.

But Adora had the current advantage. Her tongue licked and then probed once more. Catra gasped and lost her focus. Her legs shot

straight up and her toes curled. Her claws came out and sank into the meat of Adora's body, but the warrior didn't flinch. If anything she increased her ministrations. Catra shuddered and spasmed, once, twice, three times, then went limp with a keening gurgle.

A moment later, Adora withdrew her tongue and laid a gentle kiss on Catra's clit, then lowered her to the grassy forest floor. She adjusted herself and settled down next to the smaller woman, head propped up on her fist, elbow on the ground. She start lovingly down at the Magicat, who blinked up at her. Catra giggled and shook her head, "Ruin me.. Huh? Think..think maybe you got close."

Adora chuckled and leaned down to press a kiss against her lover's lips, "Think of it as incentive. So that you wish to complete the ceremony."

"Hell of a pitch," Catra sighed, drawing in another haggard breath, before she shot Adora another mock glare. Her hand darted up and she gripped the back of Adora's head and hauled her down for another searing kiss, "But you *interrupted me*. And I am royalty. We don't appreciate being overruled."

Adora arched an eyebrow, "I must have missed that lesson on court etiquette."

Catra smirked right back, "Royalty *always* eats first."

The blonde nodded, then reached down to tear the remainder of Catra's tattered clothing away. The Magicat gasped, but smiled. Adora surveyed her and then met her gaze, "One must be properly attired for dinner. Even if you did have a *bite* earlier."

With that, she moved over and swung her leg over until she had straddled Catra's chest. The Magicat noted that the scratch marks she'd left on the warrior had already healed. Adora noticed her gaze and shrugged, then seemed to blush a little. Catra's smile broadened, "You liked that?"

"I would not object to...more," Adora coughed. But she rallied again, "But now , my Princess needs her meal." She shuffled up and Catra was greeted with a fantastic view, from Adora's well maintained blonde bush which framed her clearly-aroused sex;all the way up the planes of her rigid stomach and abdomen;to the hefty breasts that hung above her.

Catra could hear the blood in Adora's veins and swallowed thickly. The blonde watched her for a moment, then smiled and reached down to cup Catra's face. The Magicat kissed at Adora's thumb, which the blonde pressed softly against her mouth. It slipped past Catra's lips and the woman sucked on it for a moment. Adora withdrew it, then turn Catra's head slight until she was looking at Adora's thigh, "Drink, *Selevenn* ."

She could see the pulsing vein beneath the surface of Adora's pale skin. Her breathing quickened as she leaned her head forwards and laid several kisses against Adora's warm flesh. She licked at the patch of skin, tasting the salt of Adora's sweat and the traces of where her arousal had dripped down her inner thigh. Then, with a growl, she sunk her fangs into the vein and drank.

Above her Adora shuddered and moaned. She groped at her breasts with one hand and bit at the other to stifle her whimpers of pleasure. She twitched and rocked, then sighed as she felt the Vampire's grip around her waist, holding her in place, despite her superior size.

Catra drank, revelling in the heady taste of Adora's blood. She took more in, somehow stronger than the taste at her neck. She knew then, once more, that she would never find anything as satisfying. That this was it. Part of her mind still *railed* at the idea, at destiny and the forcing of threads. But a warmer, softer part felt it was right. This was *hers*, all hers.

As she drank she felt Adora suddenly go completely rigid, then she felt a gush of warmth across her chest. Catra unlatched and groaned happily, then stared up at Adora's flushed features. The blonde was

breathing heavily, still groping at her chest, "Someone made a mess."

"You are a messy eater," Adora tried. Her gaze was unfocused, "That that was a fifirst." Her eyes locked with Catra and the blonde swallowed, hard, "I need more"…

Her voice was firm, yet pleading. Catra chuckle, "Where? Use your words, Adora"…

"Your mouth on me. Please"…

"So *needy*. I thought you were a raider queen, assertive and commanding?"

"For you I will be as you need. But" Adora's eyes became steely and one hand dropped down to grip Catra's head, "Fuck me. Make. Me. Yours."

Catra's hips bucked up at that involuntarily. She scooted down until Adora's core lay before her. She licked her lips, sucking down the last remnants of blood, idly noting that Adora's puncture wounds had healed over again, then pulled the blonde down onto her waiting mouth. She rolled her tongue, undulating it against Adora, then slid two, then three fingers into the woman, She curled them over to stroke at her inner walls and was rewarded with a near-howl from the blonde. Adora had to fight to not shove herself down harder, conscious of her larger frame. Especially now, half transformed.

The pair rocked and writhed as Catra pulled another climax from the blonde, followed by a smaller one as she sucked Adora's clit between her lips. With a final howling groan, the blonde toppled to one side, shuddering with ecstasy. Her eyes met with Catra's and a dopey grin stretched across her face, "I think I will be keeping you."

Catra laughed and crawled across the grass to slump across Adora's chest. She adjusted herself to kiss and suck on one of Adora's

generous breasts, which drew another shudder from the blonde, whose eyes rolled back into her head. Adora held her breath, then let out a long sigh. Catra smiled, "Another one?"

"You are good. Please, let me write to your teachers to let me thank them. And to warm them you are now off limits."

Catra cackled again at that and shook her head, "Jealous?"

Adora shrugged, "No. Only if they return. Then i may be... sorting my feelings out through direct means."

"Ah, a punch your emotions out girl, huh?" The Magicat let out a breathless laugh and snuggled closer, "I think you win on *all* counts. That... wow..." She frowned, then sat up a little to study Adora, "...huh you changed back?"

Adora shrugged, "For now . I will be whatever you want me to be, *Catra.*"

The pair settled into a comfortable silence and Catra snuggled in close, they lay back on the grass and stared up into the day. Catra sighed with contentment, then draped herself across the warrior, face buried in the crook of Adora's neck. She thought that Adora might be asleep, or doing, from her regular breaths and Catra chuckled, letting the day-sleep creep upon her.

She felt Adora's arm coil around her and hold her close, "Rest, love. I will watch over us," came her whispered words.

And Catra, much to her surprise, realised she believed her.

Chapter End Notes

AS YOU COMMANDED - The spice, it flowed.

I hope everyone enjoyed that! Normal politics and fighting will resume in the next chapter, with SOME EMOTIONAL CONVERSATIONS!

Chapter 4

Chapter Summary

A confession and realisation from our Vampire heroine.

Adora shows herself.

Home sweet home

Chapter Notes

Hey everyone - thank you for your patience! I can only plead family and my current return to work (Which has, of course, wrecked my sleep pattern and daily free time!)

So, an update to keep you all sated for a while!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The hooting of an owl roused Catra from her slumber. She was slow to wake, slower than she'd ever really been. Not lethargic: rather, it was more of a content and slow awakening. It was a new experience for her. Life in the court taught you to be aware and alert as soon as you arose; to be ready to face the threat of a knife or a silver dart; or a hemlock needle. Less so from your *allies*, more so from *interlopers*. That fear of the outside, the risk of *infiltration* and *betrayal* that anchored many of the Halfmoon nobility. That fear of being undermined or compromised.

Ironic, of course, considering that Shadow Weaver had so expertly gotten so far towards ending the heir. Or was it? After all, Catra's mother had treated it as an object lesson - if Weaver had succeeded, then Catra would not have been deemed too vulnerable, staff would have been pruned, Weaver would have been liquidated and a more

resilient heir would have eventually been produced or identified from another noble house.

Not to say Catra had been defenceless, far from it. But it was, in a way, a test of the paranoia that ran throughout their society - that preparation, that cutting blade, honed from the time of the Faerie war to the Horde incursions. Survival, uncompromising dedication, ruthless direction.

So to awake in such a relaxed state was oddly alien;Catra had only felt this way a few times, normally when she had slept in the same bed as her parents (They were politically astute, not *cold* .) after a night terror. That sense of absolute safety was so strange to her nowadays.

It was the slow sensation of fingers that trailed up and down her spine;the rhythmic rise and fall of a warm breast;the gust of breath atop the crown of her head;the strong arm that held her secure.

"Hey ," came the soft, accented voice from above her . Catra couldn't help the contented purr that rumbled from her chest. She decided to *not* deny this feeling and partially uncurled from the near-ball that she'd wrapped herself into atop Adora, before she turned her head up to stare into those oceanic eyes. She adjusted herself so that she was draped across Adora's bare torso and allowed herself a grin. The blonde watched her, a soft smile on her handsome face. Those blue eyes searched her, suddenly vulnerable, unsure. Catra reached up and pressed a finger against the other woman's forehead.

"You look like you've got some kind of cog jamming up in there," she murmured, her lips twitching as she suppressed a chuckle, "So?"

"Just." Adora glanced away, bashful all of a sudden, then returned to gaze at Catra, "You are more beautiful than... Than my dreams ever allowed."

It was Catra's turn to duck her head away, "Shut up."

Adora's fingers brushed against her chin and tilted her face back up, "I will not," her bashful smile became smug, "For you are. A glorious creation, a wonder, beautiful beyond the sea foam and the shores of my home, beyond the stars"...

Catra huffed and shoved Adora's face away, which drew a shrill laugh from the larger woman, "You have successfully ruined the mood. Sea foam? SERIOUSLY?"

Adora laughed again and grappled the cat woman, rolling her onto her back. Catra fought, but not *really*. Her tail lashed and she struggled, before she glared up at the woman. Adora's blonde hair fell around their faces, shrouding them from the world. Adora's smug smile had gone back to one of reverence and Catra couldn't help the lump in her throat as she gazed up at the woman. The blonde's breathing was slow as she took in the vampire. Then she closed her eyes and let out a breath, before she spoke again, "Be mine. Say you will?"

Catra gazed up at the fearless warrior and knew , knew with certainty, knew with her soul, more than she had known during their coupling that afternoon, that she was well and truly *gone* , "Forever ,"she breathed out, not even pausing.

The blonde's smile could have lit the world for a day and then they were kissing. It began feverishly, but settled into a slow, relaxed exploration, hands tangled in one another's hair. They broke apart to gaze at one another . A distant twig snap made them freeze, but Adora relaxed and chuckled, "Y our man, Pan, he is trying to be noisy."

Catra rolled her eyes and groaned, "It is *night* . I guess he wants to move us. We arent far now . Another full night's march and we should be there by sun up."

The blonde nodded, then sprang to her feet, before she bent down to tug Catra up, "W ell, we best be on our way, so we may inform your family!T o have them there for the ceremony?"

That made Catra pause. She frowned to herself, then shrugged, "Y eah. Shell have to handle it. It is an important part of our *international relations* after all."

"W ell, quite,"Adora grinned and rooted around for their clothes. She held up Catra's *ravaged* attire sheepishly, "Um.ah?"

Catra just snorted and shook her head, then glanced up at the trees, "Thanks, *dummy*."

"What?" Adora shrugged but looked proud, "You didn't say anything at the time.

"Pf, I was *distracted* by a single minded idiot."

"Wow, so easily overwhelmed by an opponent. Perhaps you are not such a great…"

Catra was suddenly in Adora's personal space, finger under the blonde's nose, "Say it. Go on. Try."

Adora grinned and raised an eyebrow, before she leaned forwards to nip at Catra's finger. The vampire hissed, but didn't pull back. She glowered, then, with a smirk, snatched Adora's clothes out of the warrior's hands. With a cackle she leapt back and scrambled into the treetops, leaving the blonde behind. Adora, for her part, let out an affronted yelp. Catra heard the woman begin to run, yelling endearing threats about how Catra was about to become a new shawl and the like.

The vampire leapt from branch to branch, easily, the bundle of simple clothes clutched tight to her chest. The smell of Adora filled her lungs and it was, perhaps, the most relaxing thing she'd ever

experienced, even as she dashed, excited and carefree, through the treetops.

She heard Pan's shocked yell below as the naked form of Adora barged past him, and she allowed herself a snicker, before she reached the temporary camp they'd established. She easily skirted the sentries and dropped down near her tent, which she slipped into with barely a flutter of the cloth flap. Moments later, she had a simple shift and spare britches on. She emerged, smug with the flush of victory, but froze, shocked, as she regarded Adora, flushed and gloriously, beautifully naked, in the centre of the camp.

The guards were clearly *utterly baffled* . The sentry nearest the pools looked like he was having a hard time finding his jaw , his eyes were locked on Adora's very well defined rear.

For her part, the blonde just stood there, hands on hips, eyebrow arched, an expectant expression on her face. Catra cleared her throat.

"Uhm.yes?"

"My clothes."

"Your clothes? Psh, never seen 'em."

"Catra," Adora's voice carried a growl with it. It was not threatening. It did *other* things. It was a shock to Catra how quickly she was now susceptible to the sound. She coughed and her tail lashed behind her.

"I deny everything."

"Hmmm.." Adora stepped forwards and a few of the guards made a half hearted attempt at moving in front of her. They froze at Catra's disgusted snort and regarded her as she waved them back.

"Please do not try to stab my." Catra swallowed, but allowed the word to flutter from her mouth, "*Betrothed*."

The soldiers blinked in surprise. Now, of course, many had heard the *request*, but to hear their Princess acknowledge it as a reality, a certainty was *big*.

The moment was disrupted as Kyle rounded one of the tents. He made a noise that sounded like a groan, "Adora. Please, for the sake of all of us, put some clothes on. You're making the kitty-cats jealous," he tossed a bundled up shirt to the blonde, who caught it without taking her eyes off of Catra. Adora had the dopeyest smile on her face as she hauled the item on, which only flared up more as she looked at Kyle.

"She said she will! My *Sylevenn!*"

Kyle turned to regard Catra. It was a *complicated* expression - he looked pleased, but also seemed curious, "Well then, to know with certainty. This is a *good* thing!" He nodded then moved to pat Adora's arms. His scrawny frame looked so frail next to her, but Catra knew the man was deadly. He paused and approached Catra, "My lady , if you will permit, we will make preparations. Adora has mentioned you wish for your family to be informed before? We will need to conduct the ceremony beneath a Moon at its zenith."

Catra looked at the Skald and nodded slowly, "That wont be an issue."

"No. But a delay will happy . If..if the bond has begun to form it is merely solidified by the ritual. But after the ritual, it is a deep thing, hard to shatter. Only death is a true release from it," he leaned forwards, "Adora has told you this, I know . But you may think it some heart struck maiden pining," Catra raised an eyebrow at Adora being referred to as some *maiden* , but Kyle pressed on, "To bind and not..not wish it so, to tie another to you without true care. It is pain beyond knowing, my lady. Just to consider ," Catra bristled and, somehow, didnt rake her claws across his face. Kyle watched her , then grinned, "Amazing! All settled then. I believe we are breaking camp? That's fun."

With a grunt, the Skald jogged back towards where the Seafarers had their little set of tents and fires, calling out to them to prepare. Catra looked to Adora, who was now studying her, a satisfied expression on her face, "Did he call me a maiden?"

"He did."

"Pf. He knows better . But he is not.wrong," Adora shrugged, then glanced at Catra's tent, "So, my clothes?"

"Lost cause. T otally ruined. You can come look if you like," her lips turned up in a coy grin. Nearby , Pan was marshalling more troops. He caught the tail end of her comment and coughed discretely.

"Ma'am um.we can be ready to go in.an hour? But we will ned, um.fifteen minutes to dismantle your tent?"

"Huh. Forty five minutes?" Catra stared at Adora, "After all. W e need to inspect the emissary's attire before the journey ."

Adora nodded, "Oh yes. Inum.great detail."

Pan rolled his eyes, but smiled as the giggling pair withdrew. She shook his head and returned to his tasks, a spring in his step - it was good to see the Princess smile *properly* .

It was actually a *little* over an hour that the company began to move again. The pair had emerged from the tend to sarcastic applause from the troops, which was cut off by both a glare from Catra and agut-churning *growl* from Adora. But the grins and murmured congratulations from the soldiers salved Catra's embarrassment. She hadnt realised how endearing it was to see her people *happy* for her. There was certainly something to unpack there.

The Faerie contingent split away from them to head towards a secluded clearing, where their magical circle was located. Adora looked interested, but just sent one of her people to observe instead. Glimmer had paused by Catra to wish her *good luck* with her Mother and actually *hugged* her, by fluttering up alongside Catra's horse and latching onto her. Much to her own surprise, Catra had actually returned the gesture with a tentative back pat. She had nearly snorted at Glimmer's whisper, *She is just so .. FAR!*

"Dont let your human hear that," groused Catra as she flushed. Glimmer chuckled.

"I am allowed to look. Plus, hands down, he wins. Still. Allowed to be envious of other attributes! Dont know if I want to be her or climb her."

"GLIMMER!" Catra's eyes bugged out at the Faerie princesses sudden honesty, "You seriously?"

Not entirely . Worth it to watch you squirm though," Glimmer floated back and then sighed, "Good luck, Catra. I hope this is the start of a better time for all of us."

Catra regarded her counterpart and sighed, "Weirdly enough, yeah, me too."

They'd waved the Faerie off and continued on their way. It was a few hours later as the first light of dawn was snaking its way through the tree line, that they emerged into a cleared expanse. The mountain, which had been visible through the forest canopy, now loomed ahead. A well worn path lead across the grassland, between fields and scattered homesteads, towards a huge, carved edifice. It looked like the stonework morphed, halfway up, into turrets and bastions, almost camouflage against the rock. The gates, if they *were* gates, looked more like part of the mountain itself. Just glanced at, the place looked like a shattered, half buried castle, with no clear entry. It was only as you *looked* at it, you noticed how the ramparts ran between outcroppings; how the towers were sculpted from the rock; how the massive archway was *just* about visible.

"Rather blatant," hummed Adora, "For a hidden city ."

"Well we can't *hide* exactly. An entrance is an entrance and we *do* need to interact with the wider world," Catra drawled back. She swayed in the saddle as her horse tossed its head, clearly eager to be home. She gestured at the mountain, a spikey, shattered thing, "There's ways in and out, all guarded. This is just the more *obvious* one. We spent a Century or so being very *very* subtle. But it's hard to govern your surface lands if people begin to think you're myths."

Adora snorted, "Your tax collectors getting told to go away because you were mythical?" Catra glanced at her and shrugged. The blonde blinked then tilted her head back to laugh, "Oh that is wonderful. I know of many at home who *wish* they could turn away the tithemasters. A necessary evil at times. So you made a clear front door"…

"Yeah. and *less* clear defences. You spend all that time staring at what you think is the gate." Catra smirked as their little band moved off away from the 'gate' and instead towards what looked like a small ravine in the side of the mountain. As they approached, Adora observed that the main gate did have traffic, but it seemed to be mostly people with small wagons or on foot. Their larger collection surely could have fit in there? But she also noted that the "stone gates" remained closed, with the people, small specks at this distance, seeming to enter a stone building built into the cliff face's base.

They moved nearer to the ravine, a cut in the side of the mountain, a dent. It looked to be a dead end after a few dozen yards. But the cut was wide, wide enough for wagons and soldiers to march ten abreast.

It was only as they entered the ravine that Adora spotted the cunningly concealed culverts and splits in the rock that could only be archer slits. And ahead, what she believed to be rock was actually a screen of netted vines and metal links. This "curtain" drew back to reveal an actual gate, much more clearly defined. The massive stone doors rumbled aside, accompanied by the rattle of great chains, to reveal a torchlit tunnel beyond.

A squad of Magicat guards emerged and began checking the wagons, while their captain exchanged a quiet word with Pan. The guard Captain furrowed his furry brow at the Seafarers and his nose twitched. Adora just offered a friendly wave, her arms folded over her belted clothes, the fur cloak across her shoulders giving her an even more intimidating appearance.

After a few minutes, they were allowed to enter and the company advanced into the dark. Their route sloped down and seemed to twist several times, until they crossed a narrow bridge across a dark chasm. Adora peered over the edge and nodded, "Good defence plan."

"Yeah. And you probably can't spot the *other* adjacent tunnels we have. We've survived a *long* time here."

The other side of the bridge was another rock face with *more* fortifications, a castle within a castle as it were. Anyone trying to cross the stone bridge would be peppered by arrows or worse from this side, where the fortifications stretched away into the dark. The cavern wasn't hugely wide, but Adora felt the drop was not exactly *short* . They moved through a courtyard of the bastion, but kept going, down a further tunnel. It became less militant here, the corridors that stretched away smaller and with small touches of a more pleasant environment - tapestries, the signs of pottery and stalls setup along the tunnel indicating currently-empty market stalls. More side tunnels led to small rooms that they didn't even stop to look out - guard posts;small dwellings or side *villages* it appeared, judging by the distant noises within. Adora marched alongside Catra's horse, eyeing the neatly carved walls and pillars of the corridor, "Amazing."

"Oh you have seen *nothing* yet," chuckled Catra, "This is the upper quarters. Traders, locals who work the surface fields but don't live *on* the surface. Some of those tunnels lead to whole caves of housing. We're a rather close knit people."

Adora hummed in acknowledgement and watched as a squad of troops tramped past them, all in sync. The torches around them burned with green edged flames and cast a surprising amount of light about them After a while, with them avoiding a few forks and more side tunnels, the tunnel opened up ahead. They emerged from the narrow space into a twilight of sparkling motes of light and Adora's jaw dropped.

The cavern before them was *vast* . Its ceiling was decorated with glowing gems and flickering lanterns that hung from innumerable chains - their size must have been *massive*

The group all stood on a cliff edge, with a vast city arrayed below - low, blocky buildings, with open-topped roofs; ziggurats and towers dotted the space, with a series of canals and streets weaving between them. The sounds of hustle and bustle arose from below. . It was clearly a good mile or so across, the whole place. Great stalactites hung down, with, Adora noted, bridges between them and lights across their surfaces: windows!

And at its centre, a ziggurat rose up, its tip connected to a huge stalactite that hung down, carved into a thin, inverted pyramid. Green and orange flames burned from dozens of fires along the main stairs that led up its exterior, with more from torches on the hanging rock. Adora let out a low, impressed whistle.

Next to her, Catra drew in a breath, part contented, part nervous, before she looked at the blonde next to her, "Welcome to Halfmoon."

Chapter End Notes

I had another plan for this but... Halfmoon felt too good a point to leave this at, for now!It's a little short but I didn't want this one to drag as I know I have kept you all waiting!

Trust me, more will be revealed as we meet MOM.

Chapter 5

Chapter Summary

A little exploration of the city.

A grand palace!

And a surprise.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Their group approached an ornate structure that jutted out from the cliff-edge. It was like an arched bell-tower, except that only the "belfry" was visible from the cliftop. A set of guards saluted as they approached and ushered them into the open space. It was large enough to accommodate all of them and Adora found herself gazing about with wonder, impressed.

"And what is th-" she was cut short as the floor lurched and then began to descend. Catra laughed at Adora's briefly shocked expression.

"Oh wow, you should see your face. So, this is an *elevator*. Mechanical."

Adora nodded in sudden understanding, "Ah. I see - we have similar things at home. But different," she shrugged and then looked at the cliff. Their elevator was within an open tower - basically, four pillars, the inside of which held grooves fro the corners of the floor,

which were actually large cog-wheels, to grip into as it descended at a steady pace. Adora could make out a matching tower, further along the cliff, clearly to enable more travellers to head in and out as needed. She also noted a narrow, zig-zagging path, etched into the cliff. Catra followed her gaze and smiled.

"The elevators are mostly for cargo or , well, large entourages. Solo travellers tend to just walk it, rather than waiting for these things to go up and down. The guards tend to only shift them for large groups or freight."

The blonde turned to look at her and returned the magicat's smile, "A wondrous place. Just like its Princess."

Catra flushed and looked away, "Shut up."

Adora's laugh was rich as she moved to the edge of the elevator to get a better look. Kyle moved up beside her and shook his head, "Reminds me of Colmay . Before the Horde."

The warrior woman nodded, her smile fading slightly, "Yes. We will rebuild, Kyle. Time will heal all. And, well," she shrugged, "Our wonders are matched, clearly. This...this alliance could really help. Their artisans, their knowledge, matched to ours? What beauty"... she shook herself.

"Barring, yknow...any issues, my thane?"

"Always the pessimist. You are starting to sound like Duncan."

"Is the Skald speaking sense?" the elder Seafarer trudged up to join the pair. He took in the sights and sighed, "These magicats are something. I thought the coral-lands of Salineas were wondrous. But this...this is amazing."

Adora nodded and turned to find Catra watching them, her ears flicking as she listened in. The magicat princess smirked, "So you want me for my architecture, huh?"

Adora flushed a little as Duncan and Kyle snickered, but she spread her hands, "Well, your buttresses are fantastic."

Catra lolled her head back and groaned, "I totally walked into that one."

"And I do so admire the arch of"…

"Shut up. Not another word or so help me I will throw you off this elevator." Catra glared at the blonde, albeit with a faint flush under her fur.

Adora clicked her jaw shut theatrically, then turned back to watch as the buildings rose to meet them. The elevator shuddered to a halt at

the tower base, which led into a plaza that ran the length of the cliff-base. Catra spurred her horse onward and led their band ahead and led them across the cavern floor. Adora noted that the ground was paved - not just bare rock. Either that, or someone had spent hours etching the rock to *look* like it was made up of inset, intricate slabs.

She noticed that it wasn't *just* magicats who wandered the streets, either. Humans, the occasional reptilian and plentiful Scorponi meandered across the plaza, loitering at the various stalls and caravans. Adora glanced up at her mate and raised an eyebrow. Catra cocked her head, then looked at the plaza itself, "Ah, yeah. So, this is the more frequented trading arena for our city. Most merchants or caravans just set up in the plains outside and our tradesfolk leave to barter and negotiate for what we need, or our own people bring it *in*."

"I was about to ask, for the *hidden* city, there seems to be a lot of footfall from non magicats. Surely that rather negates your attempts at safety and isolation?"

Catra chuckled, a sound echoed by her guards, "Astute. Not just a pretty face." Adora smirked and shrugged, but waited for Catra to continue rather than fire off a teasing jab. Catra smirked back, interested to see that Adora was focused, "Well, it's a good question. The majority are kept out. Those you see here are *residents*. Servants, refugees from the Horde who fled to us, or whom we have invited in."

"Why do I hear emphasis on the word *invited*?" chuckled Adora.

"Because, well...not everyone has permission to *leave* . Or rather, not to go far. We are very *very* strict about who comes and goes. And, well, getting out is quite a walk, along with some hefty security to get through. Some folk here are permanent guests. Not criminals, but, well, people we do not fully *trust* ."

She watched Adora, not sure if she would get an indignant outburst. But the blonde just shrugged, "It makes sense. W e have similar restrictions - the risk of a Horde infiltrator is ever present. And individuals can sometimes act rashly . Our own, however, we have to trust. To restrain one of us would be anathema. To deny them the freedom of the night-run, the moon-stalking. Why do you not just imprison those you do not trust?"

Catra winced, "It' s less a lack of trust in their loyalty , more a lack of trust in their ability . Many here are victim of the same curse as I - most magicats, one in four, carry the trait of Vampirism. Those that do show signs are brought into the priesthood, the guard or other civic roles, to better temper their natures. To help. Those we do not allow to leave, except for special circumstances."

"Y ou speak so openly about it?" Kyle asked as he walked next to Adora. Catra shrugged.

"W e are to be allied. The Faerie have likely told you stories, how this city is a blood soaked den of hedonism or something?"

Adora chuckled, "Glimmer merely mentioned the music and wines of your people. She sounded melancholy. I think she misses visiting

here."

Catra bowed her head and sighed, "Dammit, Sparkles. You're gonna make me like her again, Adora. Well we still have wine and music. But, yeah.it's *hard* to forget the tensions."

"I imagine having a mountain dropped on your city will do that," mused Adora with a small smile.

"Just a little," Catra smirked back, "But that's more the *old* guard who carry that grudge the hardest. The Horde is the only thing keeping some of them from demanding recompense from the Fae."

"Something to consider for the future." Adora watched the crowd as they moved from the plaza, "So, some caravans are permitted inside?"

"Yes, as I said...most stay at the main gate, forming a sort of faire. Our citizens go out to trade and revel. But trusted, long term merchants, those who we have built a bond with: they are permitted to hawk their wares here, in the Cliff-Plaza. They may wander the streets, but we do an accounting before they depart."

The group moved from the plaza into a wide street that led directly towards the grand ziggurat in the city centre. Adora looked at the various stalls and shops they passed - houses, blocky and layered, rose from the cavern floor;some seemed carved from the rock itself,

as if great boulders had been shaped and hollowed out;others were more clearly constructed in a familiar way, but all loomed and hemmed in the pedestrian traffic. It was also surprisingly warm. Adora rolled her shoulders to free her arms from the cloak across her back. Catra laughed, "This many people, plus the fires, cooking pits, and our slow air-pumps keep the place pretty comfortable."

"Hardly the stagnant crypt the peasantry talk of, eh?" Duncan chuckled. A few of the magicat guards growled at that, but the elder Seafarer ignored them. Adora shook her head.

"It is a surprising find. Defensible, vibrant, *alive* . A far cry from the Necropolises of the Horde. I see that there are many Scorponi about.armed, as well. Are they part of Halfmoon' s holdings?"

Catra frowned, "N. maybe a caravan passing through. W e trade with them and we have.long standing relations. There were plans of an alliance, but the Scorponi have managed to avoid open war with the Horde - their deserts make for poor terrain for the undead and they kinda hard to kill. The Scorponi I mean."

"Having armour that grows from your back would make you a bit harder to gut, I imagine," Adora deadpanned. Catra nodded absently , but slowed her horse as she regarded some of the wandering Scorponi. They weren't caravan guards, but wore the colours of one of the Houses. She shrugged, dismissing it. Ambassadors came and went.

Adora paused at a nearby stall, her eyes going wide, "What is… this?"

The magicat Princess halted and turned in her saddle, the rest of the troupe halting in her wake. She snorted as she watched the wolf-woman gawking over a stall of salted snacks, "Ah, you've found our sweet-vendors. Why am I *not* surprised."

"It…it smells." Adora waved a hand, as if to waft even more of the aroma from the piles of salted treats, "Sugary but…bitter too?" she looked at the surprised merchant, a magicat with greying fur and an apron across her chest. The woman glanced up at Catra and curtseyed.

"Your majesty. Um, a…a free sample? For your honoured guests?"

"I insist on paying," Adora straightened. SHe fished into a belt pouch and and produced a pearl, which she handed to the woman with a smile, "One sack of these…Brown treats."

"The salted cc…caramels? Of course mlady!" the woman plucked the pearl from Adora's fingers and blushed, then pocketed it and picked up a set of tongs. She rapidly packed a paper bag full of the caramel treats, which she handed to Adora, before curtseying to Catra, "And…and for you, your Majesty?"

Catra swung off the horse and moved to the seller, glancing with amusement at the wolf-woman, who had begun to chow down on the salted sweets. A near-indecent groan escaped Adora's lips, "So. GOOD."

"Do you not *have* sweets back across the sea?"

"We have *mead*. And sugared meats. But this… *this*…"

The magicat smirked and shook her head, then indicated some sweets that looked more like wrapped balls of grass. The seller nodded and handed a bag over. Catra plucked a few coins from her own belt and handed them over, waving away the protests of the merchant, "I pay my dues. Our thanks."

Adora peered at the small, green treats, "Hmm?"

"Oh these. Nopets. That's what we call them. Made from a weed that grows nearby, on the surface. You dry it then compress it and grind it up, then wrap the powder in boiled leaves of the same plant."

"It smells…Cold? Sharp?" Adora frowned.

"Minty but…with a bit of a kick, too," Catra grinned, "Too many makes us go a bit cross eyed."

"You have sweets that get you drunk?" Adora scoffed. Catra just shrugged.

"Is that so weird?"

"And here I thought that all you drank and ate was blood."

Catra winced, "Well, that we do out of necessity. This... this we do for fun." She darted a hand forwards and plucked a treat from Adora's bag, which elicited a yelp of surprise from the warrior. Quick as a flash, she moved to her horse and mounted it, before spurring it into a canter, crowing with victory.

"Thief! Scoundrel!" Adora called with a laugh behind her, before jogging after her. The company formed up and moved at a faster pace, whilst pedestrians scattered in surprise. Several called out, recognising their princess, before shouting in mild shock at the tall warrior who was seemingly in pursuit of her.

As they approached the ziggurat, whooping with delight, a column of troops emerged from a pair of squat buildings set at the edge of the large plaza that surrounded the massive structure itself. Catra reined her horse in and shook her head as the troops lowered their spears to point towards their advancing company. But mostly at Adora.

The blonde slowed and made to approach Catra, a quizzical expression her her face. But she froze as another line of troops

fanned out, with arrows nocked. An ornately garbed officer at the fore of the colum called out a *HALT* And levelled a spear in Adora's direction.

"Ho stranger! No one may lay a finger on our Princess! Surrender to face ju-"

"Oh shut *up* Cyrus," Catra drawled, "I can see you yanked the pole out of your ass, but please do not level it at our *guests* . We're having fun. I know you wouldn't know fun even if it got you drunk and showed you its breasts, but seriously"?

The officer, a magicat with bright orange fur that clashed terribly with his ornate, gilded armour, bristled, "Your *majesty* . I must strenuously obje-"

"I said. Shut. Up." Catra's voice was friendly, but had an undertone of ice, "The rest of you, spears up, or else my *mate* will tear them from your cold, dead hands."

That got a shocked response from the column. Spears went up rapidly, but mostly out of confusion rather than fear. Cyrus, however, seemed mostly dumbfounded, "Your.what? This… *human* "?

Adora looked up at Catra and beamed at her, "*Selevenn* ."

Catra returned the look with a confident smile, then looked at Cyrus, "Do not be so quick to assume, Cousin. Now , please, stand your men down. I do applaud their responsiveness. But we are expected."

Cyrus blinked, then shook his head, the feathers and horse-hair crest atop his helm waving from side to side, "Yes. A delegation awaits within as well and welcome *home* your *majesty* ."

His voice dripped with sycophantic oiliness. And the look he shot Adora was one of confused disdain. For her part Adora just pointed two fingers at him and winked. Her fellow Seafarers moved up and flanked her, eyeing the guards, then looked to her.

"All is well, friends," Adora smiled. "See, they are disciplined, focused. Good warriors."

Duncan nodded, "Pretty formations and fancy dress. But seeing Pan and his ilk in the field if they are as good as he, we have little to worry about from such shield brothers. A square can hold the Horde while we strike at their throats."

Kyle shrugged, "That one seems more gilt than guard though."

"A cousin, I think." Adora shrugged, "I doubt our mettle will be tested."

"If you are done gossiping about our guards," Catra drawled, "We can all hear you, you know."

The Seafarers laughed and Adora cocked her head, "We know."

With that, Catra dismounted and moved to stand next to Adora. Pan and his me moved up, while a gaggle of servants and retainers emerged from another set of buildings to take the horses and supplies. The Princess watched as the guards returned to their stations and barracks, with Cyrus barking orders at them as they went. Then she turned to the ziggurat.

Ahead, a broad flight of stairs led up about twenty feet to a set of large, bronze doors. Above that, the tiers of the ziggurat began in earnest, with smaller stairs linking each level, and arches leading inside. But not steps led from the plaza to the second level - the only way in was through the doors ahead. Green flames burned in braziers and cauldrons at each level, giving the place a baleful look, but also a hauntingly beautiful atmosphere. The stone of the ziggurat was a mix of obsidian black and white marble, with bronze gilding on the pillars at each level up to its pinnacle.

"Impressive." Adora mused. She turned to Catra. "And you were raised here?"

Catra nodded, "The main building of government and religion for us. The upper tiers are for the royal family, the middle tiers the

priesthood and governors, the lower levels for the administration and merchant families of note. Their offices, I mean. They live outside in the city proper. But this is, in a way, a city within a city."

"All in one place," Adora mused.

"Makes it more defensible, but yes... risky . I've been working to ensure it doesn't become insular ."

Adora nodded, but remained silent. Catra drew a breath, then marched forwards, her guards falling in behind her, Adora keeping pace alongside her easily. Catra glanced to her side and smiled faintly. The blonde sauntered along, as if without a care in the world, but looked at the magicat with a smirk of her own, "Will I of fend propriety if I walk in as your equal."

"Oh by the stars *yes* . But... to do otherwise wouldn't be you, would it?"

"Indeed not," Adora grinned.

They moved up the stairs and the great doors swung inward with a rhythmic clanking sound, as hidden gears turned and cranked them open. A pair of guards flanking the doors came to attention, their spears held upright and at an angle in salute. The inside of the ziggurat was as impressive as its exterior . A marble hallway, filled with columns stretched ahead, with side passages leading away, lit by the glow of orange lamps, a contrast to the eerie green outside.

Another door lay ahead, smaller than the main entrance, but still imposing.

"This floor is mostly administration and guard rooms. Audience chambers as well, for discrete meetings for dignitaries that dont merit the full royal treatment," Catra grinned at that. "And the main vestibule and throne room are ahead."

They moved ahead, through another corridor beyond the doors, to yet *another* door. Adora noticed that each door had the same stylised facade - a magicat reaching up to a moon. Or was it a moon falling onto a magicat who held their arm up as if to forestall their demise? She thought to ask Catra that at some point.

The question was shoved from her mind, however, as they moved into the main throne room, in the centre of the ziggurat.

But to call it a room was a disservice. Atrium was perhaps better, but still too small a word. It was vast. Not particularly wide, although Adora estimated that you could fit five or six of her people's longships, end to end, lengthways or widthways - a decent space to gather warriors or hold a feast. No, the vastness came from the fact that the 'room' had no roof - it stretched up, through every floor, balconies at every level, to a distant opening at the top of the ziggurat, where the tip of the looming stalactite could be seen, distantly glowing like a false-star.

The far wall held a wide, raised platform, upon which sat three thrones, along with smaller chairs. In front of it were benches, facing the chamber, clearly for minor dignitaries. The door they had entered in from was directly opposite this dais, with the wals curving around, making the room a semicircle.

Half-moon indeed, Adora mused to herself.

The room wasn't empty, either. Several clusters of people milled about the space - magicats, humans, beastly creatures. Adora's inspection of the crowd was interrupted by an echoing voice the rang out from beside them and the warrior glanced to her side. An ageing magicat, with silver-grey fur and a purple robe, announced their presence with a rich, projected call.

"Princess Catra, heir apparent to the Twilight throne."

The crowd ahead turned and then stepped aside, forming a clear path to the dais. Catra shrugged and leaned towards Adora, "Don't worry. Once we have you all introduced, we'll get you announced properly."

"It feels like a boring war-horn."Adora groused.

Catra shook her head, "We aren't at the coast now. You can't just… jump off a longship, all mysterious and sexy."

"T rue. I am sure, give me some time, we can haul a ship in here, recreate the scene, if it would help." Adora nudged the Princess and Catra huffed, swatting her back. This drew gasps from the crowd and Catra rolled her shoulders, reasserting herself.

"Behave," she hisssed, "For now , I mean. Stand back until I introduce you."

"As you command, *Sel evenn* ."

They reached the foot of the dais. A group of Scorponi were stood atop it, next to the thrones, but Catra didn't pay them much heed before she knelt on one knee at the foot of the steps, "My queens, I have returned as summoned and I bring glorious news and tidings..."

"Y es, quite," came a regal voice from atop the dais. "I am pleased to see you made good time for my summons. It is indeed an auspicious day. Alliances made. A new future ahead."

Catra frowned, "Indeed, but.you appear more well informed. I had hoped to update you"...

"Y es, a new bond, a new alliance. And with such a long-standing neighbour." Catra' s head came up slowly, the frown still on her face. The occupant of the central throne was standing. Her copper fur contrasted well with the cobalt blue of her robes, whilst the mask that sat across her forehead gleamed in the torchlight. Her blue eyes

shone with excitement and she smiled down at Catra fondly. The second woman, with her black fur and amber eyes, watched with a small, gentle smile, from where she sat in the second throne. Catra slowly stood and then took note of the entourage next to the throne.

The Scorponi were wearing not the garb of their merchant Houses; nor the robust clothing of the Craftsmen Houses. Or even the tabards of their Martial Houses. No, they wore the black-and-red of the Royal house. And they werent just Scorponi - a pair of purple-skinned-and-white-haired Orcs stood near them, clearly the renowned life-guards of the royal family.

The Queen stepped forwards to the edge of the dais, to the top of the stairs, "I am proud to announce that the long planned engagement of my daughter, Catra, Princess of Halfmoon and the Bulwark of the Hinterlands, is now *official* . Even now she returns from a sortie against the Shadowy foe, the relentless Horde;She has found us mercenaries and sellswords to guard our flanks. She has worked tirelessly in the field and as a blade to the throat of our foe. But truly, we march forwards to a new era of joined prosperity , as my beloved daughter takes her steps towards her inevitable future as ruler of our glorious civilisation. Paw-in-claw with the Scorponi Hegemony, we will carve a swathe through the undead and build a peace that will last the ages."

Catra swallowed as her mind reeled. She could hear a low growl behind her. Her tail swished in agitation, "Mother…My Queen… what engagement?"

The Queen tutted, "One long planned, although not certain. Until this past week. Come, Catra. Come take your seat and reacquaint

yourself with your fiance.”

One of the Scorponi stepped forwards, clad in a black dress that hugged her muscular form. Her hair was cropped short and she nodded at Catra with a broad smile, her own armoured tail held high behind her, swaying with barely suppressed nerves, “Heeeyyyy Wildcat. So, um…Surprise?”

Chapter End Notes

AM I evil?

Am I cruel?

Am I twisted?

Oh hell yes.

What, you thought it was going to be smooth sailing?
WELCOME TO HALFMOON POLITICS TIME KIDDOS!

Chapter 6

Chapter Summary

An audience with the Queens becomes tense, as new challenges emerge.

Halfmoon politics are about to hit Adora. Which will bend first?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

This was most certainly *not* the triumphant return Catra had envisioned. She'd hoped to saunter up to the throne, the key to their victory and survival in step with her. Instead she now found herself in the midst of her least favoured activity - *politics* .

She could *feel* Adora vibrating with anger beside her - it radiated off of the woman;frankly , Catra was surprised that there were people not on fire right now due to the intensity. She part turned and looked at the blonde.

Adora was rigid, her jaw clenched and throat tight. Her whole body screamed *fight* . Yet to a casual observer she probably just looked really attentive. Catra noticed that the rest of the Sea Farers had adjusted their stances, faces fixed on the Scorponi party ahead. Except for Duncan.

He stepped forward and laid a hand on Adora's shoulder. The blonde exhaled and her eyes flicked to Catra. The magicat Princess offered

a gentle smile and Adora relaxed with a faint nod in return.

"Uh, Wildcat?" The voice of Scorpia made Adora flinch, albeit slightly.

The large Scorponi princess was descending the stairs, an eager grin on her face, though she did spare Adora a curious glance. Catra managed a forced smile, "Princess Scorpia. A surprise"…

"I know, right! Well, I just thought, since, yknow, we're at war with those undead and it's all a bit stale and not moving, well, it seemed about time to move things along and, yknow, we've always been the *best* match. I know you are just gonna love the palace and, well, I promise you the harem is really comfortable and."…

The wheeze from Adora that *could* have been a barely suppressed snarl was hidden by Catra's own "*WHAT?*"

Scorpia winced and, high up on the stairs, a waifish blonde woman sighed and shook her head. Catra frowned, but returned her glare to Scorpia, who had her arms spread, ready to go in for a hug. Catra stepped back, which made the Scorponi princess frown. The Orcs in her party shifted their stances as well, clearly trained enough to realise that there was a risk *somewhere* in the room.

The carapaced woman sighed and a smile plastered itself across her face again, "I know, cultural differences, but *honestly* this.well. I. wanted to talk it over privately, because I know it's sensitive and, well, yknow how well we get on. And the harem thing, totally entirely

negotiable and your position within the household WOULD be diplomatically unique, due to, well, yknow!" She gestured expansively at their surroundings. Catra's eyes narrowed.

"Scorpia, the last time we spoke was five years ago."

"Yes, and we got on so well!" Scorpia beamed, "And, well, having you as part of the family, you'd do so well! Your skill as a soldier, super useful! Plus, yknow, you're smart and funny and, well, not going to lie, exceedingly attractive!"

Adora's voice cut in like ice drifting into the hull of a ship, "You stink of Sylvan."

Scorpia paused and turned to look at the blonde. Her smile was still broad but she looked curious, "Say, uh, we haven't met. *Princess* Scorpia of the Scorponi Hegemony. Heir, yknow. And you?"

Catra was mildly impressed by Scorpia's bluntness. She remembered the woman being a bit obsessive and a tiny bit of a people pleaser - or at least *eager* to be liked. She clearly had recognised Adora as something of a threat, not someone to chit-chat with. For her part Adora just gave Scorpia a single once up and once down look, then folded her arms.

"I am bored of you already. I am here to see her," and Adora jutted her chin up towards where Catra's mothers watched. Interestingly,

neither magicat had moved, seemingly content to watch.

Scorpia actually bristled and her head cocked. Her smile, however, remained in place, "Well that's rather rude! Now, *here* in *civilisation* it's customary to introduce a person. Polite, yknow. So it'd be really swell to know who I'm conversing with."

Adora tilted her head then glanced at Catra. Behind them, Kyle let out a sigh. The blonde warrior smirked at Scorpia, "This is not your house. I am not beholden to you. I am tithed only by the laws of hospitality as they pertain to meeting the Ladies of this land, who rule it by right of blood and birth. You are naught but a guest, a milk-sop currently badgering me. Your head remains atop your shoulders purely at the whim of my *Selevenn.* Catra, do you wish for me to remove this obstacle betwixt your mothers and our party?"

It was difficult not to laugh. It was equally difficult to not thump Adora in the shoulder. Catra managed to fix her own smile in place as she looked between the two, frankly, muscular women. The Orcs, and the Scorponi soldiers, had clearly *heard* the implied threat and seemed to be readying themselves for a fight. So, the situation needed to be diffused.

"I do not think that is anywhere *near* necessary. Scorpia is here on diplomatic business that needs to be *thoroughly* discussed," Catra gave Scorpia a brittle smile, then looked back to Adora, "And I think you would wish to make a good impression on my mothers, correct?"

Adora stared at Catra, then grinned, "Getting blood on their throne room floor would be…impolite?"

Catra shot her a glare but the blonde just grinned wider. Scorpia harrumphed in consternation, "Excuse me, um, hello? Yes, well, I think I can look past the rudeness, but we definitely need to have that talk, Catra and…"

"Enough!" Hissed Catra. Scorpia's jaw clacked shut and the woman looked hurt, a pincer held to her chest. Adora rolled her eyes and said something in her native tongue that had the other Sea-Farers chuckling. Catra sighed and looked at her, "Behave. Please?"

The blonde inclined her head, "As you require, *Elevenn*."

The magicat returned her focus passed Scorpia and up to where her mothers stood, observing. It was *entirely* in character for Cyra to pull this sort of thing - create an issue and observe how Catra reacted. But something of this magnitude was much more serious. The current argument was a test; but the engagement?

That was likely a reality. Politics before the personal.

Catra met her mother's blue eyes and shook her head, "Forgive me, my Queen, the journey was long, the dust from the road cakes out paws and the blood of battle stains our blades. So, forgive me for my lack of *enthusiasm.*"

"Battle? Are you hurt? Oh my gosh, shall I fetch.. Perfuma, come here, we must check the Princess for wounds!" Scorpia immediately approached *again* to fuss over Catra. This time Adora's growl was *clearly* audible and several of the guards started in shock. Even the Scorponi princess shot the blonde a surprised stare, her dress flowing about her ankles as she turned to stare at the warrior. Atop the stairs, the blonde woman had paused, clearly about to descend to render aid.

Adora huffed and strode forwards, conspicuously stepping *around* Scorpia and giving her a wide berth. Catra stared at her mate (A word that *slammed* into her chest hard) and hissed out a "What are you *doing*"?

"Negotiating," shrugged Adora. She continued up the stairs and paused halfway. The magicat Queen watched her with what seemed to be disdainful curiosity and, possibly, amusement. Her copper fur shone in the torchlight and her bearing was that of relaxed confidence. Adora rolled her shoulders and threaded her thumbs through the steel loops on her belt - of which she had *many* . The blonde tilted her head and leaned forwards, casting an obvious look about the vast chambers. She looked at the Orcs and Scorponi soldiers and dismissed them with a sniff, before she returned her gaze to the Queen, "Cyra, Spear of Midnight, Queen under the Mountain, Fae-bane and Sun-cursed. I am honoured to meet you. My people have heard tell of your people, your struggles and your strength," She looked to the seated magicat with the black fur and amber eyes, "Melendy , hearth-mother and Shield of the Mountain gate, the blade of moon-shadow and slayer of a thousand foes. An honour to meet you also."

Cyra blinked in surprise, but she masked it well. Melendy , Catra's other mother simply quirked an eyebrow and smiled. Behind Adora, Scorpia seemed to be trying to say something, but Catra hushed her, The magicat Princess watched her *mate* speak with her mother with something approaching shock and trepidation. Her mother did not like being caught of guard. She tended towards retaliation to gain the upper hand.

It was how they'd kept the city safe, after all. But it was also a tactic the woman relied upon *too much* , in Catra's opinion.

Case in point - this entire situation.

Cyra regarded the woman on the steps below and drew herself up further, if that was at all possible, "V ery formal. You charge in and disrupt a joyous event, usurp the place of another emissary and posture. You may have arrived with my daughter, but that does not afford you the right to antagonise my guests."

Adora frowned and pursed her lips, "N salt has been of fered, no bread. Am I governed by hospitality? Are we to treat without blade in hand? Y ou posture at me, do you not?"

That got an actual laugh, eerily similar to Catra's, from the seated Melendy, "She has you there, dear ."

Cyra twitched and shot a glare towards her wife, but she masked it and looked back to Adora, "A woman who enters with a blade. Acts

overly familiar with my daughter. And now offers flowery words. Catra, who is your new acquaintance?"

Catra let out a slow breath and advanced up the stairs. Adora remained silent, clearly aware enough to not answer *for* Catra. Or maybe she just actually *respected* Catra.

That was an interesting thought for the magicat Princess to mull on. To have the quiet, sweet words in the field, on a bedroll, was one thing;to see someone actually demonstrate it, albeit clumsily , in the face of her family?It felt oddly heartening. She drew a breath and managed a thin smile, "My Queen, may I present Adora Moondaughter, third of her name, of the Clan Grayskull, Emissary of the Sea Farers."

Cyra stared at Adora and quirked an eyebrow , then nodded slowly, "The mercenaries. W ell, sell swords are required, but to assume the right to just present yourself,"she snif fed dismissively, then looked back to Catra, "Y ou claim battle occurred?"

"Y es, my Queen. Adora saved my life."

That got a shocked gasp from Melendy, "What happened?"The black-furred magicat rose from her throne and Cyra looked, for a moment, equally concerned. Catra just huf fed.

"Betrayal. A Horde incursion to our lands. Adora here took her men and routed them."

Cyra frowned and regarded Adora once more, "Alongside our forces?"

"Well, no, she." Catra winced, "She knew of the assault and took the initiative. It was during the daylight hours."

Cyra nodded slowly, "And the betrayal? I note Weaver is not among your party."

Adora winced, "Ah, my apologies. Allow me to fetch your pet ghoul. Kyle!" she bellowed that last down the stairs and held her hands out. Kyle grinned and unhooked the sack from his belt and tossed it to Adora. The burlap sack sailed through the air, emitting a shriek as it did so. Adora caught it easily and unstrung the bag, then reached in to hoist out Weaver's severed head. The witch hissed and spat through the gag that was firmly tied in place, "She is... less flexible than before. But she did attempt to kill my *Sevenn*."

Melendy gasped and placed a hand to her mouth. Cyra goggled for a moment, whilst the Scorponi gasped. The Orcs just chuckled. The Queen recovered quickly, "You butchered my advisor?"

"Your foolish attempt to retain a ghoul? Yes. Well, Kyle did. He was faster than I. She had attempted to murder my Catra. This would not stand. But I did promise to only kill her at Catra's whim," Adora smiled and waggled the protesting head, "Now she is far easier to keep track of, no?"

Melendy huffed and looked away. C'yra arched an eyebrow and seemed to be a mix of impressed and revolted. She focused her attention on Catra, "And how did you allow yourself to be in a position where this depleted witch was a threat?"

"That was a mistake. The rune shackles are flawed, mother . She was able to co-opt them to drain Pan. He survived but was weakened substantially. I fear we allowed her too much leeway. But thanks to Adora she was stopped."

"And the Horde incursion?"

"Destroyed. Including a Deathknight."

That drew gasps. C'yra frowned and glanced to Scorpia, then back to Adora, "A mighty force indeed. I am however , ill at ease at the presence of a massed army marching unchecked across my lands"…

Adora laughed, "Hardly an army . A score of us at most."

You could have heard a pin drop. C'yra frowned, "A score of you?" she shook her head and scoffed, then looked to Catra, "This seems improbable. A scouting party of Horde bested, I can comprehend *that* . But a score of troops taking a company of Horde

raiders? This seems.. suspect."

That drew a frown from Adora. She looked about and then stuffed Weaver's head back into the sack. Before she could speak, another voice cut in. It sounded raspy, with theatrical exaggerations in its pronunciations and enunciations.

"Y our *majesty* , while this is.. An interesting diversion, wonderful storytelling, really, I feel we are being snubbed. The crown Princess is here and you treat with *sellswords* ? Princess Catra is alive and well and I am sure the Kingdom of Halfmoon is *supremely* grateful for the shore-raiders for crawling from the salt to help out, but we do have statecraft to discuss."

Catra spotted the speaker and her hackles rose. A purple lizard, with what looked like a sneer on its face, clothed in deep purple and black robes, covered in golden brocade and loops of ropes - the Scorponi style for bureaucrats. His snout was thick and his eyes were a deep yellow, gleeful and cold at the same time. He regarded Catra for a moment and a smirk ghosted across his features, before they settled into practiced sincerity. Adora frowned at the speaker and inhaled loudly, her forehead crinkling in suspicion. Her gaze then tracked across the Scorponi guards and her frown deepened in what looked like mild confusion.

Scorpia had ascended the stairs to rejoin her party and looked mildly affronted, albeit with a slightly brittle smile on her face now, her forehead marred with tiniest of frowns. She nodded in agreement with the speaker, "Ambassador T ong is correct, your Majesty . It is wonderful to see Catra and I apologise for my exuberance, but I was so thrilled to see her. I have,.. Side tracked us and I am sure the

weary mercenaries would love a chance to relax and experience Halfmoon's hospitality, while we can discuss, yknow , important matters."

The Scorponi princess threaded her muscular arm through the arm of the blonde woman - Perfuma - who leaned against her and patted her claw affectionately. Catra frowned and shot a retort at her, "I dont know . You seem.comfortable yourself."

"Oh Perfuma is just as excited as I am!" Scorpia enthused, "W e are just so keen to grow the family , like I said!"

"And this is why I must impose myself," Adora interrupted. She patted the bag, "Reciprocity . For our services, an agreement was made. I am bound to it. And this discussion makes me wonder if Halfmoon can honour its agreements," she shot Catra an apologetic look, "Or support the decisions of its first daughter ."

Cyra sighed and turned to stride back to her throne, "Speak then, sellsword. Ambassador Tong Princess Scorpia, I understand your concerns and believe me, we will address them. Halfmoon honours its commitments to its friends. But I feel I owe some level of attention to the apparent *saviour* of my daughter."

Adora bowed her head gratefully, whilst Tong *tsked* loudly. The Seafarer stepped up onto the same level as the thrones and regarded the Queens, then looked to the Scorponi, "Our grievances are one and the same. We have committed to support you against the Horde,

as we fought the Horde in my homeland. We are in accord with the Fae of Brightmoon and wish to come to an accord with you, the people of Halfmoon. For this is the city of my *Selevenn* , my other half."

Cyra's eyes narrowed, "That word." she watched as Catra stepped up alongside Adora. The magicat Princess looked up at the tall blonde and gave her a meaningful look before glancing at the Scorponi.

"Adora... not here. Mothers, may we speak in private? It is important."

The blonde looked down at her and frowned, then pursed her lips as she looked about the vast chamber, "I suppose. This is a conversation for a more discrete setting. Away from unknown ears."

"Your majesty , this is most improper. To defer and delay for some unknown sellsword? I understand that your daughter is clearly *stressed* , I think we can *all* see that. And I think we can surmise that some sort of arrangement has been made with this *barbarian* . Please do not believe us blind. This mercenary has presented a case, but we have *priority* , surely. I think the *proper thing* would be for you to continue with our talks, now that her Highness is returned from the field. Surely the matter of mercenaries can be deferred until we have concluded this rather delicate matter?" T ong's voice was slightly petulant but also silky smooth, wheedling with a persuasive undertone.

Catra touched Adora's arm and shook her head, as she noticed the blonde had half turned as if to challenge the Ambassador. Cyra, however, was the one to speak up, "Ambassador Tong," her voice was sweet, her face set in a far-too-broad smile, "Would you care for a seat?"

The Ambassador frowned, his forked tongue flicking out nervously, "Your majesty?"

Cyra stood and gestured to her throne, "Here perhaps? Princess Scorpia, I assume your ambassador is speaking for you? Would you care for this chair as well?"

Scorpia, to her credit, shook her head, "Your majesty, my representative is simply impatient. My ap-"

"Impatient?" Cyra's smile didn't falter, "So they would rather sit *now*? Save some time?"

Ambassador Tong looked markedly more pale. They swallowed and shook their head, "I am...merely emphasising the importance of..."

"Perhaps some Scorponi bannering would suit you? Seeing as you seem to believe this is now *your* hall. Shall I run the messengers out, inform the citizenry that the grand Ambassador Tong is now to inform them of their new arrangements?" The Queen arched a dark

eyebrow. Her copper fur seemed to have frizzed a little around her neck.

The Ambassador glanced to his Princess, "My lady?"

Scorpia inclined her head, "Um, your Majesty, my deepest apologies. I will reprimand my Ambassador after our meeting."

"Mh-hmm. Now, whilst this is *most* irregular, we *will* be discussing the agreed arrangement. Fear not, Ambassador. However," and here her expression became a glare, "Any further attempts to *force* me to *do* anything will be seen as *most* disagreeable. You are guests here, honoured. But do not assume that affords you familiarity *yet*. And you," she turned her glare on Adora, "Threaten my guests again and you will wish you had stayed aboard your little boats."

Adora seemed about to riposte and Catra held her breath. But the warrior just inclined her head, "This is your hall, great Queen. I stay my blade, lest one is raised to me first. I entrust mine and my own to your hospitality and protections and will raise no hand to your household or those beneath your eaves."

Cyra arched an eyebrow and Melendy chuckled. The black-furred Queen glanced up at her daughter, "Well, quite the guest you bring home, dear," she whispered. Catra huffed and glanced away, clearly recognising the knowing grin on her mother's face.

Ambassador Tong bowed low, his long, myriad robes and braided brocade touching the stone floor as he did so. "My apologies for overstepping my remit, your Majesty. I was overcome with enthusiasm and was vexed at a delay to the happy occasion. Forgive this humble servant of the Hegemony. May we take our leave?"

"Your patience is appreciated, Ambassador," Cyra's voice was calmer, more measured now, "Please, wait in the ante-rooms. We shall ensure you are afforded refreshment. This matter should not take long. We shall join you in due course to continue our discussions. Princess Scorpia, thank you for your *indulgence* of our domestic concerns."

It came out as a thank you but was clearly also a reminder of whose house the Scorponi were in. Scorpia bowed and shot Catra an excited smile, as if the last few minutes *hadn't* been as tense as anything. The Orcs gave Adora a careful stare, appraising. The larger of the two, a tall, muscular woman with a long white braid, gave Adora a nod and a glare. The Sea-Farer just smirked and nodded back.

The Scorponi party descended the stairs, Scorpia arm in arm with the woman, Perfuma. Tong followed behind, with the Orcs and Scorponi guards. Adora's own group stood aside. They seemed a more rag-tag collection, compared to the orderly column of the Scorponi delegation. Duncan sniffed as the group passed, Kyle frowned, but the rest seemed to ignore the Scorponi, bored as they waited.

Cyra huffed, then looked to Adora, "You, Adora Moondaughter. You will also await. I need counsel with Catra. You will be summoned should we deem it necessary," her tone was icily polite, if dismissive.

"Mother, no. You. Adora needs to talk with you."

The Queen shot her daughter a look and gestured to her throne, "Shall I repeat what I said to the Ambassador?"

Catra sighed and winced, "Please, your Majesty."

"All I know is that this woman has the severed head of your advisor, Catra, *my property*."

"She tried to *kill me*."

"Maybe. But like we know the Horde can persuade and beguile. I know naught of *this woman*. So, we must discuss in private *first*," her tone was that of a lecturer, steady, laying things out as one would to a child. Catra bristled, but knew that the Queen would not budge. And, also, this was the *right* thing to do - just arriving at court to present an unknown? Catra deflated a little and sighed.

"You are...you are correct, your Majesty."

Cyra sighed and reached out to tip Catra's chin up, "My daughter, these are dangerous times. I know this. You know this. Trust is hard won and whilst I respect your earnestness and that enthusiasm… caution is needed," she looked at Adora, who still stood, patiently. Her gaze hardened a little, "And I am sure you understand."

"Indeed, your Majesty. I am unwilling to be parted from my *Selevenn*. But I do not wish to be the cause of strife within your household. Catra knows I will depart at a word from her. Her words are my command, such is my *geas* to her."

Melendy hummed to herself and studied Adora, whilst Cyra arched her eyebrow once more, "Indeed?" she looked to Catra, who looked uncomfortable, "Yes, a discussion is most certainly needed… Steward!" the grey-furred Magicat scuttled forwards, "Please ensure another room is set aside for these guests for now. I would rather they *not* mingle with our Scorponi visitors. Prevention is better than cure, no?"

Adora chuckled, "I would not dream to begin a fight beneath your eaves, your Majesty. But I understand the caution," she looked to Catra and swallowed, "Catra?"

The Princess sighed and turned to Adora. She reached out, but then drew her hand back, "It will be ok. I just need to talk to them. All will be well, I *promise."*

Adora studied her, then smiled and nodded, "Then that is all I need. *Mylevenn*. Your Majesties," she bowed, then turned to follow the steward as he led her down the stairs, towards another side door in the vast hall. Catra watched her go and felt a tug in her chest. She desperately wanted to sprint down the steps and leap into those arms. She smiled as Adora paused at the bottom of the steps. The blonde turned and gave her a small smile and a little wave. Catra grinned and returned it, then blinked and turned to look at her mothers.

Melendy smirked at her and gave her another very knowing look. Cyra looked mildly amused but also frustrated. She shook her head, "Please...don't tell me you did what I *think* you did?" she managed. Catra smiled and rolled her eyes, to hide the twinge of guilt.

"Uhhh well, I went to appraise them, as you requested, because *Angella* said we should...and, well"…

Cyra held up a hand, "No, not here. Then you start at the beginning. And tell us *everything*," her look was piercing. Catra swallowed and nodded. Melendy stood and then she and Catra followed Cyra as they headed for a partially hidden door, set behind the thrones. They stepped through and vanished into the depths of the palace.

"Who are those people?" Scorpia huffed, "I mean, I know this was a surprise and, maybe, thinking about it, probably not the *best* way to

land this on Catra. She's never been good with surprises."

The Ambassador, Tong, hissed and his thick tail lashed from side to side as he paced. He turned to regard the Princess and shook his head, "I am unsure. But a formal declaration was to be expected. The failure was on the Queen's behalf, to announce it so brazenly, before a private conference. I cannot help but assume that was… intentional. The tricky ways of the magicats are well known."

He shook his head and continued to pace. Their group was in an ante-room, filled with plush couches and a table against one stone wall. Green flamed candles set in the chandelier lit the room with clean light, strangely enough. whilst a normal fire blazed from a hearth set against one wall.

Perfuma, sat on one couch, sighed and tutted at the lizard, "And you had to rile up the Queen. Hardly a way to engender good will."

Tong turned to her and hissed, but it shifted into a chuckle, "Ahhh, my dear consort, it is a good thing. I am resilient, the epitome of Hegemony bureaucracy. She *expect*s me to be a conniving, stuffy oaf. It is my *role* to object and huff. So that the Princess remains the epitome of poise and discrete diplomacy," he gave Scorpia a *look*, "But I would advise against rushing the Princess again, your Highness. This agreement is necessary."

Scorpia waved a claw, "Tong, I know. And, well, it's a win win! The Hegemony gets magicat support, the magicats get *our* support, more trade and, well, I get Catra! And she gets looked after, safe and

happy in the palace. I mean, *sure* I get that she may need time to adjust, but that will be so fun! We'll have time to catch up and, y'know, she'll be safe and what more could she want? I mean, yeah I need to brush up on some things!"

Perfuma chuckled, "Remember, dear, centre. Calm breaths! We can't force her. She won't respond well to that."

Scorpia huffed but looked embarrassed for a moment. She clicked her pincers, then moved to the couch, where she sat beside Perfuma. She gently took the blonde's hands in her pincers, "My love, you know Catra isn't a replacement, right? She's just"…

"She was in your heart when we met, my love. Love is not a finite thing. We just add to it. Your harem is a facet, it takes nothing from *me*. When we are together I know I am your sole focus. You bring me such peace. The least I can do is support you, be your strength. She will bring another pillar to our family. You are our heart. She will be our strength."

"And you are my *soul*, my love," Scorpia smiled fondly at Perfuma, then reached up and traced the tip of her pincer down the blonde's cheek. She shrugged slightly, "And yes, Catra was promised to me. She belongs with us. She is *meant* to be with us. It will unite our peoples, bring safety and security. Will it make me happy? Sure! But well, there are so many *other* benefits."

Tong huffed and stalked back and forth, "You won't get what you want if these sell-swords throw a stone in the plough's path. That tall one. Adora. A thug. A menace. Pah."

Perfuma nodded slowly, "I mean, she is very impressive. I could see how Catra could be…drawn to her?"

"So, that's…not great," Scorpia pouted and stamped her foot a little, "Catra's mine… *ours*. We've known each other since we were little! It was love at first sight and this…raider…this barbarian thinks she can just walk in and steal her away! Nope, no. No. Not going to *happen*. I just need to try harder, need to show Catra what we had. What we will have! How this is better."

She stood, but Tong raised a hand, "Your Highness…do not rush in. This requires…strategy."

Perfuma nodded in agreement, "Yes, my love. Catra needs to be wooed. Shown that love is the right path. We cannot force her. Cannot browbeat. She has to decide. Like I decided. Like *you* decided on me."

Scorpia nodded slowly, "Yeah…yeah you're right. We need this. Maybe. I know…having it out with those sea-people won't exactly help," she winced and looked apologetically down at Perfuma, "Sometimes I just…want to resolve things the straightforward way!"

The blonde laughed and shook her head, "I know. But your mothers trust you. They didn't raise an idiot," she teased, "They know you'll get this solved and sealed. A strong family to seal the kingdoms together, just like Plumeria is now happily enfolded within the Hegemony. Another culture, another people, living in harmony and

happily. Safe from things like the Horde."

Scorpia nodded, then looked at her guards, arrayed around the room, "Dee? Ok, you can get out of character , ok? I think we need the more subtle pincer...hand...for this."

One of the Scorponi guards stepped forwards then *shifted*, their form melting into darkness before resolving into a lithe, green-skinned being clad in soft, dark leather. They stretched and grinned widely. "Hmmm.. about time, darling."

Tong huffed and sneered at the shifter, "About time you were of some use."

"Ouch. You wound me! Just because I didn't pick a fight with Queen Bee out there," they smirked, "And, Highness, you need to get a better read on your intended. Flower girl here has it right. That kitty-kat will *not* play well if you act like a siege engine."

Tong growled, "That we know...but...this Adora. We need to know more. And if necessary... act."

Dee grinned widely again, eyes-twinkling with excitement, "Oh say no more, darlings. That *is* why I'm here after all. You just leave it allll to me. Just like always."

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for your patience! Oh yes we're about to get TRICKSY.

Also, meet SELFISH and SPOILED Scorpia! Boundaries? PSH! Those are for other people! Perfuma? ARCH ENABLER IN THE HOUSE!

And yes, Tong is... well is he as cunning or clever as he thinks? And our dear Dee.

Let's see how THIS plays out.

Chapter 7

Chapter Summary

Adora ponders, Dee goes exploring and Catra tries to explain.

What wicked threads we weave...

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora leaned forwards, arms across her knees as she shifted in the plush couch. The room they had been escorted to was luxurious in a way she was not entirely comfortable with - the green torches that, *somehow,* cast normal light felt strange. The fire was a welcome addition, but nothing akin to the wide hearths of home. THey also lack a fire- *pit* , which was far more normal in the halls of her clan.

"You are ill at ease, Adora." Duncan sat on a cushioned stool next to the couch - her entourage had left it to her, while they lounged around the room. A couple played dice at a small, finely carved table;Kyle was perusing the fruits and treats laid out on another table. Adora heaved a sigh and reached over to haul her blade into her lap. She'd propped it against the couch, unsure in this fine setting.

"I am."

"You do not like being apart from her," the ageing warrior said, a small smile visible beneath his thick moustache. Adora scoffed.

"So obvious?"

He shrugged, "You looked ready to fight the entire room. It is clear, to us at least. And to her."

Adora unsheathed the blade, then tossed the scabbard aside. She fished a whet-stone from one of the pouches at her belt and began to scrape it along the blade's edge. She huffed, noncommittal. Kyle turned, mouth half full of some pastry.

"It is not weakness."

"I *know*," Adora stopped scraping and slumped, "I just"…

A few of the other warriors glanced over and snickered. One made doe eyes and a kissy face atop his interlinked hands. Adora growled, but smiled. Kyle chuckled, "She is as smitten, I think. Or you are good enough to keep a girl for more than one night?" He waggled his eyebrows and Adora groaned.

"Shut *up* Kyle!"

"Ah! Much more fun." He paused and sighed, "But Duncan is right. You are afeard?"

"I worry. Her mothers are set on this wedding. And Catra respects her mothers."

Duncan glanced at Kyle and sighed, then leaned forwards, "Trust your soulmate. She will do right by you. You are blade-wed, blood-bound. She would no sooner refuse you than slice off her own arm."

Adora looked at him ruefully, "The bonds of duty are hard to break, old friend."

"Pah! Duty! Slavery to tradition! We are bound only by *loyalty*. Not dusty ideals. A proven rite, every day, where our focus is tested. I follow you not because of your name, but because of *you*. I follow Adam for his bravery and wisdom."

Adora stared at the man, then arched an eyebrow, "Adam... And *wisdom?*"

Duncan blinked and snorted, "He has improved. You know this."

"Ah yes, so far beyond waving his sword and yelling that silly battlecry."

Kyle mumbled into his drink, "Not like he was the *only* one."

"What was that, skald?" Adora hummed as she looked over at him.

"Ohhh nothing. Just, ahem… *honouring* your commitment to similar?" That got a few more chuckles and Adora barked a laugh.

"At least MINE makes sense!"

The old soldier next to her chuckled, "True. But still, the point stands. She will fight for you."

Adora's smile was wan, "But I cannot make her choose between her people and myself," she sighed and shook her head, "I would not do that to her."

Duncan snorted, "It is *her* choice to make, my young friend. You cannot deny her that. Being a hero is often accepting another's decision without *preempting* it. Honour her and *trust* her."

Kyle nodded, then looked down , patting the sack at his waist, "And having the head of their advisor can't hurt but intrigue them."

Adora peered at the sack and wrinkled her nose, "Maybe I should have handed that over."

Duncan shook his head, "It could have been a good offer, but better to have her as a bargaining chip. And a good message."

The group turned as a side door opened. The steward from the throne room entered and nodded at them. A quartet of Magicats followed him in, bringing fresh drinks and food. The steward regarded them all neutrally, "Her highness, Queen Cyra will see you shortly. She is concluding business with the Princess. Your patience is… *appreciated*."

He looked disdainfully at the pair of sea-folk playing dice, then gave a short bow and departed, leaving the four Magicat servants to clear and replace the platters and drinks. Kyle glanced at Adora and smirked. The blonde rolled her eyes as a few of the other warriors sniffed surreptitiously.

The skald leaned against the wall and beamed at one of the girls, "So, anything, uh, yknow, entertaining to do in this place? It's… amazing."

The girl eyed him, her tail lashing back and forth, clearly irritated, "Depends, sire. What is it you seek?"

"Oh what does any sailor seek?" he clutched his chest, "Apart from my beloveds - I seek the warmth of companionship! The sound of song, the taste of ale!"

"Ach, you preening waif!" Duncan barked, "Leave the gal alone."

Kyle winced, while Adora went back to sharpening her blade. Her eyes weren't on the girl Kyle was talking to - no, she was eyeing the third girl, as she tidied. But her movements weren't that of a servant - just someone trying to keep their hands busy. Adora harrumphed and looked at Duncan. She was tempted to switch back to their native tongue, but she wasn't sure if there were those here who *knew* some of it - the ghoul, Weaver, had known of them. That meant others might, too. And while it was one way, it was risky.

She decided to keep it bland - after all, speaking *obviously* in the local dialect would perhaps be *more* suspicious, " *What is taking so long?*

Duncan eyed her and responded in kind. They had been speaking their own tongue before, only switching to the magicat language when the steward had entered, *"Adora has the story of an age to tell. Adora the slayer, Adora the magnificent?"* He grinned at her.

Adora preened and nodded, *"This is true. I am rather amazing."* She laughed at the jeers of the others. She then leaned back on the couch and glared at Kyle, switching back to common, "Leave the wench be, skald. She is here to serve drinks, not entertain you. You!"

she pointed at the third girl, "More of this wine, for we must toast my impending wedding!"

The other warriors cheered at that. Kyle rolled his eyes and bowed slightly to the bemused servant, then moved to the middle of the room, "A song, Adora?"

"Ah, *a* , one of battle and beer!" Adora grinned wolfishly . She wasn't laying it on thick - she was letting loose a bit, perhaps, allowing her exuberance out to mask her anxiety. She did not wish to show weakness to whoever *that* was in the corner. If her nose was right, it was one of the Scorponi's band - likely here to gather some information.

Kyle launched into a song, all shifting tone and throat rumbles, odd coming from one so slight. Adora stamped her foot in time with the beat as the others clapped. One by one the servants left, their mysterious guest last of all.Adora had a feeling she hadn't seen or smelled the last of that one.

Dee sidled away from the room of barbarians and grimaced. They shifted into the form of a magicat guard as soon as they'd managed to steal away from the other servants, then ambled towards the royal meeting chambers, keeping as confident a pose as they could.

This hadn't been intended as a serious attempt to learn much, beyond to get a read on their targets. The sea-folk were hiding *something* . Dee hadn't become a spy-master extraordinaire without being able to catch tells. Except they couldn't work out *what* the tell was. Adora clearly was nervy, acting out. Showing off, perhaps. Their strange language wasn't familiar and they had stuck to it - so clearly they were suspicious. That Kyle, the singer, had been interesting. Rather blatant in their flirting, a bad actor, but clearly assuming that the servants were spies. Or the one he'd been talking to was.

They didn't seem that well organised - carrousers clearly assuming they'd found a winner with Catra. Confident in their success. But sellswords. The wedding was a clear focus, this Adora clearly taken by the Princess - could they be bought off? More time and information was needed. Just *killing* them would be difficult, at least in the Palace. They needed them *outside* of Halfmoon. But how to get them there?

This wouldn't do. Dee was paid well to get results. So, Adora was probably not going to be someone they could easily distract;they needed to see what the situation was like *elsewhere* and if that could perhaps be used to throw things off. Keeping the newcomers isolated was a first step, probably achieved *after* their meeting with the Queen. Dee had been tempted to try to impersonate her , to fool the sea-folk, but there was too great a risk of that ruse being discovered by the Magicats.

No, they needed to leverage the politics of the place;the delays, the meetings. Then, when the sea-folk were isolated, remove them either with monetary bribery or more *permanently* .

Dee grinned to themselves as they slunk towards the meeting rooms - they just needed to time things right. Forcing things was messy , but situational opportunities *always* presented themselves.

"So, daughter of mine, I feel there are...many explanations owed." Cyra drawled as she moved around behind her desk. The trio had withdrawn to the royal study, deeper in the Ziggurat. Cyra gestured to a cabinet nearby and Melendy gave a somehow sarcastic curtsey before she moved to pull a couple of decanters from the shelf. Red liquid sloshed within and Catra arched an eyebrow, her tail flicking curiously.

"The good stuf f, hmmm?"

"Your grandfather's reserve was going to waste. So I brought it up. Finest vintage. The Elberon vineyards."

"The ones we lost to blight two hundred years back?" Catra asked.

"The same," Cyra smiled as she accepted a glass from her wife, then waited for Catra to accept hers, "So, what troubles have you brought. You were simply to see what these mercenaries were about. And now one claims to be your betrothed?"

"Says the woman who drops a surprise engagement on me!" Catra protested. She bit her lip as Cyra sighed heavily, "That wasn't fair, mother."

"We are not in the business of *fair* Catra. We are in the business of protecting our people. This marriage was not something I agreed to easily," she glanced down at her glass sadly, "But duty is important. Until the Horde is vanquished, we are at risk. And once the Horde is gone *other* threats remain."

Catra's brow furrowed, "You fear the Hegemony?"

Melendy chimed in, "Fear not really. Respect? Yes. If they decided to invade, or attack us via other means, it would be an unnecessary distraction. If they did so after we took on the Horde? It would go badly for us."

"How? We have the most defensible location in the *world*, outside of the Fright lands and the Bleak citadel! If I marry Scorpia, surely that's as good as *giving* them Halfmoon."

Cyra shrugged, "Well, only partially. you will outlive Scorpia. And then be mother to the heir to the Hegemony. Which puts *us* in control of *them*," she smiled thinly, "The long game, Catra."

The Princess stared at her mother, faintly appalled, "I'm to be a brood mare? To secure our control over another nation?"

Melendy winced and Cyra looked away guiltily. It was the black-furred woman, Melendy, who spoke up, "No, dearest. That would be an opportune outcome, if we were being pragmatic. But actually, realistically? Your marriage to Scorpia would be a blink of the eye. A few years of pampered comfort?"

Catra's eyes narrowed, "I am a *warrior*. Not some preening, stuffed shirt, perfumed—" she grit her teeth, the words lost in her sudden anger.

Cyra looked at her dead on, "Then lead. Be a warrior. Take control of *their* armies, command them, join them to ours, crush the Horde. And then…" she shrugged, "Marriages can be annulled. Reasons found."

"It would be in her palace. I know Scorpia. She is clingy." Catra still felt fury but it was tempered by the blase attitude of her mothers. She was more confused now.

The elder Magicats exchanged a glance, "Perhaps. But would it be so bad?"

"I don't *love* her!"

"We don't have that luxury, dear. We are in a war for survival," Cyra sighed and took a sip of her wine, "But... we can table that. I merely ask you to consider it, consider the ramifications, consider what is best for our people. Please? Now, what of these sea-folk. They are… unknown."

Catra felt a little wrong footed - she wasn't sure if her mothers were *telling* her she had to go through with this or leaving it to her to "decided" to do it freely, to show some sort of leadership. Cyra was fond of these sort of "tests" - but Catra had to work out the lesson. She drew in a breath and drank deep of her own wine.

"They are terrifying. The Fae undersold them. They set out and saved a village, under their own power. On horses, just running through the night. I think it was... to prove to us they were serious as allies."

"But they are raiders, sellswords?" murmured Melendy. Catra frowned.

"They have raided around Salineas, I know. But we know the merfolk - they are hardly *innocent* and do like to strike at weak targets. Perhaps they bit off more than they could chew?"

"Hmm," Cyra murmured, "Continue."

"There was a Horde raiding party. Maybe a hundred or more thralls and... a Deathknight. They were destroying a village, clearly looking

to add to their number. But by the time Pan and I arrived, the battle was nearly done. I…" Catra drew a breath, "I saw Adora fighting. She slew dozens *by herself*. And I…stupidly charged in and… nearly got killed."

"WHAT?!" Melendy sat upright, "In the *daylight*?! I assume daylight as normally you would have been at the fore. You KNOW how dangerous that is! Why we must rely on our mortal brethren."

"That's what I'm SAYING!" Catra leaned forwards, "The Deathknight attacked directly and…Adora just *destroyed* it. Completely. No trouble. I…" she paused, unsure for some reason. She felt that elaborating too much now would be too far. She felt strange, keeping this from her mothers, but it was for *Adora* to reveal. Catra swallowed, "I nearly killed Adora in my haste, too…but she forgave me, told me we are…blade bonded."

Cyra groaned, "So in HER eyes, you're married?" Catra's…the disappointment in her voice was palpable and it triggered an immediate cringe in the younger woman. She blew out a breath.

"Well, I mean…sort of. But she said we would only be fully bound if I asked it *and* that their forces would work with us regar-" she clamped her mouth shut, realising she'd tried to overcompensate. But Cyra cocked her head.

"So…we could have their forces *and* carry on with allying the Scorponi to our banner?"

Catra glared across the table, "If I decide to say *no* to Adora. But I am not inclined to do so."

Melendy hummed and nodded, shooting a glance to her wife, before she looked back to Catra, "And W eaver?"

"Oh, the hag you demanded we keep around, despite her trying to kill me as a child?" Catra smiled brightly , "She tried again. Subverted our runic chains." That made her mothers both stare at her .

"Those chains were forge with cold iron and runed by the Fae."

"Y eah, not so amaizng. *Apparently* Adora's people knew that. And that the Horde can *use* death to enhance their powers. So, having her near that fight allowed her to power up enough to, well, use the command runes *in reverse* or something. Pan got thralled, but…" she shrugged, "Before she could kill me, one of the sea-folk uh… tore her head off."

The other two women stared at her, before Cyra tilted her head again, "T ore it of f? Surely you mean they cut it of f?"

Catra grinned over her goblet, "Nope. Bare. Hands. And the one who did it? He' s their *poet* ."

The older women took a sip at the same time before Cyra frowned, "Formidable indeed."

"You dont seem convinced."

"What is their goal, daughter-mine? To sail across the world, to offer their services? But instead of gold, they demand your hand in marriage?" Cyra leaned forwards, "WHat do they really want?"

Catra felt her heart beat faster and she tilted her chin up, "I dont know what they want. I just know Adora want's *me*. I know her eyes, mother. They are the eyes I dream of."

Her copper-furred mother blinked in surprise, then slumped backwards, shooting her wife a shocked look, "She is...your?.."

Catra nodded, "I believe so."

Cyra covered her eyes with a hand, "So complicated. So, your soulmate...is from some mysterious place across the sea? Why now?"

Catra fidgeted, "I think...I think because they defeated the Horde in their own lands and she...knew I needed help?"

Silence fell once more before Cyra spoke again, her voice deadpan, "They defeated the Horde," Catra nodded, "As in, let me be clear, an *army*, not just, say, an expeditionary force. From here?" Catra shook her head. Cyra continued, "They routed and freed their lands from the insidious corruption of the undead. This is what you are claiming? That THEY are claiming?"

"Weaver believed them," Catra answered back, "She was terrified of them."

Cyra nodded slowly, "Hmm, Weaver... mentioned some monsters across the ocean, before we found her true nature out. We should talk with her."

Catra baulked, "You would believe her over?..."

"Why not? You believe her in her fear? She will perhaps give us some more views. They will not be unbiased, but it will help paint a clearer picture," Cyra heaved a sigh and frowned, "But for now, Catra... I need you to return to your quarters. I will speak with this Adora woman. And then you and I will reconvene."

"I... no, I need to see her, to talk to her. We are bon-"

"You are not. Not until we have discussed this. We do not know their motives, do not know if they speak the truth or have woven a hex about you. Remember, we trusted blindly once and ended up nearly

buried alive! I will not risk *you* or our people over some possible spell or infatuation."

"Mother!" Catra shot up, her goblet toppling as she leaned on the table, "She is my soulmate. I feel it in me. I *know*. Just like you knew about *mom.* I look at her, the same way you look at Melendy."

Cyra stared at her, then smiled softly, "You will understand, my daughter, when you have kittens of your own. But right now all I see is a stranger who I do not know, with a story I can scarce believe, demanding your hand. And on the other, we have a solid friendship, a possible alliance, with a measure of temporary inconvenience that you can work past. I know you and Scorpia are not close. But you would dictate *everything* in that relationship. And it would give you authority, power, *influence*. And a true chance to strike the Horde - a *known* chance."

Catra studied her mother. The woman looked melancholy, yet there was a twinkle in her eye, an expectation. But for what? Did Catra have to accept, did Cyra want her to challenge her? What was the answer here, the test? Her heart warred in her breast. She had a long standing duty to her people, to Halfmoon.

And yet this new feeling, this deep, burning desire for *Adora* clawed at her. But was her mother right? Here and now, thinking about the right move, strategically, she could see the logic of the less romantic option. Was that all this was? Her romantic heart, which yearned for something deeper?

I…"

"Go to your rooms, Catra. THink. This is not a decision to be made lightly, I know. Let me talk to this woman, feel her out. Let your mother see her. Let us help you choose *wisely* ."

Catra shook her head and glared at her mother, "Choose what' s best for who exactly?"

Melendy interrupted, "It has been a trying journey , my love. And we have thrown a lot at you. Such is the way of leadership. So take the time. Please, trust us?"

The Princess slumped forwards and shook her head, "I for now , I will retire. But I will not be denied seeing her."

Cyra nodded, "I am sure a battalion could not sway you. Guards!" A door opened and a pair of soldiers entered, "Please escort the Princess to her rooms. She needs rest. Please ensure she is not disturbed until we call for her later."

The guards saluted and stood aside, waiting for Catra. None of them noticed the way one guard's eyelids moved in the wrong way, albeit very briefly.

After Catra left, Melendy turned to her wife and glared at her, "This is a dangerous game. I do *not* approve."

C'yra winced and turned in her chair. She grabbed at Melendy's hands, the black-furred woman wrestling for a moment before she allowed them to be held, "I know, my love. But I worry. And I know you do too."

"This is her *soulmate*. Before, I thought it a test of her judgement, her decision making. But this... this is dangerous, C'yra."

The Queen looked away, her face hard, "But we must be sure, Melendy. Catra will make her choices work, whatever they are. But… I will not allow an unknown variable to distract her, to harm her. Too much relies on our daughter being prepared should we not be around." She met her wife's eyes, "I *cannot* allow it."

Chapter End Notes

PHEW! Thank you for your patience everyone - this one was way past late, I know!

And yes, Magicat politics kicking in HARD. What does C'yra ACTUALLY want? Is there a right answer? Is it multiple choice?

Thanks for sticking with, everyone!

Chapter 8

Chapter Summary

Adora meets the mothers.

And Weaver gets a word in.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The corridors of Halfmoon were indeed intriguing - the city beneath the earth was, in itself, marvellous;the Ziggurat even moreso. The lack of windows was slightly unnerving - Adora was used to camping under the stars, or living in war camps on open plains. The underground was usually a place of crypts, or the retreats of the liches and ghouls of the Horde. To see a civilisation of the *mostly* living thriving in the supposed dark was novel, if strange.

It wasnt something Adora' s people had tried, though. The idea of bunkering up in a den was anathema to them. To remain still, to withdraw was to allow the Horde range and opportunity. To secede land and resources was insanity. Likewise it was madness to throw bodies at a foe that grew with every casualty of the Clans.

The Clans had their holds, of course - their cities and grand buildings. But they were above ground, with walls. She could see the strategic thinking of the Magicats, though - this place was eminently defensible. It was risky, though. What were their avenues of escape, should the city be breached?What other lines of defence were there.

It was an interesting strategic and tactical puzzle. Adora loved the analysis of battle - the solving of a problem. She revelled in the fight, yes, but *planning* the fight, that was poetry to her. She did not have the eye for grand strategy, that was true - she knew plans, yes, knew the great wheels of industry that drove war. But it was not her *strength* .

She was *amazing* on the ground, noting the ebb and flow of battle in the moment. Give her a castle and she would give you a dozen ways to take it. Give her a nation and she would find the scale something near overwhelming. So she approached things a battle at a time.

And what she was involved in now, make no mistake, was a battle. So she surveyed the terrain.

A home told you much about its occupants. Their attire told you similar stories - how they wore their clothing, how they held themselves;how comfortable their stance was;how confident they were in the arena. Like a swordsman’s posture: an amateur would hold a blade a certain way - so it was so with the politician, who wielded appearance like a blade. Social combat was another area that Adam was better at - he was the politician, the debonair one. She felt ungainly by comparison;but he trusted her . And though she felt a novice, she knew her way around *negotiations* .

She had been summoned by the court aide, the grey furred Magicat leading her through the stony corridors. The place was no dusty crypt - it was clean, pristine. It told of a care and pride in this place. An orderliness that also spoke to *strictness* .

The rulers wished to preserve things, to maintain. They were sticklers.

A good and a bad thing, that.

Adora had been asked to go alone, so she had left her entourage, waving away the need for a guard. She had joked, "If they wish to kill me, you will hear. And if I do not return, well, I am sure you will give them a good fight!"

That had, of course, made the guards *very* tense, but Adora had tried to diffuse things by smiling. That *hadn't* worked. But to be fair, she wasnt concerned with the comfort of the vampiric cats - currently she was being denied access to her *sjelevenn.* And while it might be necessary, she felt it was fair to vent some of her frustrations.

The chamberlain led her through the clean, well lit corridors to a small door. It wasnt imposing but Adora had the sense of intimacy and security - this place was important, private. It was clearly *home* territory for the Queens.

Her nose picked up faint scents - Many Magicats, but two stuck out as distinct. Catra.

And the changeling.

Both had departed at the same time. A frown crossed Adora's face, but it was not the time for speculation.

The chamberlain paused at the door and then looked at Adora's sword, "You will need to leave that here."

The guards looked prepared for her to object. Adora just gave the man a lopsided grin and unslung the huge weapon. She held it out, one handed, then dropped it into one of the guard's hands. The man grunted and sagged briefly, before he straightened. The vampires were strong, but her blade had caught him off guard. Adora just shrugged, "I come to parley in peace. Can your Queen's guarantee the same?"

The Chamberlain bristled, "You would question my ladies' honour?"

"I know them not. I heard they slew giants and held back the Horde; that the Fae fear them and that they are bound by no covenant that displeases them,"Adora leaned down to look at the man, "Tell me true, Ink-Spiller, am I to be safe within these walls?"

The man stared at her, then regained his composure, "You have, as I am sure some of the *less cultured* cities would say, broken bread - you have eaten our food, and experienced our hospitality. You shall not come to harm."

“A ye, salt and bread. I am glad the old ways are common across the seas. My thanks, Ink Spiller.”

Without another word Adora ducked through the door into the study. She found herself in a cosy room, lined with books and with a small fireplace burning brightly. The Queen and her wife sat behind a desk. Well, Cỳra did;the other one, Melendy , Adora remembered, was sat off to one side, a book in her hands. The black furred Magicat looked up and smiled at Adora, then coughed.

Cỳra seemed enthralled with a set of scrolls on her desk. Adora snorted briefly - she had seen her father use this trick plenty of times: pretend to be engrossed, make the supplicant wait. A good vassal would wait, or be patient. An impertinent one would be restless or nervous.

A cat trying to outfox a wolf. The thought amused Adora. She was no *skald* but she would consider herself a scholar of humour.

She approached the desk, then dragged the seat in front of it back, then sat in it. She fixed her stare on Cỳra and waited. The Queen had paused at the sound of wood being dragged across stone and pursed her lips as Adora sat, heavily, in the chair.

“It is customary for a guest to await welcome before taking a seat. Especially in the presence of Royalty.”

"And is customary for the host to acknowledge a guest promptly . Especially if they are Royalty," Adora responded with a small smile. She reached down and unhooked a bulky sack from her belt, "But before we shift to a trade of words, I must return your property."

The sack thudded onto the desk. Carefully, Adora untied the top and let the burlap fall away. The distraught and near-mad visage of Shadow Weaver was revealed. She gabbled, her voice a hoarse whisper as her eyes locked onto the Queen, "Ma..Maj..majesty . Abomination. Kill her. Ki.."

Cyra grimaced and shot Adora a disapproving look, "Charming."

Adora shrugged, "I was remiss and should have given her back in the throne room."

"And what about the rest of her?" Cyra continued. She placed her quill down, then folded her hands. She rested her chin on her interlaced fingers and stared at Adora. The expression and face were so similar to Catra that Adora had to take a slight breath. Similar, save for the eyes - nothing would match those brilliant eyes.

"A charnel pit. You must admit, she is far more manageable like this."

Cyra coughed into her hands, the smirk she was trying to hide fairly evident, "Maccabre."

"You are a vampire. I hardly think you squeamish," Adora shrugged and smiled. Melendy hummed and closed her book, then looked between the pair. Cyra looked across at her and nodded. The black furred Magicat spoke up.

"You are direct. That hardly seems intelligent."

Adora shrugged, "I could waste time with pretty words. I could come with platitudes. I feel you might appreciate it, but also see it as fawning. I would rather speak plain."

"She is... monster . Will doom us all," gasped Weaver. Cyra sighed and tentatively reached out. She seemed unsure of what to do with the head. Adora leaned forwards.

"We kept our ones in jars. Still do."

Cyra's eyes flicked up and she arched an eyebrow. One ear twitched, "Yours?"

Adora nodded, "Keldor , High Necromancer of the Horde in our lands. His skull is kept locked away, in the dark, chained in a jar . We found

it a useful way of detaining them. Of course, never *together* . Too much death in one place is like food for them. And leave them in a place of life, they will corrupt it. So, a jar , in a place of stone and salt. You may preserve her that way."

Melendy sighed, "Why not just end her?"

"You did not, even when she attempted to kill your daughter," Adora's tone was mild, but there was a hint of something there: judgement. Cyra bristled.

"And you know *what* of that?"

Adora just held up a hand, "Only what I have been told. Your ways are not known to me."

Cyra's tail lashed for a moment and she then sighed, "Everything is a lesson, in this world. A test. Weaver was a test, one I nearly failed. I kept her to remind Catra AND I that danger is often where you least expect it. But a claw you know is at your back is one you can prepare for," her expression shifted as she looked at Weaver, "Or so I thought."

The blonde remained silent and watched. Melendy stood then and walked to the table. She looked down at Weaver, then sighed. She moved to the back of the room and vanished through another door at the back. Cyra watched Adora in silence. The blonde watched her

back. After a few moments Melendy returned, carrying a large glass jar. With a sigh, she hauled Weaver up by her hair, which elicited a pained moan from the head. Unceremoniously she deposited the ghoulish woman's head into the jar, then stoppered it. Melendy gave Adora a look and frowned.

"So, you destroyed her after?"

"No, my skald intervened. She was drawing on the death and had subverted your runes. I am surprised she did not try it here, but I think the death here is wrong for her. You are not the normal *undead* of the Horde. You are more, yes?"

Cyra sat straighter, "Some say we are cursed. I say blessed. But that is beside the point. Thank you for protecting our daughter. We are willing to reward you for such a noble gesture. Halfmoon is wealthy."

"You believe I seek gold?" Adora's voice was steady. Melendy watched her. Cyra shrugged.

"You say you wish for my daughter's hand. Yet you are sea-borne raiders, if the stories are true. Surely you seek wealth. Or maybe you see my daughter as a way to gain prestige?"

Adora leaned back in the chair, which creaked under her weight. She inhaled and then let the breath out slowly. Another test, clearly. She

smiled thinly, "I."

"Surely there is more?" Cyra leaned forwards, "What do you want, Adora Moondaughter?"

"Simple. To slay my foes, see them driven before me and to hear the lamentation of their leaders. And for my *sjelevenn* to be by my side as we free this land of the taint of the Horde."

"And then what?" Cyra leaned back in her chair, "You are a warrior, true. But Catra is a *Princess*, destined to rule. I understand you offer an army. Swords are useful, but not all we need. She thinks you can drive the Horde back, single handedly. But you and a ship of people, or ten ships? That is nothing. I can hire sellswords from a Salinean tavern without sacrificing my daughter into a dead end marriage."

Adora leaned forwards them, resting her arms across her knees. She cocked her head at Cyra and met her gaze, "I see."

"Do you?" Cyra smirked, "Do you really? Look at this from *our* perspective. You are unknowns; mysterious, but potentially useful. We believed we would get masterful warriors and, I do not deny, that seems to be the case. But in terms of *trade*? Let me be blunt: The Hegemony offers us long term security. This war has dragged for years. It will drag on for more. The enemy are *legion*. Every village lost, every city razed adds to their number. We may weather it down here, but our allies need us. And we, for now, are minded to help."

The blonde laced her fingers together and pursed her lips, then cocked her head, "So, you see Catra as merely a token to trade for favours?"

That got a barked laugh from Cyra. Melendy remained stoic, standing behind her wife's chair. The rust-furred Magicat shook her head, "She believes she cares for you. What if this is a passing fancy? The ardour cools and whilst the romance of battle and the *story* of it all is wonderful in the heat of it... What then? My daughter will live for centuries. She will outlast the Scorponi and we will have an ally for *eons* . With you? Just ships and salt and rusty swords. Romantic ideas."

Adora growled, the sound low and earthy. Both the Queens startled, their fur puffing suddenly. The blonde glared, then sat up and rolled her shoulders, "You assume. You talk to me as if I am some salt stained merchant with dreams of battle? You belittle me," she studied the women, "You play a game while the lands around you burn and die. Sat in your hole. Ever living but afraid."

Cyra's eyes narrowed, "So diplomatic."

Adora shrugged, "I am no wheedling Ambassador . I am Adora Moondaughter, daughter of Randor, Chief of Chiefs, ruler of Eternia. You insult me. You belittle the bond I have with Catra. Anywhere else I would have struck you down," she delivered the line flatly , "But I am sworn to honour you. Your daughter values you, loves you. And I respect that. You may insult me, but do not pretend to know me. You ask what I want, yet have not asked what I offer."

"This is the part where you counter me," Cyra smiled sweetly at her meddling.

"I bring death. I bring ruin. I bring an *end* to all this suffering," Adora shrugged. "I bring victory. I wish for you to support Catra, to abide by her choice. Only she may decide I am unworthy of her."

"Bold words. And if we asked Weaver, what would she say of you?" Melendy asked, softly.

Adora shrugged, "She would say I am a monster. The ghouls have no young, no children to tuck in bed. But if they did, they would whisper of us as that which rose once more, purged them with steel and flame. We will never fail, never *have* failed. They know our name: We are warriors, we joined as one clan, strengthened by steel of soul and sword. We rose, as the sun rises and we cut them from our lands."

"They will not stop there." Weaver wheezed, almost inaudible from the bottle, "They will rule you. The First People. Subjugation."

Adora stared at the bottle, then looked at the Queens. Cyra stared back at her, "She raised a rather roundabout point. You are an unknown. You would bring an army to our lands, marry into our family and then? Would we be your vassals? What would this mean."

The blonde shrugged, "You would be part of the Hegemony, correct, with the Scorponi?"

"Well, that is...more complex," Cyra smiled back, thinly, "And not what we are discussing."

"But it is. You cement an alliance...and then should you perish? Does Halfmoon continue, does it fall under their sway?"

"It would be Catra on the throne."

"Would it? Would it be her giving the orders, from all the way over in their dusty palace, wherever that is? Would Scorponi have authority here?"

Cyra shrugged, "Things that can be managed, that will change. Halfmoon has resisted all. You need not concern yourself with *minutiae* of things beyond your...remit."

Adora chuckled, "Surely it would be *better* for Catra to wed one who WAS just a simple swordswoman? I would bring no rival claims, our heirs would be of Halfmoon alone?"

"You claim to be the daughter of the chief of chiefs," Countered Cyra.

“And I rule me and mine. Who wander the seas far from our home. To wed Catra would be to declare Halfmoon our home, our hearth.”

“You would bend knee to us?” Melendy asked. Adora looked at her and her smile flashed in the firelight.

“I would bend the knee to *Catra* .”

Cyra watched the blonde and then rested her palms on the table, “Much to ponder . But this is just a first meeting, Adora Moondaughter. We have not discussed *specifics* . Numbers, expectations. You ask much, yet the offer is *ephemeral* . We know the weight of the Scorponi gold, as it were. You offer dreams and promises, though pretty and well presented.”

Adora gave a half shrug, “I will let Catra decide my merit. But she puts stock in what you both believe. We shall see how the scale tips.”

“And if she doesnt choose you?” Cyra asked. Her voice was soft, suddenly, “But she asks your aid?”

There was a heavy silence, Adora’s jaw tight. She then shrugged, “She is my *sjelevenn* . To deny her would to be to deny myself. I would assist.”

"Then surely that is the most prudent course? T wo armies, rather than one?" C'yra continued, "Why force this decision on my daughter? If you care, if you value her... surely you wouldn't place her in such a position? Give her what she needs."

"But deny her what she wants?" Adora' s response was quick, sure, "Deny her the *choice* ? No. If I were to act in such a way... it would be to dishonour her, to belittle her. She is a leader, a warrior. I will defender her shield, stand at her back. She is my other half. If we are to act as one, we must be of one mind," The blonde stood, abruptly. She was taller than the Magicats, not by too much, but still tall. Her blue-grey eyes glittered in the firelight. Melendy actually took a slight step back and C'yra let out a short hiss. Adora smiled thinly , "I could make the choice. And mayhap I would have, moons ago. Believed I was the honourable, noble hero. But I would be a thief in the night. I KNOW what I want. I have to let Catra decide what SHE wants."

C'yra stared at the warrior with an expression of intrigue and, perhaps, respect. But also maybe slight condescension, "Noble. But not a leadership decision."

Adora shrugged, "I am not the leader here. I am a petitioner . This is your court. WHo am I to demand and act is such an abrupt manner, hm?" her grin was swift and the comment actually made C'yra laugh, "I thank you for the audience, noble Queens. But I will take my leave. As you say, we have much to discuss. And you have given me much to ponder as well."

That made C'yra arch an eyebrow , "Indeed, we have barely scratched the surface. But you are right - this will not be resolved in one night."

"It could be," Adora shrugged, "But I see that that is not so easy here. Fare thee well until our next meeting." She bowed, but only slightly, then turned to leave. The Magicats watched her go, silently.

Out in the corridor Adora straightened and sighed. She reached out and hooked her sword from the grip of the guard and slung it over her shoulder. The Chamberlain was waiting and smiled at her. More a grimace, really, "We have your quarters ready. Not in the palace, of course. The barracks have some space set aside for your… sellswords.

Adora felt an urge to punt the man through a wall, but bit it back. She merely grunted and added, "Lead the way."

Back inside the study, Melendy let out a breath, "What a woman."

Cyra chuckled, "Do *I* need to be worried?"

"Hardly. But I can see why our girl is so taken with her. She is confident, and well," she shrugged, "You can see it, Cyra. You *can*."

The Queen sighed and sagged in her chair. She shook her head, "But what I said was still true, Melendy. Muscles and a gift for

conversation does not a successful marriage make."

"Oh I dont know . Worked for us," cooed the black furred Magicat. Cyra snorted and swatted at her wife.

"I am hardly as...muscular as that woman!"

"Oh I was talking about me, dear," Melendy laughed and moved back to her chair. She sat down and shook her head, "I think. Well, no, I *know* what the right choice is here. Do you, dearest?"

Before Cyra could answer, Weaver's rattled voice cut in, "They will end you...and I...will laugh...as they do."

The pair of Magicats looked at the jar and sighed as one. Cyra shook her head, "And perhaps we should talk with this one. Tell us, oh great and powerful Weaver...why should we fear her so?"

"Conquerers, marauders. We are pure of purpose, seeking...unity . The First People ruled their...lands...with iron hearts and bestial fury. Only our...might... Purged them. But they struck back, hungry...they will bring that here. Defeating us...will not...be enough. They will take...all of you."

Cyra frowned and leaned towards the jar, her head cocked. Her smile was not pleasant, pensive, curious, cautious, "But you admit… They *can* defeat you."

Chapter End Notes

Thank you all for your patience! Afraid I was laid low with illness AND I wanted to finish off a couple of other stories first.

I will be zeroing in on this, Live by the Sword AND When you love the job, so hopefully that little triumvirate will entertain!

Solo focus for the most part this chapter, Catra time next one! And then we'll see what Dee has planned.

Chapter 9

Chapter Summary

Catra entertains a guest.

Dee plots and plans.

What wicked webs are being woven?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra groused all the way back to her room. She felt like a mewling kitten all over again, her choices made simple and childish in their simplicity by an all-powerful mother. It was reductive and *weighty* : a simple choice, but with the potential for *more* .

She loved her mothers. She really did. But Cyra was a trickster at heart - immortality had meant she'd become bored and in that boredom she revelled in mind games, even with her family. Or at least that was how Catra saw it. Was there a lesson in all this, or was Cyra simply spelling it all out? And Melendy , Moons bless her, was complicit. Kinder, but complicit. Oh she'd cut the games short, eventually.

But it was wearing. She missed the days of soothing purring and gently sung songs at one of the upper balconies;watching the green flames of the night-lights high up in the cavern roof. How she would listen with wonder as her mothers took her to the surface to stare at the stars. How Melendy had told her that her fate was written

between the pinpricks of light, shadowed but clear if she knew to look and to *trust* herself.

That trust was hard to find when your mothers constantly changed tactics and presented you with never ending challenges and riddles.

And then there was the other, more *immediate* concern.

The guards clanked to a halt in front of Catra's door. They took up station and Catra huffed, reaching for the weighty ring that acted as the handle. She paused, then looked straight at the rightmost guard, "You. Inside. I have an urgent matter. You, remain on watch."

The two guards exchanged a glance and a shrug, then the one summoned followed Catra into her chambers.

The setup was not gaudy - it wasn't utilitarian either. Catra understood the value of comfort. Being out in the wilderness made you appreciate it all the more. It reminded you you had something to get back to.

Her room was an apartment, broken into a larger entertaining room, with a bedchamber behind a set of heavy drapes. A balcony led off of the main room, with a view from the ziggurat. A pair of large, long couches faced one another, with a low table of black wood between them. Drapes and rugs hung from the walls and ceiling, making the

place look like some sort of tent. Catra huffed and began to unbuckle her armour, "So, why are you here?"

"Ma'am?" the guard coughed, confused. Catra snorted, then moved towards a rack to one side of the room. She placed her bracers onto a humanoid mannequin, then unbuckled her chest armour, followed by her greaves.

"Don't be coy," Catra looked over her shoulder and frowned, "it doesn't suit you *Dee*."

The guard blinked. Then the magicat smiled, the grin far too wide for the feline face, "My my . How did you guess?"

"More to the point, how has no one *else*?" Catra mused.

"And stripping for me, Kitten, my my? You must really want something," Dee purred. The guard disguise shifted, looking *off*, disjointed. Their shape shifted, becoming inky black for a moment, before the lithe reptilian was revealed, "I knew you weren't that into the thug"…

Catra stilled and hissed, her head snapping back, "I recommend you be *quiet*," she turned, still dressed in the loose under-armour of britches and a thick shirt, "Answer the question."

"But so MANY , kitten"…

"You don't get to call me that."

"Oh, she has claws."

"You know I do," Catra harrumphed, "Why are you here Dee? You know if I know you're here then my mothers both do too."

Catra took a little satisfaction in the slow blink that Dee made. The changeling recovered quickly and scoffed, "Hardly , darling. They'd too distracted by tall, blonde and stupid to take any notice of *me* . Even your precious guards haven't noticed."

The Princess regarded the changeling, uncomfortable. She realised how this looked, and felt a flush on her face. She was just… comfortable was the wrong word with Dee. *Familiar* . It wasn't that she trusted them, more that she wasn't threatened by them. And they had a rather complicated past.

She shifted tack, "So, working for the Hegemony now? Or is this just a temporary circumstance?"

"Oh I'm career now , Kitten. A perpetual appointment, entertainer and infiltrator extraordinaire!"

Catra had to inhaled to prevent her fangs from extending;Dee was somehow *more* vexing than ever, "So, a spymaster wandering the halls of Halfmoon's grand palace.what a *good look* for the Hegemony."

Dee shrugged, "Purely an innocent short cut, your *highness* . A message sent via the servants?T oo much of a risk of it getting lost, or requisitioned by your darling mothers. This way.well, as I said, I am hardly noticeable."

The Princess cocked her head, "Y ou will have been noticed."

"Only by those who know what to look for . I smell like a Magicat, I sound like one. I inhabit the role, darling,"Dee' s smile was all pointy teeth and narrowed eyes, "Only someone.acquainted with my uniqueness.m.might spot things."

Dee glided across the floor, then hopped over the back of one couch to sprawl over it. Catra scoffed, "Y ou havent changed."

"And is that such a *bad* thing?W e had good times, darling. The desert sands, nothing but moonlight and drama!Oh, such *fun* we had. And we could have it all again,"their eyes twinkled and Catra growled in her throat.

"That was a long time ago,"Catra ground out. Dee just smirked.

"Doesn't *have* to be. Look, I'll be as forthright as I can, *kitten*. My lady Scorpia wishes to talk a walk with you, to convey her *ardent devotion* and *love* and all that. But let's be really really candid here. She wants you in her harem and I know that just *really excites you*," Dee's look was gleeful.

Catra seethed, "Well that is not"…

"I mean, what Scorpia *wants* and what she *gets*… kind of… malleable. Honestly, darling," Dee adjusted their posture, rolling onto their front, kicking their heels together, "Do you think she could *stop* you. Compromise. And, well, it's just a *walk* and *talk*. You used to be friends."

"Years ago," Catra glared. But she moved to sit on the opposite couch. Dee made a mock disappointed noise and flexed a little, then chuckled.

"So quick to forget so many things! A single smirk from your new gargoyle of a suitor and all the good times fritter away, hmmm?" That drew a glare from the princess, "She must be amazing if you're willing to throw away security, long term prosperity and the chance to bed as many of a harem as you *wish*. It's all party party party, Kitten. Scorpia just wants them all to love HER first. But so *many* they have to entertain one another. But I can guarantee you it'd be a petty formality. Top dog or *cat*," Dee snickered, "And then the Hegemony's army at your beck and call. You know she'd probably make you a general. I doubt Scorpia would refuse you *anything*. And we'd get to *hang out* together again, hmmm? Doesn't that tempt you a little, Kitten?

Catra blinked rapidly. Her sense of purpose warred in her chest. The shallow part of her listed the perks;a compromise, a gilded cage, but she'd have the army she'd need. And she'd outlive them, have the Hegemony as a possible longer term ally.

And on the other, what? A small cadre of super-strong wolves and…

Blue eyes drifted in her vision. She stared into the middle distance, then blinked rapidly as she realised Dee was crawling across the table. She froze, shocked as the changeling paused in front of her and caressed her cheek, "Old times, Catra. We were good friends. We fought and drank and *lived*. Just think, out there, in the sands, free of this place…it's not so bad. You'd have your freedom, you'd be in control. Staying here? Running patrols? You're made for more, Kitten, you know it."

Their voice was honey, silk. Catra swallowed, memories warring in her mind: of tents amidst the dunes and drunken evenings, drinking the blood of a barmaid too in her cups to care, of Dee and the music and all of it.

"And if you ask, perhaps she'll agree to the blonde coming along. You are allowed servants of your own after all. And you seem to have tamed her. And, well, I'm sure I…".

Dee's face shifted, becoming Adora's for a moment.

Catra blinked, the fog in her head vanished. Her eyes narrowed, she hissed and Dee shrieked as a claw slashed towards their face. The changeling rolled, clutching the hand they had managed to bring up just in time. Catra glared down at the creature, "You… *dare*. You dare try to manipulate me so?"

Dee glared right back, but there was fear in those eyes too. Catra's fangs extended and Dee's eyes darted about. They held up a hand, "Your highness. I… I overstepped. It's just. I thought"…

"You don't *know* me, Dee. Not any more. Crawl back to your mistress," Catra turned away, "She can have her walk, say her piece. Tomorrow, before the banquet my mothers are sure to throw. See yourself out."

Dee scrambled to their feet, their face a careful blank, though the pinch of their eyes showed an irritation and the usual frustration when they didn't get their way. Catra knew Dee - the creature didn't hold grudges; they were a performer and they would spin this as just another act that hadn't gone their way, something to be adapted to. Next *time*.

"My thanks for your *wonderful* hospitality, my lady. I will convey your missive," Dee gave a theatrical, almost insulting, bow, then turned. Their form rippled as they did, reverting back to the guard-shape from before. Catra didn't watch, just listened as the door clunked shut. She swallowed and hugged herself, then bit her lip. With a hissed breath she stalked out onto the balcony.

Far below, the city stretched out. High above, the rock formations glowed with suspended torches and the crawling glow-worms that dotted the cavernous ceiling. The dwellings hewn into the drooping rocks looked like inverted hives, glistening with gold and green lights.

It was a wonder. A precious jewel in the darkness. And it was hers to protect.

Catra braced her hands against the balcony rail and let out a sigh.

If she admitted to herself, part of her could see all the advantages. Armies, a devoted lover (To a point - she wasn't *naive*) and, well, a harem. One ostensibly that belonged to Scorpia but...and it was a familiar thought. The sort of thing she'd joked about during her hellion days, when she'd been more active in the war; a skirmisher, fighting on the flanks, striking into the desert and wilderness; before she'd become the more reliable *defender*. She still fought, but not with that reckless abandon.

She'd command *two* armies.

And what could Adora offer? She swallowed the guilt and tried to look at it pragmatically.

What could some salt-soaked raider offer her? Here she would have riches, power, the ability to strike her foes down!

What could those blue eyes offer? That smirk? Those arms?

What could the raiders give her, aside from an endless horizon, the vague promise of peace, that sense of safety, that utter love and devotion - not that of being a bauble, of being possessed in a cage, gilded though it might be?

What could Adora offer?

Except everything.

Catra drew in a ragged breath. The choice felt unfair: Uncertainty and happiness; or security and mild contentment?

"Damn you, mother," she hissed, "Damn. You."

—

Dee emerged from the room and smirked at the other guard, "Seems her majesty had some… *pressing* issues she wanted to discuss," they purred. The guard they were impersonating was of the female persuasion - easier to sell the lie. The other guard arched an eyebrow and shook his head.

"Dont be spouting that. The big girl downstairs may gut you."

"Hah! Which one?" chided Dee. The other guard gave them a blank stare.

"The *dangerous* one. The one with blue eyes. I spoke with some of the other men. They said they cant tell us all, but them warriors fought like wolves. Took an entire contingent of Horde out. And that leader of theirs? Killed a Death Knight. With her bare hands."

Dee blinked, then scoffed, "Bar room chat, to make them sellable. Theyre sell swords. Some flourish. Nt like us. T rying to get in with the Princess. Shed do better with a *proper* marriage."

The other guard scoffed, "T alking like youre all into that politics stuf f. Enough that well live for years, avoid all that back room dealing."

"Oh I dont know..back room dealing sounds *fun* ," Dee giggled. The other guard snorted, then frowned.

"Hey I didnt get your name, new shift?"

"Dina. Y ou fancy..Getting of f after we get off?"

The other guard coughed, "Uh"…

"So what' s your name?" Dee sing songed, as if obliged, but they smiled as they spoke.

"Uh, Dargyl."

"W ell, Dar. let' s reconvene in detail a bit later, hmmm? Oh look… here's our relief. Maybe we have time for... a taster?" Another set of guards marched down the corridor. After a brief exchange, Dee led her new Friend' off. And about twenty minutes later, Dee left Dargyl eagerly anticipating their next rendezvous.

As Dee stalked back down the stairs their form rippled to become one of the many servants in the Ziggurat. With a frown, they studied the small scar on their hand, which was slowly healing up. They paused in the shadow of one of the many pillars of the main corridors on the floor and pondered.

"Choices. choices. She' s still *feisty* ," they mused, "But the temptation is there. I think we need to divide and conquer here," they smiled thinly, "Y es, indeed. Someone needs to exit this little tragedy in the making. And what better way than leading them by the heart"…

Chapter End Notes

Again, thank you for your patience! I hope this little updater brings you some joy as we creep through the politics and plots!

Chapter 10

Chapter Summary

A late night rendevous, while others plot and plan.

Romance and spice in their air, whilst treachery is prepared.

Chapter Notes

Warning -a little bit of SPICE for your Monday Morning!

And we're BACK!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"This is a terrible idea, Chief."

Adora glanced at Kyle as the pair wandered the torchlit grounds around the perimeter of the Ziggurat. There was a sort of garden-cum-parade ground that stretched between the edge of the massive palace's base and the stubby wall between it and the rest of Halfmoon. The space that sat between the "gate" to the complex and the Ziggurat was all open and flat. It was a direct run from the "entry cliff", down the main streets, to this wide expanse in front of the Ziggurat itself. A parade ground, perhaps, but Adora noted that it was a fantastic area for archers to cull an invading army - no cover, just a hundred paces of open ground.

The Ziggurat itself looked pretty impenetrable, with no openings at the base, only balconies higher up. One would need ladders and grapnels to get an army in if one did not take the main door.

The blonde warrior smirked and nodded at a pair of Magicat soldiers who marched past them on another gravel path. Around them, to the sides of the palace, the grounds were more like ornate gardens. She smirked over at Kyle, "It is a *brilliant* idea. Because no one will consider it!"

Kyle groaned and face palmed, "My Chief, are you *sure* the incredibly agile, hyper aware *vampires* havent considered"…

Adora tutted and folded her arms. The pair were dressed casually, stripped of their armour and it britches, vests and belts only. Adora had left her sword with Duncan after their troupe had been escorted to their accommodation - a barrack block *outside* of the walls around the Ziggurat. They had all recognised the implied insult, especially given the elaborate and mocking flourishes given by Cyrus - the pompous Magicat Captain who had "welcomed" them.

"Consider the city , consider the surroundings. Consider the Magicats."Adora' s voice was cool, composed and low, as if imparting a secret. Kyle's eyebrows furrowed and he looked about, studying the ornate statues and gravel pathways that skirted around the palace. Trees werent present, but large fungal growths that *looked* like trees abounded;grassy fronds of some sort of moss made up small, manicured lawns that divided the paths, along with strange bushes of red-leaved plants.

"I am considering, Adora. I am not seeing."

"Pah, and I thought you observant, Skald. Though considering how long Lonnie and Roge had to pursue you, perhaps I should not be surprised," she grinned and thumped the young man's shoulder, then gestured, "The guards are frilly and bejeweled. They are crisp and full of discipline... In marching. In being seeing. Watch."

Kyle watched as another pair of soldiers made the rounds. They were in lockstep, halberds held against their shoulders, eyes fixed ahead. Their heads moved side to side as they marched, both in rhythm. Neither responded to Adora's friendly wave. Kyle blinked.

"They're...parading?"

"They are parading. And what do soldiers do when all frilly and parading?"

"Make sure they don't make a mistake," Kyle murmured. Adora nodded, then pointed up. Kyle followed her finger and he regarded the ziggurat. He frowned, "No guards."

"Because they feel safe. This show of weaponry , the layers and soldiery seen to get beneath the earth. They are safe here. They are secure, confident. Oh there will be guards within - but we both know how attentive guards *actually* are. Especially after *years* of routine, of boredom."

Kyle looked at her and murmured, "Still"…

Adora shrugged, "And what if? I will come up with a story , a tale to disarm the suspicion! And Catra will be happy!"

That drew a snort from Kyle, "Not if you get *stabbed* . I do NOT wish to explain to her that you got stabbed looking for some stolen kiss. I doubt she would be…kind."

"Psh, as if she would harm a hair . She is a kind and gentle soul!" Adora scoffed. Kyle stared at her.

"The Princess. About this tall?" Kyle waved a hand at Catra-height, "Wears black armour, ran into a fight against a horde of undead because she thought you were *hurt* and drinks blood. Oh! And she stabbed you! THAT Catra?"

"Yes."

Kyle nodded and shrugged, "Well she did propose in the proper way, so yes I see. She is a very considerate soul," The pair nodded, then Kyle threw up his hands with a *gah* , "Fine, I will stand here as your watch while you go make moon-eyes at the Princess. And I thought I was the romantic one."

Adora grinned, then turned and dashed for the wall of the Ziggurat.

One would indeed need grapnels and ladders to scale such a thing. Or, perhaps, very sharp claws.

The blonde launched herself up and found purchase in the fine cracks between the basalt blocks. She hauled herself up, hand over hand, the toes of her boots finding bare purchase where she could, until she kicked them off with a hiss of frustration. At about fifty feet up she was forced to swing behind the ornate pillar that bordered a balcony as a guard marched neatly out. The man huffed, scratched at his nose while his tail twitched, before he spun and marched back inside. Adora chuckled to herself and continued the climb.

Her hands were halfway between human and wolven, as she dug into cracks and stone, pulling up with ease. She pushed and leapt between holds, to balcony after distant balcony. After about ten minutes she paused, one hand clinging to the stone, to turn and stare out over the city. She smiled and shook her head, "A wonder ."

She took a moment to sniff the air and frowned as a pair of scents intermingled. A low growl rippled in her throat and she began to climb faster. A moment later, with a huff of effort, she tumbled over the balustrade of a wide balcony, high up the side of the vast palace. Her shirt stuck to her she heaved a breath as she bent over to draw breath.

"Adora?" came the hiss of a shocked voice. Adora straightened suddenly and flailed as she reached for the balustrade, then managed to recover to lean nonchalantly against it.

"Ah hA!Y es, um, hello Sjelevenn. Um, hello."

A feline form pushed past the thin drapes between the balcony and the room beyond. Adora had to swallow as blue and gold eyes regarded her with mingled shock and amusement. Catra was wearing a thin set of night-wear - pants and a shirt by the looks of it, "What are you *doing*"?

"Um, leaning," Adora grinned at the Magicat. Catra groaned and shook her head, before she smiled and beckoned to the blonde.

"diot. W ell, come on then. Since you made the trip. I do have a *door*."

"And my chances of getting through it"?

Catra mused for a moment and shrugged, "Depends how determined you were I suppose."

"Ah, expecting me to commit a slaughter to see you"? She smirked at the woman as she followed her into the rooms. She paused as

she took in the couches and food.

Catra chuckled, "Well, I do like someone who *commits*," she paused and turned, fiddling with the hem of her shirt, "So... why are you... here?"

Adora smiled softly, "Is that not obvious, *sjelevenn?* To see you. It might not be *proper*, but... I could not be parted from you. It hurts," she shrugged and winced, "That may seem weak to..."

Her words were silenced as Catra practically pounced across the room. She grabbed Adora's shirt and yanked her down for a kiss. They were lost for a moment, with nothing but the guttering of torchlight and the gentle breeze ruffling the drapes, until they broke apart, foreheads pressed together. Catra smirked, "Shut up."

Adora chuckled and trailed a hand along Catra's jaw. Her nose twitched and she leaned back a bit, then arched an eyebrow, "You have had... company?"

Catra cocked her head, then watched Adora for a moment. She blinked then grinned as realisation dawned, "You can smell Dee..." she almost sounded as if she were talking to herself, "I was going to try to warn... but you can *smell* them."

The blonde quirked an eyebrow, "The changeling. Please, explain." she folded her arms and Catra blinked again, her tail twitching from

side to side. Her smile became coy.

"Are you jealous?"

Adora's growl was low and Catra shivered. The blonde inhaled slowly and she nodded, curtly, "I wish to be blunt. And I hope you are so with me as well," her voice was tinged with something else - a little bit of hurt. Catra scoffed.

"Adora, we have know each other a few days." She drew herself up and met Adora's eyes, "Have I not been forthright?"

The blonde cocked her head and nodded, "Aside from this… wedding."

Catra barked a laugh, "Something that was, apparently , arranged at *birth* and then barely mentioned. Honestly, I'm surprised the Hegemony have *tried* . But" she chewed her lip then nodded, "It is rather nice to see that you care."

The warrior woman frowned, "Have I given you cause to doubt? If so, then I will remove myself from your presence and we can simpli-"

Catra was in Adora's personal space in an instant, "Don't. Y ou. Dare." She blinked as Adora' s face twitched into a smirk, "Oh you…

you *sneaky* ."

"It would appear that you *do* like me. How embarrassing for one of rank to be attracted to a mere barbarian, hmmm?"

Catra snorted and shoved at Adora, then clutched her shirt. She sighed, "Dee is or was a *comrade* . I do not use the word friend. We were"…

"Whatever you were is the past," murmured Adora as she clasped Catra's hand, "What you are *now* is what matters. Speak plainly, love."

Catra pulled the blonde to the couches and sat with her, still clutching Adora's hand, "Dee and I, we fought together , scouted the Horde together, many years ago. It was part of my experiences, as I became the warrior I am. I wanted more than to just be some ruler-on-high. I needed to know the world, to be able to rule my part of it. But we were close. Dee is a mercenary, cast out from the Fae lands. They make good coin with the bands of the desert tribes and the Hegemony. They're good enough to even blend in with Horde advances. Invaluable."

"A useful ally to have. But they are with the Hegemony ," Adora prompted. Catra nodded.

"They want me, badly , it seems. And my mother she seems to want it too. Or at least maybe she does," she huf fed and squeeze d

Adora's hand. When her gaze rose to meet the blonde's, Adora's heart almost broke, for the look of confused despair in there, "Adora, if this is the sort of decision I must make when ruling, I do not know if I can do it."

The blonde pulled Catra up and into her lap, "Leadership is hard. The battlefield is no more forgiving - commit troops here, knowing they may die, recall more there, knowing you might lose a village… all things carry risk. Tell me, all, *sjelevenn."*

Catra exhaled and curled up against Adora, listening to the strong beat of the warrior woman's heart. She recounted the meeting with her mother, then the visit by Dee. She clung to Adora and calmed as Adora's hand tracked down her back.

"And that's where we are. A choice. The obvious political one against against the one I want to make."

Adora was silent for a moment, then nodded, "The *right* decision is for me to pledge my blade. For you to marry this." Adora's breathing became ragged for a moment, "Scorpia. But what then, Catra? What next? Say you drive the Horde away, what then? Does your home fall under them? Do they become your Kingdom? What of your heirs?"

Catra stiffed and her claws unsheathed, digging into Adora's skin, piercing the thing cloth of the woman's vest. Adora didnt move, "I…

"And when you rule...will your mother leave a list of chores? A guide on what she expects for *your* tenure?" Adora's voice was soft, gentle, "Does she do this when you lead troops in the field?"

"!" Catra hissed and tried to rear back, but Adora's hands held her in place. The blonde stared at her and Catra's throat rumbled with a feline growl of her own, "I am my own woman and how d-"

Adora leaned forwards, her blue eyes fixed on Catra's own mixed gaze, "Will you rule in the shadow of their desires? Will your people be controlled by the legacy of dead men and women? If you chose, make it *your* choice," Adora swallowed, her grip tightening, "I will abide. You are my *sjelevenn* . To disobey you would be to disobey my own soul."

Catra retracted her claws and sniffled, she leaned forwards and pressed a kiss to Adora's mouth. Tears ran free and she shuddered. Adora absently guided her to one of the wounds and Catra licked at the blood there, murmuring in relaxed contentment. They sat here for a moment, before Catra pulled back a bit, a frown on her face, "Wait"...

Adora cocked her head, "Yes?"

"Why would Dee be so...enthusiastic? They were very forceful, pushing the joys of *harem* life. That rankled."

"This *Scorpia* would stick you in a *harem* ," Adora actually stood up and Catra yelped a little adjusting until she was basically wrapped around the blonde. The pair faltered at the sudden movement and Adora snorted. Catra giggled as well, then wriggled a little, trailing a finger along Adora's jaw .

"Well, let's say that would NOT be a preference. Mother implied I would be...more influential but...I am not convinced," Adora moved around the couch and headed towards the bed. Catra glanced over her shoulder and smirked at the blonde, "Oh? *Somebody* is confident."

"Should I not be?" Adora grinned.

"And why are you so confident?"

"Because I believe I know your choice. And that you were forthright and honest with me."

"So if you know my choice, what then is the *real* dilemma?" Catra purred.

"That there are games in play , that you are being pushed. Tested, like you have said has happened before. That the Hegemony is looking to sow mistrust and confusion from the shadows."

"That alone makes me *not* want to be involved," Catra wrinkled her nose, "Espionage has its place, but for this, nope, not a wise move on Dee's part."

Adora reached the bed, then knee walked to the middle, before she laid Catra down upon it. She shuffled atop the smaller woman, caging her in with her arms. Catra reached up and untangled the blonde hair from its braid with a few deft flicks of her hands, allowing the golden locks to fall free.

"So you think they will try more subterfuge?" Adora murmured as she leaned down to nuzzle and nip at Catra's jaw.

"Count on it. And I am sure they, *ah*, have allies in court. The Hegemony, *uhhh*, expands by the smile as much as," she cooed as she felt one of Adora's hands slide into her pants, "As...as th-...the swoooo..ord."

Adora chuckled as Catra let out a whimpered exhalation. She drew her hand back up and stared down at the Magicat as she sucked her fingers clean, "Delectable. And a bed is so much nicer than a forest floor, yes?"

"Anywhere. As long as...it's with you."

Adora growled low again, but this was a noise of contentment, "My *sjelevenn*."

"Yes," Catra reached up to tug Adora down, but the blonde smirked and held her back with a palm, which elicited a hiss from Catra.

"Your dilemma is how do we ensure *this* happens whilst keeping the Hegemony away, correct?"

Catra stared up at Adora and cocked an eyebrow, "You are not concerned about my mothers?"

Adora shrugged then leaned down. Her free hand slid up and gripped Catra's jaw gently. She tilted the Magicat's face away to nip at her throat, then suckled against it. Catra bucked and Adora flattened herself against the woman.

"Clothes. Off. NOW!" Catra hissed. There was a blur as the pair practically tore their garments off.

Adora chcukled as she shuffled down the bed, then pressed Catra's legs up, "You wish to know my opinion of your mothers?"

Catra was about to snap back when Adora decided to use that moment to go to work and all that came out of her throat was a yowl of pleasure. Catra bucked and writhed as Adora held her in place while she feasted, bringing Catra to a yelping, spasming release.

The blonde slid back up the bed, a smug grin on her face, which Catra promptly kissed away, "Do not mention my mother 's while we"…

"I did not say anything, twas you who" Adora gasped as Catra grinned, while the feline's hand dove down to Adora's core. The blonde actually *yipped* in surprise, which drew a breathy chuckle from Catra.

"Oh more of *that* I think"…

In moments Adora was on her back, hands clutching at Catra's shoulders. Her abs were taut and clenched, her collar red with exertion as she gasped and panted through an orgasm, which culminated in a broken, choked back howl. She spasmed again, then flopped bonelessly back onto the bed, a goofy smile on her face. Catra loomed above her and smirked Adora chuckled, "Goes for the weakspot."

"Of course. And I believe we need to plan…because I want to hear that without you having to hold back" she leaned down and kissed Adora who wrapped Catra in her arms.

"Y es, a plan. But we know not what our opponents are thinking."

Catra shrugged, "I think. I think we need to ensure my mothers are *supportive* . That will forestall any major objections," she sighed as she rested her chin on Adora's chest. The blonde adjusted herself on the pillows to look down at the Princess and smiled softly.

"But beyond that, we remain flexible?"

Catra nodded, "I get the impression they do not see you as more than a frustration. And the Hegemony sees things like that as *removable* . So, they will try to dismiss you, force you to make a deal *or* remove you," her eyes fixed on Adora, "They can't do the first, as they haven't the power , you know they won't manage the second. So, that leaves the *third* ."

Adora nodded slowly, "It will just be the manner in which they choose to do it. Will your former comrade attempt an assassination?"

"Perhaps if they had not revealed themselves. But I think they know my mothers are at least *aware* of them. They may attempt something in court - try to bait you, force you to do something that would get you expelled from the city. Once Dee managed to have a diplomat and his guards imprisoned by faking a murder," she grimaced, "But there is the risk I would expose them and call the plan into question. Too risky."

"They will expect you to choose the Hegemony once we are gone, essentially," mused Adora. Catra nodded and stared up at the blonde.

"Because they do not understand," she frowned and became thoughtful for a moment, "But..perhaps, maybe..I think I do need to speak with Scorpia," she reached up and stroked at Adora's hair, "Ah! No need to be jealous… *sjelevenn*."

Adora's breath stuttered, "Catra," she breathed, "You do not"…

"I do," purred the Princess. She rose up and crawled to straddle Adora, "Because you are. And I am yours. We *will* be bonded. You are right, annoying as that is," she huffed in mock frustration, "But I must choose for myself. To compromise that leads..it leads to many other half choices until I become chained by my decisions in a dissatisfied prison. I will lead my people as *I* see fit, taking from my mother's wisdom along with my own. And I should have said from the start - I KNOW what you and yours can do. And I know where you reside," she drew Adora's hand up and pressed it to her breast, "Here. Moons know how, but you are here. So fast, so soon. It scares me, Adora."

The blonde pulled the magicat down into an embrace, "And you know not my fear walking up that beach and seeing you for that first time. I almost fell into the surf."

Catra giggled as she nuzzled the muscular warrior, "Really? All I saw was some warrior human walking from a longship like she owned the land! I kind of wanted to dislike you."

"I am very glad you do not," Adora whispered. She pushed Catra up a bit so their eyes could meet, "I love you. I know these words are laden and deep and our hearts have not known one another as long as our souls. But I do. And I would do as you desire."

Catra smiled, "And that's why the choice was so easy. Of everyone, you were the only one who didn't offer a dire choice, an ultimatum. You made it about *me*. You chose me, rather than making me choose. Well, you *made* me choose," she huffed and shook her head, "But you offered to support me. Not bribe me, not cajole. Just." Adora shrugged and looked away, but Catra drew her face back with a fingertip, "AND you didn't barge in here all bluster and accusing me when you knew about Dee. You asked."

Adora just shrugged, "I assumed you would tell me if you had… bedded another. I would have been displeased but it would have been an answer in itself. I trust you to be honest."

"Why? I wasn't exactly open when we first met," Catra asked, her gaze flat. Adora chuckled.

"Back then, I was just some mercenary. I understood. But now, now we know one another. I know you would not lie. And well, I have to trust that you won't."

Catra shook her head in wonder, "Some would call you naive."

Adora just grinned, "A fool, perhaps. But that is where love lives, in trust. Any alliance, relationship, friendship or whatever, any of those built on a lie or a falsehood or trickery will unravel. It is like the rot in a barrel of apples - it seeps and erodes at all. So, I must trust."

The Magicat snorted, then rocked her hips, "Well, how can a girl not fall for that, hm?"

Adora grinned, and pulled her back down with a whispered, "Again?"

"For as long as I have you"…

Kyle jolted with surprise as Adora slid down the wall next to him. He sniffed the air and then wrinkled his nose, "Wow."

"I know," Adora grinned and practically bounced on the balls of her feet, "So, where are my boots? We must talk with Duncan. The Princess and I have been talking"…

"Mhmhmm."

"...T ALKING and well, we think we have an idea of what the Hegemony will try. And how we might win favour with the Queens. Come, back to the barracks."

"T wo hours to talk.some speech," murmured Kyle. He smirked, "Oh, Adora?"

The blonde paused, hopping as she pulled one boot on, "Y es?"

"Y our shirt. It's on backwards. And it's a size too small."

Across the palace, in sumptuous quarters, Dee lounged on an ornate chaise and popped another grape into their mouth, "So, it would appear that our little Kitten is rather besotted."

"Gah, easily remedied," Lashor hunched near a wooden table covered in glass decanters. He hefted one that contained a greenish liquid, then pulled the stopper and poured a generous measure into a metal goblet, "Moonstruck whelp, Scorpia will persuade her ."

"Y ou really dont understand them do you?" mused Dee as they regarded the reptile, "Scorpia is… *overbearing* in the extreme. Dont get me wrong, she is *fabulous* to have on the back of a chariot as you wheel her through streets to the adoring *populi* , much like her mothers, but really? The woman couldnt persuade a bee onto a flower."

"You underestimate her. She charmed the Plumerians," sneered Lashor. Dee scoffed.

"Perfuma is no fool. And it doesn't hurt that she was already besotted. And what *choice* did they really have? The rest of the harem are, well, happily ensconced, but hardly needed persuading - a life as some forgotten sixth daughter, or a life of luxury in a palace, with a charming bit of sugared-dates in the form of a Princess that you have to keep entertained now and then?"

Lashor grumbled, "I see your point. The Princess is a different breed."

"A long lived one, too. Have you and yours factored that in? Did the Empresses consider the impact?"

The lizard-man snorted, "It was raised as a *concern* . But the benefit of annexing Halfmoon is seen as the better opportunity. Of course the Empresses don't see it that way - they just see it as formulating an alliance. The rest of us know better."

Dee reached over and plucked a thin glass from a nearby table and swirled the contents, "Either way , we must first remove the main obstacle. Scorpia can do her best at seduction, but I think we will need to offer more incentive to the princess. She needs a *reason* to ally with us. The threat of the Horde is there, but not *enough* .

Even with the Hegemony, is victory a done thing? What more can a marriage bring? These are questions we do not have an answer for."

Lashor paced again and tipped the goblet back. Liquid slipped from the corner of his mouth and his long tongue snaked out to lap at it, slathering his jaw with slimy saliva, "Yes, well, we *were* worried that the Fae would try something, but that fell through. Thank the sands that the fairy-girl seems to despise the Princess. Unlike a recent war that needed a more *thorough* alliance to cement peace at least," the lizard mused and shook his head, "And we do not want to start a war with Halfmoon just to secure a marriage."

Dee smirked, "Not one with *us* at least, hmm?"

Lashor glanced at the changeling and then grinned, "Ahhh, two beetles with one rock, yes?"

"You read my mind. I swear, Tong, you are a master," Dee cooed. Lashor snorted.

"That silver tongue will get you in trouble Dee. So sharp it may cut your own throat. So, aside from your *failure* to persuade the woman, your observations of the barbarians has given you enough insight to...what? Hire them away, to cause a ruckus, to force the hand of the Princess?"

"Oh not quite," mused Dee, "But... they are competitive. W ealth driven. *Ambitious* . We can use that. They seem to have no strategic sense," Dee smirked, "Though I think they knew they were being spied on by a different serving girl. Kept trying it on with some poor acting and talking in that ugly language of theirs."

"Save the moralising. What is your scheme? W e must secure this partnership."

Dee arched an eyebrow, then brushed their long blonde hair over their shoulder. A sinuous tail flicked out and coiled over their legs, "I did wonder why this is *so* urgent."

Lashor grunted and swigged from the goblet once more, "Partly S*corpia* ... wanted a new toy to play with. And partly... necessity . Halfmoon is a danger and that is all you need concern yourself with."

"An unsecured flank and a potential withdrawal point should the Horde start making more gains, hmm? What better place than an underground city to retreat to, yes?" Dee smirked, "Not hard to guess."

A knock at the door to the suite drew their attention. The door creaked open and a pink-skinned orc leaned in, "Y our eminence," she grunted, "A palace of ficial wishes to speak with you."

Lashor smirked, "Send them in, Captain Huntara."

"By your command," grunted the woman as she stepped aside. There was the clank of armour as a Magicat in a gilded uniform stepped over the threshold, his plumed helm held under one arm. Lashor's grin widened and he glanced at Dee who smirked and nodded.

"General Cyrus, a pleasure. A pleasure. Thank you for gracing us with your presence," fawned the reptile. The Magicat offered a polite smile, then glanced at Dee. He cocked his head.

"I see you are here. The rumours are true then."

"Of course. Won't you join us?" cooed Dee, "I do believe we have things to discuss. And a mutual worry to remove."

"Oh?" Cyrus nodded and accepted a goblet from a serving girl, one of the Hegemony staff who stood at the periphery of the room. The girl's collar clinked, as the faint chains that spiralled from it down her arms, pulled a little tight. Cyrus barely spared the woman a glance. Lashor smirked.

"You may have another… *drink* of choice later. As usual." His toothy smile widened as Cyrus twitched and nodded, almost imperceptibly, "And we brought the spices, as well, should you wish for certain flavours. It is always a pleasure to entertain."

Cyrus sat on a free couch and huffed, "Yes, well, your visits are always appreciated. And your hospitality on my last trip was…most

welcome."

"Of course." Dee sipped at their glass, "But you are used to such luxury. An easy life?"

"It chafes. We should be fighting," huffed Cyrus, "Should be driving the enemy back."

"Your Princess feels the same," mused Dee. Lashor moved to sit on a single stool, designed to accommodate his tail.

"Indeed. Hence our desire for this alliance. For too long all have sat idle, happy to just maintain the borders. We had hoped this would be a simple thing, to give the Princess the resources she would need to finally unite our armies, to drive them back." Lashor's voice was sugary with cloying disappointment. He sighed, "But things are complicated. I wish not to speak ill of the Queens, but the Hegemony is...worried. We are worried that Halfmoon is static, unwilling to involve itself, while others bear the burden."

Cyrus glared at the two others and swigged at his drink, "I *know*, Lashor. That was my entreaty to the Queens after our last delegation to your lands. But you talk of *mutual* worries. The Queens are"...

"The Queens are...set in their ways. New leadership could be needed, but I understand that is a *Halfmoon* decision. This is why we

had hoped for the Princess to be more enthusiastic. But it seems there are complications."

Cyrus glared at the envoy, "An understatement. We can agree that a closer alliance and a more proactive action against the Horde is in *everyone's* long term goals. But we are stymied. Many of the guard ponder at the wisdom of hiding. They support our Princesses continued urging for proactive action."

Dee swung their legs from the chaise, only to lean back with their arms spread along its back, "Oh? I think the solution is simple then."

That got a laugh from the Magicat, "So simple? I doubt it."

"Oh so so simple, my dear friend," cooed Dee, "A little two step - remove the blonde buffoon and then," they flourished with a grin, "Make Catra Queen."

Chapter End Notes

Angst in this will NOT be interpersonal between our two girls. They are just... well, y'know when you KNOW?

They KNOW.

It's the other idiots who try to get in the way who may have issues.

Chapter 11

Chapter Summary

Discussion, dinner and a dance.

Things begin to pick up speed.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra adjusted her tunic as she regarded herself in the mirror in her chambers. The myth that vampires cast no reflection was just that: a myth. Mostly. There were issues with certain herbs, silver was *very* effective on them (And silver backed mirrors did NOT grant a reflection), while the sun was definitely a lethargy inducing orb of annoyance.

But other things were superstition and old wives tales - faith being able to repel a vampire, for example. Or the need to reside in a coffin, or crypt. Catra wondered about *that* however - she certainly slept better in Halfmoon than on the surface, but she wondered how much that was to do with it being the 'soil of home' compared to camp beds just being ridiculously uncomfortable.

She had opted for britches, a scarlet shirt and a tunic over the top, with a slim brown belt. She had her hair done into a messy ponytail and smirked at her reflection, then checked her neck again for marks, nodding with satisfaction as she found one on her collarbone.

"That will do."

She turned and plucked a simple dagger from her dressed and slid it into a loop on her belt, then headed for the door. It swung open and she nodded to the two new guards on duty, then strode down the corridor. The two sputtered, then jogged to catch up. One said, "Ma'am you havent been sent f-"

She whirled on him, claws extended, a thin smile on her face, "Oh my, mother, you look so different." The man swallowed and his whiskers twitched. His companion clattered to a halt, the ceremonial tabbard her wore swirling as he skidded to a stop. The silver crescent of the City's crest glittered in the green torchlight. Catra glanced at the man and cocked her head, "Doesnt mother look different?"

"Y our highness?" asked the guard who *lacked* Catra's clawed hand poised at his face.

"I mean, only my mother would stop me *directly*, right? A guard wouldnt *presume to halt* the heir to the throne? Especially during such delicate times? Especially when said guard might consider the consequences down the line? I mean, what if that heir... held grudges?"

Her gaze flicked back to the closer guard who blinked rapidly, "Y... your highness, we had orders to"…

"To escort me, should I be *summoned* . Did you have orders to *detain me* ? Because if you did, well. I have a bad history with people who try to restrict me. Or control me. Or just annoy me. And my *fiancee* would probably feel perturbed."

The other guard snorted, "The Hegemony wouldn't *dare."*

Catra laughed and drew her hand back. Her laugh escalated and she shook her head as she cackled. The two guards exchanged confused looks while Catra just shook her head, and wheezed out, "Oh. oh you idiots. Oh wow , thank you. You just fall in line and *escort* me," her face switched from mirth to a glare, "But don't try to stop me again. Unless you want to be reallocated to *border patrol* ."

"Yes your highness, I mean, um, NO of course not your highness!" babbled the nearer guard. His counterpart nodded rapidly. Catra smiled.

"Great. Now , I have an appointment."

The walk through the corridors that bordered the grand atrium at the center of the Ziggurat was a short one. Catra passed by a few servants, some of whom stared at her wistfully. Catra had tried to keep her liaisons relatively quiet and *out* of the city during her life, but sometimes things happened. It was interesting to her that the thought of even just feeding off of them felt *wrong* . Truth told, Adora had sated more than her desires the night before - her hunger had abated, which seemed to be the case *every* time she fed from the she-wolf. It was a pleasing thought.

She headed towards Cyra' s study, dismissing the two soldiers as they neared the door. The men grimaced and Catra sighed, "Y ou may remain *outside* . Whether you are *required* after that remains to be seen."

"As you wish, your highness," Murmured the pair . Catra nodded, then regarded the other two guards stationed at the study door. She snorted, then pushed the door open, noting that the guards *had* flinched, perhaps intending to stop her - but had clearly thought better of it.

Catra was unsurprised to find Cyra at the desk, scribbling away at a parchment. Likely as not, the woman had probably not moved since the day before. Catra folded her arms and stared at her mother, who keot her eyes focused on the parchment in front of her. She did, however, smirk.

"Are you just going to glower at me dear , or are you here with a purpose?"

"And good evening to you too, mother ."

Cyra sighed, then placed the quill down. She folded her hands and regarded her daughter with a faint smile, "Good evening. Sleep well?"

“So well,” Catra stared her mother down, “I believe I have arrived at a conclusion. Nearly . My *own* .”

Cyra positively beamed, “Wonderful. But before you finalise whatever that choice is, have you spoken with…?”

“The Princess? I will be speaking with her ,” Catra narrowed her eyes and Cyra nodded absently .

“Good. good. Though I would ask you perhaps defer such a conversation until later.”

“Are you well mother? You weren't awake all day?” Catra huffed.

Cyra just chuckled, “Melendy did manage to drag me to bed. I can be persuaded!”

“I do not need to know!” Catra hissed with a wince. Cyra grinned and leaned back. She gestured to a desk across the study where a cloth was draped over something. Faint mumbles could be heard from beneath the cloth.

“Your former tutor was most informative. As is your mercenary… friend.”

Catra bristled, but bit her tongue, "I am sure."

Cyra studied her daughter for a moment and nodded slowly, then plucked her quill up again, "There is much to finalise. However, we are arranging a banquet for our guests. It will take place today. The necessary orders have been issued as it was arranged before your return. Please be on your best behaviour, and ensure our guests are hosted appropriately, please."

The Princess sighed, but honestly she had expected *some* pomp. Dinners and entertainment were a diplomatic tool after all. Too much to hope that the Hegemony would just pack up and go. She tilted her head, "I take it you wish for me to speak with Scorpia *after* the dinner?"

"Indeed. I don't wish for her to sit there brimming with pre-marital excitement during the meal. We know how *exuberant* she is," Cyra steepled her fingers, her smirk not changing.

"And that is the topic I wish to raise with you, I want to be with Adora."

Cyra's expression didn't change, "Indeed?"

"Yes," Catra jutted her chin out. Silence fell. It last for a moment, then a moment longer. Cyra quirked an eyebrow. Catra's own furrowed.

Eventually the Queen sighed and leaned forwards, "Is this an act of stubbornness or *have* you considered the implications?" her voice wasn't hectoring or harsh, but soft, curious. Catra sighed.

"Yes, mother."

"All of them? The fallout with the Hegemony, the potential impact of foreign unknowns taking a position of power?..."

Catra smiled, "I think you will see that any impact the Hegemony might have is negligible. Adora's people are tenacious."

Cyra studied her daughter and tilted her own head, a motion Catra had adopted after years of mimickry, "I understand. Love is... is beautiful. I was so fortunate with Melendy. I do not say that often enough. To you or her, my child. So, I would ask that we... manage this. Do not spurn Scorpia, not yet. I recognise the military *potential* of these Sea-farer folk. But I do not know if they are worthy of your hand. For the long term, I mean. I *know* you have had daliances before and they were just as bright. I do not doubt your feelings, but as I have said, your decisions as a ruler"...

"Will be *mine* to make. And mine to live with," Catra retorted, her voice sharp. Her tail swished back and forth. Cyra sighed.

"If only it were thus. Your decisions will ripple. You will be loathed and hated one moment, loved the next. Will you always choose the path for *love*? Regardless of the impact? Is *your* love enough to save this city? I have sacrificed, my darling. I have. But I will respect your final choice. To that end, please ensure you at least give Scorpia a chance? So you *know*."

Catra glared at her mother and sighed, "I know she."…

"You last saw her eight years ago. Much changes in time, Catra. If you want my blessing, I need to know that this. Adora is what she claims to be: a warrior without peer; a leader of a force *worthy* of your hand; and that she is *trustworthy*. She may care for you, but what of our people? I need to know that if I am to give a cold shoulder to our *long time allies*, that I have the concessions ready, to ensure we do not lose friends. So, this I ask of you: do not spurn her before the banquet, speak with her. Hear her out."

The princess tilted her head back and let out a sigh, "Alright, fine. I will *speak* with her. And I will be the gracious hostess. But be careful about whatever game you are playing, mother. I know you want it *all*," her voice dropped a little, "Please do not use me to try to get it."

Cyra flinched at that and looked away, then nodded slowly, "This is why I am letting *you* play, Catra. I need you to understand the weight of all of this. If Melendy and I fall, it is on you to guide our people." The Queen rose and strode around her desk. She paused in front of Catra and reached out. She paused, however, "May I?"

Catra look up at her mother and gave a tiny nod. Cyra reached out and tilted Catra's chin up gently, then cupped her face. She smiled at her daughter and sighed, then pulled her into a hug. Catra purred briefly, the swish of her tail calming, before she pulled back. She shot her mother a frustrated glare, "You are"…

"Your mother. It is my duty to ensure you are safe, protected and provided for. And, if I can…ensure you are happy as well." She patted Catra's cheek, "So, that is all I ask. I know you will be your own Queen. But let a mother be a *little* protective."

With a sigh Catra nodded, but her shoulders were set, "I know my heart mother, but I will at least hear Scorpia out. I will see you later."

Catra let the door thud behind her then snorted as the four guards clattered to attention. She gestured to her escort, "You may go."

"Ma'am, General Cyrus"…

"It's weirdly enough, outranked by *me* . Do we need to reiterate the lesson?"

The two guards guarding the Queen's chambers chuckled and Catra grinned. Her former escorts just straightened up and practically bolted. She let out a breath, then headed towards the armoury. She really wanted to spend time with Adora, but had a feeling that it would exacerbate issues with the Hegemony, until they made their final decision. She also needed to keep an eye out for Dee - to see

whatever it was that they had planned. And, she realised, she also would have to spend a fair bit of time preparing for this banquet.

She allowed herself a private groan, then continued on - The armoury, a catchup with Pan so he could pass on a message, then a bath and then choosing whatever item was most likely to make Adora lose her mind. So it wouldnt be an entirely wasted day .

The night had worn on, Halfmoon operating like a hive. There was the constant echo of noise across the city - hawkers, merchants, blacksmiths - the usual clang of industry and people living their lives. Most of those people were also blood drinking cat-people, but it seemed an almost afterthought.

Dee lounged on their balcony and watched the city's glow. Lashor joined them and grunted, "What a pompous idiot."

"A kindred spirit then?"

The reptile looked at the changeling and snarled, "Mind your tongue, lest I pluck it out."

"Oh the flirting, however will I cope?" Dee smiled and raised their goblet, "A pompous idiot, but a useful one."

"T raitors always are. Revolutionary ones even more so. We are *fortunate* that he commands loyalty here. So many other upstarts in our other acquisitions were wasted. Farmers and idealists are useful until the swords are drawn. Give me an arrogant idiot with an army over an idealist with a quill," Lashor 's chuckle was a rasped hiss.

"All have their uses," mused Dee.

"but at the crux of things. A poet dies faster ."

"Y ou think hell follow through? W ont sell us out? A wful big risk."

Lashor looked at Dee askance, "This is your grand plan."

"ELEMENTS of it are my plan. Y ou're the one pushing for a more aggressive stance. My original idea was just to remove the Barbarians."

That drew a derisive snort from the hulking lizard. He adjusted the braid and the ermine cloak over his shoulders, "Already distancing yourself. Well, if this works, we have a Queen Catra in need of allies. You're sure you can get to the Queen?"

“Whichever one, or both, if they don’t take the bait. Cyrus isn’t happy, I know, but he will aid us in this. It will *guarantee* Catra has to find an ally. Weaken the Queen and we have a bargaining tool if our little Kitten is less than amenable. Then we just ship her to Scorpia’s little palace of delights, install Cyrus as Regent until we get a nice, safe Hegemony heir to pop in place. An ta-da, ready made fortress city for the Imperial household, a military camp, or whatever.”

Lashor sneered out at the city, “And the parasites will just have to make do.”

“Oh I’m sure they’ll eke out a living as we *reorganise* everything. Conscription, redistribution. Immortal, skilled killers are useful. We just need to persuade them where in the Hegemony they’d all be best suited.”

“And the Barbarians?”

“Oh they’re all fire and brimstone!” Dee made their voice gruff and mocking, “War! Blood! HONOUR! Honestly, I saw their type in the Wastes. Like those Northern idiots, all fur and ice and *battle*. Give them the scent of blood and the chance to prove themselves, they’ll leap at it. Especially with gold in the offering. Greed, dear Lashor, is the best thing to bait. Not *just* gold, but *glory*.”

Lashor grunted and nodded, then turned, “Be ready for the banquet. Keep hidden. Don’t want the barbarians getting curious about you.

Especially if Catra recognises you. We dont have the majority in this court on our side. This needs to be done *precisely* ."

"As if I give anything other than my *best* productions, Lashor dear," Dee sunk the last of their drink and placed it upon the balcony rail. They smirked and followed Lashor inside.

The banquet had been set up in the main throne chamber, transforming it from a grand, vacant space, into a cavalcade of colour and activity. The Royal family sat at a table at the base on the dais upon which the thrones were placed, horseshoe shaped, with the "points" leading away from the dais, with several other long tables arrayed at a right angle. The main contingent of the Hegemony sat on the edges of the Royal's table, while the Royal family occupied the "head", with their trusted Household members alongside them. Catra sat to Cyra's right, Melendy on Cyra's left. Cyrus sat beside Melendy, with other high ranking advisors spread along the length.

Scorpia was, of course, in the middle of her own table, closest to Catra's side. The opposite table, however, *also* seemed to be filled with dignitaries from the Hegemony, along with other delegates from *other* small holdings. Catra pursed her lips and sighed. Scorpia waved at her excitedly, while the blonde waif at her side mooned over the buff Princess, "Hey HEY Wildcat! WILDCAT! Isnt this amazing! I am so honoured, this.. thank you!"

The woman was beaming, clearly reading a *lot* into the meal. Catra had to smile thinly in return.

She had expected this. Another *game* . Or a snub. She looked to her mother and smiled faintly, who looked about to rise as a few other guests were settling into the main tables, "Forgetting anyone, mother?"

She noticed that Melendy had a rather resigned expression on her dark-furred face. Cyra, on the other hand, just gave her an arched eyebrow, "I see everyone here that *I* invited to the banquet we had prepared weeks ago."

"The banquet you did not warn me about *prior* to my departure on the errand *you* sent me on?" Catra added drily . She took the goblet of wine proffered to her by a servant and sipped at the thick, red liquid within. It made her lip curl as it *lacked* something. There was a strange bitterness to the blood now, not as sweet as what she was growing accustomed to.

Cyra hummed happily , "Well, that was an error on my part. If you wish for changes, you should have clarified. Ask and you will received."

Catra smiled back and nodded, "Forgiveness or permission, mother?"

The Queen glanced at her , eyebrow raised. Her expression wasnt shocked, rather her smile was small and, perhaps, proud, "It depends on the action."

Catra shrugged and sipped at her wine as the main doors to the chamber thudded with heavy knocks. She raised her hand and gave a small wave. Catra watched as Pan detached from the guard contingent that stood at the fringes of the room. The man headed for the door with purpose and began to bark orders at the clearly-confused guards there - they thought the main doors were to remain closed.

The big, black doors swung inward to reveal a vision in white, red and gold.

Adora had her hands planted on her hips, her hair done into an immaculate braid down her back. A thick cloak hung over her shoulders, masking her shoulders, while her bare arms were on display. She wore a crown, now, a crest almost. The tiara was a golden piece, simple, with a pair of prongs that framed her face. It was almost red in the torchlight.

Her tunic was white, with a silver wolf's-head staring out. It looked almost like a star, a stylised impression of a wolf perhaps. A simple leather belt with a winged buckle was at her waist, with thick trousers and heavy boots on her feet.

She strode into the hall purposefully, a grin on her face. Behind her came her entourage. Gone were their travelling clothes;instead they wore colourful woollen tunics and vests. Duncan and a few others hauled a huge cauldron with them, while Kyle had a keg on one shoulder and what looked like a lyre in his off-hand.

The entire hall watched the small troupe enter. A dozen of the sea-farers, under the scrutiny of the court of Halfmoon and their allies. Adora tilted, taking it all in as her eyes scanned the room. She nodded slowly, then strode between the tables, straight towards the head table. Catra saw one of the Hegemony Orc guards move from near the end of their side of the table as if to intercept. Adora paused and stared at the hulking, pink-skinned man.

Her gaze then moved to the Queens, "My apologies. I had not realised the wedding had occurred!I see that the Hegemony now act as the guards for the Royal household?"

The blonde affected a dramatic bow, her arms splayed out. The Orc looked suddenly uncomfortable. The reptilian emissary, Lashor, growled and made emphatic gestures for the man to back off, "Captain Huntara, keep your piglets in line."

A larger Orc, standing behind the delegates huffed, then cuffed the belligerent guard as he returned to his post. Adora straightened and her eyebrow arched in mock surprise, "This is *not* a wedding feast? I am overjoyed I have not missed the occasion."

Catra almost facepalmed as she struggled to hide the grin on her face. Scorpia, however, looked on in consternation as she stared at the Sea-farer. Adora continued as she turned back to the Queens. Cyra had her elbows on the table, hands clasped together as she watched the woman with curiosity, "My lady Adora. A surprise to see you."

Adora grinned, "Ah I am sure it is not! After all, we are guests of your household and this is a banquet for guests. I am sure you would not snub visiting dignitaries who have travelled far. Who have come with palms open, no dagger within them. Your daughter, honourable and with care for the custom of hospitality, reminded me of this event, to ensure we were not poor guests and snubbed *you*!" she folded her arms and smirked, "I admit I am no scholar of your customs, your ways, but I know it would be *remiss* if I was to *avoid* such an auspicious event."

Catra had to also stop herself from rolling her eyes at how thickly Adora was laying it on with the words. Her gaze travelled to the other sea-farers, who had carried the cauldron to the space in front of the Royal table. It sloshed heavily as it was set down. Adora held a hand out and Duncan approached, placing a drinking horn into her grasp. The blonde turned and walked over to the cauldron and plunged the horn inside, scooping a generous measure of liquid up, which she then tipped back into her mouth. A moment later, as the stunned audience watched, she drained the horn, then dipped it back in. Her gaze fell on Catra and she approached the main table. Their eyes were locked as Adora paused in front of the three Royals. With a smirk she reached up and stabbed the pad of her thumb against the sharp end of the horn, which was tipped with a metal cap - a sharp one, too.

She then raised her thumb over the horn and let a couple of drops drip into the liquid, before she proffered the drink to Catra, "For the guest of honour. Your *highness* ."

Catra took the drink, maintaining eye contact with Adora, before she slugged it back.

It was sweet, and not just from the blood. Honeyed and rich, with a bitter undertone. There were hints of other flavours, almost like a beer, but it flowed like gold down her throat. The blood within made her tingle. She smiled as she handed the horn back to Adora. The court chamberlain baulked and made to move, but Adora had already stepped back to refill the horn, which she then offered to Cyra, "Your Majesty, I understand that the custom here is for Royalty to drink first. I apologise if I have overstepped but I wished to demonstrate that my offering comes with no ill intent."

The amber-furred Queen regarded Adora with her blue eyes, then took the goblet, "I take the gift in the manner it is intended. Welcome, Adora Moondaughter. I am afraid I have been remiss in not allowing for enough seating."

Adora shrugged as Kyle approached. The Skald placed the barrel down next to the blonde, directly opposite Catra and Adora sat down, after flapping her cloak clear. She gave Catra a grin and waggled her eyebrows a little, "It is quite alright. We are used to adapting."

Behind her, the other sea farmers had begun to dip more horns into the cauldron and were offering them to various guests, who looked utterly perplexed. Many watched as C'yra held her own horn. It was Melendy who huffed and snatched the item, "Stop posturing, you dramatic ninny," she glared at C'yra, smiled at Adora, then tipped the horn back. Lowering the horn, she smacked her lips and raised the horn, "W ell? Eat, drink! This is a banquet!"

Adora grinned and looked at Catra, "I like her!"

Melendy chuckled while C'yra huf fed, then leaned over her wife to offer the horn back, "A very dramatic entrance, dear . Clearly you intend to make an impression."

That drew a faint blush to the blonde's cheeks, "W ell I hope so. I love your daughter dearly."

Her frankness was clearly heard by many, including at the Hegemony table. Scorpia looked about ready to burn holes with her eyes, while Perfuma soothed her. A possible eruption was interrupted as various foods were carried out to the tables. Kyle, meanwhile, had wandered over to where some Magicat musicians were set up, their strange stringed instruments of great interest to him. He began to join them in their music and sang out a haunting song in the Sea-Farer tongue.

Adora closed her eyes for a moment and sighed, then looked to the Queens, "A song of hope and blessings upon a home. T o keep all

within it safe. Regardless, I wish this for all of you."

Duncan appeared by her side and took her empty horn, replacing it with a full one. A serving girl paused beside Catra, clearly confused. She carried a plate of small meats - considering the vampires didnt eat, but sparingly. Catra glanced over her shoulder and then gestured to Adora, "A full plate of meat please. For..for my *sjelevenn* ."

Adora's smile could have lit up a dark room, but she seemed to be restraining herself.

"My Queen, it feels...improper to have a dinner to honour our delegation only to be"..T..ong began to bluster, but Catra looked at him dead on.

"Ambassador , this is a dinner to honour *all* our guests. You are in pride of place and I have committed that I will speak with her Highness on the morrow. Fret not, I have every intention of coming to a reasoned decision."

The reptile met her gaze and nodded slowly . Catra's gaze lingered on a rather none-descript Scorponi guard at the side of the room. Adora saw her looking, but didnt follower gaze. She just shrugged.

More of the guests were drinking from the horns, while the Sea-farers had begun to swipe goblets and flagons, tipping their contents

on the floor, before scooping out more of the mead from the cauldron, which they gruffly offered back. A few of the delegates had tasters who insisted on *multiple* tastings - just to be sure. That won over many of the crowd.

Adora dug into the pile of meat she was handed, which was difficult to watch for some. Catra, however, beamed as the wolf-girl tore into meat-on-the-bone. Even the Queens seemed enthralled, albeit with mild elements of horror. Discussion kicked up as Duncan and the sea-farers circulated and began to talk with some of the lower-court: the merchants, the tradesmen of repute, alongside courtiers.

Adora stood and then turned to approach the Hegemony bench. Catra's eyes widened as the blonde gave a short bow to Scorpia.

The Scorponi princess seemed shocked. Adora straighted and nodded to the Ambassador, then to Perfuma, "I wished to apologise for my gruff introduction. I am sure, as someone who cares for Princess Catra, you can understand. I hope we can treat with one another in a decent manner."

Scorpia stared at the blonde and then huffed, "Will you withdraw your efforts to marry the Princess? Your clearly lofty ideas?"

"Only if she bids me so. My sword is hers."

The carapaced princess stared at Adora hard. Her stinger swayed behind her and she harrumphed, "I suppose we can…be civil. I accept your apology."

"Good! Please, share a drink."

"I would advise against that, My lady ," hissed T ong. Scorpia frowned. Adora just shrugged.

"Partake or not, the of fer is there. I hope we can part as friends. And not as anything else."

Adora's smile was pleasant but firm. She bowed again, then returned towards Catra. Cyrus chose that moment to stand. He adjusted the black tunic he wore, his own amber fur almost blending with it where it darkened, "My Queen? This is…I must protest."

Cyra glanced at the man and nodded, "General?"

"I acknowledge that these are guests of the Princess, with reputations among a small subset of the soldiery. But this feels… excessively permissive," he frowned at Adora, "I may be speaking out of turn but…I would seek to understand where such faith comes from."

Adora paused before she sat and stared at Cyrus. Her nose twitched a little and she drew in a breath before she continued past her barrel seat to stand in front of the man, the table between them. She towered over him and smiled down at him sweetly, "Please. If you could be clearer?"

"If I was intimidated by size, I would be a mewling ball long before now," he drawled. Adora shrugged.

"I am not one to judge a man or woman by their preferences." This drew a few chuckles along the table. Cyrus's smile became thin.

"Indeed. No, I think we need a *demonstration*."

Adora spread her arms, "But people are *eating*. No one wishes to see you disembowelled while that is happening."

The General's stare was flat, hostile, but he drew in a breath, "This is why I doubt the *usefulness* of what you claim to offer. An alliance, with people who belittle us, mock our customs, act as barbarians within our sacred *home*? Bluster is what I see. Boasting. Fantastic stories as if told by children of how they slew a thousand Horde."

Adora leaned on the table, "Indeed. It was only about five hundred, but you know how people embellish," her smirk seemed to be infuriating the General, but he took a deep breath, then looked to Catra.

"Your highness, I know you wish to take the fight to the Horde. The Hegemony gives us such an avenue, though I am loathe to admit it. I trust you, but if I am to entrust my men to the fight, if I am to look them in the eyes as I promise them allies, what can I say about…" he waved at Adora, "This? In a way that doesn't sound *derogatory* to the Royal house? I seek not to insult, but to explain."

Catra bristled, but Adora made a small motion with her hand to draw the General's attention back to her, "So, what do you suggest? You are right," he blinked in slight surprise, "A duel in here? Yes it shows what I can do. That I can kill a man. But you are right that it will not *persuade* . So, short of me killing *many* people here… what of it? And do I need to demonstrate this to all of your army? Or do you have to *persuade* your soldiers to fight?"

Adora stepped back and folded her arms. The General glowered, then tilted his chin up, "A demonstration *would* be useful. To more than just a Princess who is clearly biassed. And to a sun-drunk gathering of soldiers who did not see the battle in full flow. But… Something more. We need to see what you can do, against a force. You are raiders and barbarians with a single tale to your name. The Hegemony spans nations and territory, with armies to *spare* . Surely even *you* can see. My Queen?"

Scyra frowned up at the General, then supped at her blood-goblet, "This is hardly the *place* General."

"Forgive me, Majesty , but I feel it *is* . These tricks and performances are beguiling. But if I am to command, if *any* of your officers are to

command us into the sun, against the Horde. Please give us certainty? If only to face the families afterwards, to say we *knew* . I do not want my men to die because of… *boasting* ."

Adora met the General's gaze. She nodded slowly , then looked to the Queen, "He is right. Mostly . I am willing. We will rise to any challenge to prove our worth. You know of what he is suggesting?"

Cyra nodded slowly and stared at Cyrus, "A suggestion, earlier . We know of mercenary bands, of other forces. They have reputations. History. Yours is foggy . Unsure, old tales of visitors across the sea. Rumours. Catra is most impressed and that is impressive. And yet," she winced, then sighed, "V ery well. Cyrus, you prepare a contingent for the morrow. I will accompany you."

Catra startled, "Mother?"

"What? I rarely get out. And the chance to see Lady Moondaughter perform after all your praise? Who could say no," her smile was excited, "A few days to ensure she is not all bluster and we can set some of this to rest."

"Y our Majesty!" Lashor stood and coughed, "I is this wise? W e are in the midst of delicate negotiations! It is not my place, but I must raise a concern from the Hegemony's perspective. To be sidelined so!"

Cyra nodded with understanding, "I understand completely . Melendy will be handling that, as she has been. And this does give Princess Scorpia and Catra time to discuss as well, of course."

Scorpia sat up straighter and beamed, "Well that's a good outcome! But, your Majesty , are you sure? Can you trust these… newcomers?" she smiled apologetically at Adora, "You understand, right? I mean, this is my mother in law to be."

Adora waved a hand and coughed, "Oh, completely . Yes."

Catra looked between the conversationalists, brow furrowed, as things escalated. Cyrus looked pleased, but his brow was furrowed as he interjected, "I do object, your Majesty , to your presence. I feel that would justify a larger contingent to ensure your safety and"…

"Nonsense. You wanted this, it's happening. I will validate these claims *directly* . You may remain here, but please dispatch a representative commander of your choice, so you may feel assured that *I* am not unbiased in my old age."

Her tone was cutting and Cyrus flinched a little, "Of course, your Majesty , I did not wish to imply."

"But you did. About my daughter . Should I assume the same level of *disrespect* ?

“Well…

“General, I suggest you just continue your meal. We will discuss particulars *later*. Adora, thank you.”

Adora nodded, then gave Cyrus a short bow. She returned to her meal and gave Catra a wink. The Princess huffed and shook her head.

Later, the cauldron was moved and the tables pushed away to allow for dancing. As the music picked up, Catra found herself being twirled about the floor by an enthusiastic Scorpia who yammered about the *future* and possibilities, before Catra broke away and found herself being guided by a smiling Adora. She leaned down as the pair jigged to the vibrant music from Kyle and his new musician friends, “Quite the evening. Thank you for the warning.”

“Of course. Mother always does *something*.”

“And she seems more amenable.”

“Perhaps. You may have to impress her. This feels strange though.”

Adora nodded slowly, "I am no court politician...but be wary ."

Across the room, a Scorponi soldier leaned down to whisper into Lashor's ear, "And so the trap is set, darling."

Chapter End Notes

Oh the next part is going to be a DOOZY

Dee is super prepared for what is going to happen. So prepared. Totally ready. Yep.

Chapter 12

Chapter Summary

Adora goes on tour.

Scorpia and Catra have a diplomatic discussion.

The board is set.

It was surprising how quickly preparations went, considering. The banquet had wrapped up in a surprisingly positive fashion, with the Sea-farers leading a few of the more drunk members of the Halfmoon court into a jig. Adora had lounged, supping at her mead, while Catra had alternated between glad-handing the delegates and sprawling back in her throne to whisper happily to her mate.

Scorpia had gotten a dance, as well as a short conversation and that had seemed to placate the exuberant. Perfuma had even blushingly accepted a dance from the towering blonde Sea-farer, which had caused Scorpia to grimace, but the more diminutive blonde had been returned with a bow and an honest smile, which had seemed to leave the Scorponi Princess bemused. Perfuma, of course, was likewise confused, considering how jovial and friendly Adora was.

Cyrus had slipped away early, of course. Which probably explained why, as the court dispersed after several hours of revelry, that a contingent of soldiers was preparing in the main courtyard at the front of the ziggurat.

It was all *very* efficient, thought Catra. Admittedly she thought that with a mental eye roll.

Adora had parted from her at the main door to the palace, atop the stairs that led down to the main plaza. They'd clasped hands and then Adora had stepped back to bow low, "I fear this will be the last we see of each other until your mother is satisfied."

Catra arched an eyebrow, "You have a day. I'm sure you can take another walk around the gardens?" She arched an eyebrow and Adora chuckled, then glanced down to where a good fifty troops were preparing. She looked back at Catra.

"It seems that your General is in a rush?"

Catra nodded slowly, "Honestly, that surprised me. Cyrus has spent most of his time down here, but chafes about the war."

"A General from the rear, yes. They love the glory, but never really see the blood," Adora nodded.

"And I know he wants better relations with the Hegemony...but he also wants to win. I can't fault that. Moon and stars, we do agree on a few things. He is my cousin, pompous though he is."

"Oh, I thought there was a family resemblance that first time."… Adora hummed and Catra scoffed.

"Careful, or Ill lock my window ."

Adora frowned, "How do you lock a *curtain* ? I would just tear it open."

"Dont threaten me with an enjoyable event, Adora," Catra purred. The werewolf blinked and actually blushed. Catra exalted at that and smirked.

It was with a sigh that Adopra unclasped their hands, "I will…maybe take a walk. But I think your mother is eager. Should I be worried?"

Catra huffed at Adora's smirk and arched eyebrow, "You better not try to seduce my *mother* ."

"No, I fear Melendy would gut me. Possibly after you had finished kicking me into the sea," Adora chuckled, then tentatively reached forwards to brush a lock of Catra's hair back over her cheek, "You are my *sjelevenn* , to think of another is not within my heart. Even if she is a reminder of what you will look like when we are old and grey."

Catra chuckled but sighed, "When you are old and grey . I may not"…

Adora's scoff interrupted her and the werewolf grinned, "I have said before..we are not so dif ferent. I may age in a more distinguished manner though!" Adora' s voice took on a mock-aloof quality as she affected a serious expression, eyebrow arched. She couldnt hold it for long before her crooked grin returned, "For now , my thanks your Highness, for a wonderful evening."

And with another bow, Adora swept away down the stairs, her entourage falling in behind her, headed for their allotted barracks.

"She' s..Ne," came a slightly confused voice from next to Catra. The Princess turned to find Scorpia standing next to her. The Scorponi looked bemused, her brow furrowed. Catra nodded.

"She is an honourable and true woman."

Scorpia hummed, then looked at Catra again, "It' s late I know but… may we talk tomorrow? I know I've been well, a bit pushy and maybe that was a little *much* . What I mean today is, well," she huf fed, "It' s been so long and I had these ideas and I'd..can we talk?"

Catra stared at the Princess then nodded slowly, "I had planned on inviting you for a tour of the gardens. I think we do need to discuss many things."

The Scorponi's face broke out into a broad smile and she clasped her pincers together, "Oh that is...thank you, your Highness, you will *not* regret it."

The Halfmoon princess winced and sighed, then re-entered the palace. She walked through torchlit corridors, past the empty throne chamber, winding through until she reached her mother's study. A quick knock and she entered. Melendy and Cyra sat on a couch, clearly in the middle of an intense discussion. They paused as Catra entered.

It was an amusing tableau: the two Queens, in their royal regalia: Cyra's sleek blood red gown and Melendy's own silver one. The Princess fixed her parents with a stare, "Quite the plan. You intended to test Adora?"

"All of you, really. Cyrus is eager, for sure. I think he perhaps sees the value of your friends, given the emphatic reports from your men. He has an eye for opportunity, I will give him that. My own attendance is the fly in the ointment, but honestly, I need to know for myself. Too much is smoke and mirrors in this war."

The tawny-furred Queen sighed and slumped back into the couch. Melendy nestled closer to her and turned her amber eyes on Catra, "Your mother is taking a rather foolish risk, I fear."

"No disagreement here," replied Catra. Cyra just snorted.

"And now you see why we get so annoyed when you insisted on gallivanting out there!"

"You wanted me to!"

"Only to learn, not to *keep on*, useful though it is," Cyra massaged her temple, "I fear I drank too much. Moon and stars I havent had a headache like this in a while."

Melendy nodded and winced, "Same. Perhaps that mead is too much. Your friends are... exuberant, Catra."

The Princess scoffed, "Perhaps Im just used to it."

Melendy chuckled, "After, what, barely a week in their company? Carousing every night, hmm?" Her knowing smile made Catra cough and look away.

"I know you dont approve," she started to say, but was cut off as Melendy chuckled.

"Darling, we were far worse in our youth, before we found one another. I am hopeful," the black-furred Queen's eyes twinkled and Catra's brow furrowed.

"Hopeful for what?" her voice was slow and suspicious. Melendy shrugged.

"That the right one *wins*. If we insist on playing out this game," she nudged her wife and glared at her. Cyra just shrugged.

"We must know their heart as well as their ability. That is all I ask. A chance to observe for myself. You understand, daughter, do you not?"

Catra tried to glare at her mother but she couldn't quite muster it, "I do not *like* it but I believe I sort of understand it. I wish you would just...accept my word."

The Queens exchanged a glance and Melendy glowered. Cyra flinched a little but shook her head and stood, "A Queen decides, Catra, she does not make wishes. I am deciding."

For a moment Catra paused, wondering, pondering if *she* should decide. Was that what her mother was asking for? Or was this another assertion of authority? She just tilted her chin up and smirked. Even if it *was* a test, she decided to let her mother just play herself, "Very well, your majesty. I think you will find the excursion *very* informative. Thank you for volunteering."

She bowed, just catching the puzzled look on Cyra's face. Clearly they'd expected her to either sulk *or* assert herself. Catra

straightened and watched as her mother regarded her, trying to work something out.

"What aren't you telling me, darling?"

"Oh no. I think Adora should demonstrate her prowess properly . . . Just don't forget about mother there when she does."

Melendy actually spat her blood-wine out as she sipped at the goblet in front of her, a surprised laugh emerging from her throat. She shot Catra a slightly puzzled look, then smiled, "I hope your mother would know better than that."

Cyra frowned, "Sellswords are sellswords, brash and charming though these ones are. I hope they surprise me"…

Catra shrugged, "She is a *Princess,* mother. You seem to be doing a good job of forgetting that."

"Of a nation no one knows or deals with directly"…

"And we could be the *first* . The FAE only even deal with them as individual traders. But we could ALLY with them."

Cyra stared at her daughter , then twitched, her eyes narrowed a little, "W ell, now I really *must* see this for myself. Whatever it is that has you so entranced. Cyrus informed me of more raiding parties within our lands - their boldness troubles me, but this is an *ample* opportunity to test your new friends."

Something niggled at Catra, "Please though, mother..be wary . If they are being so bold, I am concerned about *other* surprises."

"Oh no fear , Im sure your potential paramour will protect me," chuckled Cyra. She stepped forwards and spread her arms. Catra sighed and smiled, then stepped into her mother's embrace. Melendy stood and joined them, "Now , I will be off with the sun, to battle the Horde."

"Thay day , mother?" Catra leaned back from the embrace and frowned.

"Ah, the day-blight is a *minor* inconvenience with the right wards and cantrips. Better to journey through the day , to fight on *our* terms.

The trio disengaged and Catra bade them goodnight. She left for her rooms, confident but with a sense of foreboding in her gut.

Adora watched as the soldiers of Halfmoon mounted their horses in the main Plaza, before the Ziggurat. Her small band had packed light, leaving most of their unessential items in the barracks - they intended to return, after all. She leaned against the arch that led into the plaza while her cohort sat on the flagstones or lounged nearby.

"What's going on in that skull of yours, younglun?" Duncan stood next to her, his arms folded.

"Just when we should spring their little trap," Adora smiled thinly.

"So sure?" Duncan didn't sound doubtful, just curious. Adora nodded.

"Just need to see if it's a plan of the Queen's or the Princesses. I'm leaning towards the Hegemony though."

"Hah, aye," Duncan nodded slowly, "Saw one of them Orc fellahs sneaking out of the palace last night. Subtle they are not."

Adora chuckled, "And did you spot the elfin man? The Orc was the one they wanted us to see."

Kyle plucked at his lute and looked up from his prone position near the wall, "Smelled him, yep. Heading for the lifts. The Orc doubled back to the palace after stopping at an alehouse."

"They think we are simple," Adora mused, "But they are at least assuming we're slightly vigilant. And the shape-thief?"

Kyle jutted his chin and Adora glanced at the cohort of Halfmoon troops. She snorted and shook her head, "How they do not realise a new one of their number is *not right* I do not know. Can they not smell them?"

Duncan shook his head slightly, "They are a spy . Likely they have… plans against Magicats. Counters, wards, totems, bone charms, or they just smeared themselves in pig-shit," a few of the other Sea-farers chuckled at that. Duncan continued, "Likely well practised too."

"Catra knows them, so no doubt. And I fear they are *well* aware of all things about the Magicats. Keep an eye on the Queen."

"You expect treachery?" Kyle mused as he returned his gaze to the instrument before him. His lithe fingers plucked at the strings as he hummed a tune of home. Adora drew a quiet breath and shook her head.

"What else can we expect? The Royals play games while the Undead stalk their lands. Posturing, pretending. But I feel this is at least a worthy test. But I see that our enemies will seek an opportunity."

“And who are our enemies?” chuckled Duncan.

Adora shrugged, “Whoever stands against us. They will be driven before us and we will hear the lamentation of their people,” she smirked at that, “Let us just prepare for the worst.”

“Can we not just have more mead? Why must we always be diving into the fray?” groaned Kyle from the floor.

“Because then you would have no tall tales to tell your loves back home. And Rog does so love hearing you croon,” Adora softly kicked at Kyle’s boot then looked back at the gathering of troops. It was likely approaching midday in the world above - she’d stolen an hour in the gardens with Catra, to briefly exchange a hidden kiss and final promises. Catra had warned her, of course, of her fears and what they had both suspected anyway.

Adora whistled slowly as a figure emerged from the Ziggurat and all the Halfmoon soldiers snapped to attention.

Cyra wore a set of black armour that made her relatively tall frame more imposing. It looked slightly heavier than the normal chain-plate of her soldiers, and had an overlapping quality that made it almost look like a single piece of metal. The torchlight glinted off of it and made her look like a moving shadow. An open-faced helm was clutched under one arm, while her other hand rested on the pommel of a curved blade.

"Curved swords," scoffed Adora, "Of course she has curved swords."

"Cutting. Makes sense when your fighting style is based on mobility. Slice, move, slice," Duncan nodded. "Cavalry, mobility, speed. Seems to be a Magicat staple. They dont do phalanx work, not really built for prolonged melee. Interesting, considering they are fairly resilient."

Adora nodded slowly, then glanced at the small collection of Hegemony soldiers that watched from the other side of the plaza, "There's your line soldiers, Duncan. Spears, shields, stingers. Hold the line and prick the enemy to death."

Duncan nodded slowly and grimaced.

They watched as Cyrus emerged and bowed to his Queen. A few words were said and the company mounted up, while C'yra watched. She then strode to a large grey horse, which she vaulted onto. THe horse tossed it's head until she reined it in and trotted it forwards. C'yra moved to the head of the soldiers and began to lead them out, a pair of officers flanking her. As they neared the archway, Adora straightened and gave a low bow. C'yra looked down, the helm framing her face in an intimidating black carapace, the masked-frontage raised. The design looked like it would flip down to just cover her eyes. Like all the Magicat helms, it had gaps for the ears on the sides, which had a padded covering, but it didnt detract from the warrior-look.

“Are you ready , Lady Moondaughter?” the Queen smirked down at her. Adora grinned back up.

“W e are, though it appears your people forgot to offer us horses,” she stepped forwards and the Queen’ s horse tossed its head. C'yra startled herself, surprised at her war-charger’s response. A few of the closer horses also nickered and tossed their own heads as the Sea-farers stood and dusted themselves off. Adora chuckled, “Catra’ s horses had a chance to get used to us. Though we smelled of salt and sea water. Perhaps our soap is offensive?”

“Y our aura, my chief. Clearly just.overpowering,” Kyle of fered from the back. Adora glanced over her shoulder.

“Shut up Kyle.”

He just grinned back at her and Adora tsked, then returned her broad smile to the Queen, who regarded her sceptically . C'yra hummed with some mild disdain, “A wfully.. Familiar.”

“When a person is your blade brother , it gives them a bit of leeway,” Adora shrugged, “Levity before death. Helps to ease a soul between lives, should the worst happen.”

C'yra harrumphed but smiled, “Mayhap. But I am afraid horses will take too much time. You came ill prepared.”

“Oh fear not. I just hope you and yours can keep up. But please, lead the way, your majesty.”

Cyra snorted with amusement, then spurred her horse on. Behind her, the line of troops followed, but each animal veered around the Sea-farers, disrupting their neat ranks momentarily. With a chuckle, Adora beckoned her fellows to follow, and they fell in on either side of the column, walking fast as they kept pace, headed for the great elevator and the exit of Halfmoon.

The remainder of the day had been uneventful. After bidding Adora and her mother farewell, Catra had moped about her rooms. Her other mother, Melendy, had decided to remain in her rooms, and Catra had left her to it - it had been a while since the pair had parted and it was clearly a strange feeling for Melendy.

Catra took the opportunity, as the day dragged on, to walk the gardens. She could practically sense Adora, the woman’s presence almost having imprinted itself. She knew it was a fanciful notion, but still, she allowed herself to imagine the tall, muscular blonde striding down the paths as she sought a way to get to Catra. The thought filled her heart with love.

Her reverie was interrupted by a crunch of gravel and a tentative, “Your highness?”

Catra turned to find Scorpia standing not far off, Perfuma and a few other ladies-in-waiting hanging back. She folded her arms and offered a tight smile, "Your highness."

The pair stared at one another until Scorpia averted her eyes and scratched at the back of her neck with a claw, "Huh, so...um is now a good time?"

Catra stared at the woman, her brow crinkled in thought. She couldn't help but compare the woman with Adora. Both buff, both blonde (Sort of), but so different. Adora was cocksure, brash, yet had a softness to her. Scorpia was brash in an entirely unappealing way, yet also had a softness to her that spoke of a lack of confidence in some respect.

Mirrors to one another. Perhaps in another lifetime she would have found Scorpia interesting - a diversion from Halfmoon's strange politics. And at one point, she had. She and Scorpia *had* been friends, childhood playmates, almost. Or rather closer to pre-teen. Old discussions during diplomatic visits, grand conversations of adventure and dreams of the future. And even when Catra had visited during her more adventurous years, she'd enjoyed her sort-of-clandestine visits to the Scorponi palace, happy to regale Scorpia with tales of adventure.

Truth be told, she had rather basked in the other woman's starry-eyed attentions, even if she hadn't really seen her as more than a fun conversation partner. Or an audience.

She let out a sigh and smiled, "Of course, Scorpia. Shall we walk?"

The pair fell in step as their feet crunched on the gravel. High above, the cave ceiling glittered with the twinkling motes of distant fluorescent fungi and glowing insects. Torches burned from some of the huge hanging rocks and all around the garden, bathing them in perpetual twilight. They walked in silence for a few minutes, until Scorpia finally exhaled with an, "Have you considered my proposal? Now that, well, now that she's gone, I mean."

Catra continued walking as she let the silence continue, before she looked at her fellow Royal, "She is coming back."

Scorpia twitched and a look of something else passed over her face, but then she shrugged, her expression becoming more set, "She seems a really nice person. Honourable. A bit...rough. But I can see the appeal! No judgement! I mean, I have Orcs in my harem, warriors. You know, variety..." she grinned and waved her pincers. Catra grimaced.

"Variety huh. So, that's what I'd be?"

Scorpia blinked, "No! I mean, uh, you'd...you wouldn't be a *consort*, you'd be a Queen! And, well, the harem would be...well, not *yours*...But you could be a part of it as well and"...

"What, I wouldn't get my own?" Catra quirked an eyebrow, while inside she reined in her desire to *scratch*.

"Well, no...but." Scorpia paused and smoothed down the simple dress she wore, "Ok, I'm getting all muddled. My moms got me a tutor to stop this and you've got me all scatter brained! I can't help it," she drew a breath, then stopped and turned to face Catra, "Wildcat. I love you."

Catra stared at the Scorponi Princess. The taller woman beamed, then leaned in, eyes closed. Catra leaned backwards with a snort and an exclamation of, "What are you doing?"

Scorpia stopped and blinked in surprise, "Um. I told you I loved you. And now... now we kiss? And then you and me, well, we get married."

The pair stared at each other, until Catra snorted. She waved a hand as she tried to stifle a laugh. Behind them, the ladies in waiting shifted uncomfortably. Perfuma looked indignant as she shot a glare at Catra. The Magicat Princess drew a breath in and chuckled on last time and shook her head, "Why...why do you think *that*?"

"Because...because that's how it works. The...the declaration of true love!"

Catra stared at her, then frowned, "What's my favourite play?"

Scorpia blinked, "What?"

"And my preferred weapon of choice? Do you know my preferred tea?"

"Um, but... you drink blood? I mean, yeah food... But you could drink my blood! Or , well, maybe a servant's blood, but I am totally fine with that. We have loads of serving girls!"

Catra shook her head, "Why do you *want* to marry me, Scorpia?"

The other Princess paused and frowned, "Because we love each other? And, well, we promised each other we would."

"We promised we'd fight the Horde together . We promised we'd ride dragons together. We said we'd be knights or wizards or..." Catra rolled her eyes, "We were CHILDREN, Scorpia."

The taller woman huffed, "It meant something! I have PINED for you, Catra!"

The Magicat arched an eyebrow, then gestured to Perfuma, "And her?"

Scorpia flinched, "W ell I love Perfuma too!"

"And if a condition of me marrying you was that I needed to drain her dry?" Catra met Scorpia' s eyes and the buff woman paled. The Scorponi took a step to place herself between Catra and Perfuma, although the woman didn't seem to realise she'd done it. Catra smirked.

"...no. N that...no," Scorpia' s eyes narrowed, "Y ou...that would be *evil* , Catra. I don't think we'd"…

"But you love me, Scorpia. Don't you want to give me what I want?" Catra purred and tilted her head. Her tail swished and she smirked. "Alright...just a bite? Every girl in your harem. I'll only , maybe, kill one or two."

Scorpia swallowed and shook her head, "Y ou're trying to scare me Catra, but I know this is just a test. I know you wouldn't."

"There' s one price. Let me *eat* her. Let me drink her blood until she goes pale"…

"N O! How can you even *ask* that!" Scorpia practically barked. Catra met the woman's gaze.

"Well, that's what *you* are asking of me. To abandon my true love, to marry you. Surely this is a fair exchange? Adora for your… Perfuma? That way we both lose something."

The expression on Scorpia's face morphed from horror to confusion, "That's not the same at all. I mean, she doesn't love you. It's totally different. She's just… some barbarian. Some sellsword. We have *history*! We're destined!"

"You are not my soulmate, Scorpia," Catra sighed, "So, why do you want *me*? All I'm hearing is… childhood fantasy and a desire to… own me."

"I want to keep you safe!" Scorpia huffed and folded her arms, "And, well, it just makes sense! We could rule the continent! Drive back the Horde!"

"We don't need to be married to drive the Horde back," Catra sighed. She rubbed the bridge of her nose, "You don't know me."…

"I do! You came to visit, we drank we told stories! We are best friends! How can we not be soul mates?" Scorpia shuffled and grimaced. Her expression was like that of a child who had been told she couldn't have another serving of desert. She fixed her gaze on Catra, "I deserve you! You deserve me! I will care for you, protect you, I-"

Catra was suddenly up close to Scorpia, a single claw pressed against the woman's forehead. Catra tilted her head slightly, eyes a little unfocused, "Protect me from…what? Or do you want me to protect you?"

The ladies and Perfuma seemed stunned by Catra's speed. Scorpia's eyes were wide, a mix of fear and, maybe, desire. Catra scoffed, but Scorpia nodded a little, "Yes! Protect each other, us against the world! And I can keep you safe from the politics! You wouldn't have to ask for anything ever again, wouldn't have to fight. A life of…"

Catra sneered and backed off, her patience fading, "You listened to me tell you stories, saw me speak; you've seen me talk with Adora and you assume I want *luxury*? Or security?"

"Well, of course…that's fanciful excitement, distraction. You're a royal! You want finer things and…"

"I have no need for a gilded cage. So, you want to marry me to keep me in a cage, a trinket for your collection. And what does the *Hegemony* want?"

Scorpia huffed, "That doesn't MATTER! Our people, they'll be allies! Our armies will drive the Horde away, everyone will be safe! Catra, I know you've been fighting for so long. Maybe…maybe you *need* the safety? Isn't it worth it to give this place a chance?" She waved at the

cave, "Put down the swords? Maybe...embrace love? I can guarantee so much more."

"You dont even know me, Scorpia," Catra smiled sadly, "We were friends, are friends...of a sort. My heart...my heart belongs to Adora. And when she returns, we will wed."

"She cant give you what I can!" Scorpia stamped her foot on the gravel, then sobbed, her face distraught, "She's *nice*, but she's… she's some merchant with *airs*, a sellsword! Your people deserve better! I DESERVE better."

"Scorpia."

"And what if she doesnt come back? What if...what if I told her not too, paid her off? If she comes back and... and I offer her gold not to? That would show you, show you how much you really mean, hm? I mean, she rode out of here, so eager to curry favour with your mother, right? Cant you SEE Catra, she's USING you. For gold, for glory! She wont care, she just wants *wealth*. Dee told me, we KNOW."

Catra's eyes narrowed and she straightened, "Careful, your *highness*, that sounds like you have an agent *listening in* on other dignitaries."

Scorpia's jaw clicked shut and she exhaled, then nodded, "Youre right, that was...uncalled for. But she is not *worthy* of you. Shell take whatever payment your mother offers her, now she's out and

she *won't* come back. Next you see of her will be as some auxiliary in your army, happy to have the gold. Please..please dont let her break your heart. I *care* for you Catra! I love you! And you're supposed to say it back!"

"I would never lie to you Scorpia," Catra replied flatly, "I respect you too much. I cannot give you the answer you want."

"At least..if..she doesnt return, if..if..something happens, please at least *think* on it. I will not leave until our betrothal is finalised!"

Catra's lip curled, "You would *occupy* Halfmoon?"

A hush fell upon the garden. Scorpia drew herself up, "I did not say that. My troops will remain *outside*. But I would hope we can continue to negotiate."

Catra nodded slowly, "I see. You seem certain Adora will not return," her eyes narrowed, "Care to elaborate? And remember, you said you *love* me. And people in love do. Not. Lie."

The confident expression on Scorpia's face shifted a little and she looked away, "I..just maybe..expect her to not." she winced and sighed, "Catra, Wildcat..I...maybe just expect her to not come back, ok?"

Catra smirked, "Well see. I think our discussion is concluded, your Highness. Maybe we can discuss *other* diplomatic arrangements and avenues *later* . Good day."

She gave a low half-bow, half curtsy, then turned and stalked off into the gardens. Scorpia called after her and crunched after her, "Catra! Just.I'm.you're not being a good friend right now!" she reached out to grab at Catra's arm, when suddenly a pair of guards seemed to materialise from nowhere, their speed shocking as they raced across the gardens. They juxtaposed themselves between the Princesses, halberds crossed. Scorpia reared up, shocked.

Catra turned and fixed Scorpia with a stare, "This is not your city , Scorpia. Not now . Not ever ," she narrowed her eyes, "You seem to know something. But trust me when I say things will *not* go as you hope."

Scorpia looked at the guards, then at Catra and swallowed, "I just.I . LOVE you.please at least consider ..."

"And I love Adora. And I trust Adora. And she *will* be back. Count on that. Good day, your highness."

Chapter 13

Chapter Summary

A demonstration is made.

A plan is enacted

And another demonstration is made.

TW: BLOOD AND VIOLENCE AND GORE

Chapter Notes

There's a fair bit of violence in this chapter. So, if you are averse to that... be warned.

Adora crouched on the ridgeline and cocked her head to one side. Around her, the birds whittered quietly and the trees groaned. They were several hours' march away from Halfmoon, further to the north of the mountain. It was still visible, looming high above, to the rear, the peak visible above the treeline.

She glanced to her side as the leafmold crunched under heavy footfalls and smirked, "You sound like a herd of cattle, Duncan."

"Have to put on the show of *clumsy oaf* for the audience," chuckled the older man. He leaned against a pine and watched his Chief, "So?"

"So."

"What do you make of all this?"

Adora ran her hand through the fallen bark and soil and shook her head. She jutted her chin to the west, "You smell that?"

"Armour polish and leather? The stink of dry sand and rancid poison?"

"So you do smell the Scorponi," Adora grinned, "but even downwind of us. Sloppy."

"They feel that the distance is enough. Or it is a patrol," Duncan mused as he squinted up at the sky. He heaved a sigh and adjusted the heavy leather belt at his waist. His brown fur cloak rippled as he rolled his shoulders and he wrinkled his nose, his facial hair bunching as he glowered, "And something *rotten* to the south. You suspect more."

"A changeling, a number of soldiers, an errand on a whim," Adora frowned and shook her head, her braid rocking from side to side, "I know the intent. I just cannot puzzle out the hand that guides the piece. Is it *just* the Hegemony? Or does Cyra wish to remove an impediment? Or is this a genuine test? There *are* Horde infiltrators herabouts."

"We could kill them all and work it out after?" Duncan mused, then grinned at Adora's arched eyebrow. The blonde snorted.

"That would go so well on the wedding night, yes. Dearest Catra, I may have torn your mother's throat out on a suspicion. I do hope we can put that behind us!"

Duncan snorted and shrugged, "My father in law. I wish I had."

"Angry man?" Adora grinned, "Uncle Dorik seemed nice!"

"Ah, you have never seen him when he talks about *fishing* the northern ice wastes. A man needs a cask of mead to survive such a conversation!" Duncan chuckled, then slapped Adora's shoulder, "So, shall we go and spring this trap then?"

"We shall. And let us try not to kill *too* many. And not the Queen."

The older wolf grinned and cracked his knuckles, "Ah. A *challenge*."

The pair descended from the rise and rejoined the column that loitered amid the trees. Men fed their horses apples and water from skeins, while others checked crossbows and adjusted themselves in their saddles. Cyra spoke with one of the two officers, a frown on

her face, which she schooled as she turned to face Adora, "An enjoyable delay?" she asked with a faint smile.

"To take one's time is not a delay, your majesty," Adora replied, her face stoic, "To rush in, recklessly, is a fool's errand." She shot Kyle a glare as the Skald spat water out and chuckled, "Something to add, Skald?"

"No, my chief. Just I feel I may need to go back and rethink some of our sagas," the young man deadpanned. Adora's face shifted to a grin.

"Those are *lessons* in themselves, surely?"

Cyra watched their byplay and arched an eyebrow, "Still, this seems like we are not observing your supposed *talents*."

Adora looped her thumbs through her belt and arched an eyebrow, "Why, your majesty, so forward. What would your wife think?"

Several of the Queen's guards sat up straighter in their saddles and a few hefted weapons. The officer next to Cyra growled and his horse trotted forwards, but he paused as Adora fixed her gaze on him, a low growl in her throat. Cyra chuckled, however and held up a hand, "I hope your sword arm is as quick as your tongue. Do *not* add on to that, please. The less I know about my daughter and… *anyway*, what has this little stop earned us?"

The tall blonde chuckled then looked back up the slope, "A horde patrol, or infiltration unit, perhaps a few miles south. Signs of passage, likely ranging ghouls scouting for the pack. Smoke on the horizon, faint. And mist."

The Queen's eyebrow arched in amusement, "Inclement weather?"

"Some necromancers use fog as a method to obscure their passage and to confuse their victims. It's a good way to delay resources from escaping," Adora's tone was flat, business-like.

Cyra frowned, then looked to her Captain, "Kelik?"

"The mist is correct. Reports corroborate such experiences with particular bands our forces have encountered, although it is rare. But as to the rest, our scouts have not found a sign," he harrumphed, his yellow eyes glaring daggers at Adora, "But this is *your* parade, majesty."

"Indeed so. And if these sea-farers are charlatans leading us on a merry chase, well, we will have still learned something. And anything else? Maybe you spotted a dragon?"

Adora met Cyra's gaze and smiled thinly. She leaned forwards and cocked her head, "We shall see." She spun on her heel and marched

to the head of the column, waving a hand rapidly. The other sea-farers appeared from among the trees, startling a few of the Magicats who hadn't noticed their departure. Even Cyra seemed momentarily surprised. Adora broke into a jog, her troops falling in behind her as she called out behind her, "Try to keep up!"

Dee cursed as they bounced in the uncomfortable saddle. The column was moving at a fair gallop, the sea-farers being shockingly agile in woodland. Where horses had to weave and slow among the thick trees and undergrowth, the barbarians seemed to bound and melt into the green. They moved as one, not blocking one another but slowed to allow the Magicats to catch up. Their leader even seemed *irritated* by the apparent sluggishness of the Magicats, but held her tongue, it appeared.

Their journey was also hampered by the drop in light as the sun had set and night began to creep in. To compound it, a faint mist had begun to settle, which seemed to have a few of the soldiers on edge. Yet still the barbarians kept ahead, their shouts and calls to one another oddly spine-tingling in the encroaching dark. Dee was *not* gifted with the same night vision as the Magicats, although they could emulate it to a degree, so rode as close to the cohort as they could. The barbarians had an uncanny ability to navigate: clearly being country-bound bumpkins they were used to dashing among trees.

It was oddly unnerving, as well, as Dee swore that several of the sea-farers had met their gaze more than once and smirked at them.

However, they seemed to be mocking *most* of the magicats, so Dee put it down to pre-action jtters. They got them before any *big show* , but they lived for that moment when it all bled away and they could see the shock in their target's eyes - how they'd been fooled at the last. The same as any audience - sometimes it was joy at a tale well told;other times it was the broken look of the betrayed. Either way it was a *genuine* response.

It gave them life.

Except these jtters felt of f. Felt more like warning chimes than excitement. Then again, they hadnt been in these lands *properly* for a while and hadnt done hard field craft for longer .

Dee buried the worries, as, frankly, things were too far advanced. And there was simply too much coin riding on it. They spurred their horse forward and drew alongside one of the Captains. This one lagged behind, marshalling the rear of the column, while Kelik rode to the fore. A loyalist, the man was *not* swayed. This one, however, was one of Cyrus's trusted. Absently, Dee unhooked a skein from their belt and held it to the Captain, "Sir , Captain Velk, your skein looks.dry . Take mine."

The man glanced at Dee and licked his lips. His whiskers twitched and Dee noticed the man's ears flick with nerves. But the Captain took the skein and handed his own back to Dee, "My thanks, soldier . Now back in line."

"Y es *sir* ," Dee purred, lashing their currently-cat-like tail, before they reined their horse to fall back in. A few others muttered among themselves. But a few others looked at Dee and nodded with certainty.

It was going to be messy and chaotic. But it would be *beautiful.* Dee smirked. They loved it when a plan came together.

The column pulled up at a clearing as the sun was beginning to set. The men were all grouchy from marching in daylight, of course, but seemed to be perking up as the sunset drew near. Their attention, however, was focused on the scene before them. In the centre of the grassy clearing were a few burned out huts, their blackened forms made more prominent by the rolling mist that covered the ground and seemed to grow thicker in the trees beyond.

It was far too quiet and there was a conspicuous lack of corpses. Adora growled and shook her head, then cursed. Cyra glanced down at her from her steed, "Y ou seem.very troubled."

The blonde snorted, "And you are not? This..this is a familiar sight. One that stirs unwelcome memoriesf. One I hope to see purged."

Cyra nodded slowly , her face grim, "A reality for those out on the fringes."

"And yet.." Adora growled. She sighed and shook her head. Cyra turned her cool gaze on the warrior woman.

"Well, go ahead."

Adora looked up at her and smiled thinly, "Well, your majesty . We are not yet allies. My counsel comes when asked for at a military council. For now, we are just *mercenaries* , correct? So, tell me how you wish for us to be judged. Do we run them down and bring back their heads, or do you wish to see us fight? They will not be far ."

Cyra met the icy gaze of the warrior and had to suppress a flinch, "You are.. I wish to see you fight. But here, perhaps. Kelik. Send a contingent. Find the Horde, lure them back. I wish to see, first hand, these folk fight."

The Captain nodded, whilst his comrade rode up from the rear to join them. Kelik glanced at the man, then turned his horse, before speaking, "It will be done, your majesty ."

Adora watched as the soldiers rallied to their leader, with Kelik dismounting. A moment later he led a good twenty men away into the woods on foot. She nodded, "Wise. A horse here is just more meat."

The second Captain hung back, then took a swig from his skein with a smack of his lips. He held it out to the Queen, "Y our majesty?"

The woman nodded and took a deep drink with a wrinkle of her nose, "Eugh, warm from the ride."

The Captain chuckled, "Never as good as fresh from the throat, my Queen."

Adora watched the exchange and frowned. She sniffed the air briefly, which drew a confused glance from the Queen and the Captain, but just shrugged, then turned to her soldiers. When she spoke, it was in their own tongue, *"Be ready for battle. Torvald, ready your bow if the changeling makes a move, end it. Raggi, your spears. Duncan, your chains are well apt for this field of battle. The rest, await my word. The pack does not fight yet, the people do. Our dance is not yet nigh."*

The sea-farers slapped their chests and cheered in response. Adora turned back to smile at Cyra, who regarded her with a concentrated expression. The Queen tilted her head and grimaced, "The words… are familiar."

Adora blinked in surprise and chuckled, "We have been to these lands before. Perhaps your mothers knew of us? Mayhap we taught *them* our tongue as well?" her smirk was positively indecent. Cyra scoffed.

“I wonder Melendy likes you.”

Adora shrugged, then walked into the clearing. She closed her eyes as she felt the breeze play upon her face and drew a breath. She crossed her arms and relaxed, then smiled, “Speak Skald.”

“You know of their intent, my chief?” Kyle’s voice was low. Adora shrugged.

“An inkling. They will let us battle the Horde. Perhaps a few of them will fall as well. I feel there is more at play here. They will attack us. Likely when we are at rest.”

“Who? Magicats? Scorponi?”

“Yes. And they will kill the Queen. Have you noticed anything of their cohort?” Her brow furrowed as she let the scents on the breeze mingle, a confusing cavalcade.

“There are two cohorts. One for each captain. One is for Kelik. The other for the one called Velk. Their armour is the same, bare the cloaks and the stained dye of their leather.”

“Kill Velk’s first.”

Kyle chuckled, “So sure?”

“Is the changeling wearing V elk’s colours?”

Kyle paused and chuckled again, “Of course.”

Adora shook her head, then settled on the grass to wait, the scent of burned buildings and a faint, lingering taste of wolfsbane and wine lingering in her senses.

The wait was not long. A scant hour passed, with the Magicats using the time to push their horses to the rear, hidden among the trees. The remainder formed a defensive line in the trees, halberds down, shields up and crossbows readied. Cyra herself remained mounted, to watch the engagement from the centre of her ring of steel.

Adora had remained seated in the clearing, while her comrades spread around the space, mostly in pairs. Duncan moved just ahead of her as he’d pulled a pair of hammers from his belt. She’d only said a few words, quietly, to her comrades, to prepare them.

The first sign was when Kelik and his men dashed into the clearing, their vampiric speed evident, their movements *just* out of sync with their actual speed. They skirted around the sea-farers, yelling warnings, while Kelik drew up next to Adora. He barely seemed winded, but his gaze was surprised, "Why are you not in a formation?"

Adora looked up at him from her seated position, "Would it do any good against a wave? What have you brought me?"

Kelik stared at her, then sneered, "A reckoning. They came from the mist. We just saw them," he glared at her, "You knew they would."

"Your carelessness, not mine," Adora shrugged, then rose. She looked at Kelik and frowned, "Well, go and join your *formation*. Leave the fighting to us."

The Captain glared, then jogged back to the safety of his troops. Adora rolled her neck and stretched her arms, her face splitting into a smile as the Horde broke from the treeline. They shambled out of the mist, their forms emerging slowly, ill-defined abominations. Most looked like the tattered remnants a scavenger wouldn't deign to tough, but others were fresher, whilst a few more wore battered armour. All carried some form of blade of cudgel - be it a notched sword, or a hefty log. Among the shambling foes skulked leaner creatures - more like skeletons, with stretched sinew and greying skin. Their clothes were little more than tattered rags and their faces etched into permanent snarls.

And to the rear, hidden in the mists, something else hissed out in gleeful challenge. Adora folded her arms and set her stance, then waited.

—

Dee was unnerved. Frankly, so were many of the surrounding Magicats.

The sight of the Horde was *always* troubling - a wave of rotting flesh and merciless dread. The creatures seemed to project some sort of aura of intimidation, or despair. It was a subtle thing, but was always worse when one of their *commanders* was in the field.

But this was a *large* contingent, likely having collected more from wandering citizens and outlying settlements. Far larger than anyone had expected. It would have been a slog to butcher them all for a Magicat or Scorponi company.

But a dozen sea-farers... Ripped them apart.

Where other armies formed lines and held the Horde at arms length, slowly cutting them down, the sea-farers moved in as individuals, disparate. And yet *not* . They were apart, but their fighting seemed almost like a dance.

Dee watched as their their archer began the *dance* . Their arrows flew with unerring accuracy, striking skulls and knocking down the undead one by one as the bulk of the wave shambled and began to pick up speed. More shots whizzed out, shattering limbs and knocking down more of the beasts, which in turn created temporary obstacles for the foe. Their numbers acted against them, forcing the horde to stagger and split, meaning they did not meet the sea-farers as a swarm, rather they closed in as a broken cluster.

Most armies had abandoned bows for their ineffectiveness against creatures that felt no pain and shrugged off an arrow to the knee. But here the sea-farer just plugged a target with enough arrows to slow it, or hit a target in the head to blow a creature from its shambling gait, which had a knock-on effect.

Of course, this meant that the ghouls, dashing ahead of the horde, were not *immediately* reinforced. The Horde *normally* had these horrors dart in and out of a melee: the regular undead bogged down troops, whilst the ghouls ran in and eviscerated soldiers who were grappling or vulnerable. It was awful to be fighting a shambling foe, only to have a shrieking skeleton tear your comrade's face off right next to you.

But here, the ghouls ran forward. The intent *this* time seemed to be to just overwhelm the paltry number of opponents, then let the bulk of the Horde finish them off. Except that did *not* happen.

The first ghoul leapt towards the one called Duncan. The man sidestepped and swung a hammer at the same moment. The creature's head *exploded* .

Two more closed in, but the man dropped a hammer from his second hand, revealing that it was connected to a chain. He swung and spun, knocking one of the creatures aside, its arm shattered, whilst he thrust his main hand weapon into the face of the other beast, which fell at his feet, its momentum arrested. The man began to move and spin, his hammers extending out on chains as he forced the other ghouls to part and attack to his flanks.

But that seemed to be the plan. The other sea-farers seemed to have paired up, or worked in small groups. The ghouls harried but could not get close. A few scampered back, just as the first cluster of zombies hit the line. One had already been rent apart by the flailing hammers of the man Duncan. Already a ring of corpses lay around him. Another group lurched at one cluster of the barbarian, only to find the sea-farers among them - a man with a shield shoved into the throng, whilst a comrade skewered a set with his spears, and a third swung a heavy axe that seemed to just cut through the walking-corpses as if they were paper.

To the rear, their Skald sang as the others fought. Axes, hammers, swords, spears: the barbarians were methodical, darting in and using the Hordes' own numbers against them as the mindless beasts got in one another's way. The more rotted corpses were felled easily, disabled by swift strikes. Those with armour - former soldiers or heroes - were singled out and dragged down, to be suppressed by their own fellows clambering over them, only to be finished off as the field was cleared. Duncan held the centre, his weapons splitting the forces, whilst the undead were further forced to move between the broke homes, which meant they approached the barbarians, already broken apart.

And in the middle of it all stood a vision of Death. Adora moved like a farmer scything wheat, her blade flashing out in swift, long strikes that cleaved the undead easily.

Dee stared as the blonde barbarian just waited. They frowned, unsure what to expect - the woman seemed content to let her fellows carry the battle. They felt a sense of disappointment at that, as they'd thought this buffoon was at least *brave* . Admittedly the blonde idiot was still standing in the middle of a field of undead.

And then the blonde seemed to tense. The women dashed forwards, darting between the chains and spins of Duncan's hammers. Dee stared as the woman shoulder checked a zombie into a crowd of others, then plucked another up, only to *rip its head* clean off as she did so. She slid on the soggy ground, under the grasping arms of a ghoul, then rose and spun.

Silver flashed in the moonlight as her blade bisected the ghoul easily. Then the blonde was running again, darting and slashing and *laughing* . The bulk of the horde was between the sea-farers and the broken village and the blonde had just barrelled through the lot, to the rear. The magicats and Dee watched as the blonde vaulted up a broken building, only to launch herself at a patch of mist. Her sword descended and there was a *crack* .

A shockwave shot out and the mist was blasted away, revealing more undead in the village proper, followed by a wail. The cohort of Magicats could just see Adora duelling something tall and gangly . It had slender arms and wore a cloak of brown fur. A set of antlers

protruded from a tattered hood, along with the bone-white snout of some creature's skull.

It fought with a stave, but the weapon seemed damaged. It staggered back under the violent blows that Adora raided on it. With a final swing, the creature's staff broke and the blonde darted in to thrust her blade *up* .

The creature hissed, shuddered, then went limp. The cloak flapped and then drifted to the ground.The skull clattered to the ground.

It was as if the strings of a puppet had been cut. All the undead staggered, confused. Some of the more tattered ones fell to the ground, spasming. A few just stopped whilst others continued to attack. But their movements lacked co-ordination - no longer was this a mob with a single goal, now it was a series of ravenous individuals. Yes they'd gotten in one another 's way before, but they'd been moving as a single entity. Now it was a few shambling targets. The sea-farers moved from fighting to what could only be described as extermination. To the onlookers, the barbarians moved as if bored.

Only the ghouls seemed to retain some form of animalistic coordination. A couple charged at Adora, but she barely even acknowledged them as she struck them down. A half dozen other ghouls made to flee into the forest, but half were cut down by rapid shots from the sea-farer's archer, while the *skald* just seemed to suddenly be there. He was horrifying in his sudden brutality, his lute gone only to be replaced with a pair of axes. In three darting moves, the last three ghouls fell, howling.

Adora bent down and plucked the skull from the floor, then she turned and strode back to the silent Magicats. Sweat beaded her brow and she looked determined. Dee watched as the woman approached the line and, for the briefest of moments, swore the woman looked right at them. But she instead walked up to the Captain, Kelik. He stared at her, a frown on his face, then sputtered out, "How?"

"I have been fighting them since I was *eight* ," Adora's gaze moved up to Cyra, "You wished to see us fight. We have shown our mettle, although this was a paltry force," her gaze returned to Kelik and her expression softened, "We fight as if we are the last of our people, Captain. I mourn the loss of your men. This was paltry, but an organised band. A Necromancer is not mild thing, of course, even a near whelp like this one. The Horde must be fought on *your* terms, never theirs. Next time, please let my people seek them out."

The man glared back at her, but said nothing. Adora met his gaze, then looked back to the Queen. She bowed slightly , then skirted the defensive formation. Behind her, her people had begun to form up, their macabre duty seeming done - no corpses remained standing in the field. They moved to where the horses had been tied up, the makings of a rudimentary camp.

Dee watched them go, their breath slightly shallow. But their resolve hardened as they watched the barbarians trudge away. They leaned over to Captain Velk and hissed quietly, whilst the muttered conversation of the other soldiers drowned out their whispers, "Send your runners *now* . We must strike *tonight* , while they recover."

Velk licked his lips and glanced around their small band. The formation was beginning to break up and he beckoned to a pair of younger looking soldiers, "Tomaz, Keph. A word."

The Captain dismounted and slipped a couple of scrolls from his saddlebag, which he handed to the two soldiers. The pair saluted, then moved off. Velk then walked over to where Cyra and Kelik were talking, "Your highness, Kelik. I've sent out runners to ensure the barbarians got them all. Do you wish to discuss..." he looked at the piles of corpses in the field and his tail swished in agitation, "*That?*

Cyra adjusted herself in her saddle and frowned, then kicked her spurs into her horse's flank. She trotted it across the grass and observed the piles, clearly noting how they were stacked, where the sea-farers had moved among the Horde with such brutal efficiency. Dee, lingering under the shade of a pine with a pair of other soldiers, watched surreptitiously as Cyra moved. They were curious as they watched the Queen inspect the handiwork of the barbarians.

Again, that twinge of concern trickled into their gut. Perhaps there was some regret in there, too; but Dee had long since forgotten that emotion. The job didn't allow for it. And they *needed* to get this done. Their reputation, their very survival within the bureaucratic cogwheels of the Hegemony meant they needed to succeed.

Such was the risk of more closely tying oneself to a scheme; but the *reward* would be fantastic.

Adora stared into the flames of the campfire. All around the Magicats had their own campfires going. Several were drinking from flasks of blood, and the sound of murmured conversation echoed through the trees. She took note of the uniforms, the movements and scented the air briefly. Her nose wrinkled and she shook her head as a resigned sigh escaped her lips.. Her eyes shifted up as a figure sat down opposite her and she let a small smile play across her face, "Your majesty."

C'yra leaned forwards and removed her helm, setting it down on the log next to her. She blew out a breath, then unhooked the blood-skein from her belt and took a drink. Her hand shook a little and she shuddered, "How did you know there was a necromancer?"

"It is normal. Roving bands normally have *something* in command. Rarely a necromancer will raise a *mob* and just leave it wandering, growing. Think of them as area denial tactics. But a roving band like this? Always has a commander. Maybe not a necromancer, maybe just some cultist or minor hedge mage with cantrips and the necessary items to raise the dead. In those cases, they just corral their resources until a necromancer can come collect."

She stared back into the flames as silence descended. C'yra broke the silence after a moment, "But you knew where it was. I could sense *something*, but you knew." Her gaze was hard across the flames, "Tell me."

Adora cocked her head then scoffed, “I.”

“?” Cỳra blinked in surprise.

“ Y ou demean me and mine in front of your court, you snub me, you refuse to respect my *rank* and *position* ,” Her gaze moved to behind Cỳra, then took in the whole camp. “And then we take part in this inane demonstration when I could have easily shown you back in Halfmoon.”

Adora drew a small knife from her belt, then pulled an apple from another pouch. She began to slice off segments as Cỳra stared at her, “ Y ou would risk my approval with a tantrum?”

The blonde snorted, then lifted a slice of fruit to her mouth with the blade. She studied Cỳra and shrugged, “I do not need your approval, really. I just need Catra’ s. She *wants* your approval and I will respect that. You.. you I find I am not sure I respect,” she waved her blade towards the Queen and shrugged. A couple of Magicat guards behind the Queen stif fened, but relaxed as Adora adjusted herself, the blade dangling from her fingers as she chewed.

Cỳra snorted, then took a pull from her skein, “I am curious then. Indulge me. I admit I have been.. robust. But you have impressed me. At the very least I am open to negoti-”

"No. I will marry Catra. We will be wedded. She will be happy. It is her choice, not yours," Adora's tone was matter of fact, "Out here, beneath the moon, there are no lies. It is stark black and white. And you have no room to negotiate. You know we are capable. I think you are weak."

Cyra bristled, shocked, "I am weak? How?" she seemed genuinely affronted. Adora shrugged and regarded the Queen flatly. Cyra snorted then smirked, "Well, I do value honesty. So, tell me. And then I will very firmly consider"…

"No," Adora smiled at the woman and took another bite of apple. Cyra blinked, then stood to deliver her rebuttal. Except she swayed as she did so. She blinked in surprise and coughed. Adora sighed, "And that is why."

Cyra staggered again and her guards also stumbled, scrabbling at their throats, "Whwhat did you do?" Cyra croaked as she winced. Adora scoffed.

"I did nothing. You on the other hand…why accept a drink from a changeling?" Adora's gaze drifted up and her arm shot out. One of the guards nearest Cyra was stumbling towards her, but they reeled back suddenly, Adora's knife in their shoulder. Cyra had staggered back into a seated position and stared as her 'guard' rippled and shifted, their form blackening, before revealing a slender green figure with blonde hair and a reptilian face.

Cyra gasped, "DDee?"

The changeling glared at Adora, then smirked, "Oh bravo. Turns out the muscle-head has *some* smarts." But I'm just here to prevent your clear assassination attempt," their voice was oily with faux innocence. Adora chuckled, still seated.

"And the contingent of Scorponi about a couple hundred yards away? Just a random patrol, hmm? And the slowly paralyzed Magicats? I must be so organised," Adora's eyes went wide with mock shock, "You can drop the dagger, by the way."

Dee straightened up, as around the camp, half of the soldiers began to collapse, coughing and sputtering. Captain Kelik staggered into view, "You, your majesty. We have been be-" but his words were cut off as a sword emerged from his chest, right through his armour. The man gurgled in shock, right up until a clawed hand raked across his throat. The vampiric officer hissed as his blood seeped out and he felt. Behind him Captain Velk twitched and grimaced.

"I am sorry, old friend. But this is necessary," he looked at Dee and frowned, then at the camp and called out yelled out, "To arms!"

Adora took a bite from her apple and watched as Magicats drew blades. A few advanced past Dee, who smirked. The blonde warrior sighed, "So, I take it you intend to kill the Queen?" A few of the soldiers paused and uncertainty played in their eyes. Cyra hunched over and hissed, but Adora continued, "Seeing as I am about to die, far from my home and also from my betrothed, can I ask, why?"

She sounded so confused, just baffled. Dee snorted, "Simple. Out with the old, in with the new. If Cyra and Catra had just agreed, well, then you'd have been a well paid mercenary. As is, you're just collateral. And Cyra, I am so sorry. I always liked you, but you and your darling wife, you're just stuck in that hole and, well, the world is changing. The Hegemony doesn't want to just hold the line. You dead? Catra will undountedly want to make changes. Velk, kill the barbarian, please?"

Velk nodded and gestured to his men. One soldier thrust at Adora's back with his spear.

She moved so fast that even the vampires were shocked. Adora spun and grabbed the spear under the blade. She yanked it up and *snapped* the spear-tip off the haft, then drove it *hard* into the soldier's head. It smashed out the back of his head and left him hanging from her grip like a ragdoll. The other soldiers staggered back in shock and Dee actually gurgled in surprise. Adora rolled her shoulders and her cloak fell away. She pushed the corpse away from her and glared at the group.

Shouts from around the camp were followed by screams and sudden deep, guttural growls. The blonde turned and stared at Dee, "No one touches the Queen."

Her body seemed to shimmer in the moonlight. It bulged and grew as Adora's form shifted. In mere seconds, where once a tall blonde woman had stood, now towered a monster from nightmares.

The Magicats shouted as one and a few charged. Velk shrieked out panicked orders, but was cut off as Adora vaulted the man's men and clamped a huge hand on the Captain's head. With a sickening, tearing noise, the Captain's head came free and she tossed it at Dee. The changeling stared as several Magicat soldiers stumbled and staggered backwards. Then they looked at the Queen, still hunched and half slumped on the log. Dee yanked Adora's blade from their shoulder and lunged.

And then they found themselves flying through the air. Something *cracked* as they hit a tree and the world went black.

Adora turned and watched as several of the traitor-cats began to cry out for reinforcements. A few had been in the middle of slaying their comrades - clearly trying to stage something, but none of them had noticed the utter *lack* of sea-farers. Right up until men had been yanked into the trees or axes had buried themselves into skulls.

It was chaos as the traitors, now leaderless, save their corporals, tried to rally against the things in the dark. Sea-farer's darted from the undergrowth to stab and slash. One Magicat tried to skewer Torvald, who now towered over the smaller soldier. The spear plunged into the wolf and it just barked a laugh, before it reached out and hauled the man up and into biting range. A *crunch* later and a mangled body dropped to the forest floor. Torvald then just yanked the spear out and snapped it between his meaty claws.

The sound of cantering hooves caught Adora's attention and she snarled as a Scorponi soldier emerged through the trees on horseback. The soldier had a halberd out and was being followed by

a dozen other riders;further behind came a good two dozen infantry , their armour flapping as they ran. The riders were shocked by what they saw and their horses reared up in surprise.

Adora didnt let them recover . She moved forward, her claw swiping out. The lead rider's horse neighed in shock , then fell as she left a horrible gash in its chest. The lead rider was trapped under the beast and yelled in terror, unable to bring the polearm to bear. Their stinger jabbed up, but Adora caught it and tore it off, then swiped once more to tear the rider's head off.

The rest of the cavalry were shocked. Adora was framed by campfires, which seemed to now be spreading as the fight there spilled over. Traitor magicats howled as they were thrown into the fires and shrieks of pain filled the night air. The Scorponi wavered, before one man yelled a defiant battle cry and spurred his horse forwards.

There was the crack of branches as Kyle plummeted out of a tree and smashed into the rider from above. The horse buckled and collapsed and the rider screamed as the rangy wolf that Kyle had become hefted the man up. With a swift tug,an arm came free, before Kyle threw the rider at the other soldiers. Then, with a roar, he charged them. A second, then a third roar joined him as two more wolf-men came out of the shadows and barreled into the Scorponi, knocking the troops down with their charge. Wide sweeps knocked men flying and sent horses to the ground, neighing in pain. Up close, halberds were no good. Especially when a nine foot tall wolf-monster seemed able to just lift men off their feet and throw them into others. The forest floor became muddy as Scorponi and Magicats tried to rally, tried to fight back. Blood slicked the leaf mold as the vampires tried to out-speed their attackers: their numbers *were* greater, but not

by much and they had been thinned. Six of the Magicats managed to spear Raggi, pinning him down. But before the final blow could be struck, Duncan appeared from the darkness, unchanged, hammers flying. Three of the Magicats fell, their skulls caved in, a fourth with an arm shattered;Raggi had lumbered up and ended the final three in a bloody rage.

These men were used to fighting on the group, in a line, against bunched up foes. But the wolves came from the shadows and snatched men away. They descended from the trees, knocking formations apart, or just plucking soldiers from the ranks to rend them in two. Soldiers broke and fled, trying to escape into the night, only for their cries to echo back to the battlefield.

It was chaos. It was blood. It was madness.

Adora watched it all, then tilted her head back and *howled* .

Chapter 14

Chapter Summary

Plans are afoot in Halfmoon.

Moves are made.

And Dee has a poor choice of words.

Chapter Notes

TW: Character death. Violence.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora being gone was, perhaps, the worst feeling Catra had ever had to experience. Before now she'd been an individual, only concerned for her own well-being and, in some abstract way, the well-being of her people. The former she was able to handle because she could master herself easily: she knew she could tackle issues head on;the latter she handled by fighting the Undead and supporting the decisions of her mothers.

Before now her acquaintances had been just that - people she valued and cared for, but that had a distance to them. She worried, but only in the way a commander worried. She was out with them, and so experienced those hardships alongside them.

But this was different. Oh so different. This time she cared on a level she had never invested in. It gave her a sense of powerlessness that she hadn't experienced for so long, not since that near moment with *Weaver* when she was still a kitten.

And she *missed* the other woman. She'd been content to be a loner before: isolated, an independent bastion. But she had chosen to open herself to the beautiful newcomer and now she couldnt envisage being without her.

It was pain, but a pain she realised she reveled in: it made her feel alive in a way she hadnt really understood with her dalliances and adventures before.

Of course, the whole situation left her frustrated;and Scorpia' s words in the gardens had left her seething. She'd retreated to the soldier's training halls, set behind the Ziggurat, to vent some of that anger. It was there that Pan found her, a pair of smashed training dummies near her, while she was in the process of eviscerating a third.

The Captain of her guard stood by the doorway to the training room and watched as Catra went through several hand-to-hand movements, her speed a terrifying blur of supernaturally enhanced dexterity. She bobbed and struck with such rapidity smoke rose from the wooden dummy from where her claws struck.

Her body was wreathed in a faint red haze as her speed increased, up until she leapt into the air and delivered a round house kick that sent the dummy pinwheeling across the room into a weapons rack. Training staves and wooden swords clattered to the floor as Catra heaved heavy breaths and hissed.

"I don't think Scorpia knows how lucky she is," Pan chuckled as he straightened from his position by the door. He padded across the wooden floor and arched an eyebrow, "All well, your majesty?"

Catra slicked back her hair and exhaled, "This whole thing *stinks*."

"Your mate being sent on some pointless task?" Pan chuckled as he saw Catra's arch gaze, "I know, your highness. I even spoke with the Queens. And Cyrus. Not everything, mind, as you advised on the trip back. But enough. Cyrus thinks it's all sun-blinded hogwash, of course. We were so addled from the day-fighting we exaggerated. And that I am trying to cover for my failure."

Catra scoffed and crossed her arms, "Sounds like Cyrus."

Pan shrugged, "The man's been down here a while, distant from it all. He chafes for the chance to fight. Honestly, a *lot* of the guard, the army, they all do. I think this visit by the Hegemony is stirring up some excitement in the troops. They want to do more than patrol and beat back invaders."

The Princess sighed, "I can't blame them. I've been pushing for more for *years*. But I will not… *cannot*"…

Pan chuckled, "Well, we wouldn't ask you to marry some spoiled bratling from the sands. Honestly, Adora... she suits you, ma'am. Those of us who were there thinks this whole thing stinks. But don't be surprised if Cyrus pushes for a decision. Hopefully he'll support you, if his people report back on Adora favourably."

Catra nodded slowly, "Yeah. I just worry what the Hegemony might try. Scorpia just about admitted they would do *something*."

"Well, whatever happens, we have your back. Now, instead of making kindling, how about you try a dummy that fights back?" He adopted a sparring stance, his tail lashing behind him. Catra snorted.

"Won't your wives be unhappy if I return you to them black and blue?"

"Eh, if I get a massage out of it, who's complaining? Just make it look like I actually gave you a challenge." Pan's voice was only *half* joking. Catra cackled and cracked her knuckles.

"Let's go."

A few hours later, a much more relaxed Catra made her way towards her parent's apartment within the palace. The guards let her through and she navigated down a plush corridor, with a soft carpet and ornate drapes. This was all Melendy's touch: comfort, calm and quiet. When she'd been here, living in these rooms as a kitten, it had been so peaceful, a sanctuary against the coldness and austere nature of the rest of the palace complex.

Melendy was sat on a low couch in the Queen's main living space. It was a little larger than Catra's own room, but purely for the Queen's to relax. Rooms led off to other areas: a bathing space, another private library and, of course, their bedroom. Melendy looked up from a small book she was leafing through and smiled at Catra, "Deartest, you seem in fine spirits. But I imagine you are missing your mate, no?"

Catra actually blinked in surprise at that, "Um, well, yes. But, it's… not"…

"Darling, come now . I know that she and you are basically together. And so does your mother."

That caused Catra's expression to shift and she let out a frustrated sigh, which just brought out a gentle laugh from Melendy . The black-furred Queen swung her legs from the couch and beckoned for her daughter to sit. Catra shook her head, but slumped next to her mother, "So, why all the charade?"

"Why do you think dear?" Melendy gently prodded at Catra's head, "Your mother is all about expecting you to answer and solve the puzzle. But if you *really* want my answer?" she left the question hanging. Catra just groaned and slumped forwards.

"She wants me to decide... But..." her brow furrowed and then she swore, "But for *me*. That's what this is, right? Not about the right *political* choice but... a choice I can be ok with?"

"Yes. And you haven't," Melendy shrugged, her smile small and amused. Catra scoffed.

"I think I *have*. I made it clear!"

"Well, you said the words... but did you *follow them up*?"

Catra stared at her mother, brow crinkled, "What do you *mean*?"

"Did you actually stare down Cyra, definitively *say* how things were going to be? Or... did you hedge and prevaricate and... let things happen, hm?" Melendy placed a hand on Catra's knee, "You are going to be Queen, my dear. Where Adora features in that will be *entirely* up to you, because that girl is devoted to you in a way that is probably not good for her. She thinks you hung the moon, it's so obvious that even the Chamberlain noticed and that man has been oblivious to my lady-in-waiting's pining for seven *years*."

Catra flushed and her tail whipped back and forth, "But…no it can't be *that* easy?"

Melendy shrugged, "It can. I know I'm probably ruining Cyra's game and I am *embarrassed* and, well, a little ashamed I decided to let it play out. I will agree *partially* with Cyra, in that we need to be *sure*, love. But if you follow a path, it will dictate *everything*. If you follow our footsteps, you are always in our shadow, love. But…you bringing Adora to the feast, defying us that way…that showed the direction. Honestly, Cyrus' little ruse was a good idea, but frankly Cyra does need a *little* self reassurance. Beyond that," She made a face, "I think decisiveness may have"…

Catra leaned away from her mother and shook her head, "It's all… all just *games*. I don't believe for a SECOND that mother would have just…folded," she glared at Melendy who did wince a little.

"No, probably not. We asked. We set out your options, love. And I let Cyra push *too* hard. But in this moment, now, this is *your* choice, and we will respect it. You are a grown woman, my daughter. One who WILL lead. So, lead, choose and live with the choice. But be *yourself*. That's what we have said and expected."

The Princess continued to glare at her mother, but softened at the gentle smile on the woman's face, "I…I love her, mom. And I'm worried. Why did mother take her out there?"

"Because, as I said, although it is your choice and we can see you getting there, we also need to validate." Melendy chuckled, a soft, lilting sound, "And your mother is protective. She needs to know Adora can protect you. And, well...we need to see if she can adapt to circumstances. I'm not sure *what* will happen, but Cyra is always on edge."

"The Hegemony?" Catra's eyes narrowed. Melendy shrugged.

"Most likely. A faction, an advisor, possibly the Princess. They may make a play. But honestly, do you have faith in Adora?" Catra just nodded and Melendy's smile broadened, "Then we have no need to worry. Now, does she have any particular customs or expectations?"

Catra blinked in surprise, "Um, just...well, she uh, she mentioned a ritual."

"Ah! How *rustic*. Oh, have a sniff of this, isn't it...interesting? The flavour I mean?"

Catra blinked in surprise as Melendy raised a goblet from the table next to her chaise. Catra sniffed at the thick, red liquid inside. She shrugged, "It's...kind of bland, really. Iron, but...that's it."

"AH, your palette has been spoiled by *someone*," Melendy's eyes narrowed, "Should I be worried that your mother will return and find me *dull*?" Her expression shifted to mirth as Catra blushed again,

"Oh my darling, I tease. I am glad that *that* is not an issue. Having a drink from your soulmate *should* ruin your taste for all other things. Heaven's knows it did for me."

"Mom!"

"What? But, well, it does make other things taste bland. You forget the flavours, the feelings. Makes it easy to not notice. Oh, yes, that reminds me." she plucked her book back up and handed it to Catra, "A simply fascinating chapter here."

Catra blinked, not following her mom's switchback of a conversation. Cautiously she took the book and frowned at the title of *Herbology and Alchemy:a primer*. Her mom had been the experimenter in the family: Cyra was the warrior, mostly, with Melendy leaning towards the more *scholarly* arts. Of course, that had shifted back and forth over the years - hard to stay as one thing for a milenia.

She sighed and stared at the page, which listed a few applications for Wolfsbane. Then her eyebrows rose and her gaze switched to her mother, who had the goblet close to her mouth. She met her mom's eyes and the Queen tapped a claw against the metal of the goblet before she took a tiny sip. Then the woman winked and leaned forwards, "Sometimes it is better to *wait* for one's favourite tincture, hmmm?"

Catra's eyes widened as Melendy then quaffed the whole lot and smacked her lips. Catra made to rise, but Melendy just shook her head and glanced about. Catra sat, her expression confused and distraught, "Mmmom?"

Melendy's eyes twinkled, "Fear not, little one. Your love will return. As will mine. It takes more than a few snide tricks to pull the rug out from our family, you know?" Her voice was calm, cheerful, her smile now thin, and predatory. Catra subtly shifted her gaze and noted the maids waiting just out of sight. She relaxed and stared at her mother and nodded slowly.

"Well, you seem to have *all* the answers."

"Hmm, not quite, just an understanding of the rules. Sometimes you need to flip the board, dear. Know when to show your hand of course, like you did with the banquet. And in the garden. Oh yes, I heard! But *you* are the one who guides things, makes those decisions. And people will, I am sure, follow them. Like trailing a thread for a kitten?"

Catra nodded slowly, eyes narrowed. Cyra was the trickster, but Melendy had her own ways too. Like dangling a string which a kitten could not help but bat at. She rose and handed the book back to her mother, "Well, thank you mom. And for being supportive. I have... A lot to really think about."

"I am sure you do. Now... I feel a little faint, clearly your mother's absence is weighing on me. I think I may just rest my eyes for a little, darling. I am sure I will see you later."

The Princess nodded and bit her lip with worry. But her mother's easy smile and mischievous wink said it all. *Worry not.*

She left, watching a maid refill Melendy's goblet as she did so.

Scorpia stalked up and down her quarters, her face flushed and her pincers clasped in front of her, "Am..am I not good enough?" She looked over at Perfuma, who stood with a few of the other ladies in waiting Scorpia had as part of her entourage. Perfuma sighed and stepped forwards, whilst just out of eyeline Huntara, the hulking orc bodyguard, rolled her eyes and grunted.

Scorpia paced again, then slumped onto a plush couch. She glared around at the stonework as Perfuma moved a little closer. The slim blonde smiled and shrugged, "A battle is won in the first or even second fight, my love"…

"I did with you!" Scorpia protested. She looked at Perfuma sheepishly, "Not that you were easier! No, I..I mean that it just… worked. WHY doesn't it just WORK here? Can't she see what I can offer? How we can help?"

Perfuma's smile was a *little* brittle but she sighed and glanced at Huntara, who smirked back at her, "W ell, we are all aware of the benefits of what you bring, my love. But perhaps the approach was a

little too forceful. You know Catra, does she respond to.force?Did I?"

Scorpia slumped and shook her head, "N. No you didnt but.darn, it would be *easier* if I didnt *get* it."

Huntara harrumphed, "My lady?"

"Adora!She' s strong and charming and.well, *gracious* !"Scorpia scratched her pincers together then leaned back on the couch, "But she isnt *right* for Catra. Ive known her longer ."

A door slamming derailed the conversation for a moment as Lashor stalked into the room. His reptilian eyes took in the royal party and he smiled a thin, sickly smile, his purple scales pulling back around his jaw . He bowed, his chains off office rattling as his robe fluttered, "My Princess, my apologies, I thought you would be entertaining the Princess by now."

His voice was all political sincerity, but there was a mild edge of barely contained frustration there. Scorpia huffed and flung her pincers up.

"She is..Being well, really *annoyingly* reluctant."

Lashor twitched, "Y our fabled charm will, I am sure, work wonders."

Huntara schooled her features as Perfuma glared at the lizard. Scorpia sighed heavily, "Well, I um...I think that I may not have quite got this one. I think Adora is too much of an obstacle."

The Ambassador growled, then chuckled, "Well, one soon to be removed. And, well, I believe there are things occurring in the palace that means Catra will be very much looking for *friends* soon. Fear not, my Princess, you will have your *happy ending* ."

Scorpia looked up, a faint smile on her face, "So...you managed to get rid of them? I bet thatw as expensive. Did we also manage to get them working for us?"

Lashor chuckled again, "Ah, my dear Princess. I admire your political savvy in keeping things opaque. Well, I feel our solution was remarkably cheap. Dee will no doubt be crowing about the whole thing afterwards. Of course, there may be *collateral* damage. And Catra will need a *strong arm* on which to lean, if you get my meaning."

Perfuma blinked in shock and Scorpia frowned, before she bit her lip, "Are...that doesn't...we aren't going to...what will the Queen think?"

Lashor's smirk shifted and he let out a hiss, "My Princess, let me worry about this. Catra will be Queen, if I understand the current *political* climate. And she will need a bastion. Be sure to be that one.

Play your role and you get everything you ever wanted! Isn't that what we're here for, hmmm?" his sibilant tones still had an edge of impatience to them.

Huntara rumbled a chuckle, which interrupted them all, "I think you underestimate the woman. She's not just some thug."

Lashor waved a clawed hand, "Twelve men against a contingent of *vampire soldiers*? I mean, I know the Halfmooners's are out of proper practice in warfare, but still... humans stand not a chance. Now, I think either the Queen will be supportive or she will not be an issue in any event. She is wily and will see the strategic benefit. If twelve mercenaries are easily removed, well, then she will return and embrace us with open arms I am sure."...

Scorpia nodded slowly, but her frown was pensive. She rose and brushed her dress down then sighed, before speaking absently, "I... think I will have a lie down. I hope that it all comes out as planned. I know these things usually do. Um Fuma, do you mind if... if I just have a moment?"

Perfuma looked stricken, but nodded slowly. Scorpia smiled wanly, before her expression hardened and drifted through the curtains into her bedchambers. Lashor snorted, "Eugh, I do not understand how she is so... never mind, I speak *out of turn*," his voice was a sneer. Huntara turned and glared at him, but paused as Perfuma laid a gentle hand on her arm. Lashor glanced at the gesture then shook his head, a condescending smile on his face, before he turned and left. Huntara sighed and covered Perfuma's hand with her own. She gave the blonde a pained smile.

"This is hard. For you."

Perfuma nodded, then looked at the curtains, "The things we do for love."

Huntara winced and nodded, squeezing Perfuma's hand. Her thumb ran over the smaller woman's knuckles, "Aye," this drew a sad smile from the blonde, who reached up and brushed Huntara's face. She stepped back and pulled away from the Orc, then turned towards a table that held a huge pile of food. The woman stacked a plate, then moved off through the curtains. The Orc watched the blonde go and grimaced.

"The things we do for love," she muttered.

A horse thundered down the cobble street, scattering the populace as it came. It had been a good two days since the Queen's departure and a ragged rider and horse drew worried whispers from the citizen. The beast cantered past the gate guards and rattled to a halt before the palace gates. The ride vaulted from his steed and sprinted with supernatural speed into the throne room. High up, a feline Princess noted the arrival of the messenger and sprinted down towards the Throne room.

Melendy sat on the dais, head resting in one hand which she had propped on the throne arm, her gaze somewhat vacant. Around her, advisors chattered and whispered, whilst the Scorponi contingent waited at the foot of the dais, patiently expecting another audience - they'd been petitioning for more time with Catra and Melendy, of course. The rider sprinted up the dais then skidded to a halt before the throne. He fell to one knee, panting heavily, "My lady! Your Majesty! Dire news! Betrayal most foul!"

Melendy stood, her gait unsteady, and frowned, her gaze focusing in on the man, "What? What news of my wife? You were one of her party? What is this of betrayal?"

The man swallowed and looked up, "The sea-farers, they attempted to capture the Queen! With intent to ransom her! It was a surprise assault, they ambushed the party and... and..." he swallowed, clearly pained, "And the one named Adora struck down our Queen!"

Gasps echoed around the halls, followed by a shouted, "NO!"

Catra sprinted into the room just in time to hear the fateful words. The rider stood and cowered back as the Princess streaked up the steps of the dais to stand before him, her eyes aflame with rage. A strange cloud of dark shadow coalesced around her frame. The man quavered and his ears flattened but he stammered out, "I'll only convey what Commander Velk bade! Kelik and the Queen, struck down. I... I was sent back to... to report. He... he said he expected collusion here too!"

Catra reared back as muttering moved about the room, some of the advisors exchanging concerned glances. Melendy waved a hand and stepped forwards, "This.. I..I..." and then she swooned, her eyes rolling up into her head. Catra darted forwards and caught her mother, laying her down on the cold stone floor. She looked around at the stunned faces of the advisors and then called out, "Physician!"

Catra paced in front of the closed door to her mother's bed chambers. She'd been ushered out by the various doctors and alchemists and the guards had, seemingly, been told to bar her entry. She frowned as she glanced at the door, then startled as a soft cough drew her attention.

She turned to find Perfuma and Scorpia stood nearby. The taller woman looked nervous, but seemed to rally, "Um, hi. I uh...Is your mom..um..how..how are you?"

Catra's gaze was like ice, but she seemed to calm. Her jaw worked and a thin smile came to her lips, "How do you think, your highness? I trust you heard the declaration?"

"Um, yes. I am..I am sorry that Adora was..not what you hoped. I cannot begin to understand her motive, her..her plan here? It makes no sense!"

The feline studied Scorpia then shrugged, "Mercenary , though, right? Maybe a better offer came from somewhere, like you *said* ." her question was left hanging. Scorpia held up her pincers.

"I can assure you, Wildc- *Catra* , your highness, we did not try to bribe her. I promise you that. I can show you our treasury here, all accounted for! No trinkets, nothing missing. No, no this..this is just..and your *mom* , I"…

Scorpia looked genuinely stricken. Perfuma didn't look much better . In the background, the looming figure of Huntara just remained stoic. Catra studied the two closer women, then snorted, "It like it matters. I can't even see my *living* mother."

"Well, um..you are welcome to join us, if you..you need a friend, you know? No pressure, this isn't the time, I know . I just wanted to let you know that I um, I'm here. Like you were for me, when I was all alone."

Catra regarded the Princess then nodded curtly, "Thank you. That… that's appreciated."

Scorpia nodded rapidly, then took Perfuma's hand and guided her away. Catra just caught the faintest whisper form the blonde, *"better ,be gentle. Be kind."*

Another clatter of feet from the other direction made her turn once more and her eyes narrowed as Cyrus moved up, with a small contingent of guards. The man gave her a wan smile, "Your highness. I know now is... not the best of times but I need a word."

The Princess studied the man, then nodded slowly. She followed the General, noting the guards falling in around her. They trooped through the corridors until they found an unoccupied stateroom. Cyrus ushered Catra inside, then closed the door. He gestured to a vacant chair, then slumped into another one. Catra eyed him, then sat carefully. The General scrubbed at his whiskers and sighed, "Your highness I... I am sorry. This is not the burden I am sure you wish to be bearing. But things are now tense."

The Princess sat and stared at him. Her posture was rigid and she cocked her head to one side, "Explain, General. My *mother* is apparently dead, whilst my other mother lies comatose. I do not have time for dancing around things."

Cyrus chuckled mirthlessly, then sat up and rested his arms on his knees. His armour clinked as he moved, the torchlight reflecting off the gold inlay in the metal. He stared at her and sighed, "I will be blunt then. We are weak. But we have an opportunity. It is ugly to say this, but we cannot afford a power vacuum. The people feel safe, but this strikes at the heart of us. And, well, there are questions being asked," he looked pensive and shrugged, "About you."

"Me?" Catra's tone was neutral. Cyrus nodded.

"Your supposed ally is responsible for the death of our Queen Cyra and now Queen Melendy falls ill, after you were seen frequenting her chambers."

"She's my moons-blessed MOTHER. By the stars, Cyrus!"

He held up a hand to calm her, "I know that, Catra! By the stars, we're practically litter-mates! I KNOW. But you must understand how this looks. There is a chance that… that your ascension to the throne will be tainted."

"Wait, my *what?*" Catra frowned, "No, Melendy is… she is…" her knuckled tightened and she bit her lip, "She will wake, surely? I mean, she has plans, she said she had a *plan* ."

Cyrus frowned, "What plan?"

Catra just waved a hand, "They ALWAYS have plans, games. She… she wouldn't have been taken in by poison."

The General's expression was neutral, "Who said anything about *poison* , Catra?" The Princess glared at him and he just shrugged, "I am merely asking."

"And I am *speculating* . So, what *is* the issue? The physicians have not spoken to me."

"And neither me. I only just came up. I had to debrief the soldier . I am afraid it seems likely that your friends compromised the staff and likely intended to kill Melendy while having Cyra as a hostage. Except it didnt turn out well."

"But *why* ?" Catra hissed. Cyrus shrugged.

"To guarantee the marriage, maybe? Or as some of the advisors are saying, to finalise a coup. There is suspicion that" he winced, "that it may have been *you* to poison your mother, under the influence of these barbarians."

Catra stared at him and snorted, "Unwise to say that, if it was me, surely?"

Cyrus blinked and frowned, then shook his head, "No, I mean. I know you wouldnt! I am just explaining, your highness. And anyway, my guards are outside," he smirked, "If you were to strike me down, that would be sloppy. And you arent *sloppy* . I hate to say it, but this this is a risky time and this may be an opportunity ."

That made Catra growl, low, "Oh do *tell* ."

"You are to be *Queen* , Catra. We dont have the luxury for long periods of uncertainty. THe military is already restless, having been kept down here for decades. We run sorties, skirmishes, but never *strike* . Your mothers, may the moons bless them and the stars protect them, they kept us safe but also so distant from the other nations. We are losing influence, we are losing the *war* . And now we

have these sea-faring barbarians thinking they can strike at us? The Hegemony now risks seeing us as vulnerable - will they continue to protect our flank, or will they increase demands."

"They already want me to marry Scorpia." Catra started, but Cyrus interrupted her.

"And that would put you in a position of *authority*. But to delay now? We are in a very weak position, your highness. To marry now would secure our relationship with them. But to deny it, well, diplomatically, snubbing them *and* seeming to have no clear succession"…

"Succession *is* clear, but unnecessary"…

Cyrus winced again, "And if the court rebels? Doesn't support your coronation? Infighting, civil war, my lady? What if the Hegemony decides to act on that? It's ugly but you and Scorpia, are you not friends? And maybe a marriage, leaving the city for a while to tour the lands, it would put a *lot* of the malingering to rest. It would inspire the people, reassure the people. And then…then we can do what must be done, what *you* have been saying to the Queens all along - we must take the *fight* to the Horde. And with the Hegemony. I know you can persuade Princess Scorpia to give us troops, weapons, mages. We can fulfill your ambition. Stars and moons willing, Melendy will recover, but better we are prepared, we are strong. Please, your highness. I do not wish to see my city fall, to be some vassal state. But if we can push the Horde away, surely we should do it on our terms?"

His voice was sincere, intense. He leaned forwards and Catra studied him. She let out a breath and sagged, biting her lip. Then she nodded, "Let me…let me think."

"We have no time, highness. A Queen is dead. The enemy is at the gates. Metaphorically. We need *decisions* ."

Catra looked up and swallowed, "Then I guess I have no choice, do I?"

Cyra sat up and hissed, mostly in frustration. She rolled her shoulders, then stood. All around her, flames flickered and shadows moved. She could hear screams and yells in the darkness of the forest. Large shapes darted about, their movements usually followed by a shrill scream or the sound of metal tearing.

The Queen cracked her neck and studied the dancing shadows, then turned and spotted a recumbent form, slumped at the base of a tree. She snarled and moved so fast it was as if she teleported. She squatted down and hissed, her tail lashing side to side, "Foolish."

Dee groaned and their eyes fluttered open. Slitted pupils dilated, then expanded as they regarded Cyra with concussed shock, "Wh… you.."

“Wolfsbane? Silver powder? You take me for some watered-down half breed. A sore throat and a headache is all that will give me, you dolt. Clever masking the taste. Some trick you picked up no doubt.”

Dee just burbled a chuckle, “Know your enemy, darling. Living with Catra, working with you, always pays to learn contingencies. You know that. So much *lore* on you people. Garlic, pah, just seasoning. But silver, oh, you don't like that, mhm, mhhhm. Your little toy soldiers didn't do so well.”

Cyra looked around at the carnage and chuckled, “Neither did yours. The Hegemony, really?”

Dee shrugged, then winced. A snap of a twig made Cyra leap back a foot. She crouched and glared as a Scorponi soldier staggered through the camp. The man stared about, then spotted Cyra. He carried a spear, but it looked bent, half broken. As he spotted the Queen, his eyes took on a crazed expression and he charged.

A moment later Cyra was behind him. The man shrieked as her claws bit into his neck, where the armour was weak. She stood on the base of the man’s tail, one foot out, holding the stinger at bay. Her gaze landed on Dee and she sneered, “You really know *nothing* about us.”

Black miasma seeped from her and surrounded the soldier. His scream gurgled into nothing as he *desiccated* in front of Dee. Skin dried and shriveled, eyes shrank and fizzled out. Carapace cracked and splintered, until all that was left was a husk in armour. With

another flash, Cỳra was in front of Dee once more, whilst behind her the soldier crumbled to dust. She smirked down at the changeling. Dee licked their lips, their eyes wide. Slowly they struggled to sit up and Cỳra watched with curiosity . The lizard snickered, "W ow, some trick. Please, no encore though. So, poison didn't work and, well..a blade won't. But how do you think your friends will take it, considering all these little *shenanigans* you're pulling."

"Friends?" Cỳra asked. A low growl made her fur stand on end and she looked to her right.

A massive wolf-beast stalked forwards, passing through a curtain of flame. Cỳra' s nose twitched and she scented something on the air. How she hadn't sense it before astounded her . The *blood* of these creatures, the sheer *animal* nature: it was nearly overwhelming. She had an urge to run, to flee. Her vampiric nature recognised another beast and wanted to fight.

The creature was huge, covered in white fur. In one hand it held a *sword* . The huge blade looked more like a dagger in it's clawed grip. The creature stalked towards her, then paused. Cỳra had been awake for the initial fight, but had stayed down, content to let Adora fight, to test her mettle, but the poison hadn't been *entirely* ineffective - it had disoriented her for a moment.

She stared into blue-grey eyes that seemed to regard her with a level of measure interest.

Then the beast drove the blade into Dee's leg. The changeling shrieked in shock and pain. As Cỳra watched, shocked, the wolf shrank down. The transformation was strange to watch - not sudden, but not horrific. There were clear moments of i *n between* but they faded fast, until a naked blonde stood before her, streaked in blood, towering above Cỳra. Adora planted her hands on her hips and chuckled, "Y ou live then?"

"T akes more than that to kill me. The fae dropped mountains on my ancestors. A bad drink is nothing."

Adora snorted, "N ot nothing. A travesty . Ruining a good drink," she looked down at Dee, "So this one was *not* part of your scheming?"

Cỳra studied the blonde. She noticed more of the beasts emerging from the shadows. Some carried bodies, others just *parts* . All were blood stained and had steam pouring from them in the cool night air. Cỳra took them all in as Adora cocked her head. The Queen just snorted, "N. N ot my scheme."

"But I imagine you knew?"

Cỳra sighed and folded her arms, a gesture very reminiscent of her daughter, "I suspected *something* . Mostly I believed Dee was here to spy on you, to report back. And I expected someone to maybe try something. I did genuinely want to see how you performed. At the very least I wanted to offer some sort of contract and"…

Adora leaned forwards, "I am marrying your daughter . Agree or get out of my way. These are the terms. Also, I saved your life."

Cyra stared at her and then sighed, "W as it ever thus. I know my daughter, Adora. I think you were always the option. Regardless what I said," she looked down at Dee, "And regardless of what you and yours thought."

The changeling whimpered and glared up at Adora, "What, *are* you?"

"A person who knows of changelings. Duncan, bring the chains." Behind Adora, Duncan emerged from the smoke. He unhooked his hammers from the chain about his waist, then bound Dee in them. The changeling struggled and howled as their skin hissed against the cold iron. Adora nodded and then looked back at Cyra, "So, all a game. To what end?"

"T o make Catra choose, of course. She is to be Queen, and I needed to be sure, once we knew you were a possibility."

"But you were willing to pawn her to the Hegemony? Like some brood mare?" Adora' s tone was cold and Cyra tilted her chin back.

"Duty is"…

“Speak not of duty unless *you* are willing to make the sacrifice,” Adora snarled. Around the clearing the wolves shifted their stances, “You are content to play games but now I say *no more*. You want *value*, you want to place a price on your own daughter’s happiness? I am tempted to gut you. Or just punch you through a tree.”

Cyra scoffed in shock, “You could try.”

Adora blinked. Then she punched Cyra. The strike sent the vampire Queen tumbling through the air. She spun, then managed to regain herself and flashed forwards in a cloud of black magic. She slammed into Adora and sent the wolf-woman backwards. She knelt atop the warrior, claw raised, black magic coalescing in her claws, ready to strike, “You *dare*?”

The blonde smirked up at the Queen, “Better. Less talking, more *doing.”*

Cyra blinked in surprise then flexed her jaw. Her glare intensified, “You *hit* me.”

“Yes. Now, either try to strike me, or let me. I have a woman to save.”

The Queen frowned then reared back as Adora rolled them. The Queen scrambled back and regarded the towering beasts around her. None had moved to strike her and she felt, for the first time,

vulnerable. They hadn't been worried about their leader *at all* . She frowned at the woman, "You expect foul play?"

Adora nodded, "As do you. They tried to kill *you* , your highness. What may they have planned for your wife, your daughter. This was to get us out of the way."

"We need to return"…

"And if they bar the way? We took them by surprise this time, but your city is entrenched. No, we must gather my crew ," Adora looked down at Dee, then bent to yank her blade free from the changeling's leg, "But first, we must help your people."

Cyra watched as the wolves set down the bodies around her . She watched them move with almost tender care. Some of her men groaned, clearly just poisoned, but a few had been stabbed, hacked at by the traitors. She watched as Kelik's body was hefted forward by the one named Torvald;the massive wolves yanked the blade free from the fallen Commander's back, then cradled him carefully. She stared as the wolf pricked its own arm with its fangs, then let the blood pour into the man's mouth.

"A trick of yours, right?" Cyra glanced to her left and realised the Skald stood there. The man was practically crimson from the blood all over his body, "I heard your lot were practically indestructible. I mean, immortal in more ways than one. Bar a beheading and fire, of course."

Cỳra frowned at the man, then looked back as her men, her loyal men, were carried into the clearing and set aside. She saw other wolves carrying the *traitors* to fires, where their bodies were tossed into the flames. Dismembered body parts pined the flame, whilst a few whimpering prisoners were hauled together and bound. She then looked back to the Skald and sighed.

"Yes. We are durable. Removed a limb and we can reattach it. Gut us, spear us, slice us, as long as there is blood, we can recover. But it takes more the older the wound, the more serious the damage. That is our blessing. And our curse. We must take from others to prolong ourselves. And, of course, if we are wounded in daylight, the wounds are permanent."

The Skald nodded, "Quite the thing to admit."

"I have a feeling you know already," Cỳra added wryly, "Your Adora is well informed."

"And I am sure you are aware of much about us, hmm?" Kyle chuckled, "We will burn the traitors, leave the parts out for the crows."

Cỳra glanced at the man but paused as Adora came up. The blonde gestured to Kelik and Cỳra let out a breath as the man coughed weakly. His throat was knitting shut, as the wound in his chest sealed. Other soldiers were groaning as they too came round. The

warrior-woman chuckled, "We will carry them. We cannot dally here, lest they send more once they realise their ploy has failed. We must be swift and most of your horses are gone."

The Queen grimaced, "You clearly are not the most *animal* friendly, are you?"

Adora chuckled, "I love horses. They merely tolerate me. In the interests of saving our loved ones, will you ride with me?"

Cyra chuckled, "What would Catra think?"

"Ah, now you care?" Adora shot back. The Queen just snorted, then shrugged. She looked at the groggy face of her Commander and sighed, "Kelik, you live, you old dog."

"Take more than a back-stabbing arsehole to end me, ma'am," his bleary gaze landed on Adora, "Um. You are naked. And I am alive. Or did"…

"Do not finish that sentence," Adora growled. The Commander wisely just nodded, "Mount up the survivors, burn the corpses. The Prisoners we cannot carry. I will not leave an enemy at my back, nor an informant for the foe. These are you lands, your highness."

Cỳra nodded then drew a slow breath. Her eyes closed for a moment before snarled and black miasma coated her claws. She looked at Adora, then at the defeated prisoners, "They tried to kill us. And they wanted to hurt my daughter and my *wife* ,"she stalked towards the bound Magicats and Scorponi, unsheathing her blades as she advanced, "Oh, I think I know what to do."

Dee shuddered and turned away as the men began to scream in terror. Adora nodded and watched as Cỳra dispatched the traitors. It was quick and clean - the vampires turning to dust as their heads fell, the Scorponi slumping as easily. The warrior then gestured to the group, "W e ride. Kyle, bring the changeling. They will see this."

—

The ride was a change of pace for Cỳra - half her men rode horses, doubled up on their backs, whilst others rode on the backs of these werewolf beasts. She herself clung to Adora's fur as they ate the miles. Theyd given a map to her men, then left them in the dust, able to move through the forests with ease. The moon was setting and the sun rose, then made to set again as they approached the coast. It was near to where her daughter had met these strange people a bare while ago.

As they approached, the trees became more sparse. The howls of the wolf-beasts were haunting as the night began to draw in once more and a distant response echoed back. As they drew nearer to their destination Cỳra saw more figures in the shadows of the trees - human shaped, keeping pace with the wolves, if barely.

Their band broke through the trees and found themselves atop a bluff, a cliff before them and beyond that, a mist shrouded sea. Adora stood straight up and Cỳra slid from her back. She watched the woman change and marveled at her. The cold air of the sea seemed to not phase the warrior at all, nor her fellows.Dee whimpered as they were tossed to the ground. Their jurney had afforded some time to press the changeling of the plan - it seemed half baked at best. Some grand idea to force the marriage, to place Halfmoon firmly in the pincer of the Hegemony.

Risky, but not without merit. And with the aide of several of her *own* court. Dee had kept the names quiet, clearly wishing to bargain for that information.

A group of clothed humans dashed up, but Cỳra realised they were anything but. One, a tall woman with red hair approached Adora and clasped at the warrior-chief's forearm. She glanced at Cỳra, then arched an eyebrow at the blonde, "Y ou traded up already?"

Adora scoffed, "Hardly . Mother-in-binding."

"Bold, what does Catra think?"The red-head' s face fell when she saw Adora's expression and she nodded slowly, "I will rally the camp. We heard your summons, of course. Are you here to?"..

"Y es."

Cỳra bent down and hauled Dee to their feet. She dragged the changeling to the cliff-bluff and Cỳra followed. The other wolves hung back. Adora drew a breath, then tilted her head back. In human form, her howl was still *haunting* . It was layered with something else, something unearthly, that let it carry across the winds. The breeze whipped up and the woman' s blonde hair danced about behind her.

Dee was made to kneel as Adora smiled thinly, "W atch, changeling. See how badly you have *miscalculated* . See your plans, your schemes ready to be brought to ruin. All this for *naught* ."

There was silence on the winds until an answering howl echoed from the sea. Then another. And another. And *another* . A cascading crescendo of voices as, from the fog, the shapes sails and prows broke through the murk. Ships, first one, then five, then ten, then *dozens* , emerged from the mists, torches burning on their decks. A fleet of longboats crashed through the waves, heading for the stony shore. Distant shapes worked ropes and clattered about their decks.

Dee stared, shocked, then yelped as Adora hauled them to their feet. She spun the changeling and held them up by their shirt. Dee swallowed, "I. I have, I made a mistake, I just. you understand, Catra is, well, I thought I was being *paid* ! Look, you're savvy , I can work for you. I know them, know what they're doing. I can help you! For a price, I know you won't trust me, but"…

"So willing to betray . What would stop you doing likewise?" Adora sighed and shook her head, "But you are no warrior . Those soldiers Cyra slew , they raised their blades, they knew their consequences. But you? You are not worth sullying a blade for. You skulk, you are weak. And you must live with the knowledge of your failure. Everyone will know of it - you will never work again."

Dee nodded, "Yes, I mean, I promise. I will go and I will never bother anyone I wont. I vow by the clear *love* you have for Catra I will never"…

Adora smiled and nodded, "I know . I know."

"So you will let me go?"

The blonde nodded. Dee relaxed, then yelped as Adora gave a sharp push. Cyra blinked as the changeling tumbled over the cliff.

Dee tumbled down, their last sight that of Adora, blood-streaked and moon-bathed, hair whipping in the wind, before they hit the sharp rocks below with a final, sickening, crack.

Adora let out a breath, then looked at Cyra, "No one threaten my *sjelevenn* . Now , will you accept my aid in liberating your city?"

The Queen stared at Adora as the red headed woman from before strode up to drape a cloak across the blonde's shoulders. Duncan stood nearby, Adora's sword held almost reverently in his hands. Kyle nodded slowly and watched the Queen. Cyra turned to stare down at the beach where the first of the ships were making landfall. She watched as hulking shapes leapt from the boats to haul them up the beach. Moonlight glinted from armour and weapons, whilst human and were-beast cried out to one another.

Adora had brought an army. Cyra swallowed as the dire threats spouted by Shadow Weaver echoed in her mind. She had scarce believed them, fixated on the possibility. But now she had a true inkling of the potential. And the threat.

But if she was being truly honest…

She turned to look at Adora and tilted her chin up, "I dont think I need to tell you what I would do to save my family."

Adora nodded, "Then we are of one purpose. What is the term I have heard here? Oh yes," she smirked, "Unleash the dogs of war"?

Chapter End Notes

Oh no! What's gonna HAPPEN

A lot, clearly.

Question is - do I leave this as a cliff hanger and leave it for a THIRD standalone orrrr...

Ah I'm gonna finish this one properly , fear not!

Chapter 15

Chapter Summary

Everyone's playing chess, Catra's just playing for time.

Cyrus leaned back in his chair and sighed. Candles flickered in sconces on the walls of his office. His quarters in the palace were not as opulent as that of the heir or her mothers, but they were still plush. He reached up and massaged at his temples, then reached for a cup of warm, sticky blood. He supped at the mixture and sighed with contentment, before he returned his gaze to the documents before him.

Most were standard reports - the usual banality of being a garrison commander: requisitions, daily orders details, updates from the gates and beyond. The note from Velk was what had his attention, however. A simple missive stating *It is done* . He stared at the small scroll and sighed.

It gave him no real pleasure, beyond that of knowing a duty had been done. His allies in court would be satisfied, of course: the nobles and merchants of Halfmoon ever jostled and chafed against the sheer static nature of things. Bad enough that the court never really *changed* , but to be stuck in a stalemate with the Horde just gave a sense of dreary inevitability. And that the Queens seemed content to wait things out, or maintain some sort of equilibrium vexed many.

It would be a lie to say he wasn't swayed by *other* things of course. The promise of power ever had a pull on him, and the current station

he held had always felt lacking;a commander , but never *leading* ;a warrior but never *fighting* . Of course, when he had been offered the chance to go, he'd always been busy or had duties - that was besides the point. Now , however, *now* things could change. Provided their willful princess played her part, of course.

A knock at the door made him pause. He called out, "Enter!" and smirked as a guard swung the heavy, wooden portal open, "Ah, Pan. You have news, I trust?"

Captain Pan stepped into the study and clasped a fist to his chest, his black armour like oil in the candle-light, "Reporting as requested, sir. I am pleased to inform you that the Princess is entertaining Princess Scorpia currently. I am due to meet with her later, but our prior conversation indicates she is...understanding of the reality of things."

Cyrus gestured to the chair opposite his desk, then reached for a carafe that sat next to his paperwork. He topped up his own goblet, then poured a generous measure of blood into a second goblet, when he slid across the desk to Pan. The other magicat nodded and took the goblet. Cyrus raised his own and smirked, "To progress. Sad times, but...we must look forwards."

Pan nodded, and drank as Cyrus did. He sighed happily, "Good stuff f. Fresh too, someone I know?"

Cyrus chuckled, "I have a regular . She is always happy to help keep things topped up."

The Captain grinned and held up a hand, "Say no more, sir . I wouldnt wish to run afoul! Always nice to have a ready and eager supply. Never touch another man's source, you know?"

"Too true! So, tell me, truly , is the Princess *really* amenable? I mean, it's a *terrible shock* . One mother dead, the other on death's door. Is she... Fit?"

Pan stared into the goblet then sighed, "Honestly , sir? I think she's in shock. Capable, mind. But perversely, I think she's more upset about that Adora woman," he took another swig, "We need her, sir. To rally the men. She's been out there, advocating for a charge. Hate to say it but maybe... maybe now we *can* push? If this is some tawdry trick"…

Cyrus narrowed his eyes, "Sounds awfully like you dont *care* about our Queens, Captain."

Pan straightened and swallowed, "No, sir , I do but... I'm a soldier , sir. I see the battle in front of me. I'm hoping Queen Melendy recovers but... I've tried to focus the Princess. She's been betrayed, she's in shock and... I dont know if she believes it. But I think she knows she's got to do *something* . So, shell go ahead with Scorpia, no doubt. But we leave it too long, shell get doubts and" Pan grimaced, "She'd been talking of riding out, to check herself."

Cyrus twitched, "Not possible. We can't risk the crown princess as well! What if those barbarians have *more* people out there"…

"They do, sir. By the coast. A camp of them. Unless it was them that sprung that ambush, of course," Pan stared into his goblet, "I don't think Catra will rest easy until she sees the bodies, sir."

"You're awfully free with your words, considering you're her confidant, Captain," Cyrus mused with a smirk. Pan nodded and grinned back

"She's my charge, sir. You're my commander. I can do my job if I keep you informed and we can act." He shrugged, "Plus, working with a Princess gets frustrating. What did I do to annoy you to get this job?"

"Blind luck, Captain," Cyrus leaned back in his chair and sipped his goblet, "And we definitely need her inspiration. I may disapprove of some of her approaches, but the thrust of it - the need for direct *action*, I support. So does the court. We need her, at the very least, active. Though I am afraid that she will be connected with these events. I explained it, but I think a word from you will tip the scales. Continue to report back on her movements. If she makes to leave the city, *stop* her. If we need to we will place her under house arrest. Let's try to avoid that. The transition will be easier if she is *here* and *agreeable*. I am sure Queen Melendy will recover, but to what extent I am unsure. The council is saying that it's a sign she should withdraw from the throne."

Pan nodded slowly, "But Catra...are they going to accept her? I know some of the men are worried about a coup. Like you said, sir, there's some worries about collusion."

"W orried, Captain? I hope you quashed that talk?"

"Of course, sir . Cant have that sort of talk. But I raise it because it' s important." Pan fidgeted then gulped the rest of the drink down and set the goblet on the desk, "Do...do we know how the Queen fell ill?"

Cyrus frowned at the man, "Why do you wish to know , *Captain* "?

Pan sighed and his ears twitched. He stood and spoke, "If they can get to the Queen, what else have they sabotaged? The garrison rations? An assassin in the wings to take out a noble? There' s rumblings that if they can kill a Queen, well...no one' s safe."

"Rumours. This seems to have been targeted, only the Queens. T ell me Captain. Having worked with the Princess, do you think she is capable of murdering her own mother?"

He met Pan's eyes and smiled thinly. The Captain let out a breath and shook his head slowly, "Not sure, sir . I think I get what you're saying, though."

"You said she seemed more unhappy about this… *Adora* ."

"Then why have her on the throne if she staged a coup? Theoretically speaking, of course," Pan frowned and rested his hand on the back of the chair, "I mean, she is ruthless, dangerous. But not callous. I don't think so at least. But she changed when that Adora woman arrived."

Cyrus nodded slowly, "Of course," he knew his allies in court wouldn't try anything. That little rumour was a nice threat to dangle over the Princess if she didn't co-operate, but it was a hidden threat, an insinuation. Of course, there were always unknowns. And if the rumour spread to the citizenry well, a riot was a possibility . Cyrus wanted speed, but Pan's words reinforced it. He didn't trust the man, of course - he wasn't privy to the scheme, but was a loyal soldier and therefore useful: And he had been keeping Cyrus up to date for months now. And if he was sharing information *back* to Catra, well, then the message would be delivered. The General leaned forwards, "You understand we are at a crisis point. You are her closest confidant now. Keep me informed, as you have been, and… persuade her that the marriage must happen *soon* . This Adora is now out of the picture if the reports are to be believed and I *believe* them. Catra, if she *is* responsible, is isolated and will need allies. The why matters little. Just what we do to ensure *moving forward.* "

Pan nodded slowly, "Understood sir ."

"Good. Dismissed, and keep me informed."

Pan saluted and departed. After he'd left Cyrus stared at the door and chewed his lip. With a hiss, he stood and swept his helmet up. He pushed out of his study and ignored the guards who fell in behind him as she stalked down corridors and through halls, towards the Queens' chambers. He pulled up short outside and knocked on the door, not sparing the guards on duty a glance. There was a pause before the wooden door opened to reveal a magicat in robes adorned with various sigils. The smell of incense wafted out. Cyrus regarded the man and arched an eyebrow, "Well, Alchemist?"

The man blinked owlishly and nodded, "All is well."

"She is stable?"

"Yes. And. She will remain so. The tonics are keeping her in torpor, sir. As you asked."

Cyrus smiled thinly and looked to the guards, "Good, good. It is important she be kept *stable* . If she begins to awaken"…

The man nodded stiffly, "She will not. It is as you asked. For her safety."

"Good. Keep me informed," he turned, then let out a small sigh of relief. Things were still under control. For a moment, after his talk with Pan, he wondered if the man hadn't been fishing for information, asking about the *how* . But then again, it'd been made fairly common

knowledge that it was poison. Still, Cyrus felt a little on edge. The comment about Catra wanting to see the bodies was of course another issue. They'd need proof;hopefully that would arrive when Velk and his party returned. But they'd need to keep things under wraps until then.

With a sigh, he moved away, heading towards the Hegemony guest quarters, leaving the Magicat Alchemist at the door. He didnt notice the tendril of smoky black that snaked around the alchemist's throat. Nor had he spotted the slightly glassy-eyed expression of the guards. The alchemist closed the door, his eyes staring straight ahead, unfocused as a faint, musical laugh, echoed from the Queens' chambers.

Pan exited the Ziggurat and strode into the gardens. He slowed as his feet crunched on the gravel and drew to a halt near a particularly large mushroom. He heaved a sighed and probed a fang with his tongue, "He' s definitely up to something."

"Duh,"came a voice from nowhere.

"Alright, you're so clever , you go spy on the smarmy bugger."

"No thanks. Bad enough I have to do what I need to now ,"Pan scoffed as Catra's voice drifted from all around him, barely audible, "So, did he let anything slip?"

"Aside from reinforcing the *maybe Catra did it* line? Not much. He knows a lot. Had a note on his desk, bold as brass, saying *It is done*. Thinks that because it was in cipher and barely legible an old hand like me wouldn't notice. Oh and he has a regular girl he taps for blood. SO, someone he trusts in the serving staff."

Catra's voice became a low growl, "That two face"…

"Easy, ma'am. He's one fish. We want a netful, remember? Wants you married off quick, like. I'm supposed to push you that way. Funny thing is, he definitely agrees with you about doing more."

"Bloody stupid way to go about it," muttered Catra.

"Maybe. Makes sense though. And does, unfortunately, paint you as the most likely suspect - frustrated princess angry at her mothers lack of action? Funny thing, you could come out a hero with that narrative too - if, say, you beat the Horde."

"You aren't seriously saying I should go along with this?" Catra sounded incredulous.

"Psh, no. Thing is though, from one perspective, it's a good idea. Just, well, didn't exactly factor any actual elements of *you*, in now,

did it?" Pan chuckled as Catra let out a huf f. The Princess seemed to hum for a moment.

"I mean.... when you think about it, it does make sense. I suppose it is something to think about. But as for Cyrus, that's a risk I cannot tolerate, whatever the outcome. We need proof. And I know who to get it from. To the kitchens."

"As you command, Princess." Pan straightened up and headed back toward the palace. A pair of guards patrolling the grounds nodded at him, and Pan smiled thinly in response. Behind him, the tall mushroom rocked faintly, as if someone had brushed past it, or leapt from its top towards the Ziggurat wall. He paid it no mind and strode in through one of the side gates into the Ziggurat, wending his way through corridors. He paused by a guard room and knocked twice, sharply. Several men emerged and nodded to him, then fell in behind him.

The past day had been hectic. Catra had found him as soon as the news had filtered out and they'd gotten organised. It'd been a day and no news, but Pan wasn't one to sit around. They'd needed to get a feel for what Cyrus was up to or if he was even involved. C atra's own troops were loyal - they knew what it was like out there and had had their hides saved by not just the Princess, but by those wolf-people, too. The small group found their way to the kitchens and pushed inside. Pan took in the hustle and bustle, then gestured to the soldiers, who fanned out to block the exits. Pan stepped forwards and hopped up onto the table, "Attention everyone. I need everyone to come here and take a seat."

A matronly magicat turned and glowered up at him, her sleeves rolled up revealing tawny fur and thick arms, "Oy , soldier boy, no fancy lads in here. You want to dick about with the scullery maids do it *out* of my Kitchen and so's they dont miss their rounds."

"Chef Pallat, Id advise you *not* disrupt me," Pan sighed, "Ive been asked to detain everyone here for a chat."

Pallet folded her arms and glared, "And why' s *that* ?"

"Because the Queen was *poisoned* , Chef."

The woman looked mortally offended, her ears going flat and her lips drawing back in a snarl. A few of the maids looked shocked, and a few pensive. Pan gestured to the table, his eyes tracking one particular serving girl who seemed to be looking around for a way out. Pallet huffed, rolled her eyes and made an impatient gesture to her staff, "W aste of time. The General already cleared this. Was them barbarians and their foreign mead."

"Id be careful what you say , Chef," Pan chuckled as the staf f nervously sat down around the communal table. The Chef snorted.

"What, or youll get *rude* with your questions? Im not afraid of you poncy soldiers. Ive been here over a hundred years."

Pan shrugged, "Let me asking the questions."

A serving girl squeaked as hands clamped down on her shoulders. One of the soldiers had stepped forwards and had a firm grip on her. The helmeted head lowered , eyes fixed on the Chef, "Yeah, that'd be *me* ,"snarled Catra.

The serving girl whimpered and Chef Pallat's eyes widened, "Y... your highness. Bb..ut"…

"Shut. Up,"Catra hissed. The Chef 's jaws clicked shut, "I tolerate this being your domain, professional respect and all that. But when it comes down to it, this is *my* kingdom. And one of your little girls has hurt *my* mother. Now either it was on *your* order..or someone else's."

Pallet stared at Catra. Part of her wanted to scold the woman - she'd yelled at the Princess enough times when she was a kitten. And, unfortunately, she felt emboldened, "Easy enough, it was *your* wench what did it, no need to blame our lot because..."..

The serving girl shrieked as Catra's claws sunk into her shoulders. Catra didnt break eye contact with the Chef, "Whatever happened, Im going to be Queen at some point. You think it's wise to *antagonise* me?"

"The Council"..the Chef started, weakly .

"The Council will cajole or whatever , but theyll go with the easiest option. Which is *me* ."

"Melinie hasnt done anything. What happened to you, what did that *woman* ..?.

The Chef froze as Catra pulled her claws free then trailed a finger to Melinie's throat, "SHe hasnt? Well, that's not quite *true* is it Melinie?"

The serving girl whimpered and the Chef frowned, "Melinie it' s ok, the Princess is upset but"..the woman trailed off as she saw the girl sniffle and looked away. Her expression fell, "Oh..oh Melinie, please tell me"...

"Yeah, please tell me what was worth *murdering my mom,"* Catra purred. The serving girl flinched while all the others stared, some in horror, others with the gazes averted. Catra looked at them all and snorted, "Her . Her. And *him* ."

The soldiers stepped forwards. Knives slid free from sheaths and the servants whimpered as the blades were pressed to their necks. Melinie was shaking while the Chef looked confused, lost. THe big Magicat stared at the Princess, "Your highness..what..what is?"..

Catra shot her a look that could curdle milk, "You've got ambitious staff. Melinie, you serve General Cyrus regularly, right? Top him up, perhaps? What did he promise you, hmm?"

Melinie sniffed, then looked at the Princess with terror in her gaze, "I wasn't, ma'am, I wasn't! It was to help her , I swear!"

Catra's slap knocked the girl back to the table, "Maybe you should have *told* my mother?"

The girl sniffled, "He..he said it was alright. That... that it was already agreed. A tincture is all. He wouldn't, he's a good man! Loyal! He thinks the world of you, ma'am! Wants us out there."

"What did he promise you, Melinie?" Catra's voice was low, almost honey, her eyes boring into the serving girl's, "I think you need to tell me..everything.." The girl blinked a few times and her shoulders relaxed.

"Yes, I'll tell you...everything."

Catra sighed as the Kitchen door clicked shut behind her. She looked at Pan and frowned, "Melinie we need to watch. The others…

get them to the gaol. Cyrus will notice if his little treacherous blood bag isn't about. The rest we can hide away, but tell *no one* except our people why they're really in there. Make up something about theft from my chambers."

"She won't let it slip?" Pan mused. Catra shook her head, then tapped her temple

"No, basic little trick. She won't remember this, but she will be compelled to stop at a certain part of the Palace corridors and leave a written note in a pot, which she will then forget about. Something my mothers taught me and that *Weaver* made me practice. She was good at it as well, but not as *naturally* good as we are."

"How come I can't do that?" Pan chuckled. Catra just smirked.

"You aren't charming enough, Pan. The simple minded and desperate get swayed easily."

"Ouch, is that why I always do what you say?" Catra scoffed and swatted the man's arm. He chuckled, "I'll get those three moved. And the Chef? Hell, the *rest* the staff in there?"

"She'll be quiet. They all will. She won't want to risk her position. Or me gutting her," Catra spoke nonchalantly, "And the others, well, can't hypnotise them all, but the loyal ones are just going to have to be a risk. Their options are *keep quiet* or *risk talking to Cyrus* who might just kill them anyway to keep things quiet..."

"Fair . Now , what else are we doing? All very well *knowing* , but Cyrus isn't acting alone."

"No, he isn't. So, little Melinie will just keep gathering us tidbits. You keep tabs on her. And I need to buy us some time."

Pan chuckled, "Your white wolf coming to the rescue, you think?" His tone was worried.

"She better be," Catra huffed, "And while you're at the wall, see what you can see. If it's as I fear, then we're going to have more guests on our doorstep. If it all goes wrong, this is going to be a hell of an event."

—

Princess Scorpia turned the page of her book with a claw tip. The book was in a holder on the small table in front of her. She looked up and smiled as Perfuma walked up with a steaming cup of tea, "Oh, um, thank you."

Perfuma smiled, "Of course, dear . You seem calmer."

Scorpia shrugged and looked back at the book, "You know what this is?"

"Um..a journal, your highness?"

"Please, Fuma. Scorpia when we're alone. You being formal is so weird. You've started doing it more." The muscular woman shrugged and pursed her lips, "Just..am I doing the right thing, Fuma?"

The willowy blonde regarded her Princess and winced, "You are doing what you think is necessary, Scorpia. But..is it the right way?"

Scorpia tapped her claws together, then gestured back at the book, "It's my journal. From when I was a child. Catra would visit us - she was almost the same then as she is now. The war was still pretty active, yknow? And I was mesmerised. This adventurer, this woman making the world her own! A princess but..she was out there. I felt jealous, you know? And I knew I was in love. Like when I first met you and I knew..I knew *it was meant to be*. But I was clumsy, and you made up for me being a fool," Scorpia blushed. Perfuma's face went through a mix of emotions - happiness, frustration, fondness and a tinge of sadness.

She reached over and placed a gentle hand on Scorpia's claw, "It's never easy, navigating our heart. But you wooed me. And I think..I think Catra just needs time to"…

A knock at the door distracted the pair. They heart Huntara move around in the main living area, beyond the drapes that led into Scorpia's rooms. There was a muffled conversation, then the big orc-woman drew the curtain back, her face a mask of concern, "Your highness, you have a visitor."

Scorpia nodded, then rose, before she offered a claw to Perfuma. The woman took it and allowed herself to be led out. The pair paused to find Catra standing in the room, wearing a simple red and black dress. The vampire Princess turned her chin up and heaved a sigh. Her smile was weak, "Princess Scorpia. If I may say two things. Firstly, I would like to apologise for my attitude and conduct these past few days. You are a guest and I made you feel unwelcome. And secondly... I wish to accept your of fer of marriage."

Chapter 16

Chapter Summary

Adora is preparing.

Pan gets a shock.

And Catra gets her first revenge.

Chapter Notes

TW: Character death (ANOTHER ONE) - though not sure this counts?

Mentioned grief.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Watching the sea farers set to a task was impressive and not a little terrifying. For decades, near centuries, Cỳra had seen her city flourish - a marvel of ingenuity, survival and magic. It sat as a testament to resilience: the Horde, the Fae, even elements of the Hegemony had battered at their walls, or rattled sabers to intimidate.

But now, for the first time, she saw a foe that might be able to break their gates and bring something new to their dark halls and dusty ways.

Cỳra and Melendy had always been cautious, always with an eye to their people's survival - but they knew it wasnt a long term solution. Catra had always been the plan - the one who would, eventually, be seen as the driving light and the revolutionary force that would lead

the Magicats out of the dark. Cỳra had set things in motion to be *just so* . But now all that was being hamstrung by over-ambitious underlings and a set of bad timing by a mooning Princess. These had been factored in, to a point.

What she had not factored in were sea-faring werewolf beasts with a penchant for violence and a strange leader with a nigh-fanatical devotion to her daughter.

Cỳra stood in the midst of a copse of trees as the band of sea-farers gathered and prepared. Their ships had landed and their forces had alighted, bringing some small measure of surprise. These were not jµst man-shaped beasts. Among their number were humans, liƶard-folk and Orcs. All wore similar attire - chain and woolen armour, some steel, but mostly lightweight, mobile kit. Axes, spears, bows, they were well equipped.

She adjµsted her position and watched, silent and alert. There were maybe two or three thousand of these people. Teela, Adora's apparent second in command, had taken a moment to explain. Sheʻd had a smirk as she did so, tinged with a bitter twist.

‟W e were a conquering folk. Thralls and supplicants. We fell, long before the Horde, to our own hubris, our own madness. But the Horde made us all equals. We used to believe the strong ruled as was their right. But strength means nothing if all you touch is dust. We learned. We changed. The war made us one again. And Adam and Adora.thẹy led at the fore. Bringing people who long feared us to our side;stragglers and the lost."

Cyra had stared as a wolf-man, a towering nine feet tall, stomped past, clad in shining plate armour. He carried a blade the size of a tall man as if it were nothing, and dragged a stack of lumber, fastened with tight cord, behind him. Another followed, with a bow almost as tall as him, like some sort of ballistae.. She'd looked at Teela, "Surely you are *enough*? You could rule"…

That had drawn a snort from Teela, "I have a kingdom, and my king, over the sea. Why would I want another?" she paused, "Oh, you mean *us* overall? No, conquest comes with *issues*. Taxes, administration, resentment. But, we may ask for space here. A place to call our own, as part of your kingdoms."

Cyra had chuckled, "I am hardly in a position to negotiate. A Queen away from her people, potentially hostage to barbarian invaders."

Teela had just shrugged in return, "Adora will not trade for Catra's life. Should Catra ask her to leave and for us to sail away, it will be done. Though Adora *may* destroy the Horde first. And this is me telling you this, one Queen to another."

It was said with such nonchalant confidence that Cyra had had to make a double take. But Teela had just flashed her a toothy grin and walked away.

And true to her word, the Sea-farers had made a palace their own - within half a day, a small shanty town had been established - tents,

repurposed boat timber and felled trees gave way to rudimentary cabins and pontoons. A camp had been made, more than just a humble hunting space; this was the beginnings of a settlement.

Adora had led them inland a bit further, the majority of her forces rallied and ready. And now here they waited. Cyra chewed her lip as around her, her own troops marshaled. Kelik approached and coughed gently, "Your majesty. May I speak freely?"

"You may."

"Is this wise?"

She looked at the man, "I fear you need to be more specific, commander. Which *bit*? Marching on Halfmoon? Marching on Halfmoon with a foreign army? Allying with monsters of legend?"

"If... if these are the First Folk... then they are demons. They subjugated this land, humbled the *Fae*."

Cyra clucked her tongue, "And what are our alternatives? If it is only the machinations of the court, do I simply hope that they accept they failed? Do I singlehandedly wade into my own city, murder my own troops, until I find the way to the throne room? And what if there are others? And we just hand ourselves in?"

"The guards..."

"Half of our men tried to *murder* us, Kelik. You aren't this naive." She leveled a stern gaze at the man, who sighed.

"Are we not trading one treachery for another? This wolf woman and her coterie of"…

"A fine way to thank us," Adora's voice chuckled from behind the Commander. He stiffened and his ears twitched, "Really need to brush up on those reflexes. Your kind *really* do over-focus, huh?"

The towering blonde crunched bare-foot over the leaf-mold and stepped around Kelik. She wore only a wrap around her chest, and loose wool-britches, Her sword was slung across her shoulders, with a cloak beneath. Adora offered the man a half smile and he squared up, "My apologies, um"…

"Warmaster will suffice," Adora chuckled, "And you may address Teela as *your majesty* should the need arise."

Kelik blinked and Cyra snorted. The man coughed, "So she is in command? And you are the subordinate. Your majesty, surely we should be talking to the *Queen*, then?"

"Oh you are," Adora chuckled, her half smirk shifting to a full grin as she arched her eyebrow, "After we get this done. Teela is Queen at

home. Here, she is my shield-sister, as much as she is...ah...my sister in law? This is your term, I believe. Now , should you wish to march back and hope your friends there are not setting another ambush, feel free. I will not stop you."

C'yra arched an eyebrow and let out a low rumbling purr that shifted to a chuckle, "You would sacrifice the element of surprise?"

Adora met her gaze, "I would let them kill you and see how they did it. You, maybe not, Queen C'yra. I feel your daughter would not be as forgiving should I not do my utmost to keep you alive. Him, though?" she jutted her chin at Kelik, "He I would let die, then maybe bring him back to see if he learned *again* ."

Kelik sighed, looked at the forest floor, then back at Adora, "You can see why I am not filled with confidence."

"You are rude. You demean me and mine, after you were tricked by your *friend* . You suspect me of underhandedness after you and yours tried to *kill* me," Adora leaned in, "Do. Not. Push. It."

A warbling growl pulled Adora's attention away and she smiled, then turned to open her arms. A large beast emerged from the darkness of the forest, as if concealed. C'yra blinked in shock - she had not even *smelled* it. Behind the creature, more could be seen padding through the trees, many with people atop their broad backs.

They looked like huge jungle cats, of all colours and a strange combination of sizes. The one Adora was half wrestling, half hugging was dark purple, almost black in colour, with strange, near luminescent eyes. The creature butted Adora away and yowled, then cocked its head at Cyra. Kelik breathed out, watching the parade of other cats to the rear, "What the heck are they?"

Adora chuckled and scratched at the big beast's ears. It stood almost to her shoulder and looked like it could have taken Adora on in her wolf form, "These are our battle cats. Long time steeds and allies. And this one," Adora gripped the creature by the jowls and gently rocked its huge head, "Has been patient indeed."

"You need *steeds*?" Kelik stared, shocked. Adora nodded, "Quite the sight, yes? You ride horses, though you could sprint, hm? Battle cats are more effective against the Horde as well."

"This one is yours, then?" Cyra approached the creature, which still had its eyes on her. She felt *something*, as if there was a question in the air, unasked. Adora's fingers soothed at the beast and she shook her head.

"No, this one is destined for another. Mine fell. He was a brave one. Noble, proud, forceful, a loudmouth, forever demanding of attention," her voice drooped as she swallowed a lump, then she looked to Cyra, "Those of us who bond with a cat, bond for life. None replace them. I will forever be bereft of that. But this one, like me, was destined for another."

Cyra nodded in understanding, "Catra?"

"Yes."

The Queen nodded slowly, while Kelik stared at the massing troops - Orc, human, lizard and wolf. Some rode atop the cats, small collections of archers or spearmen astride broad saddles, whilst others just had single werewolves atop them, creating a terrifying visage. Cyra stared at the night-like beast, "What is their name?"

Adora smiled and scratched the cat again, "Melog."

Pan was not surprised. He'd escorted the prisoners up to the goal, which was hidden on the path out of the city - a simple place to put it - any who escaped would have to fight their way *into* the city or *out* of the mountain. Neither prospect would be easy. After he had deposited the miserable servants in their cells, with strict orders to keep them secure, he had continued onwards, towards the surface. Instead of heading to the main entry-way, he'd taken the side passages that led to the "false gate". This was a fortification in its own right. The entrance there did have a tunnel that led to the main thoroughfare, but that was currently sealed by several large blocks of stone that the magicats put in place. Any who breached the "false gate" would be met by rocks and smooth walls. Scorpia and her ilk would have been let in via that entryway. Quite why Catra had shown the Sea-farers the *actual* entrance was a bit of a puzzle, at least at

first. But Pan had realised it was a testament to her trust in the wolf-woman.

The fact the Hegemony didn't get the same courtesy was another thing he had kept in the back of his mind. No doubt, if Cyrus was in their pocket, then they were likely aware. And they might have a counter. So, he needed to see what they had ready.

He emerged into the small garrison they kept at the gate - really a small post to give the illusion of entry. Caravans and others would be shuttled in, the stone moved enough to allow passage as they were led to the main tunnel, in darkness. But honestly, most trade was done on the field outside the mountain, with carts taken in by the *actual* entrance in secret, hidden by illusions and trickery.

Guards nodded to him and some called greetings as he moved from the side tunnel, across the earthy floor of the main tunnel. It was like a small, covered courtyard. Doorways led to small storerooms and bunks. Palisades were set up, to act as cordons and guides for travelers. The rear of the gate was in front of him, towering and true - and very shut. No even sunlight was visible. He moved to the base of one of the towers that flanked the gate and moved up the stairs. He reached the battlements and emerged into the afternoon sun. He squinted as his eyes adjusted and fought the wave of sleepiness that hit him. The guards here were often the non-vampiric troops, or those who had been trained to tolerate the exposure. A dozen were arrayed along the battlements, spears held upright - a show of force. Pan padded across the stone, the wall of the mountain behind him. Above, another battlement rose, set into the stone, with another above that. The towers continued up on either side, giving quite the impressive effect. He glanced out across the field before the

mountain and did a double take, before he was interrupted by a voice.

"Captain Pan, a surprise!" another magicat bustled towards him from the other tower - golden fur and glinted under the man's black armour and he pulled a salute, "To what do we owe the pleasure?"

Pan snorted, then looked out at the field, then back at the man, "Oh, I don't know, Sergeant Miyek," he gestured at the scene on the field, "Perhaps the *thousand Scorponi* sat in front of the mountain that weren't here two days ago?"

The sergeant winced and a few of the soldiers nearby muffled their laughter, "I was told it was approved."

"Oh, by whom?" Pan arched an eyebrow. The Sergeant paused and frowned.

"You should know... by the Queens of course!" Pan studied the man, then grinned.

"Excellent. Glad to see the messages are getting through. Worried since what happened with the Queens. By the Moons it's tense, glad to see some people still know how to do their jobs!" he clapped a hand on the Sergeant's armoured shoulder. The man blinked then grinned.

"Ah, yes. Cyrus ordered us to not interfere. I understand this is to ensure security, should the barbarians return," he frowned, "For the Princesses security."

Pan looked out at the fluttering pennants and massed tents. Scorpia had had an escort, yes - an honour guard. Likely, to traverse the sands and the tundra, they'd dispatched a full contingent, but they were supposed to have remained at the border. He nodded slowly, "Seems very sudden, speaking my mind of course. A sad day when we need the Hegemony to guard *our* Mountain, hm?"

A few of the soldiers seemed to nod and shift at that. The Sergeant met Pan's gaze and licked his lips nervously, "Well, the future is one of co-operation. We will need to work with them."

Pan nodded. *Ah*, he thought. Out loud he hummed and added, "True. We've been buried long. We need to see many new things. Work with people. End the war."

The Sergeant nodded, "Been cooped up, guarding, watching people to and fro, too long. Sorry, Captain, speaking out of turn."

"No, no you aren't wrong, Sergeant. Just wonder why it took an assassination to get us here."

Silence fell, save for birdsong and the distant clatter of the Scorponi encampment. It stretched across the whole visible arc from the gate, between the trees of the massive field, blocking the road. Pan could, distantly, see a mass of huddled caravans on the far side of the Scorponi camp and he smiled thinly. No doubt supplies and citizens were behind *held back* for security concerns. The Sergeant followed his gaze and shifted, "Ah, we ride out and escort approved visitors in. And of course, they're stopping any potential fugitives."

"Approved?" Pan gave the man a steady stare.

"Well, the Scorponi are doing their own checks. Can't stop them really. And it saves us a bit of a job. And any of those assassins still in Halfmoon definitely can't escape."

Pan nodded slowly, "Thank you Sergeant. Good to see the orders are being followed. You're a good solider."

The Sergeant slammed his fist against his breast-plate, "Thank you, Captain."

"I will inform the General. Any changes, I will return. The Princess will be delighted to hear her fiancee is considering her security."

"Oh! She has agreed?" The Sergeant seemed relieved, "I mean, of course she would. A relief, though. I can only imagine..." he glanced at the army outside and Pan shrugged.

"Yes, Catra is definitely a wise one. Im a little surprised," Pan chuckled, which drew a few gasps from the soldiers, "But she knows how to play the game. She knows what's best for our people. Remember that. And she no doubt will remember who has helped her after all this bad business comes to an end," he stared at the Sergeant, then looked at the troops, on the battlements around him and above, "She will remember all of us for our actions, for she is her mothers' daughter. Long live the Queen!"

"Long live the Queen!" came the echoed chant. The Sergeant startled and was only a word behind as he followed up. Pan grinned, returned the salute, then turned to head back into the darkness.

One thing was for sure. Catra was going to be *pissed.*

Catra paced in her rooms and bit her lip. She knew the next day or so was going to be *hard* . It was going to need precision. And right now, she only had half the puzzle. Pan had returned at a run and given her an update, which had left her seething.

An *honour guard* that was besieging her city in all but name. A knife at their throat if they did not acquiesce to this marriage, really.

With a huff she smoothed down her skirts and glanced out into the darkness of the cavern, beyond the lace curtains. She had maybe a few hours before she and Scorpia were due a brief walk in the gardens to finalise a few arrangements. Already the court representatives and bureaucrats were finagling the finer details of alliance.

It was interesting how she had been faintly sidelined from those talks - as if her mothers'were still here, but she had been diminished. Cyrus had apologised after she had returned from accepting Scorpia's proposal but reassured her she would, of course, have input.

It felt like another test. But there was also so much else that threatened to overwhelm her. She had control over small things - the staff, her direct guards, her own aides, few as they were.

But it was the bigger picture she lacked. She needed to know more. And, frustratingly, there was only one real avenue to get at least a glimpse of what she needed. But she needed to disrupt a few things first.

With a sigh, she stepped across to her small table and glanced down at the papers there. She had managed to get her aides to gain copies of the documents being discussed. She sat on her diva and flicked through them, her expression growing more and more angered by the moment. With a flex of her hand, she stood and stalked to her desk, while shadows pooled around her. She snatched up a quill and inkwell then nigh-flung herself back down. She managed to calm herself enough to stop the ink spilling as her grip

nearly cracked the well. She cursed herself for nearly losing control. Her powers were mostly body-related, unlike her mothers', but she did need to practice more. And her strength sometimes slipped.

WIth a decisive nod, she set to scrawling over the documents, making amendments and comments She knew these would be ignored - or they would be until the meeting she had planned later. Some of the Court were trying to use the limbo of the current situation to claim she had no *real* authority. She'd heard those whispers already from her maids and aides - word had, subtly, gotten around that Catra wasn't tolerant of *duplicitous* behaviour. Not the details of why, but seeing serving staff vanish and hearing the fear in the chefs voice likely made several staff reevaluate their loyalties - Catra was going to be in charge and it was now a reality. Best get on her good side.

She stacked the papers, her amendments done - mostly it was about the ridiculous tithes the Hegemony expected, or the promise of military support, which was actually closer to *seceding part of their military* to the Hegemony. Then there was the request for a garrison, land and border items, the works.

This would gum up the negotiations a *little* , but the Hegemony was famed for being able to blitz through paperwork when it wanted to. And the courtiers would try to keep her phased out so she couldn't do this more than a couple of times. They would hope to overwhelm her with documents that she would have to rubber stamp, most likely. Especially with the wedding timeline. But if she *hadn't* agreed, then that would have caused further ructions - likely open revolt and an *actual* coup attempt. And she could only fight so many people. The Wedding was imminent. She had expected more planning, more time - months perhaps. But they seemed to want a formal

declaration here, before a more lavish event in the Hegemony. Her stalling tactic of accepting had only bought her a couple of days, given ow Cyrus seemed to be pushing things. No doubt they would defer the detail until she was safely away and married off. The logistics seemed well planned. Unsurprising, given the Hegemony seemed to have contingencies for *everything.*

She opened the door to her rooms and handed the sheaf of papers to a waiting Magicat maid. The woman curtsied, then dashed away. Catra glanced at the guard at her door and nodded to the man, before she marched off, heading towards Cyra's study. Servants bowed as she passed and soldiers saluted with a mumbled, "Your majesty."

That irked her - she hadnt been *crowned* yet. And that was another thing she was using to her advantage - but so was the Hegemony. She had said she wished to be Queen before marriage, whilst the Hegemony seemed to be angling for some sort of co-Queen status for Scorpia. Catra was currently pushing for a coronation of herself but as *regent* , *then* a marriage. Of course, it did rather depend on Melendy. Some in the court were arguing for the Queen to be forced to abdicate in absentia, Catra crowned, then for her to be promptly shuffled off to the Hegemony.

She would remember the names of *those* courtiers.

Most likely, she would be married as a Princess, as that seemed to suit Cyrus - he and his would retain control, with her acting as puppet regent, then she would be guided away. If she stayed in Halfmoon, no doubt they intended to keep Melendy in some form of

torpor, preventing Catra from *truly* ascending, and empowering the Court. She would be encouraged to *lead the charge* in the field, acting as a rallying warrior. After a few years, no doubt she would be welcomed back, but she imagined things would have changed so much and the Hegemony would have become so ingrained that any attempt at actually *ruling* would be diverted.

She scoffed as she walked - the frustrating thing was that *that* part she would have gladly done for her mothers'. For her people - been at the front, taking the fight to the Horde. But now, being forced into it, while her home was gutted by venal vultures and the ever encroaching thing that was the Hegemony? It stuck in her throat.

It was a bit of guess work on her part, but she knew the games of court. Pan and her, and even Adora, had talked it over. To some she was a beacon, to others a pawn. And with Cyrus' implications, they expected her to play along, otherwise she'd be accused of usurpation.

As if the old Magicats hadn't made a sport of that sort of thing, even before vampirism had taken hold. She snorted at the notion.

Catra paused in her thoughts as she reached the study door. The guards there shuffled uneasily, but Catra glared at them, then moved to the door. It clicked open and the guards startled - clearly it had been locked. She smiled at them, winked, then slipped inside. The door shut and the lock engaged. She let out a sigh and felt a twinge of pain in her chest.

The room smelled of Cyra still, mingled with the scent of pages and the lingering aroma of incense. Catra moved to the desk and stared down at the parchments. Her eyebrows rose as she studied the papers there - words like "*First People*" and "*The masters*" dotted the pages. Notes about a long vanished people from across the oceans, powerful and arrogant, but also possessed of feats of might and intellect.

She blinked and chuckled, "Adora? Huh. You and me need to talk, clearly."

She trailed her hand through the papers, but saw it was mostly half remembered records, myths and suppositions. She saw no mention of Adora's beast-like nature, just commentary on how these folk had once ruled the lands, then vanished after an uprising, driven back to their own lands, or drawn back, it wasnt clear.

Catra shook her head, ears twitching and tail flicking, before she looked to the side table and the item that sat there - a covered jar. With grim determination she strode over and pulled the cover away. Glassy eyes stared up at her, while dark hair lay lank around a scarred face. A sneer tried to pull itself across Shadow Weaver's face as her jaw moved - her disembodied head leaning up, awkwardly against the jar.

"Oh, it's *you*," came the ghoul's cracked voice. Catra smirked.

"Hey there Weaver. How's retirement?"

The witch-ghoul hissed, "Whelp. Your time will come."

"Maybe so. But we're talking about *you* now. And what you can do for me."

Weaver's eyes narrowed before a thin smile slid over her cracked lips, "You need my *help* . Has your little pet failed you?"

Catra studied the woman. At one time, those words would have riled her, send her into a rage. The barbs, the teasing, the cruelty - even when the woman had been brought to heel. It was vexing. But now she just smirked.

"Well that's what I need to know. You know me, never *great* at magic. And, well, things around here are...tricky ."

"Hardly an incentive for me to assist you," sighed Weaver, "Watching you fall would be *glorious* ."

"Maybe so. So, let's negotiate," Catra pulled a chair over and sat down. She cocked her head to one side and smirked, "I could play you a tune about how I killed my moms, how I used Adora, how I just want power or something. But we both know that even if you believed me, you'd try an angle to kill me, or control me or… something like that."

Weaver met her gaze and snorted, "At least you have a grasp on some things, child."

"True. But my moms *are* dead. And what a chance for the Horde, huh?"

Weaver blinked, stunned for a moment, before her eyes narrowed, "What game are you playing?"

"My moms. Are. Dead. And I want revenge. And you can give it to me. I need to track the Hegemony, need to see where they are. They are *coming* here. And if they take this city, then, well, the Horde is next. The combined forces of them and us? They'll crush you."

Weaver spat out a laugh, "Hardly."

"They killed Adora. That woman you were so scared of. My mother too - I'm surprised you haven't managed to reach out, to sense what they have planned."

"My accommodations are hardly the height of *luxury* child. But I still see no reason to aid you. Your misery brings me some comfort. And the risk of such an alliance is negligible."

I want help with a scrying spell. I need a bowl, some magical components and a chant. And you're going to help me."

"Pah, unlikely ."

Catra sighed. It had been a long shot, I was trying to be reasonable. To do this nicely," she looked down at the sigils Melendy had painted onto the table. No doubt part of whatever interrogation her mothers' had subjected Weaver to before. She smiled thinly as she traced a few of the carvings, then pulled her hand away, "Well, I tried. I guess I'll just have to make do."

She stood and turned, then headed over to a shelf. She scooped down a bowl which she set on the floor, then moved to a cabinet. Blue magic glowed from within as she removed a decanter, then poured the contents into the bowl. Blood oozed and flowed and Catra nodded slowly. She bit her own finger, then let a droplet fall in. Weaver scoffed from her jar , "A start, but you lack the right component, a catalyst. Such a spell requires a trigger. And you are no mage, just a parasite, a waste a..".

Catra cocked her head at Weaver and chuckled, "Oh I know . And if you'd helped me then I am *sure* I could have found something. But now I really have only one choice," her face screwed up into a scowl, "And it' s about time I took Adora's advice."

Weaver's eyes widened as Catra lifted the lid of the jar . She reached in and hauled Weaver out by her hair, then moved to pluck a torch

from its sconce on the wall. She dipped the blunt end of the torch in the blood, then traced sigils around the bowl, tracing patterns while Weaver cursed and spat. Then Catra lifted the ghoul's head to eye level.

"Goodbye W eaver. I release you. You're welcome."

Catra held the torch above the bowl of blood and then held Weaver's head atop it. The green flame caught and seemed to be drawn into the ghoul, who burst into flame with a howling shriek. She disintegrated into motes of black ash almost instantly, what was left of her magic drawn into the flame, down the torch and into the blood. The torch guttered out and Catra tossed it aside, then picked up the bowl. She paused, watching as the blood bubbled and popped. She drew a breach as the surface roiled, then tipped the bowl back and drank deep. Her eyes fluttered and she collapsed back. Something oozed in her mind, an echo. White eyes at a child' s bedside, a blade raised. Catra balked and hissed, her fears resurfacing. Images of Halfmoon swarming with Horde;then swarming with the Hegemony; then in ruin and decaying;then again in flames.

Catra had had this dream before and she slashed at the remnant of her childhood terror. But this time, the Weaver at her bedside cackled and reached for her.

Until something grasped at the shadowy figure and hauled them back. Hands that were not there tilted Weaver's head and Catra saw her chance she lunged, her body shifting from child to adult. Her claws became flames and Weaver screamed and burned and yelled.

What was left of Weaver screeched away into the void, to be replaced by calm. Catra sighed, or exhaled, or relaxed. Around her was dappled moonlight and a forest, but also nothing. There was the sensation of movement, lots of movement. And then a pair of blue eyes in the dark - ice cold and full of warmth. Another set of eyes, pale and purple opened and Catra felt more. She felt recognition as well, as if she were staring at those eyes through someone else's for the barest moment. And then she saw blue eyes through *this* set of eyes. She was disoriented, but a word filtered through.

Adelevenn.

Catra laughed, giddy and tried to think, tried to convey something, but it felt like a distance was there that words could not cross. She just *wanted* . She wanted so much. And she knew it was returned.

Catra blinked and found herself staring up at the ceiling of her mother's study. She felt relief, but also a sense of uncertainty - was that real? Or some final trick of Weaver? Had she gotten the script right? She couldn't be sure, but she would have to trust.

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Across the woodlands, near the shore, Adora blinked rapidly. Melog let out a low purring growl. The blonde straightened and let out a howl, which was picked up all around. She turned to Cyra and a startled Kelik, "We ride."

Chapter End Notes

Ok, we are about to have the midden hit the windmill in a GOOD WAY.

I almost had Catra try to fool Weaver, but tbh there was no real way for that to work. Obv Weaver would have betrayed her anyway, and it felt too tricksy and Catra is dealing with ENOUGH complexity without having Weaver add to it.

Chapter 17

Chapter Summary

An avalanche begins with the shifting of a single snowflake.

A battle hinges on the decisions of a single commander.

And sometimes the best lessons are delivered in person.

Chapter Notes

TW: Gratuitous gore and pseudo torture of a smug individual.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Tong Whippor bit down on the haunch of meet clutched in his clawed hand, whilst his gae drifted across the serried ranks of tents and whipping pennants. Campfires blazed and torches flickered in the drawing dusk. His fork tongue licked at the grease and he chuckled, taking it all in. Beneath him, his mount chuffed and chittered, its gait causing him to rock from side to side slightly. It was a motion he was used to and his body rolled with it as he inspected the perimeter of his camp.

He had doubted his brother, Lashor, at the start of this, but really he should have known better. The dry-scaled old bastard was a cunning creature. As akin to a log in a stream to his opponents, he knew the currents and the shifting of the rocks to strike at a confused prey. Whippor was impressed.

At the start, when he had marched the Princess'Legion out as her escort, Lashor had assured him that his role would be needed to

combat *resistance* . Lashor had a plan, but then he had a backup and a backup after that. No egg-molt on that one.

His mount paused and his escort stopped around him. The creature he rode was a large beetle-like thing, with a single compound eye on its head. Natural denizens of the Hegemony's tundra-like lands, the Em-la were resilient and stubborn. But raised correctly, they were terrifying mounts - capable of charging a horse and breaking it apart. Spears would be hard pressed to easily puncture the chitinous hide and arrows would simply rattle off of it. They were hard to field en-masse but the few elite of the Hegemony cavalry corps were gifted with them as mounts.

He peered ahead and snorted - they had reached the line of Halfmoon citizens that were petitioning for entry to the city . Them and the human surface-serfs the vampire-cats seemed to keep around.

A harried looking Scorponi was arguing with a stout woman. The magicat's ears were flat and her tail was lashing back and forth as she argued with the soldier. Whippor tossed the remnants of his food forwards and his mounts head jerked up to catch it in its mandibles. A few swift crunches and the bones disappeared into its horrifying maw. The reptilian commander rolled his shoulders. His armour creaked as he adjusted himself, the overlapping bronze disks rattling over the boiled leather, while the cowl of his helm made a faint scrape against his pauldrons.

He spurred his mount forwards, whilst the footsoldiers kept pace, their pikes held high. The civilians noted his approach and seemed

to still, backing up slightly. The angry woman paused in her tirade and froze, staring up at Whippor . The reptile looked to the Scorponi.

"Sergeant, is there an issue?" his voice was soft, almost sneering.

"Sir , these people were petitioning to return to the city ."

"Ah," Whippor chuckled, his throat bulging slightly with amusement. He regarded the collection of magicats and humans then shook his head, "I am *afraid* , due to a recent event, interlopers caused a problem within you *noble* city. At the request of the Princess we have been asked to maintain a cordon. No one is permitted to pass until the emergency is resolved. Any attempt wil be seen as an act of… war."

The woman frowned, her tail lashing picking up speed, "But…war? We just want to go home."

"And as soon as your Princess Regent confirms that all is well, it shall be thus," Whippor chuckled.

"But we have grains, food, milk. It'll spoil!"

"Well that would be a shame. I suggest you hand it to us and we can process it through to the city for you."

The woman glared at him, "No, I don't think so. You and yours, likely to nick it, I know how you Hegemony lot work. A fee here, another one there."

Whippor stared at the woman then tilted his head, "You seem… argumentative. Besmirching my nation too! I am afraid you will be seeing a lot *more* of us soon, once our alliance is formalised. So I suggest you learn to work within the rules. You will not be entering the city, not without permission from *within* the city. I am sure we can carry a message, but it may take time."

A few soldiers snickered at that and the woman huffed, then looked at them, "This isn't right"…

"But it is what is happening," Whippor chuckled, "We can likely move things along with an inspection of your goods. We have areas set aside for you and yours. Perfectly safe. I *insist*."

A howl suddenly rent the air. Around them, at the edges of the fields the surrounded the cliffs, birds took flight, looping and wheeling as if trying to evade something. Another howl brought through the air. Then another. All around, from one tree-line to the next.

And then as suddenly as it started… it ceased. Whippor stood up in his saddle and stared around, his soldier's instincts immediately on alert. He looked sharply at the Sergeant, "Ready the men. First positions. Archers and magi ready. Rouse everyone, rally the

runners, get the arrows lined up for the rows. Go. GO!Men, with me. Clear these civilians, corral them!"

He looked about as his men set to, ignoring the shouts and curses as the citizens were manhandled out of the way . A flicker of light caught his eye and he focused on it.

A few hundred yards away, at the tree line, a solitary light emerged from the forest. A single rider, atop *something* , came out of the darkness. They were distant, a silhouette. Whippor fished about at his belt and pulled up a brass spyglass, which he raised to his eye. A frown creased his scaly brow.

It was a woman, human by the looks of her. She rode some enormous cat beast and her torch was actually some sort of lance, with a flaming brazier atop it. He watched as the woman drew to a halt halfway to their camp, before she drove the lance into the soil, where it stuck - a beacon.

Whippor lowered the spyglass and hissed to himself. This was unexpected. The message he had had from Lashor was simply to corral the city, to act as a potential noose in the event of a *lackof co-operation* . Oh it was also to ensure there was a ready escort and, ostensibly, to be there for the Princess Scorpia, may the dunes bless her. But an external threat?That hadnt been mentioned aside from some request he sent a contingent to handle the Queen and some mercenaries.

That had been the only worry the past day or so - he hadnt seen his company. He had assumed they'd just held back or continued on after stragglers or escapees, given that the messenger from the traitor Magicat had gotten back unscathed. But he hadnt received a further word. He had sent scouts but they took time to investigate and he had been expecting them back imminently. But now he had a mystery woman and a big lion.

"Corporal, go prepare the cavalry and fetch me a couple of magi."

A few minutes later a Scorponi and another lizard, clad in robes of dark crimson, approached on horse back from within the camp, flanked by ten more light cavalry - humans, Scorpioni and a couple of lizards. Whippor nodded then urged his mount forwards, then infantry falling in behind the mob of cavalry, who had formed four columns behind him.

He sat up straight as he approached and took stock. The woman was actually taller than he'd expected, as was the cat. Their combined height meant she was taller than he, the beast being the size of a cart-horse. His mount was a little lower to the ground, but still a match for most horses.

She wore her hair braided and seemed to only have a simple tunic and tabard on over britches. A long sword was slung over her back and she had a mildly irritated expression on her face. The look she gave him was insulting, as if he had been assessed and found wanting. Whippor tasted the air and hissed as they drew closer, where he pulled his mount to a halt. It shifted and chittered, seemingly nervous.

Whippor tilted his head back, his throat flaring red with irritation, "I am Commander Tong Whippor, Household division of the Glorious Hegemonic Army, honour bound to protect the heir apparent to the Hegemony from all threats. I *reqest* you state your business here."

The woman stared at him, then sniffed, "I am Adora Moondaughter , and I am here for a wedding."

Whippor blinked and exchanged a few confused glances with the magi that flanked him, before he snorted a laugh, "Well, *friend* , you are early. The wedding will not be for weeks. Such pomp takes time. But I am afraid we cannot allow you entry. Dangerous times and I would be *remiss* in my duty to the Princess."

The woman smirked, "Oh you misunderstand. I am here for my wedding. I do not go in for fancy affairs. Seems a waste. WOuld you deny me access to my beloved?"

Whippor scoffed, "A paltry reason for someone of no import. I am sure you *beloved* can wait while affairs of state are conducted."

"I doubt that. She is the Princess and remarkably impatient,"Adora leaned forwards in her strange saddle and made a mock whisper, "Working with a Princess yourself, I am sure you understand."

"You.what? Are you mad?" Whippor chuckled, disbelievingly .
Adora shook her head and grinned. It was a worrying expression and seemed to have too many teeth.

"Also, I am bringing her mother as well. I know she would hate for her to not be there."

Whipport stilled in his saddle, his chuckle dying on his scaly lips. His eyes narrowed, "Who *are* you?"

Adora peered past him at the army arrayed and encamped around the mountain, "Most strange. Are the Magicats aware there are soldiers besieging their home?"

"We are here at the invitation of..That is none of your concern. Who. Are. You?" Whippor hissed.

Adora nodded slowly, "I told you. Adora Moondaughter . Are you hard of hearing? I wish to speak with Catra, I am sure all this will be cleared up as a simple mistake. Grant us entry and all will be well."

Whippor hissed, "The mercenary . Where are my men?"

It was shocking how fast the woman's face went from cold boredom to dead seriousness, "AH, so they were yours?" her head tilted to the

side, "They were…delicious."

The cat beneath the woman rumbled something and adjusted its stance. The horses nearby whickered and stamped, their riders trying to keep them reined in. Around them, then infantry were fanning out. Whippor held up a hand, stopping their advance, "Where is the Queen."

"The one who is supposed to be dead?"

"The one you murdered? I assume she is your hostage," Whippor smirked. Adora smiled right back, then half turned.

Another figure emerged from the woodline, this one on horse back. Whippor swallowed involuntarily as the Magicat rider approached. Her armour was black as midnight, hear helm showing a regal face and eyes that bore into him terrifying focus. The blonde woman turned back to him, "As you can see. Safe and sound and under no bindings."

Whippor let out a slow hiss, "A trick. The Queen is *dead* . We had a message."

"Then you have been deceived Commander ," said the Magicat, "By those disloyal to the throne, who would seek to use you and yours. I am sure you would not wish to be…entangled in Halfmoon af fairs."

Her voice was commanding, authoritative. But Whippor was a stubborn soul and not one easily swayed. He stared at the woman, "Some Magicat in looted armour . But perhaps I will indulge you. Surrender yourself to our custody, we will bring you before the Princess Regent."

The woman's eyes narrowed, "Why not my *wife* ?

"Queen Melendy is..I .am told..indisposed," Whippor shrugged, "An *internal* Halfmoon matter."

Adora leaned across and glanced at the Magicat, who shook her head slightly. Adora nodded slowly, then looked back at Whippor, "That..will not be happening. Bring Princess Catra and Queen Melendy here. They may vouch for us, we do not enter the city, your orders are not interrupted. A simple solution."

The reptile stared at her, then looked at the Magicat. He knew it was her. Knew it in his bones. He could pretend and try to whip things up, but once she was in the city, well, it would be revealed that his troops were somehow involved. It was messy. It would lead to questions and a risk that Lashor had *promised* would not arise. How hard was it to kill twelve humans and some poisoned, sun drunk vampires?

He licked his lips, then nodded slowly. A slight glance to his magi ensured they were close to him, before he looked back at the pair. All alone. Far from the trees. Maybe some of the Queen' s folk had

survived. Maybe the mercenaries had escaped somehow and his troops were still out there, having lost the trail.

He needed to resolve this, to ensure the situation in the city was not challenged. He could risk it, of course - claim ignorance, let the woman in, but he was being insulted and challenged here. He straightened up, "I can request an audience. Will you not join me at the camps edge. You must be tired from your escape."

The two women exchanged a glance, "Escape?"

"From the traitors. And those mercenaries."

"And your men?" Adora smirked.

"My men were there to assist. I am sure it is all a simple… misunderstanding."

"I think we will await here," the Magicat said smoothly. Whippor nodded slowly.

"Of course. I will be sure to convey a message of your arrival, your *Majesty*. Is our parlay concluded?"

Adora tilted her head and smirked, "It is."

"Good," Whippor smiled back, then looked to his mages, "Kill them."

Things happened fast. The mages, who had been holding their power ready, raised their arms. Lightning crackled from the Scorponi's claws, but it went wide as an arrow five foot long slammed into the mage's chest and took them off their horse so fast, the animal reared in shock.

The lizard's spell sputtered at the sudden strike and he tried to regain, only for the blonde's cat to lung forwards. It leapt and took the mage out of his saddle with a bite. The reptile's shriek was silenced with a *crunch* , before the cat was among the cavalry.

Horsemen are effective at a charge - lances ready, sweeping in to trample scattered infantry. They can strike down into a throng, too. But milling about, static, when a beast is at head height and can take a horse's throat out with a swipe? Then they are not so effective.

Whippor was shocked at the speed of things. He watched as the magicat spurred her horse forward and she too leapt. But she didn't jump. Instead her form flickered and she was suddenly on one of the cavalry man, a dagger in the man's throat, between mail and the helmet cuff. The man gurgled, but the Queen was gone, back on her horse, which was riding hard for the forest.

Whippor tried to turn his beast, but the Em-la let out a shriek as another massive arrow split its compound eye. The creature reared, then crashed to the ground, sending the Commander rolling.

He struggled to his feet and hauled his curved scimitar free, only to stare in horror as his cavalry tried to fend off a fast moving, giant cat. Half the horses were down, gored, their riders unmoving.

But what was more shocking was the *rider* . She set about his infantry like a scythe through wheat. She ducked pike jabs and used the men's proximity against them, yanking a weapon free here to drive it into the gut of a man *there* . She swept a leg and sent a man falling only, to yank the man's *own* dagger free from a sheath to drive it into his throat.

One soldier got close and drove a spear into her thigh, but the woman twisted and *snapped* the pike haft. She grappled the man, moving and spinning, keeping the others at bay. Then she *tore* the man's throat out with her bare hands. She flung the gore at another soldier, before she pulled the pike head free. The wound didnt even seem to phase her as she charged another man and tackled him down, leaving the broken spear in his gut. She rolled away and scooped up a discarded sword. Then she went to work.

Whippor made to approach but after a few steps, his honour guard of eight men lay dead. His cavalry were dead. His mages.dead.

He clutched his scimitar before him and stared at the bloodied woman before him, whilst the great beast roamed up behind her. The warrior stared at him, arms smeared with blood. She smirked at his blade, "A man without honour . You could have chosen the simple path, the *right* path . Now many will die. Run back to your army , if you can, and know that you have miscalculated *terribly* today."

Whippor surveyed the corpses of his men, then looked at the woman. Then he looked *beyond* her at the trees. Some of them were swaying and he could make out figures in them - huge shapes, taller than the largest Scorponi. Slowly, lights lit up as torches caught flame in the woodline. They spread, all around. The blonde smiled at him, then tilted her head back and *howled* . It echoed around and was answered on all sides.

Whippor turned and ran. Back towards his camp, the safety of the shield walls. His massed mages and archers.

Adora watched him go then reached across to pat Melog, A few figures joined her and she tilted her head back, "Let him reach the line. Then attack, as we discussed. Harry the perimeter. Heavies in and over their lines. I want them broken. Take what prisoners you can. We are to send a *message* . Do not harm the Magicats if you can avoid it."

"As you will it, war chief," murmurred Tella and Duncan. Adora nodded, her gaze fixed on the cliff and the carved gate far distant. Her gaze drifted to the side, to the hidden entrance - she knew both would be guarded. By loyalists or traitors? There was the rub.

But one problem at a time. First, to crush the enemy before her. Then rescue a Princess. Or at least save the people *from* the Princess. Adora had no doubt Catra was more than handling her own. She chuckled. Time to have some fun.

Under the mountain, Catra was entertaining. She sat on a chaise while opposite here, Scorpia babbled and chatted about the wonders of the Hegemony and the sights in the capital, Sheba. Perfuma sat demurely to one side, smiling politely, but her gaze kept shifting to watch the Magicat Princess. Huntara, the ever present bodyguard, hung near the door, opposite a burly Magicat soldier.

"...and of course we have the waters of the gardens - all piped in on a near permanent stream. Had that designed for us by the Spider Queen you know! This was back when Dryll was still speaking with us of course, before, well, the Horde, but you know that! Of course you do. But, yes, that'll be amazing and I can't wait to show you… and the library of orders! It's where all the stuff about the Hegemony is handled! Hundreds of clerks, so much scroll work, amazing to see. I like to go there sometimes and just hear the rustle of quills! It's like..like a heart, you know? Relaxing and impressive and, well, just gotta be seen? Oh! And of course there's the arena - they do plays there too. Have you seen The Thousand Nights of the Dunes? Oh well I will have to get them to put on a production in your honour! It's four hours long and, oh my gosh you will LOVE it."

Catra stared at Scorpia and swirled her goblet, then adjusted her legs. She was wearing a dress, but more functional rather than glamorous: red, with black accents, over a black shift. Her gaze flitted to a frustrated looking Perfuma and her nose crinkled. She cocked her head, then glanced at Huntara. A small smile flickered on her face and Scorpia beamed. Catra blinked, confused, but then rallied, "Oh wow , I mean, yes it seems so…much. I may not be… great company at first. You understand?"

"Oh of course. Of. Course. I am sure your mom…I mean the one here…I am sure Queen Melendy will make a full recovery . And then you dont need to worry!SHell be here, youll be safe, we can, well, keep thingsss…table. I know it isnt ideal Catra and…and I wish and hope youll be ok with things," the Scorponi Princess clutched her claws together, "I promise I will ensure you are…Safe and we will keep Halfmoon safe. That's what matters."

Catra heaved a sigh and nodded, "I know I know . It's just…so hard. You think you can trust someone. You open up…And they betray you. Keep things from you. Their plans, their intent," she sipped from her goblet and stared at Scorpia, "Y ou know what I mean?"

Scorpia stared back and bit her lip, then coughed, "I…ah, well, I know. The Hegemony, it works but it's so complicated, that sort of thing cant happen!T oo many moving parts, you couldnt…uh"…

Catra looked at Perfuma, "I mean, you get it. I am sorry for…for asking Scorpia to get rid of you. That would have been awful. A real betrayal of her bond to you. I know, having thought I had one…to betray that, or make someone betray it would be *awful* . I mean,

imagine if someone close to her, someone she trusted with her life, did something that..that undermined that? Sorry , sorry I am..poor company."

She laid the back of her hand against her head and sighed, then stared at Huntara. The Orc stared right back at her, impassive. A small smirk crossed Catra's face and she glanced at Perfuma, then back at the Orc. The purple woman seemed to pale for a moment, before Catra leaned forwards. Scorpia hemmed and hawed, "I..I.. wouldn't want to let you down Catra, but..but in politics things will happen. I mean, right now, this..this feels like I'm taking advantage and, well, I..I"...

Catra placed her goblet down on the table and nodded slowly, then reached over to pat Scorpia's claw, "I know . Circumstances. I am sure you are doing what you feel is *right* . Just if anything untoward happens in our future..Y ou would tell me, right? I'd hate for our partnership to start on the wrong foot, especially after all those memories we shared?"

Here mismatched eyes met Scorpia's dark green ones. The Scorponi Princess blanched and she pulled her claw back gently, "I"…

Catra sat back and sighed, "I'm sorry to be so..dour . Would you excuse me for a while? I know we have the signing later and..and I fear I must rest first. You have been a rock, Scorpia. So reliable. Such a support when I needed it. I am so glad I have someone I can trust. And you too, Perfuma. I am sure we will be the *best* of friends," Her smile was thin and showed a hint of fang. Perfuma actually

swallowed a little and Catra leaned over to grab her hand. She gave it a gentle squeeze, "We'll be like sisters. So much to *share*. Never had a sister!"

Her voice was honeyed, almost saccharine, before she let out a sigh and a sniffle, then nodded curtly. Scorpia rose, "Oh um, it...it must be a lot."

"Yes, I am...so so sorry. Please. Excuse me. I will see you shortly, in the gardens?"

"Oh of course! Yes, we will um, await summons. And thank you Catra for um...um." Scorpia winced, "Just...thank you?"

The door clicked shut behind them as they left and Catra relaxed with a snort. It'd been scant hours since her episode with Weaver and the circle. She knew *something* was on the way, something familiar. What it'd look like she didn't know, but she needed to prepare things. And this was an element of that.

For all her faults, Scorpia was still, ultimately, someone who *thought* they were decent. And after this little meeting there was a tantilising bit of extra information. Quite how scandalous it was, Catra wasn't sure, but she had just put a tiny little chink in the armour of the Hegemony's heir, along with her entourage. She wasn't sure how long she had, probably a day or so at most, and then it'd depend on how Adora would deal with the Army at *her* gates, then the potential traitors on the walls.

She needed to deal with the rot *here* , to stop it from impacting her *Belevenn's* return. Catra was going to get *married* before the full moon come hell or high water. She was done playing nice.

A knock at the door revealed one of her reliable chambermaids. The Magicat girl curtsied and Catra beckoned her in, "Ah, good. I need you to deliver messages of summons to the key negotiators. Here's a list of names. Get the Chamberlain to organise. Throne room, one hour. Do not tell Cyrus.. but do let him find out."

The serving girl grinned, "Yes, your highness."

Catra rolled her shoulders and nodded to herself. She needed to do this - impress her authority. She knew they'd ignore her or try to neuter her via platitudes. She'd heard horror stories of puppet leaders who only *thought* they had power. She was determined not to be one of them.

As the servant departed, Catra moved with purpose. Her dress she tore off and discarded, before she approached her armour rack. In moments she was clad head to toe in her black leather and steel coverings. Her blades went to her hips and a few daggers were added to sheaths across her torso. She studied herself, flexing her hands and letting her ears flick under the helm.

With a nod, she stepped out of the room, her guards falling in beside her. She'd, or rather *Pan* , had managed to get her actual loyal

troops assigned to her, under the guise of *"it looks less suspicious"* in his messages to Cyrus. Catra was paranoid enough to have ensured Pan was definitely loyal to her, but that road of suspicion was potentially a minefield. Either she could trust people or they'd betray her and she would *resolve the matter* .

She journeyed down to the throne room and was pleased to see that, as requested, someone had set up a table at the foot of the throne dais, complete with ornate chair. She strode across the room, under the gaze of the many guards around the place, and took a seat. Already there were piles of paperwork stacked there, which she then set about working through. She glanced up and smiled at the Chamberlain, who had approached from the throne room's entrance. The man studied her carefully and then smiled.

"Your highness… We have a few petitioners who have been… waiting."

"I expected as much. Did the General not handle them?" Catra asked, a smile on her face. The Chamberlain gave a slight inclination of his head.

"Some, yes, but only those with possible connections within the Privvy council."

"Ah. Well, please send them in, at a reasonable rate. And send a clerk in. We must record things, mustn't we?"

"Indeed, your highness. I am glad to see you take after your mother ," the man's lips quirked in the faintest of smirks. Catra snorted and nodded in dismissal.

The first few were simple - requests for arbitration on minor matters. Catra sent them away to appeal to justice of the peace in the city as they were *not* Royal concerns. A few were from prominent Merchants, concerned about the sudden blockade and change in fortune over the past few days - almost a week of changes. They were being excluded, sudden surges of interest from diplomatic representatives from the Hegemony. Catra grimaced at that - things were moving fast, clearly. Some people seemed impatient.

A few messengers arrived, from her courtiers and the negotiators, stating they were unable to *respond* to her enquiries or accede to her invitation to meet. Simply *too busy* . As she'd expected.

She did notice a couple of the guards had slipped out of the room, however and smirked. She worked through another stack of paperwork - taxation agreements, adjustments on some excavation requests, the usual minutiae of daily court life. Some of the work was clearly meant for an underling, but she was effectively reviewing and rubber stamping - she'd asked for a favour from one of the many clerks in the palace to basically be given as much paperwork as possible. She'd not taken too much of an interest in the past - but that hadn't meant she'd taken *no* interest. Part of her upbringing and education had been all about the intricacies of the palace. Much like her mother had left her in the care of Weaver, even *after* they betrayal, so had she been exposed to the reality of *all* courtly life.

Its cunning. Its brutality. Its mind numbing bureaucracy. And while she found it groaning dull and awful, she was *good* at navigating it.

She chose to be outside, fighting the Horde, yes. But she was a woman of many talents.

She didn't look up as she heard the main doors to the throne room creak open once more. In a bored tone she huffed, "One moment, you may raise your petition shortly."

"I will not be addressed like that," came a huffy voice. Catra glanced up, her face a mask of mild irritation, to regard the courtier in a frilly robe. A few more were trailing in behind the man. Clearly they'd made a beeline to get there.

"Baron Cleve. I think you *missed* something there," she hummed and very deliberately laid her quill down, before she folded her hands together.

The Baron glared at her and sneered, with a small bow, "Your Highness, I merely ask you accord *me* the respect I am due. And I wish to know why you are acting in this manner!"

"What manner is that?"

"This! You are to be wed, why are you involving yourself in these things. It is unseemly for a young lady"…

Catra held up a piece of paper, "My mother , a lady by the way, had a decree stating that all trade concerning underground fungi farms would be handled with oversight by the crown. However, I am given to understand *you* are making purchases of farms under threat of repossession *in the crown's name* ."

The Baron's eyes bulged and his tail whipped from side to side, "This does not conc-"

"And you, there, Lord Fenwick, I am given to understand you are in additional talks with the Hegemony on surface farmland being requisitioned for their use?"

The man coughed, "This is high level negotiations for"…

"And you, lady Frald, I am given to understand from *this* that you intend to offer land in our city for a Garrison? Already signed, but I have had no oversight."

The woman drew herself up, though she seemed a bit off balance, her greying fur puffed out, "All above board, your Highness, I can assure you. You are young, this must be *very* vexing and you should not be troubling yourself"…

"I would also like to point out, Baron, that Lady Frald is, well a lady. Why is she able to conduct terms, hm? Whereas I, the *fucking heir*, am not?" she smiled sweetly at the man and placed the various pieces of paper down in front of her. The baron huffed and rolled his shoulders.

"Your *Highness*, we all know the reality. You are... you should not be concerning yourself with the murkiness of state. Your mothers, they delegated, hosted banquets, that sort of thing. Leave this ugliness to us. The good General is operating as Regent, as you are, well, in a fragile state. We simply wouldn't wish things to go wrong, or for people to... Get the wrong idea."

Catra regarded the man and then smiled widely, "So I'm the heir, but not really? In which case... why would the Hegemony want me? If I am not that valuable, well, may as well call this off... but if I *am* the heir, I have authority. So, which is it?"

The Baron's smile was thin, "We were thinking, well, the Royal family serves a purpose, and you are the heir but... well... you won't be required, you understand? It's simply reality. Your authority is, of course, recognised... but not needed, your Highness. Now, I appreciate you are making a point and we will be sure to let you read over the treaty so you understand"...

"You will *let* me read the treaty?" Catra's voice was dull. A few of the courtiers frowned at that. The Baron smiled.

"Well, of course. So you understand the value of your contribution and what is expected"...

Catra barked a laugh out that echoed around the chamber. She leaned back in the ornate chair and smirked at the man who frowned back at her, "Wow. You guys are *dumb*."

"Exexcuse me?" the Baron huffed.

"Putting all this aside, you're basically telling *me* what to do. Dress it up how you want...but that's the intent here. And your little attempts at coercion haven't gone unnoticed, by the way. Implying I had something to do with my *mother's* situation..." her smile twisted, "Funny thing though, if you're at *all* a student of history of the Magicats...we used to usurp each other, betray each other, assassinate, plot all that. So the thing is, even if I *had* plotted to kill my parents...I'd still be the fucking Queen."

The room grew silent. The Baron stared at her then seemed to notice that she wasn't in a gown and was armed. He frowned, "Now, girl, you know..."

"And ANOTHER thing," Catra leaned forwards, elbows on the table, "If I was the person who murdered my mom, or set it up or whatever...do you think it'd be wise to threaten someone who did that? Or that they'd stop with their own parents to get what they wanted? Turnaround, if someone was accused of that and threatened...what do you think they'd do to people they felt had *wronged* their family...given our history, I mean? The history where

we waged a bloody, centuries long campaign against the Fae, against each other, against the humans?"

The Baron blinked and realised the other courtiers had stepped back a little. He scoffed, "You are clearly upset. This is why you should not be involved in any of this you are simply"…

His voice cut out as suddenly Catra was there in front of him. The papers on the desk barely fluttered at her passing. But her claws were at his neck and a blade was slicing his abdomen open. The Baron gurgled as he was held in place. He tried to scrabble and claw at Catra, but his claws simply slid across her armour as his guts pooled at his feet. With a snort, the Princess released him.

Around the room a few guards moved forwards, hesitantly. She looked at them and glared, "Go on. Raise a blade against your fucking *Princess*. Your soon-to-be-Queen. See how it goes. But know this. I won't kill you. I'll let you live, then drag your families in here and make them *watch*. And make them know *why*. And then I will banish them to the sunward realm, never to return and strike their names from the books of this city. Never will your children see this place, never will they be welcome. All will turn from them. And *you*," she leveled her blade at the huddled courtiers, "We are not *done*. You attempt to steal from my people, attempt to barter our home away brick by brick. Sell my honour for *baubles*? Sell our dignity? Insult me, insult my *line*? Well, I am *altering* the deal. You have *one* chance. Join talk. Or join the Baron on the floor."

She looked down at the wheezing man. His guts were trying to retract in as his vampiric healing took hold. Catra smirked, then

jammed a blade into the pile of entrails, pinning them to the floor . The Baron howled as the silver of the blade hissed and fizzled. But he lived. Catra looked back up at the group, her smile broad and near feral, then looked to the doors of the throne room. She saw Cyrus enter and pause - he looked flushed as if he'd been running, clearly wanting to intercept her as much as the courtiers.

"Princess Catra I"…

"General, please be advised I am detaining these traitors. I am concerned they may have been involved in corrupt dealings as part of our negotiation with the Hegemony regarding our upcoming alliance," she turned and walked back around the small desk to retake her seat, "Please ensure that the Palace is secured and send in the Hegemony negotiators. I would speak with them directly."

"Your Highness, I don't" Cyrus tried to go with authoritative, but his gaze kept slipping to the whimpering Baron on the floor .

"Ah, yes, quite right. Please remove the former Baron, unseemly to negotiate with that fouling the corner up. Clerk, take a note, all holdings of the Baron are now property of the crown, pending review and assessment, under the acts of Treachery. General, the Baron attempted to threaten the Royal personage and to coerce me to action. I will not tolerate that. These courtiers will remain here, under guard, as we negotiate the supposed dull minutiae with Hegemony. I am sure most of it will just be…me smiling and nodding. But it must be seen to be done, yes?"

Cyrus stared at the Baron, then at the soldiers around the room. His brow furrowed as he counted them and noted their uniforms. Those on the walls behind Catra wore *her* colours. Only a few wore the household livery on their armour. He mused for a moment and smiled, "As you command, Princess. A bold move, one your mothers would be proud of."

"You are too kind, General. Please see to things and send the Hegemony in."

The two eyed one another and Cyrus bowed. He rose, then turned and marched out, leaving his allies behind. Catra watched him go and chuckled, then glanced at the courtiers. Her smirk was *not* pleasant.

Outside the throne room, Cyrus cursed under his breath. He made for the ante-room where the Hegemony staff were waiting and paused as he almost ran into Pan. He glared at the Captain who shot him a puzzled frown in return, "Sir?"

"I thought you had her reigned in?"

"The Princess? I heard she was taking court. SUrely that's what we want, sir?"

"No! She is..she stabbed the baron!"

"She didn't?" Pan shook his head in disbelief, "Sir she may have gone mad. Surely we can…"

"No, if we want the marriage to happen, we need her…damn. We can't remove her , the Hegemony might use that to push for more. No, we need to play it safe."

"What about the courtiers?" Pan whispered. Cyrus shook his head.

"They won't talk, not yet. They admit anything they're dead either way. Best to pretend something minor. Once Catra is shipped off, we can help them…or not," he paused, "Actually…this could work to our advantage. Fewer parasites in court, more central control… yes…yes. This could actually be good."

Pan nodded slowly, "She doesn't suspect?"

"No…I have no idea what the Baron said…I'll have to debrief the guards afterwards. Talk to your men. Play along. Lets give her what she wants, for now. She may even do us a favour."

Cyrus nodded and chuckled, then patted Pan on the arm and marched off towards the Hegemony rooms. Behind him Pan smirked, and vanished towards the Throne room. Cyrus paid him no heed and instead rapped on the heavy door to one of the many ante-chambers. It creaked open to reveal the towering form of Huntara

who gave him a baleful glare. Beyond, Cyrus could see the worried face of the Princess and a haggard looking Tong Lashor. He arched an eyebrow, "Eminent guests, your Highness. I was only expecting Lashor and his... assistants."

Lashor scoffed, "The Princess was seeking *advice*. I have *advised* her that our plan is perfect and suits all involved. This tragedy can… come to some beneficial arrangements."

Cyrus hummed and frowned at the Princess - how much did she know? Clearly she was aware of *something*. No matter, they were where they were, "Indeed. Now, please, follow me. The Princess wishes to speak with the delegation to go over the treaty."

Lashor blinked in surprise, "What?"

Scorpia's eyes widened, "What?"

Cyrus shrugged, "A surprise, but can you blame her for taking an active interest in her future?"

Lashor chewed his lip then shrugged and gestured to the few clerks in the room, "It matters little. If you will excuse my bluntness, your Highness, I doubt she will pose a challenge."

The Princess shook her head, and muttered, "But..we were supposed to meet in the gardens"...

Lashor ignored her and made to stride out, "Let's go meet the girl then."

Scorpia suddenly darted forwards, her pincer on his arm, "And me too. I need to see how this works. It's my future too."

The Reptilian vizier looked irritated, but masked it quickly, "Of course, my lady. Shall we?"

Cyrus stepped aside to let the small group exit. He felt an anticipation building, but for some reason couldn't shake a nagging sense of dread as well. It was a dangerous game, but they were close to the end now. A simple signature and then it would be a matter of logistics. Then Catra would be on her way and he would be able to run Halfmoon, in Melendy's name, of course, as it should be - to drive the Horde back. And, maybe, to get some additional benefits.

All would be well. He just needed to hold the line a little longer.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for your patience everyone. So, the battle is gonna be BIG. Couldn't squeeze it in with all the drama into one

chapter.

So, here we go, we've set the scene, now you got the opening salvo!

Hope you like - this was written on 2 cups of coffee at 1 am, whilst also fuelled by a sense of guilt and obligation, my core muses!:D

As ever, let me know what you think!

Chapter 18

Chapter Summary

Battle commences. Physical and mental.

Blood is spilled.

Who will loose their heads?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Whippor had faced many foes in his years of campaigning for the Hegemony: the desert lizards of the Crimson sands;pirate Merfolk of the Salinean reefs;human nomads and cavalry;even the odd Fae interloper sortie. And, if course, the Horde - far more often these past few years, the Horde had been an ever present foe. But they were almost like the seasons, rote in their arrival and their manners.

The Hegemony held, with the Fae and the Halfmooners holding their own. But neither of those realms *pushed* . The Hegemony tried, tried to reclaim the lost lands. But while they now could hold the Horde back, they failed at pushing *into* those territories. Better to sit in their fortifications and throw rocks and magic at the hordes of Horde that tried to push into their borders.

All of this meant that Whippor was a seasoned campaigner, used to trials and challenge and, dare he admit it, loss. He recognised the potential for a losing battle. And this was teetering horribly close to it, at least based on the prowess of a single warrior.

He was seasoned *enough,* however, to know a battle did not rest on a single combatant. A single skilled soldier would fall to a phalanx or a volley of arrows. A well placed lightning strike would fry a master swordsman. Far better to *not* meet one of those in honourable combat and use the Hegemony's tried and tested method - grinding advance with a solid defence.

And yet, the ease with which a single warrior had dispatched his entire guard;and then the *arrow* ?He had seen it - far too large to be launched from a bow. They clearly had siege engines. Were they intent on laying siege to the *mountain* ?It made no sense - the reports said it was a dozen humans!Humans could be strong and fierce but *twelve* ?

Whippor had made it to his lines, shrieking at the shell-shocked soldiers to rally. The Hegemony was a vast mess of territory and bureaucracy but its military was well drilled and capable. Bells rang, fires were doused and men slipped into practiced formations. They'd erected only the most rudimentary of palisades and stockades around the perimeter of the tents - enough to hold back a cavalry charge, but they were ostensibly an "escort" for the Princess in supposedly friendly territory.

But Whippor was no fool, oh no. So he'd had some modicum defences put together. Not enough to spook those Magicats unsure of their intent, but enough to keep his army secure and ready.

The General now stood atop a temporary tower, one that his troops had easily lashed together in mere moments. He was back, near the center of the camp, far easier to send orders and observe the fight. That dash back to the lines had been one of the most intense runs of his life: he'd fought and been in retreats, but that had been humiliating. No ordered withdrawal, or a rally . No, he'd been bested in *moments* and been found wanting. It made his cool blood run hot and his tongue flicked out in irritation to taste the air. All he could feel was the sweat and stench of his men, along with the evening mists.

The torches around his camp had been doused, mostly, to allow his men to adapt to the dark a little. The tree line all around was visible, albeit now shrouded in a thin fog. Behind the army rose the mountain cliffs and the main entrance. Torches burned there, vast braziers atop the tiered walls that arose above the gate. They cast light, but not far, contrasting the shadows in patterns that tricked the eye.

"Sir , shall we send out the scouts?" murmured a young of ficer, a human, next to Whippor on the scaffold. The reptile hissed and looked at his hastily gathered commanders. This was his first *real* chance to brief anyone.

"W aste of meat. We'd get the horses back and lose the men. Hold position. Zith," he looked at another lizard, "Keep the shield line locked between the defence gaps. Rilka," he addressed a Scorponi woman, "Archers three men deep, facing all sides. First sign of a charge, low volleys, repeat. And Frelin," this he addressed to another human, "Magi with the archers. Of fensive magic, but if we can deflect any incoming, do so. They have siege weaponry."

The sun was gone now, the impending battlefield shrouded in darkness and silence fell, save the jngle of armour and clank of spears against shields as the army waited. Whippor stared into the dark and hissed again. The Scoutmaster, Hunin, spoke again, "Are they.baiting us?"

Whippor shook his head slowly, "No, their devil of a leader , she said she was coming. You dont do what she did and then *hide* . If she wanted us to chase she would have fled.and I would have fallen for it," he snarled. Pompous though he was, he wasnt a bad commander. At least not according to his own measure.

"We could burn the forest," murmured Frelin which drew a chuckle from the other commanders. Whippor scoffed.

"I believe the Magicats might get *uppity* ."

"Hardly our problem after today , sir," smirked Rilka, "All part of keeping them safe from raving Bar"…

A howl ripped across the night. Another followed, then another, then *another* . An echo of the howls from earlier. All sides of the camp, all the way to the side of the mountain where the trees perched perilously on steep scree and near sheer rock. Below, Whipport could see messengers dashing across his camp, keeping the commanders informed and on task. A few clambered up to exchange hushed words with the officers, before they retreated to carry out the orders. Mostly this sort of defence was an automatic thing - each

portion of the camp knew their locations, their responsibilities. The command was there to pivot should things become *too* chaotic.

But this was unexpected. Whippor cursed himself for not having dug proper trenches or sandbanks. Proper towers or walls. And he cursed his foolish brother for rushing all this. But he knew he had a capable force. Fifteen hundred soldiers, magi and cavalry. Not a true army, no, but a respectable force nonetheless. And their prowess and trainee would make them a match for any ten barbarians in furs and loincloths!

But the image of that woman butchering his men alongside her war-beast chilled him. She had been *smiling* as she did it. And her comments. His clawed hands tightened on the rail as he peered into the dark while the howls faded. He could see the tiny pinprick of light that was the torch the bitch had planted in the soil. A beacon that shone a faint light on the shrouded forms of the dead around it.

Whippor squinted and ground his fangs. Another pinprick had appeared. Then another. And more. A veritable starfield began to light up in the trees. Hundreds, no, *thousands* of lights. In the trees, *up in the trees* , light ominous fireflies.

"A trick to hide their numbers," murmured Hunin, "They seek to strike fear in us."

"Archers?" Rilka asked, turning to her commander . Whippor shook his head.

"That torch is *just* beyond the reach of our bows. Barely. Volley fire as soon as they emerge, then switch to direct targets as they close."

"Yes sir," Rilka leaned over the tower to bark short, coded orders down. The commanders paused at a faint whistling noise then exchanged confused glances. On the lines they could hear the *clang* of metal on metal, but also the screams of shock and pain. Whippor peered at the fringe defences and gawped. He saw arrows, mere streaks in the dark, slamming into the shield walls. They were large, the same that had taken out the mage, and they punched into the shields with ease, knocking down soldiers, or skewering those behind if they found a gap. The men behind moved to shore up the gaps, hauling the shields back and hunkering down. The screams echoed from all around, panicked shouts as the steady fire came in. Even if a man wasn't knocked down, the arrows were *heavy* and Whippor could imagine the difficulty of holding a shield up with that weight. He turned to Frelin, "Shields - disrupt their attacks!"

Frelin nodded and traced a glowing symbol in the air. Immediately, faint blue glows began to emanate around the camp as rippling barriers formed in front of the shield walls. Arrows then arched over them and into the troops behind as the enemy adjusted their arcs. The mages countered, forming another layer of barriers. Still the fire came in, clattering off the shields, or blow off course as the mages redirected where they couldn't form shields. Maintaining a barrier was an intense task as well - it wasn't a solution, but it would buy them time.

Whippor growled - the fault with a defence is that you ceded the ground to your foe. They held the initiative. Rilka gave voice to his

worries, "We cannot return fire if they're…

And the enemy made their move. Hulking shapes strode from the forest, surrounded by torchlight. Nine foot tall *beasts*, wielding weapons as large as a man. Whippor couldn't make them out clearly, as they were surrounded by the more regular sized warriors of humans and lizards? He pulled his spyglass up to try to get a better account and gawped.

The huge warriors slammed their weapons to the ground and let out ear-splitting howls. The cry was taken up by their comrades as something else moved out of the forest directly ahead of them. Whippor lowered his spyglass and tilted his head.

"Is that a *boat*?" The enemy were carrying the hulls of ships out of the trees, the hulls upturned. Warriors huddled beneath, marching with them. Whippor raised his spyglass again and saw more of the huge creatures beneath the boats, carrying them, although he could barely see legs. Realisation dawned, "Our archers, get the mages to target the vessels! Hit the carriers. Rilka, direct fire as soon as"…

The warriors not shielded howled again and charged, breaking into long, loping runs, sometimes falling to all fours temporarily. They closed the distance *fast*, their shorter brethren warriors following in their wake, while the boats advanced towards the line. More hulls emerged from the forest, bringing torches with them. They drew the eye and Whippor snarled.

"East flank!" came a cry from below . Whippor spun his spyglass and let out a hiss. A whole contingent of the beast-cats had emerged from the forest and were making for the flank. Arrows whizzed from the riders atop them. They pinged harmlessly against the barrier but that was clearly the intent as the beasts closed.

"Drop the shields! Archers, free fire, take them down, take them DOWN!"

The messengers ran, yelling commands as they did. The blue dropped on that flank and the archers began to fire. A volley wouldn't work, the enemy closing too fast, so the archers fired between the shields. The huge cats jinked and moved, their riders swaying easily , returning fire as they did. A few arrows struck one beast which yowled in pain and rolled, its riders leaping free with graceless tumbles. They all rolled and continued advancing, while the big cat yowled in irritation, curling up so that its armour shielded it.

Arrows flew over from the advancing foe and Hegemony archers dropped, gurgling, while more arrows slammed into shields and stuck. The Sergeant on the line screamed for the spears to *brace* , readying for the impact that was coming.

Except the cats didn't hit the wall. Oh no.

They leapt *over* it. A couple landed on the spearmen at the rear with messy crunches, before they turned and began to swipe and snap at their foes with abandon. Some of the spearmen managed to haul

their pikes up and skewered one cat which thrashed and howled, although the blades seemed to have mostly only caught on its belly-armour and saddle-belt. The weight of the creature was pushing the weapon in, but one of the creature's riders, a slim woman with black hair and red-on-black armour, swung from her perch and dropped into the middle of a crowd of soldiers, her eyes filled with rage. She moved like a snake, hair whipping around like a black mist as she cut into the soldiers, fast as lightning.

Another woman dropped down, her armour dyed blue, a pair of bucklers on her hands, her bow slung across her body. She let out a snap kick that broke the spearman nearest her from his grip, before she punched out several times, snapping the spear hafts that had partly impaled her great, white beast. Then she leapt into the fray, with a bellow that seemed almost elemental.

Whippor stared as his Eastern flank began to buckle. Regular warriors were advancing from that flank, spilling from the woods at a dead run. More of the heavy arrows flew in, skewering troops further from the fighting. Already a melee was beginning to form there as his troops rallied. Some were clearly locked into brawling and he saw flashes of magic as the mages made to fall back behind the soldiers who retreated a little, holding their lines. Battered, but not yet broken. Whippor turned to look at the forward flank and swallowed.

The big warriors were at the line, and were *hammering* it. He could make out enemy wounded behind them, but they seemed to be just getting up and yanking arrows clear . It reminded him of the Horde. He watched through the spyglass as a few helped the more seriously wounded back towards the treeline, but they seemed less than bothered.

At the front, a huge wolf-beast with twin swords slashed and broke the spears thrust through the shield wall at its huge form, whilst a second smashed a soldier into paste with a maul that had a hammerhead the size of a man's torso. The beast swept it along, sending shield bearers to the soil. The enemy too advantage, warriors spilling over the fallen men and into the breach, axes flying and swords ringing as they charged in.

A few charged and flung lamps that burst into flame, which quickly spread to the tents behind the rallied Hegemony troops. Whippor watched as one torch thrower was skewered by a pair of spears but the man just screamed. And then he *changed*. His form bulged and flexed, until a grey furred monster towered above the soldiers. The creature snapped the spears then sized up one screaming soldier. It tossed the man into a burning tent then leapt after the second. The pair went rolling into a mass of sparking timber, before the beast smashed the soldier into the ground several times. It then bounded away into the camp, pursuing a pair of mages.

The line was partly broken, as the enemy moved around the slowly isolating forces. Whippor cursed and looked to his commanders, "Have the perimeters fall back to the second line. Tighten it up," he shuddered, having expected the enemy to test the line first. But their force seemed able to assail on *all* sides.

"West! The west!" came another cry and Whippor turned in horror to see a woman atop a dark beast, followed by thirty Magicats and a good fifty of the wolf beasts, all loping along easily around her. The blonde stood atop the beast, sword held aloft, her cape flapping behind her. She seemed to glow in the moonlight, visible to all as

she charged with reckless abandon. He could see her yelling something, but couldn't make it out: *honour… day…*

He hissed again, "Have the western flank fall back. Do not engage, do not engage. Bolster at the second line."

"Sir!" That was Zath, "Why?"..

"Our forward defence is breached, and will fall if encircled. We have foes in the camp. The Western flank will be cut off and attacked from the rear, most likely. She is *distracting* them, while we falter on the other sides. Pull them back!"

Zath nodded curtly and yelled out more orders. Slowly, the shield wall on the western flank began to split and fall back, in an orderly fashion.

Even within the camp, Whippor had ordered other lines of defence. These would not be so obvious - not being on the edges. He'd had pits dug, hidden trenches excavated. Smaller, more compacted, but enough to allow for a fallback.

He hoped it would be enough.

Catra leaned back in her chair and smiled at the collection of representatives across the table from her. While Cyrus had gone to fetch the diplomats she had had servants bring in several chairs. They were functional, from the servants quarters, and clearly not comfortable for prolonged use. She made a mental note to have the servants furnishings looked into.

Scorpia shifted on her seat and her eyes trailed to the still groaning Baron, who remained impaled, before they then shifted to a gaggle of nobles who were kneeling off to one side of the throne room, a collection of soldiers behind them, "Uh..Wildcat, this seems..a really odd situation. I thought we were"…

Catra raised a hand as she flicked her gaze to Cyrus. The General stood off to one side, positioned midway between the Hegemony and the Princess. Catra's gaze flicked to the Baron, "Didnt I tell you to clear that up."

It wasnt a question. Cyrus twitched, "You also asked me to request the presence of the Hege-"

"So you put me in a position of seeming like some *tyrant* who leaves tortured souls in their throne room"?

"Well it was you who"…

"I. Hadn't. Finished," Catra smiled as she lounged back, arms folded, "You were in such a hurry to fetch the diplomats, you ignored a command."

Cyrus coloured a little under his fur and his grip on the helm he had clutched against his side tightened, "I felt that these talks were more important."

Silence fell. Catra studied, "You felt?"

Tong Lashor leaned forwards, "I imagine the good General only has your best interests at heart, Princess."

"Shut up, before I turn you into a tapestry," Catra sing songed. She looked at the reptile, "My mother warned you about speaking out of turn before. This is your *second* warning. But do tell me, is Cyrus on your staff?"

The reptile's throat bulged for a moment and he made a noise like a boiling kettle for a moment, before a sickly smile stretched over his features, "*Princess*, no, but Cyrus has been instrumental in our negotiations and, frankly, seems more...".

"Catra leaned forwards and her hand slapped down onto the table in front of her, "Negotiations that seem to hand a lot of land off to them," she jutted her chin at the nobles, "Who, incidentally, appear to have favourable relationships with your Hegemony. But not much in

the way of return for my people. Oh for them, yes, but not my *nation* ,"she looked at Scorpia and smiled, "I trust you are aware of *all* of the details of the treaty arrangements, your Highness"?

Scorpia blinked at Catra's shift from snarling to sweet, "Um, I..I havent read it, but Ambassador Lashor is a real stand up, well versed master of letters who"...

"So good to have good staf f, right? Gotta have those loyal serfs that scurry about? Y ou can really rely on them huh? Like your Orc girl there, Huntara right"?

Lashor looked over his shoulder, confused by the sudden switch of conversation, "Why is her entourage of concern?"..

"Because you know a *lot* about a person by whom they surround themselves. And you know about a *kingdom* by the nature of its functionaries, their attitudes, their loyalty, their *priorities* ,"Catra said this while staring at the big Orc woman, who stared back stoney faced, "Y ou, I bet you're loyal to the core. Lay down your life, take an arrow to the knee, or whatever. Big girl, all power, used to cracking skulls in the name of your mistress"?

Catra's eyes flicked to Perfuma and Huntara's eyes widened a fraction. She stayed silent. Scorpia looked at Catra, then at Huntara, confused, "Uh, Catra..what does this have to do with..us"?

"Everything, Scorp. Everything. You promised me safety. Security. Guarantees. Sadly, though, I don't have *faith* right now in your ability to deliver. Not when *he*," she leveled a claw lazily at Tong Lashor, "Has been working with *him*," she switched her finger to Cyrus, "But not *me*. And also that both of them have worked with *them.*" She flicked her wrist at the kneeling nobles, one of whom was sniffling.

Tong Lashor licked his lips, "We understand you were grieving a *hideous* betrayal, having lost your mother. Such grave responsibility on one so young."

Catra's gaze was flat, "I am at least fifty years older than *you*, boy. Vampire, remember?" Lashor looked confused, unsure as to the veracity of the statement. Catra's expression split into a grin, "But I digress, now, where was I, oh YEAH, so your friend Lashor here has been making nice with all sorts in the court. But not me. But I've been expected to just.agree. In *fact* I've been heavily *advised* to agree by my advisors here. But as you can see, they're on their knees and Cyrus there is five seconds away from me cutting his throat, because I'm a *little bit upset*. So I wanted to remind you, as diplomats, about the chain of command and who. The. Fuck. Is. In. Charge."

She said all this with a smile. Her gaze flicked to Cyrus. The General glowered at her, "Princess, you are...not handling"…

"I said shut up, did I not? So, that's *twice* you've incorrectly interpreted my orders, Cyrus. Another word and I kill one of your friends over there. Ah hell, let's do it anyway."

She raised a hand and one of her guards slashed down, beheading one of the vampire nobles. There wasn't even a scream, only a hiss as the body flared with green magic and then crumbled to dust. Scorpia actually shrieked a little. Catra turned her gaze back to the Hegemony. Lashor swallowed, "Wh..why are we here for this?"

"Because I want to illustrate what you should *expect* from me. I am *not* to be shuffled into a harem. I am a soldier. A leader. I will brook *no* arguments. And I accept no falsehood or compromise. And, frankly, that's all I'm hearing. Granted it's my people, and they may have led you astray," she crooned this last bit, almost condescendingly, "Filling you with hopes and promises. I want to assure you we don't tolerate corruption or betrayal. Which brings me *back* to my point. Loyalty. Trustworthiness. And, Scorp, that's my *big* issue right now."

Cyrus looked to be stock still, eyes fixed on the pile of ash and charred clothes that had been one of his allies. The others were looking down at the ash, then up at him. He swallowed, then looked at Catra, "M..yo..your highness"…

A rattle at the door announced a rather tense looking Pan, "My apologies, your highness..we, um...may I speak with the General?"

Catra studied her loyal second then grinned widely, her eyes lighting up, "Oh, please do."

Pan dashed over and whispered something into Cyrus' ear . The General staggered a little and stared at the man, then nodded shakily. He shot the Hegemony a glance, seemingly conflicted, "My lady, your highness, it.th.ere appears to be an issue in the plains beyond the gate. I fear that your mother's killers are.so.mehow… assaulting the *Hegemony* "?

Catra's smile didn't fade, "That so?.W ell, run along. I'm sure you can defeat band of a doz.en humans, hmm?"as Cyrus turned Catra clicked her fingers, "Oh *wait* .weren't they all killed"?

"It.it. must be the remainder of those who j.oined her . Revenge, perhaps."

"Still, only a doz.en or so, by my tally . And we have what?" her gaz.e fell on Scorpia, "A thousand brave souls out there, j.ust ready to fight for the *independence* of Halfmoon, right?"Are you sure our allies can't handle a few thugs"?

Cyrus stared at Catra and swallowed as realisation began to settle in, "My lady"…

"Run along, General. W e have matters of state to discuss,"she dismissed the General and nodded at Pan, "Captain Pan, please act as a go between, keep me *informed* "?

"Yes, my lady," Pan bowed, then ushered a rather shocked Cyrus from the room. Catra looked back at the Hegemony representatives, who seemed confused. Lashor seemed agitated, Scorpia just confused, while Perfuma looked a little shamefaced.

The feline princess rested her arms on the table in front of her and tapped the paperwork, "See, Scorp, I *have* read the treaty. It's not great. Lots of concessions, lots of us giving away land and...for what? We provide more troops, we take the fight to the Horde, great. I can get behind that. But, well, it all comes back to trust. I'm not in a great place about that right now. Because, and you'll find this freakin' *hilarious*, turns out that my own PEOPLE aren't trustworthy. Imagine that, not being able to trust the people close to you? Imagine if you couldn't trust Perfuma, right? Or Huntara there. Or those Orcs on either side of her. Or Lashor. Good old, upstanding *Lashor*."

She leaned back and her chair creaked. The reptile opposite her hissed, "This...is this is grandstanding. I do not know what you expect to achieve with this. Frankly, I have a mind to remove any offers of support. I have never been so *insulted*. This is...pure mockery of our great nation, theatrics with no goal! This is not how negotiations are done. What is the point?"

Catra snorted, "You done? All finished there? Scorpia, you want to pull out?"

The Scorpion Princess stared into Catra's two tone eyes, "...what's going on Catra?"

"Oh I think you know . Or maybe *some* of it. But let's be frank here, this is politics. You want us in the war, full time. You want a secure location, you want more free trade and access to resources. It's how the Hegemony works. Perfuma there, her kingdom has nice protections, security, guaranteed trade. They just had to give up some things. Like Perfuma."

The blonde waif straightened, "I am very happy . I chose this path."

"Easiest way , I imagine," Catra nodded understandingly , "Ob comes with perks, right?" her eyes flicked to Huntara again. Perfuma glared.

"I love Scorpia, This isn't some penance. I support her , she is worthy of that. If you'll excuse my bluntness your highness, you are being unfair."

Catra shifted and looked down at the papers, then glanced back up, "Am I? Really? My own people try to usurp me during a time of tragedy, to ship me off, selling out the realm from underneath me? Nope, not unfair . Though I imagine Scorpia is, yknow , genuinely concerned about me. To a degree. But what about... Adora?"

Her gaze flicked to Scorpia, her eyes cold. The Princess couldn't meet her eyes, "Um, she.. she betrayed you."

"Ah, wasn't her . Poison isn't her style. She'll stab you in the front and meet your eyes. If she thinks you're worthy . Know how I know?

Because she is my soul mate, my other half. And guess what… she's still alive."

The Hegemony looked from side to side, perplexed, Lashor sputtered, "But…that has…that has nothing to do with this. W e are discussing the union between our kingdoms! What does it matter?"

"It matters because of *trust* , Ambassador. Old Cyrus, who just walked out of here, tried to sell me to you. These leeches here did the same. They promised you everything. But how could you trust that? Which in turn leads me to wonder how I can trust *you* , if you were so quick to aid them. Sets all our deals up on shaky footing. This isn't me just hopping into a carriage and traveling to the Hegemony to sit on silk sheets, sorry Scorp. Once I'm out of here, what guarantees are there? What trust? Sorry , I keep missing my point. I'll be plain. I can't trust you because you made deals that actively harmed, or sought to harm my people. And you worked with people who actually *did* harm me."

Scorpia frowned, "W ait"…her gaze turned to Lashor and her head tilted, "Lashor , what did"…

"Be quiet, Princess, please. This is a delicate…matter ."

"I mean, he actively tried to have my fiancee killed, I'm pretty sure. As for my mothers," Catra' s smile was not pleasant, "I don't think he had anything to do with that, directly…but awful convenient, right?"

Scorpia stared at Lashor, her jaw working, while expressions of shock and guilt played over her face. She looked back at Catra, "We, no that can't be true, that can't…"

"But you see my problem Scorpia. You make promises, you smile, you encourage me. But now I see you can't trust your advisors! And what about your bodyguards? Are they guarding your body…or someone else's?"

Catra shrugged and Scorpia stood suddenly, "I…we…we're supposed to get *married* Catra. This is what all this is about! Why are you fighting it?"

"Didn't you *listen*?" Catra smiled sadly at Scorpia, "Either you were part of a means to *steal my kingdom*, or you trusted people who conspired to do so. That's my option A. Option B is…well right now I imagine she's killing her way to get back here." The Magicat Princess grinned wildly and leaned back in her chair, then planted her boots on the table, scuffing the papers there, "So, now we have all that out in the open, let me hear your *proposal*. A Princess to a *Queen*. I'll let you confer."

Scorpia swayed and Lashor stood, grasping at her shoulders, "My Princess, this…this is conjecture. We followed a plan, we merely acted in good faith with the governing body. Please, let me…we can handle this. It is just some…negotiating tactic," he searched her eyes, "She is showing us she is…not to be trifled with. That is all," his words were a hiss, sibilant and reassuring, "She is making a powerplay…and frankly, it is my fault, I should have expected her to

assert herself. And I respect her for doing so. She is no thrall, no pawn. This is good!"

The Scorpion Princess nodded slowly, then more firmly, as a smile split her face, "Sure, yes. Makes perfect sense," she sat back down and her claw blindly sought out Perfuma's hand. The blonde princess smiled as she squeezed Scorpia's claw. Catra sighed as she watched them, her ears twitched and she glanced up at the various balconies above them. She snorted and shook her head, then looked at Lashor expectantly.

The reptile turned and adopted a supercilious expression, "Your Highness. This is all on me. I made a grievous error in judgment and clearly should have been speaking to the true leader here. Honestly, this is a far better arrangement, selfishly, for us. A ruler, not a Princess. A marrying of equals, not just a warrior with capabilities. I am sure we can start again. All previous arrangements null and void, But of course, we would wish to find concessions, as I am sure you will request as well. May we begin afresh? I can say that we were not party to any actions in the City against yourself."

Catra smirked, "And outside the City?"

"All I know is that it was your messengers who brought word back. Our forces are here purely as security for our darling Princess. Were any of ours privy to such potentially nefarious actions well, I am sure we can deliver swift justice for heinous acts and would seek to ensure reparations were made. You appear, forgive me for saying, pragmatic. Are we able to speak on these things clearly?"

Catra splayed her arms wide, her smirk never shifting, "W ow, colour me *impressed* . Speak your piece, Ambassador. Im all ears."

She could indulge them. After all, she was the Qeen. And she just needed to buy a little more time for her *wife* to get here.

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Cyrus shook in the corridor, his expression glassy, "She knows."

"Sir?" Pan looked alarmed, "I, surely not? She..she' s been grief stricken!"

"I, she knows. She..or she' s paranoid. Or taking..dammit she' s *cold* . She's seiing power . Crafty little hellion. We..we need to act. Or else well be found out."

"But sir ," Pan started, cautiously , "This could be..good. If she is, maybe, being proactive then..she could get us a better arrangement?"

"I I was meant to..be regent," Cyrus hissed, "She was meant to lead from the *front* . That's where she is needed. I t here. I am

meant for this,” he scrubbed at the fur on his head, “I, we..we need to salvage this. She just straight up killed a man. In trial. In… nothing.”

Pan studied his commanding officer and had to hide a smile. He coughed to cover it, “And..and the assault?”

“How bad, surely just a few suicidal idiot humans? Why the urgency?”

“W ell, sir, I felt I had to get you out of there. It all seemed tense.”

Cyrus studied Pan and then nodded, “Good..good thinking. So?”

“Honestly sir , there seemed to be a lot of them. Lots of torches, according to the messenger. But the Hegemony has a defensible position. And we can seal the mountain in the worst case.”

“Good. I doubt it will come to that. In, we need to secure here. Lock down the palace. I will rally the garrison. We need to..take the Princess into protective custody, for her own safety.”

“But..what if she ratifies a deal with the Hegemony?”

"Don't be ridiculous, Captain. In an hour or two? Hardly. And Lashor will flex as we need. If we demonstrate we are truly in control and that the Princess can be handled?"

"Sir, playing the advocate of the devil here... why not work *with* the Princess now?"

Cyrus turned on the Captain, "Because she *knows* I was involved. I can see it. And if she sets the terms with Hegemony, you and I, Captain, are out on our arses. They will flex as they need. It's how the bastards survive. They were willing to help us *kill the Queen*. To get what they want, you think they won't throw us under the cartwheels? The Hegemony. Does. Not. Care. A soldier matters nothing. A village is a check on a scroll. A thousand men dying in a valley to zombies is a nuisance. They will. Not. Care. We are an avenue that won't have worked, so they will take the one that DOES. We have to demonstrate *value*. And that means pacifying Catra. Get your men ready. I will get the Garrison. I trust those in the throne room are just... acting for show for now."

Pan nodded, seeming uncertain, "Yes. They... will not disobey her directly, not now. Not unless she orders them to do something against the plan, I am sure," he pointedly didn't say *which* plan.

"They readily executed a noble," muttered Cyrus.

Pan chuckled nervously, "Well, an opportunity of a lifetime, right?"

Cyrus stared at him and actually snorted, "Honestly , I wanted to gut the Baron myself so…no, no getting sidetracked. T o your duty Captain," he paused and grimaced, "What we do is…hard. But necessary. To defeat the Horde. These small things will have *big* changes. And after this you will not have to listen to her orders anymore."

"Oh what a relief!" Pan smirked, "Small mercies, sir ."

Cyrus nodded and stalked out of the main gates. Pan watched him go and grimaced. He watched Cyrus pause to issue orders to a couple of the younger officers en route. Several troops with them then tromped away, heading for the balconies above the throne room. The Captain sighed and shook his head as the troops poured past him - not many yet. But it could pose a problem. The whole garrison wouldnt turn against the Princess. But with enough vague orders they *could* take down any loyal guards and isolate Catra.

Though he severely doubted that would impede the Princess. But it would be messy. He chewed his lip and then moved to the guards near the throne room entrance, "Bar the doors. Then bar the front of the palace. Spread the word. No more troops inside. Get anyone else from the Company together who isnt in the throne room. W e're going to have to cause some chaos."

The squad of men exchanged glances and grinned excitedly, "Y ou got it, boss man. For her Highness."

Adora approached the enemy line, her smile broad, sword held high, "For the honour of Greyskull!For Blood!For glory!For Catra!"

Melog pounded hard, the soil beneath them easy purchase for the big cat. Around here the Magicats rode hard, their black armour almost lost in the dark. And beyond them ran her closest warriors, her loyal shield brothers and sisters. Ahead, she could see the enemy falling back - she smiled a toothy grin: they were not complete idiots. It was refreshing to fight flesh and blood, warm foes. The Horde fell into predictable patterns oftentimes. A true, living foe gave a challenge with their ingenuity, rather than relying on endless reserves and magic.

The other fronts were clearly making headway, too. Flashes of magic lit the sky, whilst screams and flames rent the night air. To her right, the mountain loomed, along with its hidden entryway. For now they ignored it, keen to focus on the foe. No doubt the Magicats would have concealed it further anyway. But in good news, the vampires also appeared to be staying out of the conflict. Idly, Adora wondered why - had Catra seized full control? Or were the guards not totally compromised?

She pushed the thoughts aside, her sole focus the battle ahead. Her blood was up and her vision was red with excitement. Melog dashed and then leapt. The straggling line of Scorponi braced as the big cat slammed down onto them. Adora flung herself clear as the battle cat set to the foe, tossing men and women around like ragdolls. Torches flew into tents and oil braziers toppled, spreading flame. Around her the magicats launched from their mounts, moving faster than they eye could easily track.

Scorpion braced shields, only to find a soldier behind them, with a blade in their spine. Howls of shock echoed as the magicats set to their grisly task, flitting about in the shadows, dueling and dealing swift death. They were hampered as the Scorponi rallied and managed to use their armour to their advantage, making quick kills harder: Shields up, halberds and blades swinging;magic flaring to stagger or disorient the fast moving vampires. Still soldiers fell, their armour dented from super-human impacts, or being grappled by biting, hissing felines.

Adora strode into the melee. A Scorponi lunged through the smoke and Adora dodge, then drew her blade across the trooper's gut, where the plate armour gapped briefly above the leather skirt of the soldier's armour. The chain and leather split under the strike and claws clutched at spilling entrails. Adora moved on, parrying a strike before swiftly removing a head. The next soldier got a punch to the jaw that sent the soldier to the ground. Adora reversed her blade and stabbed down, eliciting a shriek as she pierced a leg.

She wanted to strike a blow, but *not* cause a massacre. She knew it was unwise to leave a foe on the battlefield, but a message had to be sent. But utter slaughter was *not* the goal, even if it was likely.

Two humans charged her. She blocked one blow, ducked another, then kicked one of the men back. A flick of her sword disarmed the other man, before she cold cocked him with the pommel of her blade. She darted to the other man and headbutted him, hard, before she sliced his leg open. He fell and she kicked him, hard, to one side. An arrow whizzed by and Adora darted forwards, ending an archer's career in a single swipe. She paused as the rest of the

Scorponi fell back further, then halted. She studied them, a good hundred yards away, noting how they had narrowed their march, then expanded back. Her raised blade called her own soldiers to halt.

She could see, through the smoke and ruins of campfires, tents and palisades that the other lines were falling back, but in far less order. Clearly her massed assault there had done more damage and they had fallen back before they could be encircled. Their commander wasn't *all* bluster then.

Just a sneaky little shit.

She grinned as she stared at the enemy line, then up at the raised tower beyond. Her push had compacted her enemy further - made their defences tighter. She smiled as the odd, heavy arrow whistled in, only to slam against a blue barrier. Her eyes widened as she heard the clatter of bowstrings and she managed to shout out "Brace!" before she hauled up a corpse from the battlefield. A rain of arrows descended down littering the camp. There was distant laughter as the troops under the approaching boat hulls mocked their foes. She watched as a few more volleys skittered harmlessly down on her sheltered troops.

A frown crossed her face as she heard a magicat yowl in irritation and watched as one of the vampires fell, partially pincushioned. Adora chuckled and the cat glared at her. She recognised Kelik and arched an eyebrow, "Used a corpse?"

"Sod of f," hissed the cat-man. Adora grunted and shuf fled over as another volley descended. She hauled the man into the cover of a cart and tore out the arrows. He glared at her and then spoke, grudgingly, "Thank you. Again."

Adora shrugged, "Y ou are no use to your Q een dead. And we need you to speak with the garrison at the gate. Remember, we occupy them, you move there. N w , do you require blood?"

The magicat shook his head and took a swig from a canteen at his belt, "On of your , um..comrades..gave me some," the man looked faintly flushed.

"Oh?" Adora smirked, "Live through this to thank them. I am sure they wish you to live."

She patted the man then strode out of cover, arms spread, blade held out, "Hunker down, cowards. Or do you have the fire to face your death head on? s that ice in your bellies or *fire* ?" she braced her blade across her shoulders as Melog strode up behind her, "Y ield and we will show mercy. Fight on and make peace with whatever grain gods you follow!"

Howls and cheers arose from across the battlefield - her troops wouldnt *all* have heard that, not with the distance, but they echoed their cheers. She watched the tower and saw some movement. Slowly, she nodded to herself, then leveled her blade, "DEA TH!" she broke into a run, headed straight at the shields. All around wolves,

men, lizards, charged. The Scorponi held fast, spears poking out between shields.

Then the battle cats passed Adora and leapt over the line again, distracting the foe, while the wolf forms battered into the line. Men shifted as they ran, clothes tearing, their weapons becoming like daggers in their hands, flung ahead with monstrous strength. These beasts vaulted or tackled the line. Some were impaled on spears, but just writhed and snapped the hafts as the clawed their way ahead, foaming jaws and slashing claws. Adora saw a gap and vaulted a pit. She rolled up and sliced at the legs of a staggering shield-bearer. The man went down and suddenly Adora was in the middle of a scrum of shocked troopers. She shouldered one aside, then gripped her blade by the hilt and blade and slammed it into the neck of another. She spun and dodged a spear thrust, cut down another soldier, then disarmed another as she twisted her blade about and above her. A soldier staggered forwards and Adora brought her blade down hard enough to split the trooper's helm *and* head. She kicked the corpse away, then ran through another soldier. The man toppled away and Adora released her sword. She ducked a swipe and slammed the palm of her hand into the chin guard of another soldier, then snatched *his sword* , which she used to parry another attack.

She jammed to blade into the woman-soldier 's leg then kicked the pommel, driving it in further. She leapt back from an axe swipe, then hauled her own sword from the twitching corpse it was embedded in, before she dove forwards to cleave the axe-head from the haft of the weapon, then swung back to remove the soldier's clawed arm.

Around her, the Scorponi shield line was breaking, but her side were taking losses. She saw a couple of her own lizards fall, riddled with

arrows. A wolf went down, impaled on twelve spears as Hegemony troops hacked at him, whilst more wolves barreled into the fray, their cleavers hewing at the enemy. A battle cat yowled in distress as a fireball burned its face and arrows peppered its neck.

Adora roared defiance and pushed ahead, eyes fixed on the tower. She saw a robed figure spot her and begin to gesture wildly at her. She was still a solid hundred and fifty yards away, but she watched the robed man levitate and dive towards her. More figures in similar robes emerged out of the smoke, with battered soldiers with them.

The troops charged and Adora dispatched them swiftly, right before one of the robed beings lanced her with lightning. The others scattered to aid their fellow soldiers as, all around, more of Adora's war-band pushed forwards, hacking and cleaving through the shattered Scorponi troops, who were forming mini-shield-walls with shields over and around them, to make sort of hedgehog style defences.

Adora grunted as she realised this was, perhaps, the leader of the mages. He who had descended from the tower. The man paused then flashed another bolt of lightning at Adora, while another two mages joined in the assault. She sank to a knee, sword held tightly in her grip. The mage yelled out, "YIELD! And we can stop this bloodshed! Submit! You will be treated fairly!"

Adora looked up and her eyes flashed, "You're magic? Well, I'm magic too."

The mages blinked then unleashed their lightning again. Adora rose slowly, as strange tattoo lines glowed across her skin. She grinned as the magic fizzled and popped across her flesh. Her hair smoked and frizzed up and she gritted her teeth. Then she *changed.*

Where once there was a woman, now stood a massive white-gold wolf beast. The mages' attacks sputtered out as Adora' s fur sparked and frizzed up. Then, with a howl, she lunged. Hunnin barely had a moment to scream before Adora hoisted him up and tore his head clean from his shoulders with her jaws. The other two mages tried to scramble away, but a swipe from Adora's claws opened the back of one of them, while the other was clothesline by the tossed corpse of the former mage-leader. A second wolf leapt on the prone mage and ended her with a bite.

Adora powered forwards, ignoring the arrows that hit her, before she scaled the tower. A Scorponi woman stared at her then lunged, tail whipping out to strike. Adora caught it, then used it to spin the woman above her head before she tossed the soldier away, across the camp.

Two reptiles stared at her, along with a human as her weight settled on the planks. One of the lizards charged her , but her claw swipe knocked him back into the human and both toppled from the rickety tower.

Below, the melee was in full swing. The Scorponi were using their meager defences well, for the most part - trenches and traps meant that the wolves and humans had to funnel in, which had allowed them to hold the line in some places. But when your defences were

breached by massive beasts elsewhere and your rear-guard was flanked? It made it a simple matter of time.

Adora shifted down, stark naked and regarded the sole general. She smirked, "Yield. Your command is gone. Your men are being butchered. You have lost."

Whippor stared at her and hissed, "I am a proud General of the Hegemony"…

"Without *honour*," sneered Adora.

"...what guarantees do I have?" Whippor glared at her, "If I surrender."

"You tried to kill the Queen of Halfmoon. And me. In a decent diplomatic arrangements, I would demand your head. Five seconds. Choose," she glanced down and winced as she yanked an arrow from her arm.

She looked up as Whippor swung at her. She leapt back and he pressed his attack. He swung, clean, neat slices and thrusts. Adora ducked and dodged. She slapped the flat of his blade away and glared at him. The reptile hissed in desperation. Clearly he thought he was dead anyway.

Remove the head, or something like that, maybe?

Finally he swung and Adora clumsily slipped. The blade bit into her shoulder and lodged there. Whippor grinned triumphantly, but Adora didn't sink to her knees. Instead she placed her palm over the back of the blade to hold it in place and met Whippor's gaze. The reptile blinked, then tried to yank his sword free. It didn't move. Adora grinned at him, blood on her teeth, "What was the plan? Hope that my troops would flee if you brandished my head?"

Whippor snarled, "Maybe"…

"Well, you'd need her head too."

Whippor blinked and his gaze slid to the side.

A Magicat glared at him. Before he could move a blade flashed out. His last vision was a tumbling world, with only a glimpse of his headless body crumpling to the wooden deck of the scaffold.

Cyra caught the head and held it up to her eye level with a sneer. She then looked at Adora and arched an eyebrow, "Was that… necessary?"

The blonde snarled as she yanked the weapon free. With a snort, she strode up to Cỳra, "W ell, I had to give you the killing blow. This is *your* city, after all."

The Vampire Qeen stared at the werewolf and pursed her lips, "Y ou are odd. But I see why my daughter likes you. Qte the gesture," her gaze fell on the battle below . The ferocity had tempered as the battle ebbed. The sea-farers had abandoned their boat-shields and now had clusters of Hegemony troops surrounded. Already, cleared pockets of the camp were being sorted, wounded and dead and prisoners being hauled and sorted, whilst the main fights now looked more like corralling.

Cỳra held up the decapitated head and drew a deep breath. Her voice echoed out across the camp, "Y ou leaders are dead or defeated! In the name of Halfmoon, yield! Y ou fight for nothing! I am Qeen Cỳra! Fight on and it will be *war* with the Hegemony!"

Adora punched the air and let out an "Aroo! Aroo! Aroo!" her troops raised their weapons around the resistant Hegemony and echoed the cry. Massive beasts waved their mauls and blades, while reptiles and humans leered, drenched in the blood of the fallen, lit by flickering torches and burning tents.

There was a pause, followed by the clatter of weapons and shields as the remaining troops tossed them to the ground. A few remaining mages sank to their knees, arms raised. Adora looked at Cỳra and grinned, "W ell, that worked."

The Queen nodded slowly, then looked towards the towering "main" gate of Halfmoon, her gaze narrowed. Kelik and his troops were moving up, arrayed before the gate, "Now, I think we must finish what we have started. And if they have harmed a *hair* on Melendy's body"…

The werewolf smiled grimly as her wounds began to knit closed, "We shall sing songs of the liberation. And then we will drink the mead of memory for the lost. But for now…let's go get our girls."

Chapter End Notes

ARE YOU NOT ENTERTAINED?

Chapter 19

Chapter Summary

The gates fall.

Cyrus plans, a fools errand, as something in the Palace stirs awake.

In the darkness of the tunnels, they advance.

Sergeant Miyek stared out at the flames that danced across what had once been an orderly camp. Where an army of Scorponi had stood, now there were just blackened tent frames and smoking wreckage. Shapes moved in that maelstrom, while distant screams and whimpers pierced the night.

He'd watched, along with the gate-watch, smugly expecting the barbarians to be turned aside like the ruffians they were. He'd been excited when the Hegemony had arrived - a sense of *progress* , that things might have changed. And, well, the opportunity for promotion as well - people heading off to war meant open spaces and advancement for those back home. He was a career soldier, yes, but he appreciated the routine of the city, even if he did long for the Horde to be nothing but a distant memory.

Now he was, for the first time, shocked. He had fought a Horde army, once, a few decades prior. It had been harrowing, even for his nigh-immortal soul. The dead did not break, did not fear. It was like fighting the sea as the tide came in. This battle reminded him of that, although *far* noisier. These barbarians had come on like a howling storm, hundreds of them. And they had cast the Hegemony aside as if they were chess pieces on a board.

"S..sergeant?" came a worried voice from next to him. He glanced to the side and tilted his chin up.

"Stand firm, boy . Our walls are no mere palisade. We held the fae off;a collection of barbarians are *nothing* compared to the wards placed upon this place. Take heart!Y ou hear that boys!T ake heart!"

He swallowed as a cheer echoed up and down the rows and battlements above him and alongside him. He wanted to believe the words, but something in the flashes of magic and flame told him that this was an enemy he hadnt encountered before. He'd seen a Death-Knight cleave its way through his fellows on a bloody field years ago - Vampires torn down by a blade that seemed to sap their very will. Something about the fight out there felt familiar to that event - a creeping sense of inevitability.

"Riders!" came a cry from along the wall and Miyek peered down, his eyes widening. A collection of horsemen were cantering around the perimeter of the fallen camp, whilst the fighting was still ongoing. His eyes widened further as he realised the riders were *Mgicats,* dressed in the armour of the Queen's own guard.

"Open the gate!The Queen' s-guard have returned!" called a guard. Miyek barked a rebuttal:

"Hold!It could be a trick!The Queen' s guard would never attack an ally!"

He cringed a little at that. He didn't know anything, not really. But he wasn't *stupid*. He and a few of the other enlisted and officers were aware that Cyrus had a plan, a goal, to get Half Moon back on the front foot. He knew it involved the Princess. And something to do with the Queen's. It didn't take a genius to know that there was some level of opportunism there. But he knew the Queen had died, at the hands of these same barbarians, by all accounts. He wouldn't put it past them to have coerced traitors or to be using the armour of the dead.

The riders pulled up a dozen yards from the gate, well within bow range. The lead rider looked up and spurred his horse forward a little before he stood in his stirrups and called up, "By order of her Majesty, Queen Cyra, The blade of the mountain, Lady of the Seven Nights of vengeance, holder of the Twilight caverns and Mistress of Bloody contract, I order you to open the gate and permit entry."

Miyek's gut twisted as he recognised the voice and the man below. He gritted his teeth, "You speak well for a dead man? Have the Horde taken your body to puppet? The Queen is dead. And you are either a puppet or a TRAITOR! You carry an army to our gates, slaughter our allies? And expect us to allow them in to pillage? THese gates have stood against more than raiders and treachery. Begone!"

The man stared up at him then laughed, but there was no humour in it, "And who am I speaking to?"

"Sergeant Miyek, of the line of Clin, *Commander* ."

"Excellent. I will ask the Queen to write a suitably morose letter to your family, dictating your sense of duty in the face of evidence, you *bloody stupid little man!* I have been poisoned, stabbed, *nearly killed* , by Scorponi and *treacherous* Magicats. My patience is at an end and I think you'd better listen to *me* , now, you horrible little *oik* , before the Queen gets here, because she is NOT amused."

"We will not let traitors in. You killed Queen Cyra, poisoned Queen Melendy. We will not be fooled by your...".

The Sergeant's words stuttered to a halt. Where before there had just been horsemen, now a woman in the full battle regalia of the Queen stood before the gates. Her gaze locked onto Miyek and he found himself frozen by that stare.

"Melendy has been *poisoned* "?

The sounds of battle seemed to fade - everything became as if silence had blanketed the surrounding fields and forests. The cold fury of the words echoed around the gate. A few soldiers shuffled away from the Sergeant, leaving him the *sole* focus of the woman below.

The wards , he thought to himself, *they will hold anything. The gates will stand, and our archers will.*

His thought did not finish. The woman was now on the battlements. In fact, she was nearly nose to nose with Sergeant Miyek. He couldnt break eye contact, his very will locked to hers as she studied him, as a natural philosopher would study an ant beneath a lens. Her lip curled in a sneer as soldiers yelped in surprise nearby and staggered back.

Miyek was about to call out for the gates to be opened when a cry from above nearly shattered everything: "T reachery!The enemy is on the wall, shoot her!"

The voice was some Lieutenant. Miyek recalled he was one of the Household officers, one of those who was normally in Cyrus' chain of command. He had a sinking feeling he knew why that command had been shrieked with such desperation. And such a stupid thing to do. Miyek blinked as the Queen vanished;or rather she *blurred.*

The young man's voice rang out again, this time in terror. It cut off in a wet gurgle and Miyek looked to the rampart above to watch a head tumble away, disintegrating into ash as it fell. The sound of screams and terrified yells reached him, along with the clash of steel. More movement caught his gaze as he watched the Queen's guard rapidly scale the wall, vaulting up it like mountain goats as the supernatural speed and cat-agility lent them speed. They passed his rampart and Miyek managed to yell out a strangled, "Hold fire, HOLD FIRE Damn you all, lest we become ash!"

He watched the guard vanish above, over the lip of the next layer of rampart. The sounds of battle had diminished somewhat and an eerie calm settled. A moment passed, then the Queen stood atop the lip of the battlement and glared down at Miyek, before her gaze moved up to stare at the upper layers. The distant clatter of armour echoed as men backed away from the edges of the defences, clearly afraid.

Queen Cyra snarled, "Traitors. Traitors *everywhere*. Well, if you doubt me, doubt my *sincerity*, doubt my *right*? BEHOLD, ingrates."

A red glow suffused her hand and the gates below them rumbled. The wards on their surface flashed red and guttered out. Cyra dropped her hand and Miyek looked up, before he dropped to a knee. Around him, the soldiers followed suit. More metal echoed as troops above saw the sensible path ahead.

Cyra stepped off the battlement and *glided* down until she reached Miyek's level. She hissed, low enough so that only he could hear, "Melendy?"

"Rumours, your majesty. Poisoned by the barbarians."

"You mean my daughter-in-law?" Cyra's voice was cool and Miyek couldn't help but jerk up to stare at her in confusion. Cyra's smirk was twisted as she glanced to one side, "Adora, does that sound like something you'd do?"

Miyek turned his gaze and found himself staring at a blonde woman perched on the battlement crenellations, arm draped over a knee. Her gaze was shockingly cold and emotionless. She wore britches, loosely tied by rope, a leather harness for a sword across her back and *nothing* else. A head hung at the belt, the reptilian commander of the Hegemony forces. The blonde studied him and snorted, before she looked to Cyra, "No. Poison has its uses, but that was our *old* ways. Poison is no good against the horde. Also... it spoils the meat."

Cyra chuckled, then looked down at Miyek, "So, are we *allowed* in, now, Miyek, of the line of Clin?"

The Sergeant dropped his head and bit his lip, "Forgive me, your majesty but... I... was following orders. I thought we were finally going to fight the Horde, that some good might come of your death."

"And what of my daughter? Because Adora here is rather anxious to see her and, honestly, I wouldn't want to be between her and Catra right now. I mean, that camp was," Cyra gestured idly at what was left of the Hegemony forces, "And we can see how that all worked out. So, in the interests of speed, what forces await us?"

"My lady?" Miyek stared up at her, shocked, "You would... allow an army into Half Moon?"

“Seeing as *my own army* seems to want my family, *dead* , Sergeant?” Cyra’s tone was little more than a sneer. THe Sergeant flinched and bowed his head.

“She, my lady . We expected a dozen people in furs,” he glanced at the Adora woman who had just started to laugh.

“He has the right of it there, after a fashion.” the blonde grinned. Cyra grunted.

“I see your sense of humour is *entirely* Catra’s sort.”

“Of course. She is my *sjelevenn* . We are matched in every way.”

“Cute. So, Sergeant?”

“..there should be the garrison. They will react to interlopers. THey have been trained that way. And all believe you dead, my lady.”

Cyra cursed, “I will have to kill my way through my own people to save my wife.” her voice was hollow . A silence settled until Adora broke it with a thoughtful sound.

"Perhaps not against a mortal army, this may not work but you and yours unless we remove the heart or head, you are resilient. I… may have an option."

Miyek looked at the blonde, then to the Queen, "We are at your service, too, my lady."

Cyra stared at Adora, then looked down at Miyek, "Are you? Or were you looking to scramble atop my grave for a chance at glory?"

Miyek winced, "I would be lying if I did not see opportunity in Cyrus' offers and ideas. He promised a world of freedom, if he could convince you. And with you gone, the Princess secure as the wife of the future Empress? It was a golden promise my lady."

"At least you are honest. And ambition should not be punished. A dead man learns no lessons. You are now the Gate commander, Sergeant. The Lieutenant is unable to fulfil his duties. So is the Captain of the Gate. You are de-facto in charge. Do not obstruct the men below. Kelik, with me. Adora, please, walk with me. Tell me your plan."

Miyek sagged as he heard the two warriors depart. He sense a figure pause beside him and glanced up into the face of Commander Kelik. The man stared at him, then leaned down, "Speak to me as you did early, Sergeant. I will drain you and leave you for the crows as the sun rises. But I will at least respect your lack of flexibility

against a potentially hostile army. Moons know these dogs did not endear themselves to me easily."

He slapped the Sergeant on the shoulder and then departed into the stairwell of the nearest tower. Miyek frowned in confusion until he glanced over the battlements and realised that there were *wolf men* clinging to the wall and rocks all around the gate, clearly awaiting an order to swarm over them all, although now they all seemed a lot more relaxed...relatively speaking. More were below , marching in through the now open gates, carrying weapons the size of a grown Magicat. The Sergeant promptly sagged against the stone and slid down it, whimpering in fear and relief.

Cyrus crammed another pile of scrolls into a satchel and snarled in frustration. His little maid was no-where to be found. He briefly pondered if she had betrayed him but dismissed the thought - it mattered little and, frankly, she was a servant. When would she have the opportunity? And she would have been implicated. He knew how the court worked - they would discount it anyway. And Catra…

He paused then and hissed. The Princess had proved more than just a soldier, less malleable than he had assumed. He had believed she'd either be too distracted by her mothers' situations or at least supportive of his end goal. A miscalculation. But this was fixable. They had an army beyond the gates and his troops were moving into position to take control of the Princess and remove her influence. The Hegemony would take her as a hostage as much as a bride, no doubt.

Right now, he was consolidating. He needed to meet with the Hegemony, after Catra was dealt with and secured, to smooth things over. Likely the Scorponi Princess would need calming down - she seemed more sentimental that Lashor had implied.

Satisfied he had the right documentation, he hauled the satchel onto a shoulder and stalked out of the barracks and into the square before the Palace. Another contingent of soldiers was moving towards the front doors.

Which were closed.

Cyrus frowned, then saw a couple of his loyal officers approaching, "Report, gentlemen."

"Sir..the doors have been barred. W e've tried the side entrances but they're sealed as well."

Cyrus frowned at the man in front of him and licked his lips slowly, glancing at the Palace. He hissed in frustration and shook his head in understanding, "Pan..he has played us. That or he' s been taken out. N matter , she can't keep us out and we still have enough on the inside. Get men up to the balconies, scale the walls if we need to. They don't have *enough* men to hold us, the traitors. We must rescue the Q een and prevent the Princess doing anything foolish in her grief."

The officers exchanged uneasy looks, "Sir , this is far beyond what we planned. I understand she may have been swayed by the barbarian, but still, she is the heir and"…

"Do not finish that sentence. Will we allow a mad monarch on the throne to plunge us into chaos? No, we must *help* her. It is our duty. Now , get to it, yes?"

A runner drew up short, panting, his fur flat and ears back, "Sir, sir… sir. The Hegemony troops."

"We have no need of them, we are"…

"They're GONE sir ," the young soldier coughed out. Cyrus actually staggered a little.

"What? They *left* ?"

"No sir, routed. I just came from the wall. Didn't see the last bit, but the Lieutenant said you needed to know. The barbarians, a huge army. Monsters, they don't *die* sir. It's, it' s like"…

One of the officers frowned in shock, "Is it the Horde? Here? That could be the only thing. Maybe the barbarians weren't killed by us. It was the Horde all along?"

"Quiet, fool," hissed Cyrus. The officer just scoffed at him.

"Too late now, sir. We're in deep. But could it?"

Cyrus twitched and rolled his shoulders, while his ears flicked in annoyance, "It matters not. The barbarian is likely dead, the Queen is dead. If it *is* the Horde, this will be to our benefit and means we can negotiate more favourably. Captain, take another three hundred men to the gate. If the true entry has not been sealed, ensure it has been done. Keep whoever it is at the main gate, whittle their numbers, then sally forth and cut them down."

The Captain, a grizzled vampire snarled and nodded, "By your command."

The other one, the more sceptical of the two, just arched an eyebrow, "And us?"

"We take the Ziggurat, in case we require a fallback position," mused Cyrus, "Rally the rest of the men. Quietly. Do not spook the citizens. We do not need a mob asking *questions*."

Sighting down the bolt of the crossbow, Felik bit his lip as a conflict roiled in his gut. He was only a young man, barely out of his downy

furs and full of the vigor and passion of earnest bravado. The promises of his commanders, the sad justifications - it didn't feel right. But he had been told that the hard decisions were the ones that weighed heaviest - it was how you KNEW it was the right call - if it was easy, it likely lacked value.

He was aiming for one of the guards - the tainted blood on the tip of the bolt able to paralyse and disable the vampires below. He could see the Princess holding court, pretty much literally. That strengthened his resolve a tiny bit - she had some of the court on their knees, whilst another had been killed, and yet another had been dragged away to Moons knew where.

It felt barbaric. He'd admired Catra, who of his ilk had not? But she seemed to be manic. He licked his lips as that uncertainty nagged once more. What was the end of this? They wanted to take the fight to the surface once more. Catra was doing that, wasn't she? And yet his officers had said the Princess was mad with grief.

She didn't look insane. She looked calm. In control. And about to reject the Hegemony alliance, apparently , if the officer had been believed. That man was two floors up, with another group of archers, ready to give the signal if Catra looked about to..what?

But he was a soldier. He had his orders. And the Royal family had let them stagnate too long.

That discomfort roiled, still, however. He steeled himself and tracked his bolt to line up with the Princess. He was doing the right thing. He was.

A noise made him twitch and he almost pulled the trigger. It was a scraping noise, accompanied by the shuffling of feet. He glanced to the side and frowned. A man in a physician's robes stood on the balcony, partly hidden in shadow. Felik recognised the man - one of the Queen's current attendants - he'd escorted the man to the chambers and been sworn to secrecy. It was an honour, but he wasn't sure what was happening. Clearly they wanted the Queen's condition kept secret, but why was the man here?

"Go away," Felik hissed. The physician tilted his head. And then he moved, so fast Felik didn't even register it, not until he found his wrists gripped in a vice-like hold and fangs sunk into his throat. For a moment Felik had the shock of pain. And then... nothing.

Pan slowly stalked up towards the balcony landing that looked down on the throne room. He could see several men setting up with crossbows and knew there were more down below ready to rush into the throne room. This place was one order away from becoming a really brutal battleground.

He had a few dozen loyalists in the halls, the rest mostly in the room below, guarding Catra. A few of Cyrus' boys were down there *too*, but Pan wasn't worried. His men were battle hardened and brutal. Cyrus' troops were well drilled but hadn't had a *real* fight outside of intense sparring for years.

Slowly, carefully, he drew a thin blade from his belt as he crept up on the first crossbowman. The man glanced back and his eyes widened. Except he wasnt looking at Pan. The soldier spoke. And then the soldier *died.*

A gangly figure in the robes of a physician leapt from the shadows and pinned the man, who didnt have a chance to even scream. There was a wet sucking noise and the soldier spasmed, then went limp. Pan froze, eyes wide in shock.

The creature in front of him was a vampire, a Magicat and yet it looked like something the *Horde* would have created. The physician turned on all fours and locked milky eyes with Pan for a moment. Its appearance made Pan shudder. The man - it had been a man before - was now rail thin, his robes practically swallowing him and hanging off him. His face was gaunt and his fur was smeared with blood. There was nothing resembling *sense* in those eyes anymore. Just *hunger* .

Pan readied himself, but the creature just made a low moan before it darted off, bounding from the floor to a wall before it launched itself at another secreted crossbowman. Pan strained his ears and could pick out the faint *thumps* and the twang of a bow as *something* or something *s* were setting-to above him along the many balconies. He shivered at the thought of *more* of these things. He turned and made for another stairwell, suddenly focused on securing the Queen. There was a Horde infestation, or something and he needed to alert *someone* - Catra was well guarded and he was sure she'd be able to protect herself and Princess Scorpia.

The loyal Captain rounded a corner, then darted from the stairwell onto the upper landing. More bodies littered the floor here and they were starting to move - they now had that equally drained *look* of the physician. A physician who Pan knew was supposed to be tending Queen Melendy. Pan stopped and frowned in surprise as he noticed two servants cowering against a wall. One of the newly animated *things* stood and regarded them, before it, too, skittered away, completely ignoring the pair.

Very very un-Horde-like.

He shook himself and headed for the Queen's rooms. He staggered to a stop when he reached the door, and his eyebrows furrowed.

Two guards flanked the door still. It remained shut. And yet the guards were stock still. And they looked a little more *sallow* than he remembered. Neither looked at him. Pan approached slowly, "Alright lads. Seems there's a minor emergency. Is the Queen safe?"

They did not answer. Instead, the door creaked open and another of the physicians moved into view. His motions were jerky and he looked a little more aware than the other one. However, his eyes were pleading and full of fear, rather than feral. He croaked out, "The Queen. oh. please. Please help"…

A hand gently placed itself on the man's shoulder and pushed him aside with little more than a whimper. A new figure stepped into view,

a smile of genuine warmth on her face, while red light glowed in a faint aura around her eyes, "Oh, Pan! Lovely to see you, darling boy. Would you care to join me for a drink? I'll have to make it myself, seeing as these foolish little men thought they should be *proactive* about administering certain things. Silly boys, really."

Melendy's expression was all smiles, but when she looked at the whimpering physician it became cold. Pan sheathed his blade and looked at the stock-still soldiers, then at the physician, "Your handiwork, your majesty?"

Melendy looked back and smiled once more, "Of course. I knew that buffoon Cyrus would try something and I can't have Catra getting threatened right now. She did very well and, well, a mother looks out for her daughter."

"They look…ghoulish. Like the Horde"…

Melendy nodded and pursed her lips, "Yes, yes they do. Well join my daughter shortly, but I suppose a brief explanation?" she paused and nodded slowly, "The difference between us and the Horde is paper thin in many ways. They are decay, whilst we are, potentially, eternal preservation. But when you have been around as long as I have, you learn to pick up tricks. The Horde's magic is not necessarily *evil*. Just the use to which it is put. But again, all things must be balanced. These men are…thralls, more than proper undead, in the *Horde* sense. Hunger, base thinking. A vampire at their most starved. It's a horrible hex, to basically take *all* the blood from one of us and make it so they can *never* be satisfied, chained to the will of another," she studied her claws for a moment, face set and grim, "And that's what you get for trying to murder me. And my *family*." Melendy's tone went

dark for a moment before she smiled at Pan. A thoughtful expression shifted across her face as her eyes went unfocused for a moment, "Ah, seems the rest have retreated to an upper room and barricaded themselves in. All to the good. But it *also* appears we have more coming in through the balconies on the lower floors. Come, Pan. I have frustrations to vent.oh!" she beckoned to the physician who staggered forwards, movements stilted. Melendy smiled gently at him, "W e gave you work, tutoring, opportunities. And you betray us for.what?"

The man whimpered, his tail trailing listlessly behind him, "Please… I.. just.followed orders."

Melendy's eyes narrowed, "A Horde soldier has better honesty of purpose than you. It is a mindless *thing* . But it fulfils a role. You are.a disappointment. Eternal life and you use it for paltry gain and to try break me. And worst of all?" she leaned closer , eyes narrowed, "Y ou tried to hurt my little girl."

She crooked a finger once more and the man whined as he stepped closer, then tilted his head to one side. Melendy leaned forwards and cocked her head. The man shuddered, but didnt seem able to move. Then Melendy struck and swiftly swiped a finger across the physician's throat. His eyes widened for the barest of moments, before his life's blood poured down his front. He didnt move, didnt manage anything. Then, with a wave of her hand, Melendy released him from whatever compunction she held over him. The physician slumped to his knees, then thumped to the plush flooring. He seemed to shrivel up as the blood poured free. Pan arched an eyebrow, "N regeneration?"

"No. I have removed it." she didn't elaborate beyond that, but instead sniffed and jutted her chin to the door, "These men were all rather weak willed. A shame, really. I've known some of them for years. Very intelligent. But stupid in so many other ways," she sighed, rueful, then shook her head, "I have not seen Cyrus in the building, so I assume he is outside? Shall we go ensure my darling daughter is ready?"

Pan frowned again, "Ready for what?"

"For her fiancee to kick in the doors of course!" Melendy smiled widely, "I have a feeling that girl will be rather forceful in her entry."

Pan winced, "There is a likelihood that she and your wife may be dead, my lady."

Melendy just met his gaze and chuckled, "My dear Pan, you clearly do not know my wife. And I assumed you knew Adora better than that? The impression I got was of one who would burn the world if need be. And, well, I have a feeling there's more than meets the eyes to that girl."

WIth that she turned and exited her apartments. Pan chuckled quietly to himself, then followed after with a whispered, "Oh you have no idea."

"They keep coming!" came the shriek from the line. More Magicats piled forwards, trying to hold a shield wall up, whilst archers fired over the top. Their arrows, however, didn't stop the advancing foe: a wall of wood - shields that covered the tunnel floor to ceiling, overlapping on each side. In fact, to call them shields felt like an understatement - they looked as if they were fragments of ship hulls. But that would be ridiculous.

The Magicats tried to hold as the shields advanced, steady, inexorable. The spearmen jabbed ineffectually at the massive, wooden blockade that, impossibly, advanced. The men knew what would come next.

Gaps opened as the enemy parted their defences. A few archers tried to aim between the gaps, but all they glimpsed beyond were impossibly large figures, clad in mail and steel. Some had arrows in them, unbothered by the weapons it seemed.

And, as before, massive arms reached out and snatched at shields, spears and men. Swordsmen hacked at limbs as they were plucked and dragged behind the line, vanishing as their cries were muffled by chuckling growls and the clank of wooden barricades being hauled back into place.

The enemy had come from the gates. They had gotten past the first five checkpoints unopposed, until Cyrus' reinforcements had chanced upon a group of Magicats meeting with the nearer garrison guard. Recognition had sparked and Cyrus' loyalists had moved to apprehend the "traitors". Which had failed as the *Queen* herself butchered the first few men. Their shield wall and a volley of archers

had forced her to retreat.and then the wide caravan tunnel had been filled with charging beasts. The vampires had met their charge with equal ferocity, but found their foe as resilient, if not *more* so than their own forces. So they'd hunkered down and fallen back. They'd felled a couple of the beasts, spears and swords hacking a pair of great, red-brown wolf things down until they had groaned and slumped, dead.

The howl that had followed chilled the rest of the soldiers to the bone.

And then the wall had come down the tunnel. It pushed them back, as soldiers from behind had sallied forth from rearward checkpoints and reserve barracks to join the loyalists, unaware of their foe, only seeing invaders.

The vampires pulled back, a few of their battlemages sending fire down the tunnel, or black arcs of blood magic. They had tried to trigger runic traps, but that only seemed to make the wall stumble, not fall. The Lieutenants briefly debated collapsing the tunnel itself, but that was a last minute folly. Instead they decided to fall to another inner gate, where the passage would narrow and hold there.

As they fell back there was a rattle from the wall. The soldiers, falling back, paused, ready for a charge.

The shields parted.There was the creak of wood. Then the shocking whistle of arrows. Bolts of wood four feet long shot out, splintering

shields and men, sending howls of surprise through the Magicats.

The survivors staggered, realising only a few had been hit. And then they noticed the ropes attached to the arrows.

With shocking speed, the ropes went taught and men were hauled towards the wall of shields. With screams of shock and pain, Magicat soldiers were dragged away from the safety of their lines, leaving holes in the defence. More arrows whipped out, spearing men and, again they were hauled back, dragged into the enemy lines by massive, clawed hands. Soldiers, hooked to their shields, desperately sawed at the leather, trying to free themselves. Others clawed, desperately at the ropes, thick with salt and brine, tougher than wire cable. A few tried to haul themselves away, their vampiric powers tugging against inhuman strength hidden behind the broken hulls of former vessels. Fear matched against the gleeful barks and chuckles from behind that barrier, shouted challenges in a foreign tongue, barbed mockery that showed their foe held no fear for them.

They were sport.

A few of the soldiers broke and ran. Others charged, eager to save their comrades, only to either be snatched as well, or skewered. Dragged away along with their fellows.

"Fall back!Fall ba-"an of ficer cried, only to be silenced by an arrow through his chest, which yanked him clear of the line. He clawed at

the stone floor, leaving a smeared trail of blood behind him. The shields closed again and the foe advanced.

The Magicats ran.

At the next gate, their foe simply charged, shields up. The wards flickered and died, as something behind the inexorable wall *just broke them* . The gates fell open, pushed aside by ten foot tall wolf-beasts that swung clubs and hammers, knocking men into walls, crushing all before them.

And yet, if one watched, if one took the *time* , these beasts seemed to maim and not kill. That might have led to some horrifying conclusions.

The Magicats finally rallied at the ledge that overlooked the city. Their last line. Spears arrayed in a semi-circle around the gate, the survivors numbering just a few dozen from their garrison of hundred - more men were being summoned from the Palace but there was, apparently, a delay. A siege of some sort there, the commanders were confused, though a few of their number seemed more panicked than was normal.

The final gates had been barred. Something heavy slammed against it. Once. Twice. Three times, the boom echoing out across the cavern. Down in the city cries were roused as the citizens emerged from homes, shocked, confused by the strange sounds from the entryway to their sanctuary.

Those near the palace could see soldiers milling in the courtyard near the big doors and seemed to be trying to break it down, with little success. Panic slowly began to seep into the people of Halfmoon as men and women streamed into the streets, towards the Ziggurat - the rallying point for safety , should the cavern be breached. Except they were stopped by soldiers and angry commanders who tried to force them back, while soldiers scrambled up towards balconies and attempted to batter down the main doors.

Up on the ledge, the Magicat soldiers readied themselves. SIlence reigned.

And then the gate bars slid aside of their own accord.They swung *inward* , impossible, given their hinges. A single figure stepped through, small in the vast space between.

Queen Cyra glared at the men arrayed before her as black tendrils of shadow tinged in red wreathed about her *just* out of sight to the naked eye but somehow still there. The soldiers stared in shock, many recognising their Queen. A few lowered their weapons, but a couple of commanders shrieked to hold position.

"Really? You so openly announce your treachery? Men and women of Halfmoon, do you so easily fail your oaths? Do you seek glory in ignominy?" Cyra hissed, her eyes finding the commanders who had ordered them to hold, "Do you side with a snake who sought my death?"

"W e..you are an imposter!" cried out a desperate of ficer, "The real Q..een would not lead monsters to our door , slaughter our men!"

C'yra smirked and raised a hand, "These men?"

Behind her, from the darkness of the tunnel marched Magicats, led by Kelik. Men and women with shocked, angry expressions - the faces of those who realise they had been led on a fool's errand. They lined up behind the Q..een, faces set in determined anger . And none seemed to be wounded any longer.

The treacherous commander rallied, looking to his fellow officers for support. But only a couple nodded in return, albeit nervously. The others were exchanging confused looks, "Some..enchantment. An illusion! Y ou ..the *Queen* was murdered! Slain by . ..by the barbarian whore."

C'yra blinked and winced, "Oh, not a good choice of words."

Rumbling growls echoed from the cavernous tunnel as eyes glowed in the shadows. Deep barking laughs echoed out of that darkness. Easy laughter, the sort that saw no real threat nor challenge. It faded and a voice called out, "Empty words from a whelp, your Maj..esty . This is your hall. Bid me kill him, I will do so. But we tarry when my *sjelevenn* needs me."

Cyra smirked, "Your mercy is truly something, War-chief Moondaughter. Commander. I don't even know who you are. Now, either stand aside. Or be drained to ash," the Queen's voice was cold, toneless as she refocused on the traitor. The man ground his teeth, ears flat, tail lashing.

"Take her!" he called out.

No one moved. The commander looked about, seeing all the soldiers stock still. Some strained, those closest to him in the command chain, but they seemed locked in place. Cyra hissed in irritation, "You make me command the blood, commander? I am a QUEEN. I have sat on that throne since before you suckled at your mother's wrist. I saw mountains fall and Fae burn. I will not be stopped by a paltry *sentry*."

Before the man could speak, the Queen was in front of him. Her fist punched into his breastplate and she tore his heart out, before she tossed it into the void over the city. The man gurgled, then crumbled to ash. Around her, the soldiers staggered away, terrified as her aura shifted. One of the other traitors fell to his knees, arms up. She looked at him, eyes narrowed. She twisted, her sword suddenly free from its scabbard and the man's head flew from his shoulders. He, too, crumbled to dust.

The soldiers that had been "captured" fanned out as the confused defenders recognised their comrades properly. Though there were some absences. Those emerged moments later, shackled together - soldiers and officers, most clad in the livery of the Household guard.

Behind them, Adora strode forth and gazed out over the city . Her eyes narrowed on the Ziggurat. Her lips thinned into a line.

"Your majesty . A decisive action. You were sure they would not attack?"

Cyra regarded the wolf woman and smiled, "You know your war-pack? How they are loyal to you and yours, how it balances?" Adora nodded slowly, "As it is with us. A natural hierarchy . Oh we fight and those strong in the curse *can* fight and challenge another. But the rest they recognise, down to the blood, the truth. Many do not know this, some so diluted as to barely be true vampires, aside from the thirst, but all recognise, at their core, who I am, though it is draining to turn it into passive recognition that can be ignored to *active* influence. Something Cyrus should know, Hence why he wanted me away and Melendy disposed of. Catra, isolated, would still be a challenge, but undermined, he likely believed he could challenge her."

Adora's smile was near feral, "I know she will expose the mistake there. But I still fear more treachery."

"Yes. We must leave *nothing* to chance," Cyra looked at the tall woman and gestured to the city, "Let me descend, then follow . I do not wish for my city to become a blood-bath if we can avoid it."

Several horses were led out from the tunnel, and Cyra mounted with her honour guard. She spurred them along and rode for the huge

elevator that would lead them down to the main road to the Ziggurat. More Magicat troops followed, while several others moved to station themselves next to the captured traitors. Some of the commanders looked non-plussed as wolf-men, lizards and humans emerged from the tunnel to set up a guard position at the gate alongside the Magicats.

Adora strode to the edge of the cliff and looked down its slope. She smirked as Kyle, Teela and Duncan strode up alongside her. More of her crew joined them and Adora grimaced, "We lost how many today?"

Teela sighed, "Twenty of the clan. A good four dozen dead riders and auxiliaries. We have another five score wounded. But they will recover."

"A price paid in blood," mused Adora, eyes pinched, "Is…is it worth it for my happiness? Teela, should I have simply boarded my vessel and left? I have ordered men to their deaths for…for"…

"For justice. For the right of things. For the honour of our people. We came here to help these people, Adora," the redheaded wolf-woman reached out and grasped her friend's shoulder, "Why the doubt?"

Adora rolled her shoulders, "Before we fought for survival. This… Politics. It is grimy. It taints all. We slaughtered those outside.."

"Not all of them," Kyle murmured, "We spared who we could, though it made for a harder fight. I believe Gregor tallied at a good third still mostly alive."

Adora snorted at that, "We fought the dead, those cursed. We freed them. But now we fight the living, as we once did. Once we ground many under our heels. And now I do likewise for my own petty needs."

"Bollocks," rumbled Duncan. Adora frowned at him. The man snorted and grinned at her, "Don't let the sea of doubt drown that flame, pup. The world knows you and that fanged warrior are meant to be. Our people will thrive here and will grow. We are answering a call for help, Adora, you know that. Where is this coming from?"

The blonde warrior clenched her jaw and shook her head, "If I could have walked in here, alone, to challenge them, I would have. If I had simply beheaded that Princess in the throne room, then"…

"Then we would *definitely* not be here," smirked Teela. Adora rolled her eyes and nodded.

"I know. But sometimes I yearn for the simple solution."

"Oh I don't know," Kyle chuckled, "Invading a city to rescue the Princess seems fairly simple to me. Even if there is a quandary of rivalry and betrayal. Truly, Adora, this is a song for the ages, high

romance, treachery. A song that will be sent from lips to heart. I cannot wait!"

Adora shook her head at the man and opened her mouth before Teela interrupted her, "You can also tell Catra about Adora's tortured moment on the verge of victory. How she truly *wondered* , how she questioned her resolve!" the redhead grinned at the other two, "A truly *heroic* moment."

The blonde growled, but Duncan chuckled, "Ah, yes, that moment where all that death really came to naught, because our leader became *conflicted* ." Silence hung in the air and Adora's growl deepend. Duncan spoke softly, "So?"

"What if...when we get there...she has changed her mind?" her voice was soft, quiet, "What if...if I have to follow my oath, serve but not be *with* her? What if the Scorpion girl has her heart and this was just to...Purge a few obstacles?"

They lapsed into silence once more, the sound of the elevator creaking in the distance the only sound nearby. Soft mutterings of the guards were a whisper, whilst the distant shouts and protests from near the Ziggurat faded by distance. Kyle coughed.

"Really?" His voice dripped with irritation, "You *really think that?*

Adora turned to glare at him, "I"...

"My lady , shut up. Please. You can gut me later and feed me to Melog after Catra has finished fussing over the big idiot. That woman believes you hang the moon, has aided you in supporting your plan to impress her mother, has trusted you, tried to kill a Death knight for you and is frankly almost as disgusting to watch as Rogelio, Lonnie and I can be. We are your sworn swords brethren. We are here for fate, for the future of our people. We know when we fight that we may fall - and what better death than to see the truth of love, to see a future saved, to purge those who would weaken and cripple others? So, do you wish to whine and bemoan the waxing of a summers day, or are you going to unsheath that blade and continue to carve a bloody path so those who fell fell for a reason? Because I know you know that woman loves you. And we fight not just because of that, but because we know you have done similar for us, for the clan. You put yourself at the fore, risk yourself to save us, to fight on regardless. And we would *all* be lesser if we did not seek to repay that debt to you. "

Kyle was breathing hard and was almost nose to nose with Adora: impressive, given he had to be on tip toes to reach up to her. The blonde stared into the other wolf's eyes. They held their gaze for a while, before the taller woman nodded curtly, then grinned, "Well said, skald. A ruler must be brought to task when their fears overwhelm. And if she rejects me, I will force you to eat your lute."

"I'll take that wager ," muttered Teela, "A win whichever way the bones fall."

Duncan nudged his daughter and gave her a mock tutting, then looked at Adora, "You done crying like a pre-weaned whelp?"

“Go bugger a knothole, old man,” The aged wolf barked a laugh as Adora shook herself and snarled, then turned to look down the slope, “I will trust my *Belevenn*. I will always trust. Melog!” A low growl came from the tunnel as the huge Battle-cat bounded out of the darkness. They skidded to a halt near Adora who nodded up at the beast. She looked at her comrades, then at the monstrous cat, “Let us go. I have a meeting to keep.”

With that, Adora leapt from the ledge and began to slide down the slope of the cliff. With a whoop, her fellows followed her, then Melog. More wolves sprinted to the edge to join the cascade, until fifty of them were descending to the city below, Adora at their head, her face set in a grim smile of resolve.

Chapter 20

Chapter Summary

It all comes together

Comeuppances galore

Some surprises in store.

Chapter Notes

It's almost over, chaps, chapettes, chaperati.

The big showdowns, the reveals, all for this. I hope it meets expectations. Not quite done yet - Another chapter and an epilogue and then.... then we're done.

Thanks for coming along on this amazing ride. Stick with me for the rest of it!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra practically lounged in her chair, a smirk on her face as Lashor waxed lyrical in front of her. She had to give the lizard credit, he was a pretty good orator. Bombastic, gesticulating, even mildly persuasive with his faux-sincerity. Her ear twitched as the faint clatter of armour reached her sensitive ears. The Hegemony delegates didn't stir , the noises too faint for their normal senses. Around the room she could see her guards shift ever so slightly;saw their gazes track up, some in confusion. But no one moved.

She felt relaxed, sure of her security: Pan was up there and she had faith in her guards. She'd heard the initial ruckus. She had a feeling Cyrus might try something *very* stupid: he was a good commander,

but there was a reason he was kept mostly in the Household command duty. It was because, at heart, he was a bureaucrat. A man capable of dealing and handling the logistics of things. But when it came to actual combat, actual battles? She was impressed at how quickly he was trying to move, however. However, that was likely panic as much as tactical nouse.

The man thought in either overly complicated plans or in simple, decisive strikes. It was a contradictory thing, but it was only now she was really noticing it. A lot of the officers in the Army who had spent the majority of their time in the city were like that - dreaming of amazing battles, of the glory of war or the final freedom of the kingdom. And, really, she didn't blame them. After all, she had been petitioning her mothers for years to do *more* .

She shifted as Lashor wound down, "...so, a united front would bring unparalleled, guaranteed trade, secure routes and a more inclusive, decisive band of leadership. It would be a mutually beneficial unification. My lady here would be fortunate to have you as a partner, of course, but the Kingdoms would be better able to co-ordinate and challenge the encroaching horror of the Horde," his reptilian face somehow managed to shift to a sorrowful expression, "And, really , we would benefit from your aid. Immortal warriors who can face down the ceaseless masses of undeath? Where we wear away, you would be a bulwark. So, Princess Catra, I present to you these terms. I realise my error in engaging with persons we believed to be of influence. Our unfamiliarity with the nuance of your court meant we misjudged their intentions and their focus. W e truly believed we were acting in the interests of our nations."

Catra's tail swished as she stared at the lizard-man. Her dual-coloured eyes stared him down and he shifted, but he remained upright. His own tail dragged on the stone floor with a faint scraping

sound. Then the Princess wung her legs from the arm of the chair and stood.

"V ery nice. Poetic. *hspiring* , almost," She placed her hands on the table in front of her and smirked, "As you can imagine, however , your involvement in a near coup of my Kingdom raises many questions. And, really, it all comes back to what I was saying before. Trust."

She dragged a claw across the table, the noise of it cramping into the hard top a faint screech that made those near wince slightly. Lashor's tongue flicked out in irritation, "W ell, this agreement would be to build a baseline. We must begin somewhere."

Catra nodded, then jutted her chin at Scorpia, "What do you want Scorpia?"

The Princess blinked, "Um, well, I..I am pretty sure I was clear on that Wil- uh, Princess Catra. I want you."

"Why?" Catra' s reply was whip-crack fast, out as soon as Scorpia finished. The other Princess blinked.

"Uh, because, well, I uh...Love you."

Catra smirked, "What do you love about me, Scorpia?"

"Uh, your...um, your decisiveness. Y our loyalty. Your ability as a warrior. Your focus. And, well, huh," she actually blushed, "Y ou are beautiful. Your eyes, your bearing. I mean, you're beautiful."

"So...I...am valuable, I am a precious thing to own?"

Scorpia frowned, "I didn't say that."

"But Perfuma here, she is beautiful. She is loyal. She seems decisive. Focused. So, if she has those and you want more, is it not to add to a collection, to *possess?*"

"That' s not what I said," Scorpia mumbled, then straightened, "I want you, Catra. I've always cared, always longed for you. From afar , yes. And I love Perfuma, too. I care for my harem, but...but this would be different. Just like Perfuma is dif ferent! I can love more than one woman! I have much to give! As well! I want the best for you, to give you what you want. This...this would give you security , give you an *army* . I mean, isn't that what we spoke about, years ago? About the end of the Horde? Peace on the surface? The ability to just...sit and stare at the stars, never worrying about tomorrow?"

Catra regarded Scorpia for a moment and her face softened. She nodded slowly, "W e did. Out in the Wastes, thinking of just...running away from it all. But those were the idle thoughts of escape. Not really real."

"They were real to *me* , Catra!" Scorpia whispered with a smile. Perfuma, next to her, looked conflicted, but determined. Catra nodded slowly, then tilted her head.

"They were the words of a soldier who just wanted an end to death, Scorpia. You know , hoping for a break. They weren't declarations of love. Of wishing for some quaint homestead in the forest. And you wouldn't be offering that, either. I get, what, to sit at the head of an army and then to sit in a shaded complex in the Endless Palace, being served warm blood in a cup while you, what, decide which of your playthings to indulge that day?"

Scorpia coloured, "That, that's not how it works! I care, it's, we have, we're a family!"

"So, sharing. I get to be on a list? Or do I get the time when I want? What about Perfuma? Can I jump ahead of her in the queue if I'm up for some fun?"

Some of the guards around the room snickered and Lashor hissed, clearly tense. Scorpia coughed, "We uh, we are fair . I make time, I want to make sure everyone is cared for, looked after," she met Catra's gaze, "I mean, many are their own state heads, they have their duties. Time not together, so we plan around that, if you want to get, um, logistical."

"So I need to be ok with sharing, that' s one thing. Do you need to be ok with sharing?" she tilted her head. Scorpia looked confused.

"Uh, I mean, some of the family spend time together , hunting, riding, uh"…

"Romantically . I mean. I assume that I can find amusements for myself when your schedule is too full," Scorpia blinked rapidly and her claws clacked suddenly. Catra smirked, "I am not a *possession* after all, as you said. And it sounds like I'd not be your main focus. So I would need distractions. What if I'm on campaign? A lot of time alone out there. Would you begrudge me a concubine for those cold nights?"

Scorpia swallowed thickly, "I..uh..I..dont think we should discuss these things here, this is a diplomatic"…

"Oh it' s very relevant. After all, if I'm in this, I want to make sure I have the same rights and freedoms as Perfuma. Who you seem to imply I'm similar to," Scorpia frowned, then looked at the blonde next to her, who seemed to have gone pale again.

"What..uh, I'm lost Wildcat."

Catra's own brow furrowed, then she smiled sweetly, "I assume I'd be allowed to. Since Perfuma and your Captain of the Guard seem

to have something going, I was hoping we could come to a similar arrangement?"

Huntara stiffened, while Perfuma's jaw dropped. Scorpia scoffed then looked at Perfuma again. Her face scrunched a little and she looked at Huntara, then snorted and shook her head, "No, I mean… no. That sort of…that."

Before the Scorpion Princess could finish her thought a boom echoed through the vast chamber. There was a second, louder boom and the doors shook for a moment. ALl the guards around the room shifted, hands on sword hilts. Then, with a slow, groaning creak, the massive doors swung inward, heaved open by a lone figure.

Catra's face split into a joyous grin. She vaulted the table and sprinted across the space, dropping to all fours to run, unashamed. As she neared the figure, she leapt, only to be caught in a pair of calloused, strong hands and spun around. She wrapped her legs around a bare stomach and felt hands hold her up by her rear. Her tail swished as she stared into beautiful, grey-blue eyes.

"Hey , Adora."

The outside of the Ziggurat was a near-riot, as panicking citizens jostled and shouted at the nervous soldiers that had formed a shield

wall in front of the gate. A young Captain was barking at the crowd to stand back. Cyrus stood in the middle of the vast square that stood before the Palace, his remaining soldiers mustered. Well, mostly his soldiers - the rest were rank and file, but clearly happy to just follow orders, even if they were nervous about it.

He had seen *something* flash across the cavern, a sense of immense power from the entrance to the city. He didn't want to even consider what it *might* be. His only hope now was to secure the Ziggurat and the Princess, so he could operate from a position of strength - a negotiation.

He was beginning to realise that this plan might not see fruition - but he was going to try to get out of it, or at least mitigate the damage.

A scream from one of the balconies above drew his focus, distracting him from the worried conference he was having with some of his junior officers. A soldier tumbled off the balcony, with none of the grace of a vampire or magicat, let alone a combination of the two. Another figure was latched onto the man, rail thin and *wrong* . Cyrus' eyes widened as he realised it was one of his men from inside, the man's armour half off and cracked like a shellfish after a meal. The pair slammed onto the step of the Ziggurat below the balcony , bounced off of it, then tumbled to the stone flags of the square. They rolled breaking apart.

Then the rail thin creature staggered upright. It stood in a strangely hunched pose and moved in staggering jerks. Behind it, the fallen soldier gurgled and stood as well, his own posture similarly off. The two looked around the square, then sprang forwards, their

movements horrifyingly quick, even faster than a normal vampire. Soldiers cried out in alarm and set upon the strange new threat. Spears impaled one creature, but it thrashed and foamed before it spasmed into dust. The second one jnked and slid under swords and spears. A man cried out as he was gutted by a claw swipe. Another screamed and clutched at his face as that thing leapt up and tore at his jaw .

Two more soldiers managed to tackle the beast and pinned it down, stabbing repeatedly until it fell still.

Cyrus stared, eyes wide, then looked at the doors, "We need to get inside *now* !More men into the balconies!Thethe Horde is here?" he sounded unsure, panicked. His ears twitched as a trumpet sounded from the gate. He snarled at his officers and pointed at the Ziggurat then stalked to the guards, about to let rip.

He froze and stared as he saw the civilians parting to allow a procession through. Soldiers on horseback, following a very familiar face.

Queen Cyra stared at the wall of shields before her , until her eyes rested upon Cyrus. He felt his blood run cold as her lip turned into a sneering snarl. He made a decision.

It was a very bad one.

"Imposter! The Queen is dead! Shoot her!" His soldiers delayed, confused, uncertain. The crossbowmen exchanged glances.

"Sir, the... the Queen?..."

"She is dead, She. Is. DEAD! It's a Horde trick! They're in the walls! Kill her!"

That sent the crowd into a panic, screams echoing as they jostled and tried to flee. Bowmen raised their crossbows and took aim. And Cyra just sat on her horse and stared.

A howl tore through the air and everyone fell still. It was a sound that crawled up into your mind and froze you in place. Even vampires, arguably hunters in their own right, froze at this sound. Figures appeared on the rooftops near the Palace. They stood or crouched, staring down at the crowd. Cyrus stared up at them, shock in his eyes as he recognised a tall, blonde figure. He swallowed and cursed, "He said. He said he"...

Cyra spurred her horse forwards at a slow pace. The crowd was frozen, whimpering. Black light seemed to emanate from the woman, reinforcing that terrible howl, cowing all responses. She paused twenty feet from shields and raised spears, before she spoke in a cold, hard voice: "You are in my way, gentlemen."

A crossbowman fired as Cyrus shouted "LOOSE!"

The bolt was joined by several more. But Cyra wasn't there. Instead she was right in front of the shields. A soldier shrieked and tried to draw his spear back. But she was too close. The man's shield was torn away and he found himself being kicked back into the row of men behind. They tumbled back and Cyra lunged into the fray, her blades out and flashing. Limbs spun away from howling men and women as she darted among the panicking guards. Her own troops bellowed and charged in on horseback, slashing down, breaking the final defence.

Cyra slashed and a man staggered before he crumbled to ash, his head parted from his shoulders. Cyrus stared and pulled back as more troops entered the melee. He saw his hundred guards trampled by horses as they fought back, but saw most of them seemed unsure, confused that they were fighting *magicats*. He wondered at the lack of barbarians, noting they seemed content to hold back. His focus was drawn as a snarling soldier lunged at him. Commander Kelik's glare lasered into Cyrus from beneath the slitted helm before him. The other Magicat kicked Cyrus back then lunged forwards.

Cyrus parried the blow and then darted forwards, slashing with his own blade, "You died!" he snarled, "I know you did! How?"

"Never send a thug to do your dirty work, *traitor*," the Commander growled back.

Cyrus just hissed, then jabbed again, before responding, "T raitor. Rallying with the Horde and barbarians!"

Kelik moved backwards and chuckled. His amusement was odd as he stared at Cyrus, "Oh you have no idea, Cyrus. N one. I could almost understand why you betrayed us for the Hegemony. Almost. But you really picked the wrong roll of the dice here."

"I do what I do for the Kingdom. Y our precious barbarians tried to murder the Queens! I am saving this Kingdom. It isn't too late, throw off this imposters shackles, join me. W e can win this, make this Kingdom great!"

"Y ou honestly think Ill fall for that?" Kelik shifted his stance, "Y ou know she's the real Queen. I do. Stop digging. Surrender . Itll be easier, trust me."

Cyrus snarled and lunged again, his attacks swift and lightning fast. But Kelik was a more seasoned fighter; more patrols, more exposure, more experience. He hadn't spent years just reading maps and planning contingencies. He'd bloodied his blade. He parried and struck back, causing Cyrus to stagger. One of Cyrus' Lieutenants charged into the fray and swung at Kelik's unprotected rear, only to find himself stumbling past the other Magicat, who had darted out of the way. Blood spray as Kelik caught the man, then yanked him back, shoving his sword through the officer's gut, just below where the armour protected his back. Kelik dragged the blade to the side in a spray of gore, felling the officer, who spluttered and held his torso, as his vampiric powers tried to heal him.

Cyrus growled and charged, his attacks blindingly fast. Kelik laughed as he parried, "You need to find better blood, Cyrus. I can recommend some sources, though I doubt they'd share now"…

The Commander's boot slammed into Cyrus' gut and the General tumbled backwards. He rose and managed to bring his sword up in time to block a downward strike . However, Kelik followed up with another kick that snapped Cyrus' head up and sent him reeling again. The melee swarmed around him and Kelik vanished from view. Cyrus turned, expecting to see his troops from the Palace joining the fray , but his hopes faded as he saw what was happening.

The soldiers in the square had tried to join the melee. Before they could, they'd been distracted: howls had came from the open windows and balconies and several dozen *things* vaulted free, scrambling down the walls or leaping into the fray - ragged, baying, feral things that tackled men and women to the ground, tearing and biting.

This carnage met Cyrus' eyes and he shouted out a rallying cry . Men and women fell back, fighting, trying to seek an exit. Black armoured Magicats surged and slashed, taking down and wounding several soldiers, hauling them away to where others bundled them into bindings and seemed to be almost sequestering them. A ring of steel and fangs bore down on Cyrus and his men.

Cyrus' loyal guards staggered back from both fronts until they found themselves back to back, a bare cohort of fifty men and women, spears up. The General stood at the centre, eyes darting about wildly. He looked up to the rooftops where the figures still stood. He

frowned then surveyed all that was left. He saw some of his fallen men standing back up, their bodies unnaturally twisted.

"I suggest you lay down your weapons," came Cyra's cool voice, "And then take me to my wife and daughter."

"You...you are a servant of the Horde!" a frightened officer challenged, his sword extended in defiance. Cyra emerged from the ring of black clad guards and the twitching...ghoul-things. She glanced at the shivering, glassy eyed revenants and smirked.

"You all played such a bad hand. You made Melendy break out her toys. Stand down, child. Or you will join your fellows. In this half state of perpetual starvation, to be sent to the Wastes to hunt the zombies for ever more," The officer shook with fear as the Queen met his gaze. He tried to fight back, but his sword clattered from his hands as he whimpered. The Queen nodded slowly, then looked at the others, "You were supposed to be loyal servants of the Kingdom. Now I see you are bought and paid for. You are Mercenaries. Sell swords. No *honour*. Party to an attempt on *my life*. On the life of my *wife*. Of my *daughter*. Traitors."

The soldiers exchanged glances. But all of them were true believers. They were following orders, they thought. There was a clatter as more weapons hit the flagstones. Several soldiers dropped to their knees, sniffling. A few others tried to stand firm.

Cyra glanced over her shoulder as tall figures pushed through the crowd. Adora joined her and stared at the small group of soldiers.

Cyrus stared at her, shocked. He inhaled and nodded to the Queen, "Lay down your arms..we..we have failed. The Horde..."

"Shut up Cyrus," Cyra waved at him with a bored expression. The General blinked in shock, "You tried to have me killed. I'm rather lucky that Adora here is a very talented killer. Your little band of traitors were *very* co-operative and informative. The ones left alive."

Adora smirked then plucked something from her belt and held it up. Cyrus blanched as he regarded the severed head of a reptile. He vaguely recognised the man as one of Lashor's cronies. Adora replaced the gruesome trophy on her belt, then looked at the Queen, "Your majesty. May I?"

"Yes. I am sure she will be happy to see you."

Adora quirked an eyebrow, "You don't seem worried about Melendy?"..

Cyra smirked and gestured to a twitching ghoul, "If they're here, then she is having a *ball*. She doesn't get to let loose all that often. Cyrus here has given us *ample opportunity* to do so."

Adora chuckled and nodded. She looked at Cyrus and flashed him a feral smile, then moved towards the Ziggurat. Cyrus watched her go and shook his head as his men disarmed all around him. He looked back only to double over as a punch landed in his gut. The wind

expelled from his lungs in a wheeze as he felt several things break inside. Cyra glared down at him, then hauled him upright by his hair, "My sister would be *ashamed*, Cyrus. She was ambitious but... not *stupid*. And now... now we're going to put all this to rest. Because I need to show you and all your little lackeys how badly you *fucked* this. I must shoulder some of the blame. But you... you have failed this Kingdom, failed these people failed *me*. And I do not know for what."

"My... my Queen"... he wheezed as around him his soldiers looked on with fear, themselves behind manhandled and bound by the Queen's guards.

Her blue eyes bored into his, "But we will find out. And the, Cyrus… then you will finally fall."

Adora had found the whole battle slightly anticlimactic. She had watched from the rooftops as Cyra had proceeded through the city, drawing citizens and soldiers into her wake. She'd watched as the guards had put up a paltry resistance and seen the crowd ready to scatter. Her howl, to rally her troops, ready for the fight had been almost unnecessary, but had at least startled the fleeing citizenry enough for Cyra to seize control.

She had to admit, though, watching the Queen carve into those vampires had been rather amusing to watch. The woman was a

dervish, so like her daughter. Catra was more acrobatic, less reliant on magic or all her vampiric abilities; Cyra was a cleaver, carving into meat with brutality and directness.

Adora strode past twitching near-zombies and a few of the live Magicats. She stood before the doors and, with a mighty kick, slammed them open. She strode into the hallway that acted as the ring corridor around the Ziggurat and stared at the second set of doors that led to the royal chambers. A few guards milled about, uncertain, until a familiar face appeared from an alcove that led to a set of side-stairs. Pan grinned at the blonde, "About time. She's getting tired of them trying to convince her a wedding is a good idea!"

The blonde grinned at the Captain, "You live then?"

"Well, vampire. Given value of living. And fret not, the other Queen is alive. I trust her Majesty is outside?"

"Yes." Adora barely managed to get the words out before there was a flash of something dark that fluttered her hair with its passage. Pan smirked.

"Well, that's one reunion. Best you go square this next one away," his eyes caught on the head at Adora's belt, "Do I want to know?"

"You will. But not a story for now. I am sure Kyle will embellish."

Pan chuckled, then inclined his head and gestured to the throne room. Adora grinned and nodded back to him, then moved to the huge doors. She drew her sword and smashed the hilt to the door with an echoing boom, almost as loud as the first when she'd kicked the outdoor doors open. As the echo died, she resheathed her blade and shoved at the cracked doors, forcing them open.

Adora strode into the throne room, bloodied, dirty and tired. Her blonde hair hung free and flowed down her back;her cloak billowed behind her and she held her head high as she strode into the throne room. She took in the crowd and the guards, but her focus zeroed in on to one thing only. A magicat sprinting towards her with supernatural speed. Then the woman was flying at her.

Adora caught Catra and spun her about, laughing as she did so. She stared up into mismatched eyes of blue and gold as Catra murmured a happy "Hey Adora."

"Seljelevenn," Adora whispered. She swallowed a sudden lump in her throat, "Are you well? Unharmed?"

Catra chuckled as she cupped Adora's face. Her thumbs traced over the blood and ash that covered Adora's face, "Isn't that my line, dummy? You look like you've been in a war." She paused as Adora grinned and Catra snorted, "You have *actually* been in a war haven't you?"..

"Yes, but it's also a bit your mother's fault," Adora chuckled, "So, not just me!"

"She's ok?" Catra sighed with relief.

"Yes, but a tiny bit...angry..." Catra winced and she Adora smirked, "Good news, I think we are getting along now."

"Should I be jealous?" Catra glared down at Adora. The blonde shrugged.

"Nah. I think I lack the distinctive black fur necessary to be of interest. But if she is an indicator of you when you grow up..." Adora arched an eyebrow. Catra gasped in mock shock.

"Ok, let me go. Wedding is off, Im gonna marry someone else"… Adora held Catra tight and growled low. The Magicat princess purred and flattened herself against the taller woman, "Hmm, or maybe not."

The pair paused, then Catra clutched Adora's face and kissed her. The pair seemed lost in their own world. Until a outraged hiss pierced the air, "Wh...what is THIS?"

Both Catra and Adora broke their passionate embrace to look at the Hegemony. Scorpia was standing, a shocked expression on her

face, which was morphing into one of hurt and betrayal. Perfuma looked pale and still confused. Huntara looked outraged and Lashor.Lashor looked appalled, frightened and also furious at once. Adora blinked, then smiled a thin, malicious smile. Catra blinked at her loved then felt Adora adjust her grip to free a hand. The Magicat blinked in surprise as Adora shifter her, holding her with one arm, while Catra clung to her. The blonde hauled something from her belt and raised it up. She looked at it, then at Lashor and spoke loudly enough for all to hear, "Friend of yours?"

Adora tossed the severed head across the room. It tumbled and rolled, coming to rest near the Hegemony representatives. Some of the other diplomats reared back in shock and horror. Perfuma covered her mouth and Huntara's jaw set. A few of the Orcs moved in front of Scorpia. Catra glanced at Adora and arched an eyebrow, "Care to explain?"

The blonde's smile remained, "They said I wasn't allowed to see you. And they tried to kill me. And your mother. We took offence."

"How much of fence?" Catra asked as she looked back at the Hegemony ambassadors.

Adora looked lovingly up at Catra, "All of it. They lie in ashes, their survivors ours to interrogate and do with as we will. Consider it an early wedding gift, my love. A removal of pests from your home."

Lashor staggered forwards and bent down. He picked up the head and hissed out, low and angry, "You...filth. You...you will pay. This is an act of war! You intend to murder us! Betrayal! BETRAYAL! Kill her, Kill her!"

Huntara paused, but her fellow orcs did not. Two charged at Adora. The blonde threw Catra back, confident the Princess would be fine. She charged to meet the foe and ducked the swing of a curved blade before she hooked her leg and tripped the warrior as she passed him. She came up as a downward stroke narrowly missed her. She grappled the Orc's arm, then twisted, sending him to the floor. With a twist, she snapped the bone and then stamped down, cracking his shoulder. She sidestepped as the other Orc rallied and came back at her. She ducked and dodged, not retaliating. Then, as the Orc thrust forward, she caught his wrist and broke it. He staggered and she spun him around her, until he was on his knees. Adora stood behind him, ready to snap his neck.

"Hold!" Huntara growled and stepped forwards, "Fine. You want a fight. You hurt my blood-brothers. Slaughter our people? I'll give you a fight."

The big Orc woman drew her blade and strode forwards. Perfuma raised a hand, but dropped it, her gaze flicking between Adora and Huntara.

The blonde cocked her head, then shoved the wounded Orc down. Both the wounded men scrambled back, out of the way of Huntara. Adora watched the woman approach, then shrugged her cloak free. It pooled on the floor behind her as she rolled her shoulders and

cracked her neck, "You wish to die in the service of liars and tricksters?"

"I know my oaths."

"Do you?" Adora smirked, "That why you stink of the blonde one? You fight for your Princess?"

Huntara growled, "Draw . Your. Blade."

"Make yourself worth it," Adora smiled. They locked eyes and Huntara licked her lips, uncertainty playing in her eyes. Her own warnings to the Hegemony rang in her memory, but she quashed them. She slid her foot into a new stance and raised her blade in a double handed grip. Adora hunched a little and watched her.

The orc woman sprang forwards, with a series of flowing attacks. Her bulk made people assume she would go for bruising, slugging swipes. But she moved with the inevitability of a river - one slash that led into another. Down at an angle, reversed up, then across, to bring the large blade to a new position, held at an angle behind her.

Adora sidestepped the downward swipe, then pirouetted the second. Then *ducked* the next strike. As Huntara drew the blade into the next ready position, Adora was suddenly in front of her. She delivered a punch to Huntara's jaw that sent the Orc backwards.

Huntara rallied and attacked again. Adora ducked and dodged, then moved to Huntara's side and kicked the Orc in the side of her knee. The bigger woman staggered in pain, but swung back. Adora darted backwards and brought her hands up, palms open. The Orc snarled and jabbed forwards. Adora moved to meet her and slapped the blade to one side. Then, with the same hand, backhanded Huntara across the face. The Orc staggered and Adora followed up, landing a pair of hard punches to Huntara's gut. The Orc coughed and bent slightly, only to be sent back as Adora punched upwards. Hunatara managed to bring her blade up as a shield and held it in two hands, like a stave, then "punched" it forwards.

Adora jnked backwards as Huntara tried to press forwards. But it became clear from the blonde's smile that she wasnt even really trying.

"Dont *mock* me, blondie," snarled Huntara. Adora paused and nodded slowly.

"As you wish."

Huntara raised her blade high and brought it down. Adora was suddenly in front of her, holding her wrists. With a twist she tore the blade free from the Orc's hands, where it clattered to the stone floor. Adora's hand shot up and clamped over Huntara's face. She lifted the woman up and then drove her down onto and *into* the stone floor. Hard. The *thud* of the impact echoed around the chamber as silence fell. It was broken by a wail as Perfuma darted forward.

"Huntara!"

The blonde Princess skidded to a halt as she knelt next to the unconscious Orc. She glared up at Adora, but the warrior just stared back at her and nodded, "Loyal. In her own fashion. She will not die today."

Catra, who had been standing by watching, sauntered over, "Thanks for the throw."

"You landed on your feet," smirked Adora. The pair then looked at the remaining delegation.

Scorpia was staring, eyes glassy, gaze fixed on Perfuma and Huntara. The other delegates were shying backwards, terrified. Lashor looked almost scarlet, his purple scales flushed, as he ranted suddenly, "Useless! All of you, USELESS! I should have know Cyrus would fuck this up. So CLOSE. So close and... and you *lived*? How .. How did you LIVE!? We were sure. And *you*, not good enough to be part of the Hegemony? I knew we should've just killed your mothers outright, be damned. Keeping one alive? Stupid. STUPID. Should have checked himself, that *useless* worm."

Scorpia blinked and turned to look at Lashor, "You... you planned this?"

"Oh don't be so innocent. You wanted her. We wanted Halfmoon. And you wanted the blonde idiot there out of the way! And now my BROTHER is dead. You said you wanted her GONE. You wanted that leech of a Princess. Isn't enough you have the pick of the Hegemony. Isn't enough that you demand they fawn over you. Isn't you wanted that one. Well, it would have WORKED. We had a plan. She just had to go along with it. And when she DIDN'T we had to use the OTHER plan. You KNEW. You aren't *that* stupid!"

Scorpia shook her head, "You...you tried to kill the Queens?"

"Oh grow *up*," Lashor fumed. He turned to the Princess, "We're *dead*, Princess. If Cyrus is out there, he's spilling his guts. They MURDERED our army. This is war, no sense of pretending. Now… now we have to crush this awful little rats nest, take it the hard way. They can't touch us with our immunity - bad enough they killed our guards but we can still leave. They wouldn't *dare* hold us hostage, so, nod, smile and we can just GO. You lost, we lost, but we can"…

He froze and gurgled. His eyes tracked up to where Scorpia's stinger was lodged in his forehead. His fingers twitched and he spasmed. Pink foam formed at the corner of his mouth as his eyes began to turn black and red, the blood vessels toxifying. Then, with a wheeze, he toppled backwards, twitching in his death throes. Scorpia stared down at him as her jaw trembled, "I...I just...no. Not this way. Not this." She turned and looked at Catra, who stared back at her. The Magicat Princess felt a pang of sympathy, but didn't move to her. The Scorpion Princess looked at the huddled form of Perfuma and Huntara and nodded slowly, then looked at her retinue. She drew a deep breath, "Prepare...we will be...leaving."

Adora stared at the Princes and frowned, then looked down at Catra, "This is awkward?"

Catra nodded slightly, "Uh huh."

Silence fell in the room as Scorpia straightened and inhaled. Her claws clicked nervously as she looked around, eyes clearly bright with tears. Before she could say anything, a man stumbled into the room. Cyrus looked ragged, his armour stripped and broken, his eyes wide with terror. He took in the sight of the throne room and keened. A pair of women followed him into the room. Melendy leaned her head against Cyra's shoulder, then straightened and waved at Adora, "Ah, lovely! I see you made it. Never a doubt in my mind. Oh, we seem to have missed something."

Cyrus flexed his hands, and came to another decision. He hissed and charged at Catra.

She saw him coming and was ready. Except a large, furry beast was suddenly in her way. Cyrus shrieked in alarm as a massive paw hoisted him up, wrapped around his head. Adora snarled as she pulled him taught, then clamped her jaws around the man's leg. There was a wet, ripping noise as she tore it off, then flung him up into the air.

Cyrus tumbled and hit the flagstones, hard. He stared up as Adora crunched down on his limb. The werewolf stared at him, then pulled the torn leg from her jaws and tossed it to the floor. Catra sighed and

stepped closer to the fallen General. She squatted down next to him, "Cyrus. I assume my mothers didn't kill you because, well, they were going to offer you a deal, or something...or they expected you to be an idiot. Anyway, meet Adora. Adora Moondaughter of the First Ones, Princess, Warchief and commander of a *thousand* werewolf warriors. They defeated the Horde in her lands. They have routed your allies. And now," she looked at Adora, who morphed, slowly, back into her human form, "Well, what do you want to do with him?"

Adora wiped at her bloody mouth, "He is nothing. Not worth roasting. Some of the lizard folk I know believe you gain the knowledge of your foes by eating them. If that were the case, I would be stupider after him as a main course."

Catra snorted, then looked back down at the mewling Cyrus, "She has a point. I think your blood has run its course, Cyrus. Well be sure you bury your ashes with respect, though."

"Princess wai-" Cyrus held up a hand, but Catra lifted him bodily and bit into his neck. He screeched, before she tore it out completely. He flailed, desperately, before Catra slammed him to the floor and punched *into* his chest. She tore his heart out, and it blazed with blue fire as Cyrus howled into oblivion. Catra huffed and then dusted her hands off, before she glared at Adora.

"I had him."

The wolf-woman smiled, "I know. But I owed him as well."

"Ok. But I could have still taken him *first*."

"I know."

Catra glared at the smug woman, then glanced down, "You're naked, Adora."

Adora's grin widened, "I know."

"Ugh, idiot."

"Oh, I know."

"Shut up."

"Make me."

Catra rolled her eyes, then slinked towards the tall blonde. She reached up and grabbed the woman's chin, then pulled her down for a bloody kiss. They broke apart and Catra hissed, "You are taking me soon, ok?"

I know ,” Adora growled.

“Ladies, please,” called Cyra, “We have guests present still,” The Queen sighed and then looked at the huddled, cowed Hegemony representatives. Her gaze was flat as she took in the huddled Perfuma and Huntara, the broken Orcs who grunted in pain, the dead, slumped form of Lashor and the dazed delegates and shocked Scorpia, “It would seem that this is quite a mess. I am sure my daughter will elaborate on things, but perhaps, your Highness, it would be wise for you to see to your people. And then to leave. We will be sending missives back to the Endless Palace about what has transpired and we will convey our displeasure at recent events. I will, however, ensure you are not implicated at this juncture. I fear this was a wasted journey for you.”

Scorpia met Cyra’s gaze and nodded, “I understand. Is are they all dead?”

The Queen softened a little, “No. We spared who we could. But it was a battle and half measures only lead to more deaths on one’s own side. You may take the survivors. And let it be a message: Halfmoon is not to be taken lightly. We show mercy out of respect for the history of our two nations. And the fact that the conspirators appear to have been dealt with.”

Her gaze tracked to the other delegates, who all nodded profusely . Melendy chuckled next to her wife. Behind her, the ghoulish figures began to stagger into the hall, “Well that is good. I didnt want to have to enlist more *recruits* .”

Scorpia didn't bat an eyelid. She held herself tall and drew a deep breath, then strode forwards. She paused next to Perfuma and Huntara, but didn't look at them, merely motioned to her entourage, "Please, assist my them. See to her wounds. Please"…

"Scorpia" Perfuma looked up at the Princess, pain and guilt in her eyes.

"It's it' s fine. All fine." Scorpia nodded sharply , then looked over at Catra, "I see now . And I'm sorry . I thought…W ell, doesn't matter . Maybe we'll see each other again," she looked at Adora briefly , and her lips pursed, "Maybe."

And with that, Princess Scorpia of the Hegemony, heiress to the Endless Palace, strode from the room, her entourage in tow, broken and battered. But not entirely bowed.

Catra watched them go and sighed, "I think this is a problem that will come back."

Adora nodded slowly, "Y es. Maybe you should have married her"…

The Princess looked up at the blonde in shock, "Y ou WANT me to marry her"?

The blonde smirked, "I never . But it would have been the easiest idea...maybe."

"Maybe?" Catra huffed, irritated and confused.

"I have never broken an oath, Catra," mused Adora. She turned her gaze from the doors and stared down at the Magicat Princess, "But I think I would have if you had asked me to forfeit you."

Catra stared back at Adora and then nodded slowly. She traced her claws across Adora's collarbone and bit her lip, before she smirked, "Good job it was never on the cards."

"Yes. Infiltrating a whole palace by myself, then fighting through a harem would have been...vexing. I would have been...irritated."

"Jealous?" Catra chuckled.

Adora stared back at her, "Irrationally so."

Catra nodded, "Good. But it'll never happen."

The Queens broke into their periphery . Cyra regarded them both, then smiled, "You have a good one, here, Catra. I...was very very

wrong. So very wrong. Can.. .can you forgive me?"

Catra stared at her mother, then swallowed, and lurched at her, gathering her into an embrace. Cyra closed her eyes and sighed, hugging her back, hard. They pulled apart and Catra raised a finger, "No more second guessing."

Melendy chuckled as Cyra raised her hands in defeat, "Well, we have much to do. I need to see which of these little beggars needs to be restored and which ones we send out to the Wastes," she gestured to the gathering ghoulish vampires, "And then...".

There was the sound of something heavy moving at speed. A large, dark furred blur rumbled into the room and headed straight for their group. It leapt and Catra had a vision of purple and teal before something huge slammed into the floor in front of her and skidded to a halt. She met strange eyes that bored into her soul. It was like seeing Adora again, but different. Where ADora was the other half to her, this was like...A shadow . But in a comforting way. Adora was her completion, but this felt like an extension in some way - not intimate, but still a closeness.

She blinked as a word floated in her mind, "Melog?"

The huge beast yowled, its voice a strange sound that seemed to echo and reverberate. Catra reached out and pressed her hand to its nose and sighed with delight. She looked at Adora and blinked in surprise. The blonde smiled, "They were...a surprise wedding gift.

Always meant for you. Seems the big lug was impatient to meet. I cannot blame them."

Catra chuckled and stroked at the big cat, "You got me a *cat*? On the nose, Adora."

"Well, one day you will give me puppies, a fair exchange?" Adora waggled her eyebrows and Catra actually spluttered in shock. Cyra coughed and tried to glare at Adora, while Melendy glanced up and down at Adora, before she looked at Catra dead in the eyes.

"Honestly, darling... are you complaining?" the black-furred Queen grinned happily, then clapped her hands, "Now I think we have a wedding to plan!"

Chapter End Notes

Could I have given Cyrus an epic final stand? Maybe.

Did he deserve one?

HELL NO.

What did the Queens DO to him out side? Well, that will be covered in the next chapter, briefly, as we get everyone ELSES point of view :D but, basically, he goes down like a punk. He isn't some great warrior, not some master tactician. He underestimated EVERYONE. He's no boss fight.

And yeah, Huntara... poor Huntara. But she ain't dead!

Lashor... Lashor got what he deserved. If he HADN'T seen his brother's head, he may have held it together, keep the whole

plausible deniability thing... maybe. But oh well!Scorpia seems to have turned a corner... but where that corner goes, who knows?

Chapter 21

Chapter Summary

Kyle loses a bet.

Catra and Adora get VERY reaquainted.

Final things are set in motion.

Chapter Notes

THIS HAS SPICY SEXY TIMES!TW : Blood;vampiric sex; switching;rampant horny ,

If you don't fancy the sex scene, stop at the second line break, then resume after the next one!

Hope y'all enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Kyle lounged on the rooftop and studied the aftermath of the battle below. Next to him Teela was in quiet conversation with Duncan. He winced as he observed Cyra and what appeared to be her wife, Melendy, put another Magicat through a proverbial ringer. He recognised the figure as Cyrus and winced as another one of the strange, ghoulish Magicats pummelled the General, before the man was hauled to his feet.

But the forgiving sorts are they?he mused as he leaned his chin on his knee, while his other leg dangled over the edge of the rooftop.

Teela paused and chuckled, "Can you blame them? I mean, you saw what King Randor did to the traitor clans. And this turd *did* try to assassinate the family and stage a coup. Just very expertly, but he tried."

Duncan rumbled a chuckle and folded his brawny arms, "You sound admiring, daughter. Careful, or Adam will bust through the cavern roof all a-fluster."

The red headed woman shot her father a scowl, but then glanced up at the cave ceiling with an almost wistful look. Kyle snickered and then heaved a sigh, "Fear not, mlady. Once all this is sorted I am sure Adora will pack you back on a boat. She doubtless has *no* desire for some nagging messenger from the homeland. But you did sound a trifle...admiring."

Teela sighed and shook her head, "I can respect ambition - the man had a plan but, well, the execution was lacking. From what Cyra said on the ride...he wants to fight the Horde. I cannot fault that. But his methods are sloppy and wasteful. Now, if the royal family *were* impediments to that, would it have been a *bad* idea?"

Ducan sucked air through his teeth and harrumphed, "You know as well as I that Adora would not have accepted *that* outcome."

"Which one?" Kyle squinted down as more of the Magicat traitors were lined up and corralled, "The family dying, or the Horde being enabled?"

"Adora would find the best solution. As she has here. The family *was* an impediment. Now they are not. The Queens will either hunker down in fear, or rally. And having walked with Cyra, I believe they will rally. They know they cannot hide down here. We have shown them that," his grin was, to put it mildly , wolfish; his beard and moustache bushing out as he smiled, "But I think Adora would have just ignored this place if they were completely obstinate."

Kyle chuckled, "Really? With Catra here?"

"Oh I very much doubt Catra would have been *here* . Adora would have ignored this place *after* Catra was safely out of here. You've seen her rip a Corpse Giant to shreds, fight through a flock of rotted-drakes and then behead a Necromancer just because they threatened a *single* village. What do you think would stop her when her *mate* is trapped?" he gestured with both arms at the entirety of the city, "My point is proven."

"A well made point, and a honed edge to it too," Kyle grinned. He focused back on the courtyard, "Ah, seems they're done tormenting the idiot. Shall we?"

"A ye, let's see what needs to be done."

"Bets on Adora already being entangled with the Princess?" Kyle sing songed.

Chuckles rose from the other sea-farers as Teela groaned, "I will not take that bet."

Duncan harrumphed and quirked an eyebrow, "Clothes on or off?"

Kyle cackled, "You're on, old man."

"Waves be damned! That's five horns of mead I owe Duncan!" Kyle lamented, a few minutes later, "Adora! Really?"

The royal family, plus Adora and Melog, were gathered at the foot of the dais that held the thrones. And, of course, Adora was stark naked, unabashedly so. They'd passed the demoralised Hegemony delegation, who seemed less united than when they'd seen them last and now found themselves in the throne room. Ghouls were moving in and out, under some wordless orders. The royals all turned and laughed. Adora just shrugged, though she did blush a little, "What? Some idiot went for Catra."

"And you couldn't have *stabbed* him?" Teela huffed as she sidestepped around a set of guards who appeared to have a few *other* soldiers restrained in front of them. Adora grinned.

f needed to demonstrate how *badly* he has misjudged things."

Duncan nodded as he joined his daughter , "The correct way . To defeat a foe is not enough. To let them realise the magnitude of their defeat is necessary. And for word of that to propagate," Kyle rolled his eyes and mouthed *"Just saying that cos you won the mead."* Duncan stoically ignored him.

The two Queens regarded the sea-farers before Melendy nodded slowly, "Wise words, Lord Duncan. Though your party does raise a very relevant point. Lady Adora, I do feel you should be properly attired. We do have matters of state to discuss. And I do not wish for my daughter to claw my eyes out when her rather possessive streak begins to override her relief."

Catra let out a mild hiss, while next to her the massive form of Melog let out a rumbling growl. The Queens just cackled and Catra shuf fled closer to the tall, blonde warrior, who hugged her close. Adora let out a sigh, "My love, might we retire? I do need to wash the blood from my hands and the ash from my face."

The Magicat princess tilted her face up and squinted at Adora, then nodded, "Fine. My rooms. Now . Chamberlain!"

The grey-furred Magicat materialised, as if from no-where, with Pan at his side, "Your highness?"

"See to it that the Hegemony representatives are monitored and sequestered until they are ready to depart. And ensure that appropriate guest rooms are assigned to the representatives of the Clan-folk."

The man's eyes flicked to Adora, then to the three others, before he returned his gaze to Catra, "All of them?"

Catra met his gaze and he bowed low, then departed without another word. Pan chuckled, then looked at the other sea-farers, "You're all alive. Good to see. So, while these two get *reacquainted*, shall we find somewhere noisy?"

Teela coughed loudly and Kyle snorted while Duncan grinned. Adora drew in a breath and Catra let out a hiss. But then Adora turned and swept up the smaller woman, carrying her bridal style off towards the doors that led to the more private parts of the Palace. Catra's cries of "*Put me DOWN*" were drowned out. Melog let out an amused yowl as their tail lashed side to side, before they then darted out of the main doors, away from the crowd.

As the laughter died away, Duncan turned to the Queens, "Your Majesties, we are at your service, should you need us. But…we are aware that having strange soldiers in your halls may not look *proper* to those who are scared and confused. Especially since, well"…

Cyra chuckled humourlessly, "Indeed. However, I think a show of co-operation will help. If you can have your people mainly round up and

corral the Hegemony prisoners and wounded. We will be handing them back to Princess Scorpia once she departs. Right now we need to solidify our presence and expunge any unsavoury elements from our guards."

"Forgive me your Majesties, I have taken the liberty of getting a head start there," Pan stepped forwards and withdrew a furled scroll from a satchel at his belt, "Princess Catra and I were most active the past few days. The officers should be all accounted for in there, as well as the notable nobles. Anyone else will likely go to ground, but given this show of force, I think any actions by them would be desperate at most. I also took the liberty of sending runners to the gates already, to ensure no one can leave."

Cyra studied the man briefly then grinned, "We appear to have a vacancy now in the command structure. Perhaps?..."

"Begging your pardon, ma'am, but I think I best serve the Queendom in the field. For now at least. And I don't want to miss an opportunity to watch our new friends rip the Horde a new one."

The Queens exchanged a look that seemed to be an entire conversation - arched eyebrows, small shrugs and a few smirks, before they both looked back at Pan, "Well, I can attest it is quite the sight, now," Cyra mused, "And I understand your reticence. Let us discuss it with Catra as well. I feel that a command role and a role in the field will be very much overlapping shortly. Lord Duncan, Lady Teela, Skald Kyle, if you will excuse us. My wife and I need to prepare for the inevitable judgements we must preside over."

The three sea-farers inclined their heads as the Queens turned and withdrew. Pan cricked his neck and then turned to the other three, "So, no rest for the wicked?"

Kyle grinned, "You really think they're *resting*? Honestly though... I think they've earned it."

Catra let out a shuddering moan as her hands clawed at the bedding. Her knees were pressed into her breasts by strong hands that held her almost folded over, as they gripped her thighs tightly. The vampire Princess' eyes rolled in her head as a desperate tongue lapped and probed at her, as if she were Adora's final drink after a long sojourn in the desert.

The analogy was perhaps not entirely off.

"Pp...uhp...lease!" Catra whined. She wasn't sure what she was begging *for* exactly. She just needed Adora. All of Adora. As much as she could get. In her, on her, around here. Her fingers flexed in anticipation. She wanted to release, but wanted to watch Adora flush beneath *her* as well. The past few days of being careful, cunning, violent, it had built an anticipation and an expectation.

Adora pulled away a little and licked her lips, her blue-grey eyes nearly black from how blown her pupils were in the low light of Catra's room. Her smirk was clear and Catra barely had a moment to glare heatedly at the woman before Adora's mouth latched back on to Catra's clit. The Vampire let out a very undignified yowl as her back arched. But Adora held her firm.

They'd barely made it into the room before Catra had practically scrambled from Adora's arms and wrapped herself around the blonde, their mouths locking together. She'd barely realised that the blonde had expertly begun to divest her of her armour until she felt cool air on her furred skin. And then Adora had flung her onto the bed and then pinned her in this delicious position before practically tearing the rest off of her.

Catra convulsed as Adora continued her assault. Her pulse quickened and her legs spasmed and jolted as her release closed in and then peaked. Her body jerked as Adora pulled a rough orgasm from her. It was quick, urgent and barely scratched the itch.

But then Adora shifted. She moved up the bed and used one arm to pin Catra's legs. She leaned down and kissed the vampire roughly. Catra's tongue snaked out and Met Adora's and she tasted herself on the werewolf's own tongue. Her hands flew up and gripped at Adora's hair, holding the bigger woman in place as she sucked on the woman's tongue. And then she felt Adora's free hand stroke over her vulnerable core. She shuddered and twitched again, then moaned into Adora's mouth as the blonde slid a finger in. Catra whimpered as Adora massaged her thumb across her clit. The build up was slow now, for her second peak. She was sensitive, but the needy edge had been ever so slightly dulled. The rough push of a finger inside her eased the burning need in her and that was further

helped by Adora's addition of a second finger. Catra purred in contentment and flopped backwards with a wide grin, "So, so good. Missed...missed this."

Adora panted happily and stared down at the Magicat Princess with adoration in her eyes, "Missed you, my *sjeleven* . I will not leave your side again. Not when I can see *this* face." Her smile shifted from loving to mischievous as she practically levered Catra up a bit more and began to build her pace to a more rhythmic thrusting - not hard, but firm, regular. Her eyes locked onto Catra's and the vampire Princess whimpered and bit her lip. She clung to Adora as the werewolf warrior thumbed Catra's clit and owned her body. Catra's legs kicked and twitched as her clawed toes curled and flexed as time seemed to loose all meaning. Only the sensation mattered. After what could have been minutes or seconds or *hours* , her whole body locked and she spasmed again as her whimpers shifted grunts and snarls as another orgasm hit, then washed into another. Adora kept going, the pace increasing, her gaze fixed on Catra's eyes.

The Princess shuddered then broke eye contact as she arched once more, as a loud, high yowl escaped her lips. Her claws shredded into the mattress as Adora crooned at her, "My good girl, my Princess, my *sjelevenn* . Let go. Let me look after you."

Catra's yowl developed into babbling as Adora released her legs and lowered her a little, her hand still pumping away, but now the heel of her palm pushed against Catra as well. Adora lowered her head and licked and sucked at Catra's breasts, gently teasing her nipples as her newly freed hand snacked up to cup Catra's face. The Vampire turned her head, eyes half lidded in bliss. She snatched Adora's hand and sucked on her fingers, then her thumb, moaning around

the digits. They popped free and Catra licked at Adora's wrist. She gasped and managed to focus on Adora's face, "Mmm..may I?"

Adora beamed and gently pushed her wrist towards Catra, her other hand continuing to minister diligently at Catra's core. The Vampire sighed happily, then turned Adora's wrist a little more before she gently bit down into it. Warmth flooded her mouth as a tingling buildup began once more in her sopping cunt. Her hips bucked as she sucked greedily at her lover's wrist. Adora groaned happily, her teeth gritted, eyes aflame with desire. Her movements increased and she shifted to push her thigh against her hand, adding a thrust to her fingers. Catra bucked and latched on tighter. Her own thigh came up and found Adora wet and willing. The blonde continued to thrust whilst also grinding her own centre against Catra. Her voice was hoarse, needy and urgent as she stared down at the splayed Princess, "Mine, all mine, always. Have my pups, my Queen, my goddess, my *sjelevenn* ."

Catra smiled and gasped as another orgasm tipped into her. It felt so quick, but she knew they had been at this a while - the frenzy of it felt like things were flashing past. She screeched, then lurched up to cling to Adora, before her bloody mouth found the blonde's and they tumbled across the bed, locked in a spasm. Adora grunting in frustration and glee as Catra rolled her onto her back. Catra stared down, her tail lashing back and forth, her smile broad. Her gaze flicked to the side and her smile grew crooked. She darted off the bed and Adora blinked in surprise. There was a rattle from a lockbox near Catra's dressing area and the Magicat was suddenly back on the bed, something clasped in her hand. It looked cylindrical, with a rather familiar taper to it. Adora arched an eyebrow.

The Magicat smirked, "Scared?"

"I trust you implicitly ," Adora answered sincerely . Catra swallowed and nodded, but managed to maintain her smirk.

"Not going to ask any questions?"

"I assume you required relief before I arrived. Since no one else is up to that task?" Adora grinned a challenge up at Catra who shrugged.

"Not wrong. But I want to reward my brave warrior . Can *you* be a good girl for me?" Adora' s cheek twitched and she swallowed suddenly. Her face went red suddenly and Catra's smile turned into a giggle, "Oh this is *good* . Well, then… I want you on your front, my *sjelevenn* ," she leaned down at feathered a kiss to Adora' s lips, "T ime for you to let your guard down."

Adora nodded, then drew in a breath. Slowly, she rolled over, her legs parting automatically. Catra purred happily and pressed her smaller frame against Adora's back. The blonde shuddered as Catra nuzzled at the nape of Adora' s neck, "I missed you. These days… they"…

"Shh" crooned Catra. Her hand slipped down between Adora' s legs. She smirked as the blonde's hips jerked and rose a little, lifting Catra up as well. She traced her fingers through Adora's folds, collecting the moisture there, "It was torture for me too. So… let me return the favour, my love."

She smeared the rod in her hand with Adora's juices, then held the base to her own crotch. Her fingers traced a few symbols across it's surface and then she trailed her finger from its base to her own body. A black glow suffused the base and the phallic thing adhered to her. It was a simple little trick, part of the Vampiric spells around motion and the control of objects. As well as a little blood magic to replicate feeling.

She trailed her fingers through Adora's hair, feathering it out. She looked down at the scared body beneath her, still covered in the grime and blood of battle. They would bathe after this, but that sense of the dirt of all this was erotic in its own way. The urgency, desperation, the *vitality* of it all. She smiled as she slid down Adora, until she was hunched behind the woman, between her thighs. Prone, she twisted her head and dragged her tongue between the warrior woman's muscular thighs. She tongued and probed, but Adora was clearly already willing and ready. She suckled gently on Adora's swollen clit, which drew a whimpering growl from the blonde.

"If you wish.. To fuck me..Then… *fuckme* ,"snarled the woman.

"Ohhh so tetchy . Feeling antsy"?

"I did not butcher an envoy' s bodyguard to be… *teased* ,"Adora growled, but it was closer to a whine, and her hips bucked, "I.I need you. Need you now . Please"…

Her voice shifted to plaintive with such speed that Catra couldnt help but bite her lip. She stared at this powerful goddess of a woman. A woman who had fought *for* her. Had brought an *army* for her. Had challenged her mother, supported her, stared down another whole nation…

Who was she to refuse such a request?

"As you wish, W archief Adora"…

She moved up, then gripped the base of the shaft before her as she lined up. Adora wiggled before her and then Catra sheathed herself into the willing Werewolf. Adora groaned so deeply it was a rumble. Her broad shoulders tensed and trembled as she took the false dick. Catra Felt Adora's legs bend up as the Werewolf accommodate herself to the stretch. Catra hunched over and pressed herself into Adora's back, her hands moving from Adora's hips, to scratch into the blonde's scalp, before they moved across muscular arms to then clasp Adora's outstretched hands. Adora groaned again, "So… good."

"Good girl. N w..hang on."

Catra pulled back, then thrust forward. Adora's breath left in a whoosh of excited release. Catra thrust again, slowly pumping back and forth. Her pace was steady but began to build. She moved pack, hands releasing Adora's. She place on at the back of Adora's neck, then used her other to grasp Adora's hip to pull her up into a semi-

kneeling position. She thrust harder, the slap of flesh on flesh filling the bedchamber. Adora's voice was hoarse grunts and whispered curses.

Catra leaned down again as she slowed her thrusting, which drew a needy whine from the Werewolf, "I can't *hear* you my love," She chuckled as she nuzzled Adora's neck, "Louder please."

Adora cried out at the next thrust. Her vocalisations and grunts entered a rhythmic gasping pattern as she began to push back into Catra's pounding. A hand flailed back and she held onto Catra's hip as the Magicat jerked and pushed. The slaps and pressure was having an impact on Catra as well as she felt another release, slower but no less powerful, beginning to build. Catra's movements became less rhythmic and she hunched over again. Her breathing was getting ragged and her teeth scraped against the side of Adora's throat. The blonde tossed her hair aside and turned her head. Their eyes met and Adora grinned, then tilted to bear her neck to Catra.

The Vampire whined and Adora reached over her shoulder with her other hand. On her knees, she held her core straight, bent over, whilst being railed. One hand held Catra's hip, whilst the other grabbed at Catra's hair. She tugged her down roughly, to press Catra's face against the side of her neck, "Own me, Catra. Own me. Mark me, as I will mark you when the moon rises. Show me your power. Show me the Queen you will be."

Catra's teeth throbbed and she bared her fangs. She sunk them into Adora again and drank as her hips jerked and thrust. Adora's grip in her hair tightened and Catra felt the warrior woman spasm and thrust

back. She felt a splash of wetness across her thighs as Adora let out a broken howl of delight. The woman's body locked and tensed, while blood dripped onto the pristine bedsheets. Catra succked and drank, feeling the intoxicating flavour consume her. Her hands were around Adora's torso and she squeezed and mauled at Adora's bare chest, pinching and pulling at stiff nipples. Adora laughed happily as she gasped her way through another rolling orgasm. She pushed back and turned, forcing Catra to unlatch from her throat. The Vampire found herself on her back, Adora still impaled on the fake cock. Adora glanced back and smiled wolfishly. She rolled her powerful shoulders, while a trickle of blood ran down the side of a barely visible breast as she stared at Catra over her shoulder. The woman flexed, then rolled her hips, the pressure of the motion sending a shockwave into Catra's own body.

"I believe you said…hold on?" Adora's grin was predatory. And then she moved her hips again and began to bounce with measured movements.

Catra groaned and reached forwards. She held on to Adora's hips as the warrior brought herself off against Catra and, in turn, brought Catra to another release, which caused the Magicat's tail to go wild once more as her legs stretched out and shuddered.

With a happy sigh, Adora slid from the cock, then spun around. Catra, dazed, barely felt the phallus slip away, as the magic holding it to her fizzled off. Adora shuffled up Catra's body until she knelt atop the Magicat's head. She stared down into Catra's lust filled eyes and smirked. Catra stared back up and drew in a breath, then wrapped her arms around Adora's thighs, "Taking your throne, Warchief?"

Adora snorted, then arched an eyebrow, "I've had much worse chairs."

"Well, let's make sure this one is comfortable."

Adora's intended retort was lost as Catra pulled her down to her waiting mouth.

A couple of hours later the couple emerged from the Princess' bedchambers back into the throne room, bathed and sated. Catra had not replaced her armour, but had gone for a more formal set of britches and boots, with a vest over a half-dress-half-shirt. It was all in maroon and blacks and gave her a slightly mixed look.

Adora had, after a maid had appeared with her belongings, donned simple britches and a white shirt, barely laced together at the throat.

The Palace was a hive of activity, with Pan and a few other officers and clerks acting as the conductors of the chaos. The Captain turned and grinned broadly, revealing the figure of Kyle next to him. The Skald looked chagrined and he shook his head, "Another three horns of mead. I swore it'd be another two hours. Your Highness, please don't tell me my mighty warchief gave in?"

Catra snorted, "Shut up, Kyle."

The Skald grinned and shook his head, "Practically family already . My lady Adora?"

"Ah, no stories on this one. Not until I recount it myself!" The blonde smiled and winked, then looked about, "I fear we shirked our duties."

Pan shook his head, "Hardly . It's why you keep people like me around, mlady . We've got the troops sequestered, the traitors I mean. Princess Catra, your mother is…processing the ghouls. That may take a while. And those who she…spares are likely"…

"They won't be healthy for a while," Catra shook her head, "It's not an easy curse to manage. It'll have its toll on them. And the Hegemony?"

"Packing up as we speak. They're all under guard, for their *own* protection. Wouldn't want some angry co-conspirators trying to mess things up, now, would we?" He smiled knowingly and Catra shook her head with a chuckle as she hung on Adora's arm, "Honestly , ma'am, we're ok. The sea-farers are helping with patrols in the city and Queen Cyra has sent out the criers to spread the word. I think the plan is for public punishments on the morrow."

Adora arched an eyebrow, "Executions?"

Pan nodded, "Not many. The soldiers will be put on front line duty, while others will be exiled to outposts, or just sent out to the Wastes with their family...if the family choose to go. For the officers and nobles, I mean. The soldiers will be judged *less* harshly."

"Exile seems...risky. Might they not rebel?" Adora arched an eyebrow, "We culled the sympathisers and those who sowed discord. It was brutal, but necessary. Their clans were absorbed into ours, though."

"Exiles have a chance to redeem themselves, over time. We are long lived. The truly guilty will receive a true death, of course. But those nobles exiled will be sun-cursed, after all. Vulnerable in the light as not many are used to it. They're sent to the Wastes, after all, where if they try raiding or the like, they will be put down. By us, the Fae, or the Hegemony. Or the Horde. So most will try to lie low, eke out a living and find a way to return here, to the sanctuary of the city."

Adora pursed her lips, then shrugged, "A cruel punishment in many ways. It gives them hope. And you have fewer vengeful families."

Kyle nodded, "Aye, that was the hardest thing for us. A clan bond is hard to break. Easier with the young, but hard for a family to accept their loved ones died fighting kin."

Catra glanced between the pair, then laughed, "We aren't all that similar. The Hegemony does all this stuff via cloak and dagger. Our people's seem a bit more...open about it."

"This was open?" Adora smirked. Catra huffed.

"We *used* to be more open. Wars between noble houses over blood stock, or influence. Hells, even before the blood curse, when we were *just* Magicats, we were vicious. The Fae war and the blood curse didn't help as we fought but...we learned that working together and having understandings and rules kept the peace and kept the *stability*. No major rocking of the boat."

Adora nodded, "With us it was the Horde. We could not afford dissent. It could have led to butchery and tyranny, but it lead to us being *better*. We had discarded old cruelties anyway, but we became more but finally forgetting our arrogance."

Silence fell and Catra coughed, "You...honestly got rid of your arrogance?"

"What?" Adora looked down at her, mock hurt on her face, "What are you saying? That I am arrogant?"

Catra smirked, "If the boot fits."

"It is not arrogance if it is true. Arrogance is *false*. Nothing false about me," Adora smirked. Catra rolled her eyes, then tugged at Adora's arm.

"Well, it sounds like it's in hand. We best find my mothers and discuss what's next."

They left Pan and Kyle, who refocused on the various patrol schedules and walked out of the throne room, back into the maze of corridors that led to the various living quarters for the Palace. It didn't take long to reach the door to Cyra's study, where a new set of guards stood on watch. A brief knock was all it took, before the pair were invited inside.

It was a markedly different audience this time. Adora stepped in and found the place much the same as she'd last left it. There was evidence of books having been moved and the desk seemed less imposing. The Queens looked a little bit dishevelled as well, both now in more regal gowns rather than armour, but Adora tried to ignore the obvious scents in the air as well. She managed to suppress a smirk while Catra obviously blushed.

Cyra grinned, "Ah, we wondered when you may grace us with your presence"…

Catra grunted in response, "Doubtful. Not too busy with *paperwork*?

That just made Cyra grin wider, "Oh I had much sorting to do." a cuff from Melendy cut that short, though the dark-furred Magicat had a fond smile on her face as she looked between Catra and her wife.

"Now now. I think this isn't the right venue. Adora, if you would like to join us in our lounge? It's a little more homely. Less formal."

Adora just nodded and the quartet left to move up to the Queen's quarters. Servants and soldiers moved about the palace, but seemed less skittish than before. Several gawked openly at Adora, whilst also bowing and smiling at the Royal family.

The quarters themselves were very opulent - similar to Catra's but, obviously, larger. Melendy gestured for Adora to make herself comfortable and the werewolf settled into one of the plush couches. Catra joined her by promptly flopping into the taller woman's lap. Cyra sat on the opposite couch, eyebrow arched. But her lip was quirked into a smile, while exploded in an exhalation as Melendy copied her daughter's move with a heady laugh, "Sorry dear! Couldn't resist."

Cyra grunted, but wrapped her arms around her wife and sighed, "Good," she looked over at Adora and Catra and grinned ruefully, "This has been an experience, Warchief Adora. I have had to reassess many things. My own ability is chief among it all."

Melendy's mischievous smile softened into a sympathetic one. She reached up and stroked her wife's face, before she slipped off her

lap to sit next to her, "I think we both learned much. Games did not help us this time. We were…complacent."

Adora stayed silent, while Catra interjected softly, "I know what you were trying to do. And maybe it would have worked. It certainly made me…think more," she huffed and looked away with a half shrug, "I suppose."

Cyra laughed, a short, sharp bark, "Well, there we go then. But…I should have perhaps been less obtuse. Though having *all* the knowledge would have helped," she glared at the pair. Adora met her gaze and shrugged.

"And knowing that you had immortal beings capable of shape shifting in your court would have helped…how? The demonstration was necessary. But considering the attitude I did not feel it…wise. Though with hindsight, maybe opening with that could have helped?" she grinned and quirked an eyebrow in question.

Melendy just chuckled as Cyra shook her head, "Hindsight is all well and good. Likely I may have been equally stubborn and mistrustful. Either way, Cyrus was the real issue. Even if we had come to an agreement, he was likely fixated on the Hegemony as the solution, our sovereignty be damned. I think…I think his original plan was viable, though naive. As soon as he sacrificed our nation to become a *vassal* that was the point it became madness."

The blonde nodded and leaned back, Catra still in her arms. A servant entered and poured wine into goblets. A few more entered with platters of small meats and olives. Adora surveyed the food and looked mildly disappointed. Cyra shook her head, "This is a starter. We will move to the private dining room for a *proper* meal. I have sent for your people, Warchief. We have plans to discuss. Martial ones."

"But for this room, well I think we need to discuss *marital* ones," Melendy interjected, a hand on Cyra's knee, "I understand there is a ritual for your people?"

Adora perked up, "Yes. It's less a formal event. More personal. A public ceremony under the moon and a private one just for us. But still one that is traditional. That will just require us to be outside, a bonfire and a feast. We do not stand on ceremony over much."

Melendy clicked her tongue but shrugged, "Fair . But we will need something for *our* people as well. And it may be wise for our citizens to observe *your* ceremony. When does yours need to happen?"

The blonde sucked in a breath, "At the rising of the full moon, a few days hence, otherwise we must await the next cycle. It is ceremonial but important. A bonding at the height of the moon's power. Tying us together forever, with a following ceremony at full moon-shadow at mid-month."

The Queens nodded, while Catra stared up at Adora with a small smile on her face. The Princess looked to her mothers and frowned,

"And *our* ceremony?"

Cyra shrugged, "Two options. We do a rush job after the judgements tomorrow, to cement the message of transition and security," she held up a hand as Catra's mouth opened, "Honestly, I was half expecting YOU to suggest that, being all pragmatic and that you want to argue with me because I just suggested it?"...

Catra's jaw clicked shut and she scowled, while Adora chuckled, "She has you there, *sjelevenn*."

"Idiot," Catra hissed, without heat.

"Your idiot. And an observant one," Adora mused. Catra nuzzled her jaw and huffed.

"Shut up."

"No. You said two options, your majesty."

"You punched me, Adora. I think you can continue with Cyra."

Catra sat up, "Wait, you mentioned something like that before… what"...

[illegible] now dear . Suffice to say, Adora and I understand one another a bit more. As to the second option, we defer until after your ceremony, or hold it during the day before yours? We can minimise it. But it will be a rather traditional affair. We have *many* traditions, as I'm sure you can understand but we can likely curb some of them."

Catra glanced between the two, then huffed, "Maybe an announcement after tomorrow's events? Then then I'd rather have it *after* the ritual?"

Adora looked down at her lover, "Oh?"

Catra nodded and stared at the floor with a frown, "Ok, you can't laugh. It's because I I want to be yours in your eyes before the whole big event. I want it to be indisputable. Before we sit through speeches and parades and all that."

The blonde reached down and gently lifted Catra's chin with a fingertip. She smiled softly at the other woman, "You are already mine. As I am yours. And I am so honoured you wish to perform the ritual first. Thank you. It is not necessary but." Adora swallowed, "It feels real."

Cyra smiled at the two and let out a breath, "I think given what you have done for us, Warchief Adora That we can accommodate that. As you say Catra, we will announce it. And well, we just need to understand more of what is needed to prepare. We do have a

battlefield out there to clear. But I believe it will pretty simple. As to our own ceremony"…

The Queen looked to her wife, while Adora chuckled. The blonde blinked as Melendy slipped from her seat to retrieve something from a nearby shelf. The woman returned and thudded the tome onto the table between the two couples. She unfolded it and smiled widely, "So…how do you feel about pastels?"

Adora felt Catra's hand grip her own tightly. She took in the eager expressions on the Queens faces and realised that, perhaps, this was going to be the most intense experience of the past day, bar none. She looked to her side and saw Catra's worried, but excited face and she relaxed.

All very much worth it.

Chapter End Notes

YES! We have a final chapter count.

Wedding. Then Epilogue.

We're nearly there folks. Thanks for sticking with us!

Chapter 22

Chapter Summary

An ending.

Wedding ceremonies and celebrations.

Chapter Notes

TW: Blood and dramatic ceremonies - graphic depictions of a ritualistic nature.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

For a city hidden in the dark, Halfmoon could certainly conjure colour and flair. Bright flags and woven ropes hung from the cavern ceiling and the inhabited, vast, stalactites that tapered down. Torches burned in sconces along rock and rope bridges, while colourful streamers fluttered from rooftops in the city below. All manner of colourful garlands and dyed clothes adorned the buildings, while green and amber flames consumed vast bonfires across the city. And among it all, people danced and cheered.

Kyle watched it all from the balcony of one of the suites that had been graciously provided.He had his elbows propped on the balustrade as he marvelled out at the colour and vibrancy of it all.

"Have to say , wasnt quite expecting this level of frivolity ,"rumbled Duncan from just behind him.

Kyle chuckled, "I know . It's, uh.well, it' s certainly unexpected. I was expecting, like, dirges and blood rites."

"W ell, they are cats," Duncan mused, "I surprise they like colourful bits of string."

Kyle snorted, "Careful, the Queens might take of fence at that."

The larger sea-farer chuckled in response and joined his comrade at the balustrade, "Ah, no. They're not that thin skinned. Likely they would make a joke about me not learning new tricks," his moustache ruffled as he smirked, "They are good people. Complicated, flighty , overly thoughtful. But good people."

The pair lapsed into silence before an exasperated huff caused them to turn. Teela barged her way through the interior of the suite and glared at the men, "Where is she?"

Kyle affected a look of innocence, "Who?"

"Dont try that, Skald. Adora. W e have another rehearsal before the event. And the dignitaries are due and. . Bah! Why am I *doing* this?"

"Because a competent second should plan the battles sometimes?" Kyle grinned at his friend, "And you are doing an admirable job. I

mean, you should have seen Rogelio when we got married. THe poor man was all over the place."

"Aye, but he had Lonnie and you to ease the burden, while my little cub here has no scratching post to hand," Duncan snorted and winked. Teela flung her hands up.

"It's so..so… *ceremonial* . Have you seen what happens?"

Kyle shrugged, "Not dif ferent from ours, really."

"It's VERY dif ferent!" Teela practically yelled, "All these positions and oaths and"…

"No, it's the same," mused Duncan as he shifted to face his daughter. He leaned back and grinned, "Ours is less formal, at least on the surface. But it's all just a dance."

"Mine wasn't this complicated," Teela groused, arms folded.

"That was just *our* ceremony," Kyle reminded her, "And..it was on a battlefield."

The two men smirked as Teela's face took on a wistful expression, "Perfect. The fires, the smoke. Just…It felt *real* ."

Duncan hummed and gazed up at the Ziggurat, idly chewing his lower lip, "I think it's the person that matters, Teela. But besides the point, you seek Adora?"

"Yes!" Teela snapped back her focus on the men, "If I have to plan this, then she will suffer with me. Queen Melendy has…has… SCROLLS! She has *maps* . She has entire rolls of cloth. Why? WHY?"

That got a snicker from Kyle, "Not every day you marry off your only daughter," his face went melancholic for a moment, "Truth told, it makes me yearn for the hearth of home."

Teela went from grousing to quiet in a moment. Her head cocked to one side, "Well, the ships will be returning for fresh supplies and soldiers. Mayhap you should journey home?"

Kyle shook his head, "No, no, my duty is here. To my Warchief, my sword sister. My mates know this. Though it pains me, I must aid Adora," his wistful look switched to a more mischievous one, "Even if it means making her do the right thing. She went to the Catra's rooms. I think she wanted to get some quiet time."

Teela grinned and chuckled, "Thank you, Skald. Now, I have an errant Warchief to corral!"

The two men laughed as Teela practically sprinted from the room. Duncan glanced at the Skald, "That was mean."

Kyle shrugged, "T eela will understand. And anyway, this gets Teela away from the planning as well."

"And do the Royal family know their part in *our* ceremony?"

Duncan's arched eyebrow just made Kyle' s grin widen, "In theory , yes. I dont think they quite understand but they seem game!"

"Oh, this I cannot wait to see," chuckled Duncan.

The stars were beautiful and clear. A cloudless night revealed the moon, almost at its zenith and fullness, which was only a few days away. Adora sighed happily and tried to adjust herself.

"Ol."

The blonde arched an eyebrow and glanced down her prone from, to the brunette mop currently draped across her, “Hi?

“Hi.”

“Hi what?”

“Hi moving. I’m comfortable.”

Adora grinned as Catra moved to settle in even closer. They were clothed, albeit in lightweight shirts and britches, rather than armour, but the cool air bothered neither of them. And yet, it felt almost as intimate as when they were wrapped around one another in their now-shared bed. Adora let her hand trail up Catra’s spine and revelled in how the vampire-cat’s tail twitched and swayed languidly in response.

“Far be it from me to disturb you, my Queen.”

The purr that rumbled through the magicat made a lump form in Adora’s throat. It stuck as Catra shifted to turn her amber and blue eyes to regard Adora. The gaze was lazy, amused and utterly relaxed, “Indeed. How dare you.”

They stared at one another for a moment before giggling. Catra shuffled and snuggled closer in while Adora sighed contentedly, "I could get used to this."

"One day , this is all we will have to do," murmured Catra.

"One day ," Adora mused.

They lapsed into silence, nestled on their little hillock. Just beyond, behind them, the mountain loomed, lit by campfires and torches. Where once a hostile camp had stood, now a newer, more vibrant tent city had emerged - Fae folk, Sea-farers, humans, all mingling in a carnival of preparation. The gates stood open as all sorts streamed in and out, readying for the many-days of ceremony and celebration.

But here, in the grass, was an oasis of peace. Respite from the madness of the past several days - an escape from enthusiastic mothers, of tailors, of planners and cooks and all the logistical and political insanity that nuptials brought.

It had been several days since the Hegemony representatives had trudged away through Halfmoon's streets, watched by silent citizenry . Several disgraced noble families had joined them, forced to walk in their wake, as signs they were now *subjects* of the Hegemony. Scorpia hadn't tried to argue against it.

That sad, little procession had found the battered remnants of a proud army, lined up, disarmed and huddled in the light drizzle of a late morning. A battered Scorponi Commander Rilka, had hobbled towards the small Royal procession, her armour battered and a pincer in a sling, to make a vague differential attempt at ceremony. The survivors had been treated, corralled, then allowed to await the departure of their delegation.

They had left with little fanfare - a diminished column of troops, bearing wounded on wagons, their weapons bound away in crates or bundles on sleds. They had looked more like refugees than soldiers. They had vanished towards the border, broken and cowed: a message as much as a mercy.

Adora wondered at the consequences of that;but the Queens seemed fairly relaxed about it. Adora disliked politics, but knew the realities of it - there would be ripples in the wider world from this. But here she was, with her *sjelevenn* and they would weather it.

Their tranquillity was interrupted by a sound that could only be described as *glittery.* It elicited an actual groan from Catra, "Seriously? NOW?"

"And hello to you too, fuzzball!" came a familiar , amused voice. Adora snorted.

"Glimmer , now you choose to arrive? You missed quite the party."

The fae princess fluttered down from where she'd magically appeared in mid-air and landed lightly. She huffed and planted her hands on her hips, "I *heard* . And you didn't think to, I don't know , maybe ask *us* for help?"

Adora winced, then looked down at Catra. The Magicat hadn't really moved, merely turned a little to glower unconvincingly at Glimmer. The constant purr undermined any actual pretence of irritation. WIth a sigh at Catra's lack of response, Adora rolled her eyes and smiled at the fairy Princess, "W ell I was with C'yra. And can you see her asking for help?"

Glimmer opened her mouth, then frowned, "I mean, maybe?"

"From the *Fae* ?The people who tried dropping a mountain on us?" Catra deadpanned. Glimmer winced then let out a breath.

"That is, actually , a fair point,"she conceded. Her face fell, "But we WOULD have helped!"

Catra sighed, then shuffled to sit up. Adora shot her a soft smile, which the Magicat returned before she stood up. The vampire regarded the fairy then shrugged, "Y eah, maybe you would have,"a smile crept onto her face, "But I think it wouldn't have been nearly as dramatic as *this* one doing what she did."

Adora scoffed and leaned back onto the grass, "Y ou loved it."

"Never said I didn't, idiot," Catra drawled as she gazed fondly at her *sjelevenn* , She looked back at Glimmer who was trying to hide her own grin by biting her lip, "Ugh, yeah we're in love. You should have guessed it by now."

"But, this..this is it's so ROMANTIC!" Glimmer was practically vibrating. She looked between Catra and Adora, then spread her arms at the vampire, "Please?"

They stared at one another, before Catra let out a huff, "Fine! Get it over with."

Glimmer let out a laugh and skipped towards Catra before she enveloped her with a hug. She spun the Vampire around then plonked her down, "Bow will want one too. He is so so happy that YOU'RE happy . It's, well, it's actually kind of a bit *much* ," she confessed, but she said it with a smile.

Catra snorted and offered a shrug, "Yeah. But that's Bow. You know how to pick the sappy ones, Sparkles."

"Yeah. Yeah I do," Glimmer smirked, then peered around Catra to Adora, "So, are we all ready? I mean, my mom is coming. Bow's escorting the contingent by *foot* ! Can you believe that? We're WALKING here."

"From Brightmoon?" Adora asked, curious. Glimmer blushed and shrugged.

"W ell, no. From the standing stones."

"Oh such a hardship!" Catra cackled. She shoved the other Princess and smirked, "I'm sure she'll get over it. Y ou staying for both ceremonies?"

Glimmer arched an eyebrow, "Both?"

Catra nodded, "Adora' s being a bit hush hush. But uh, it' s it' s gonna be something."

"W ouldn't miss it for the WORLD," Glimmer grinned, "But right now… I saw there's a whole *fair* outside you city! Can we, maybe, go look?" she smiled hopefully at the pair. Adora chuckled, then levered herself up to standing.

"Alright then. Shall we?"

Two days later, the moon rose to a city holding its breath. Banners furled, music jangled across the streets and bonfires continued to burn. The citizenry piled out into the streets and hung from windows to watch as a procession of fur-clad warriors marched down the main avenue of the city, towards the open gates of the Ziggurat.

At the head marched a tall blonde, her hair braided into a complex tail that ran down her spine. She wore a burnished, crown-like mask of red-gold, while her tunic and britches were stark in their white brilliance. At the gates a pair of guards crossed spears and barred their way.

A smaller figure moved from Adora's entourage and began to strum on his lute. As he played, she began to sing, a slightly off-tune melody, but heartfelt in its rendition. It was a short song, a verse at most, of her journey, and her desire to see the woman beyond the threshold.

With solemnity, the spears uncrossed and the blonde and her entourage marched into the courtyard. Around its edges various dignitaries from Halfmoon and beyond sat to watch the ceremony. At its centre stood Queen Melendy, garbed in a dress of deep crimson. She held up a hand with great solemnity and called out, "Who entreats?"

"One who hears the call!"

"What call?"

"The only one that matters. Blood calls to blood, heart calls to heart."

"And what do you bring?" Adora spread her arms and her entourage moved alongside her to present ceremonial trinkets. Melendy scoffed, theatrically, "Gold melts."

Adora made another gesture and her guard placed their items down, to draw their blades and flourish them. Melendy again scoffed, "Iron rusts!"

The blonde warrior stepped forward, hand to her breast, before she intoned, "My heart."

"Its strength endures," Melendy replied with a formal bow . She stepped aside and Adora strode forward alone. At the steps before the massive doors to the palace stood another figure, this one clad in black. Cyra grinned at Adora, "Who entreats?"

"One who hears the call?"

"What call?"

"The only one that matters. Blood calls to blood, heart calls to heart."

“And what will you take?”

“What is freely given.”

“And what will you sacrifice?”

“All that I am.”

“And what will remain?”

“The blood of our family .”

Cyra bowed, then stepped aside. Melendy drew up on Adora’ s other side, the pair now flanking the doors. A creak announced the opening of the inner palace doors, to reveal a solitary figure in black and crimson. Her attire was a form hugging, cloth body-suit, with a set of skirt-like tails, along with a cowl and veil. She carried a bowl before her as she walked, slowly, towards Adora.

Catra descended the steps and proffered the bowl. Adora reached forwards to grasp it with both hands as she stared at Catra’s veiled face.

"From blood we are born," Melendy intoned and Adora moved her left hand towards the woman, still holding the bowl with her right.

"And to blood we will end," Cyra responded. Catra extended her left hand out, her own right hand on the bowl's lip.

The two Queens pulled thin blades from their belts and, simultaneously, gently sliced the thumbs of the betrothed, before speaking somberly, "In blood we are united. In deed and intent, as one. Two in one, under the light of the stars."

Melendy looked to Adora, "Adora Moondaughter , do you vow to honour and protect Catra Driluth, of the House of Driluth, Heir the Cavern throne?"

"I do so swear ."

Melendy nodded, as the two women moved their cut hands above the blow. A low, red glow suffused the bowl and thin trickles of blood were drawn from their cut thumbs to pool together in the bowl below. Melendy continued, "By your blood be bound. Do you swear to love her, to counsel, to grieve."

"I do so swear ."

"By your blood be bound."

Cyra took up the words, "Catra Driluth, do you vow to honour and protect Adora Moondaughter, third of her name, of the Clan Greyskull?"

Catra stared at her beloved, "I do so swear ."

"By your blood be bound. Do you swear to love her , to counsel, to grieve?"

"I do so swear ."

"By your blood be bound."

The mothers bowed slightly and intoned together as the women returned their free hands to grip the bowl, "Drink and be one. Drink and be loved. By blood we are born, by blood we shall die, by blood we are bound and by blood we know our hearts."

Adora gently pushed the bowl towards Catra, but stayed holding it. Catra held it and tipped it gently, sipping at their conjoined fluids. She swallowed and then lowered the bowl, only to push it towards

Adora. The werewolf grinned, and lifted it to drink as well, while Catra gently pushed it to tilt it back.

The Queens bowed again and spoke, "By your blood be bound, heart and soul,forever in the light of the moon. Hearts to beat as one, to shield and save, to love and to grieve. In shadow and in light."

Melendy gently took the bowl away and Cyra smiled between the two, "Hearts now bound, you may kiss your bride."

Adora reached forwards and lifted Catra's veil, which was faintly stained by their blood where it had dipped in the bowl. They stared at one another, before they slowly came together in a gentle kiss.

Beyond them, around the city, the crowd erupted into cheers and wolf whistles, as well as light applause from the dignitaries. From balconies around the Ziggurat, banners unfurled, revealing the wolf-head of the Grayskull clan, over a pattern of the Driluth House - a Crimson field with a crescent silver moon on it. Pastel streamers and flags flapped from raised pikes as the honour guard of Magicats raised their weapons in salute.

The couple broke apart, smiles on their faces, before they turned to the crowd. Adora offered her arm and Catra looped hers into it, before she joined Adora as they moved across the courtyard, meeting the dignitaries in a practised slow march, while outside across the city dozens of smaller celebrations broke out - ale casks

cracked open, wine poured and willing donors offered their throats for a night of revelry.

Faces blurred into one as the couple did their official duty, before they finally reached the end of the long line, of note having seen the Envoy from Salineas (A rakish man with a moustache and a rather over-dramatic flair) and the Queen of the Fae, Angella - a tall, regal woman who had a kindly bearing, albeit a sad one. She had said only a few, short words as they had greeted her: *"Cherish it. Please."*

Then, at the end, the pair clambered into an open-topped carriage, with Adora's entourage flanking it and the Queens and their guards riding behind, the bulky shape of Melog directly behind the carriage itself. Their small convoy made their way to the end of Halfmoon's main road and ascended the elevator, with only a few of the dignitaries following along. The proclamations had said there was to be an addition to the traditional Magicat ceremony and many were very curious about the mystery, but it was supposed to be more private.

The small procession wound its way out of the city, past the citizens and guests who cheered and waved, up through the tunnels, before they emerged into the night air.

The moon hung low and huge in the sky, lighting the plains and the woodland in an eerie glow. The vast fair and tent-city dominated the open ground, to the point one would have never known there had been a battle there just over a week prior.

A way away from the tent-town a large patch of ground had been cleared and marked out. Ritual masts had been erected around it, marking a clear perimeter, adorned with clan symbols and carved figures. Remnants of the ship hulls that had been carried inland had been arranged to reinforce a perimeter, while great stones had been hauled into place to create a henge-like structure. At its centre stood a low shelter, made of woven branches and stacked stones.

The carriage pulled up not far from the ritual site and Adora helped Catra down. Soon their entourages had joined them, while the few guests streamed around the site. Guards stood watch, keeping a distance between the distant revelers and the ritual site. Several of the Fae took to the air to observe, curious. Glimmer hovered close by, her husband clutched in her arms. He waved enthusiastically at the couple who had to bite back their laugh, before they turned their focus to the circle. The large form of Melog padded up and sat to watch, silent, despite their size. Catra glanced up and smiled at the battle-cat, before she looked at Adora.

"Are you prepared, my *sjelevenn*?" Adora asked, as a smile tugged at her lips. Catra smirked.

"Always."

They moved into the circle, then broke apart. Adora walked briskly across the circle, around the shelter, until she was on the opposite side. Teela, Duncan and Kyle joined her and the four divested themselves of their cloaks and stripped down to britches and, with the women, breast bindings.

Across the field Catra glanced to her sides as her mothers drew up alongside her. Pan also stepped up and shook his head, "This is a very strange tradition."

"I just drank mine and Adora's blood from a bowl. That's probably strange to some."

Pan shrugged, "Maybe. You know, it used to be a mingling of wines, back when we used to all be vineyard owners." Catra glanced at him and he offered a lopsided grin, "It's true."

"He is right, love. Only had to alter it a little bit over the centuries to embrace our cultural changes," Melendy smiled. She rubbed her hands in anticipation. She still wore deep crimson clothes, but the flowing dress element had gone, replaced by functional britches. Likewise, Cyra had gone for a functional, yet still black, look. Catra gave them the once over.

"Remember the rules?"

"Oh yes," Cyra's grin was positively gleeful.

One of the Sea-farers stepped into the circle, "The clans are strong! The clans are one! But under the moon, we must show ourselves worthy of this strength! Who comes to claim this right of mates?"

"I, Adora Moondaughter , third of my name, of Clan Grayskull, come to claim my *Elevenn* , to take her from her clan, to make my hearth her own!" Adora bellowed.

"And what say you, oh *Elevenn* of the Moondaughter?" barked the sea-farer.

"I, Catra Driluth, come to claim *my Elevenn* , to make my hearth her own!"

"And will your clans lay idle in this?"

"NO!" bellowed six voices.

"Is your claim strong in the eyes of the moon? Can it stand against the bonds of birth and blood, to forge a new way? Will you stand and fight to take what you wish?"

"Aye!" shouted Adora and Catra together .

"Then prove it by claw and fang! Gang, *kreve ditt hjerte!*"

Catra darted forward, as her mothers and Pan lunged to stop her. She angled across the field, heading for the shelter. Suddenly, Teela was there and Catra had to duck a wild swing from the woman. She spun and scythed legs out, which caught the red-head on the back of the calf and almost made her fall.

She spotted Kyle as he leapt and pushed off of a stone to barrel at her. Catra leapt into the air, caught the man and spun, to send him tumbling down towards Teela.

She caught a glimpse of Adora as she tossed Pan across the grassy ground, only for Melendy to dash towards the blonde. The pair grappled and then Cỳra was there as well, heading for Adora, intent on þining her wife to trap the blonde.

Catra dropped to all fours and sprinted across the grass. She slid and tackled her mother, Cỳra yelping in surprise as Catra sprung to her feet.

The Princess had to dart back as Duncan darted from around a towering stone monolith, faster than his siz would suggest. He stood between Catra and Adora, a wall of a man. Catra backed away and the old sea-farer chuckled low. The Catra charged at him. The man blinked surprised, then grinned. But Catra grinned right back. She feinted a move, to go under him, then leapt up and flipped over his head. He reached up to grab at her, but then staggered forwards as something thudded into his back: Melendy, whom Adora had tossed away from her.

Catra landed gracefully and darted forwards. Ahead, Adora stood, feet planted, firm. Ready. Behind her was the shelter. Behind her, Catra could hear the muffled yelps and shouts as her family roused themselves and jostled with Adora’s kin-folk. As one, the crowd gasped as the six family members chased after Catra.

But the Magicat’s eyes were only on the blonde. She leapt and Adora caught her. They grappled, each trying to overpower the other, to claim superiority. Their grins were wide as they laughed together.

Their family paused, now the pair had finally met, and formed a semi circle. And then, as the two struggled, they staggered to stand at the shelter’s entrance, where they relaxed. Then, Adora tugged Catra into the shelter.

From the sidelines, the sea-farer called out, "Of binds of old, a new link has been formed in the chain!Under the moon, a new bond is forged. In the fire of a new hearth a home is made. By this new hearth, our clans are united!Do you clans relent, or will you break their chain?"

Six voices intoned, "By force and fang, by courage and claw , they formed their link. We shall not unbind their skein."

The sea-farer nodded and raised his arms, "A cheer for the Chief, a cheer for her bride!A cheer for the clan skein, woven afresh!"

Around the ring, the sear-farers raised a raucous chant that sounded like wolf barks and howls. Around the small shelter, the six panting members of the Driluth and Grayskull families exchanged glances. Cyra shook her head, "Well, that was a first."

"No regrets, love? Dashing about in front of all these dignitaries?" Melendy teased.

Cyra heaved a breath and smiled, then looked over at Teela, Duncan and Kyle, "Are all your weddings like this?"

Kyle grinned, "Yes. I had to fight my way past all of Rogelio's nest mates. *And* Lonnie's sisters. That was difficult."

"We could've made it harder on them," mused Pan. Duncan chuckled and shook his head.

"Did you really want to stand in front of Catra in this?"

"You make an incredibly insightful point," mused the Captain. He shook his head, "And now, I think, we should allow them their privacy." He nodded towards the stoic, seated form of Melog, "And maybe feed the giant beast before it gets bored?"

Laughing, their group moved away, heading for the small gathering of confused dignitaries nearby, while above it all, Glimmer cackled with embarrassed glee.

And in a small woven shelter, in the middle of a ritual circle, Adora and Catra gazed at one another . Moonlight filtered through the gaps in the weave, granting a faint, luminescent light for them to drink in one another.

There would be drinking and speeches;matters of state and formal meetings;this was a small part of a greater event - a celebration amidst a turbulent time. A crisis averted and the looming cloud of danger ahead in an unknown world.

But in this moment, the reality that mattered was them. Adora reached out and caressed Catra's cheek. The Magicat leaned into the touch, her eyes aglow in the moonlight. The werewolf spoke softly, "Are you ok?"

"Better than ok," murmured Catra, "Is this...real?"

"More than real," Adora smiled back.

"Good," Catra purred. Here eyes locked with Adora's, "I love you. I think...I think I always have."

Her voice cracked a little with wonder. It wasn't new, it just felt like a revelation each time. Things unsaid, things that didn't *need* to be said. A warrior who fought through an army for her; who'd crossed the oceans to save her people, to save her. A woman who would have left if Catra had bade her, would have suffered for her.

And for whom Catra would fight anyone, challenge anything, stand firm against everyone. Her moon, her stars, her *sjelevenn*.

Adora stared back at Catra, eyes wide, smile soft, "I love you too."

They leaned in and kissed, the muffled sounds of music and revelry lost in the moment. After what seemed an eternity they broke apart. Catra was flushed and her tail was fluffed out. She smirked at Adora, "I think you said puppies? Really?"

Adora arched an eyebrow. And in the light of the moon, as she reached for Catra, her intent was clear, "Well, maybe not just yet. But we should practice."…

High in the sky, the moon hung, as below, the people of Halfmoon and the sea-farer clans celebrated; fae and human, lizard and magicat, beast-folk and fairies, revelling in their connections, a celebration of togetherness.

Tomorrow would bring plans and talks; battles and blood; the harsh reality of it all. But for tonight, bound together, blue eyes and mixed

gaze was all that mattered

Chapter End Notes

And that's it, barring our epilogue.

I didn't want to... over egg it. But I think a little insight into how Cats and Vampire cats do a ceremony is fun. Hints at how it came to be. Cats singing, yowling to be let in to see their lover, presenting gifts...

And werewolves basically fighting off family to get to their mate. It just resonated a little.

I hope you enjoyed this! We have one more thing to expand upon, then... well, the third and final part needs to be told, to close out the Horde threat.

Epilogue

Chapter Summary

Some closure for our Scorpion Princess

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The procession was a sombre one. Humiliating, even. The carriage had rattled down the silent street in Halfmoon, under the cold gazes of hundreds of Magicats and dozens of their new friends. Hulking wolves watched, silent and smug, as the Hegemony was *dismissed* , draggin a few cowed and banished Magicats with them.

Scorpia had sat in the carriage, alone. Perfuma had moved to join her, but a guard had gently guided the Princess to a waiting horse, whilst the other ladies clambered either onto spare mounts or other, more crowded carriages.

The humiliation had only been reinforced in the rain outside the mountain - the smouldering wreck of a once proud army, the air grey with drizzle and ash. Their small convoy had paused and Scorpia had dismounted to meet with the commander - or whoever was supposed to be in command. A Scorponi officer with haunted eyes met Scorpia - the woman had a pincer in a sling and her caprace seemed dull and cracked. Soldiers huddled, ash-stained and shivering, around small fires, whilst the dead were arrayed in rows or were being loaded into wagons. A third of the army remained *effective* , but in truth they were broken or only *marginally* wounded. Half were dead, the rest so injured they also needed to be loaded into wagons.

The weapons had been removed from them and bound up in hemps rolls, preventing easy access. These, too, were stacked into more wagons, some from the army, some clearly *donated* by the Magicats.

Huge creatures - wolves and cat-beasts - prowled around what was left of the wrecked encampment. A final testament to the futility of this endeavour. Scorpia had surveyed the final ashes of her folly and inhaled, before she granted permission to the cowed Rilka to begin moving the troops.

She returned to her carriage and sat in silence, ignoring the questions of riders who approached, as they made their silent way away from Halfmoon.

Scorpia stared down at her pincers as the carriage rocked from side to side. Her heart hurt, but surprisingly not for the reason she expected. Catra's rejection had, she realised, been fairly well flagged. It was only Scorpia's boundless hope that had eclipsed it. And now, seeing the *beast* that had wooed her, Scorpia felt conflicted. She actually pondered the words of the Vampire *and* the Wolf.

Would she have treated Catra as some sort of thrall? Some prized possession? She didn't *think* she would have. But the words had left something in her core that worried at her. The way the pair had so openly embraced, their clear obsession with one another. Surely that was not sustainable?

Her pincers clicked briefly as Scorpia mulled her thoughts over. She was angry, embarrassed and, honestly, frustrated.

But the greater pain was the *betrayal* . Catra she could fathom, barely. Disappointing, yes, but perhaps something that could be salvaged, maybe rekindled. She knew, just *knew* she could bridge that gap and maybe come to an understanding, especially once that enamoured state wore off. And, if as she expected, war was to truly come, then no doubt the wolf would rush off and, well, it'd be a tragedy but could present Catra with an opportunity!

SHe knew it was a faint hope, but Scorpia was nothing if not optimistic. Which was why the betrayal cut deeper. That was what she couldnt parse and it sent spiderwebs of doubt through her other held beliefs.

It was why she ignored the entreaties from riders as they approached, or from her ladies in waiting as a camp was set up with the drawing in of the night as they approached the border. A tent was set up, but Scorpia dismissed everyone, Perfuma included. Huntara tried to approach, but was rebuffed by several Scorponi guards.

Her night brought no satisfaction nor easy answers. Scorpia knew that there would be consequences across the Hegemony for this. Blame would be laid and her mothers would have opinions. But she knew she would be safe, though likely her influence would be curtailed. Though that had never really been something she had

really considered - her opinion mattered, her errant words sprung upon by courtiers like dune scarabs on scraps of meat.

She had reassessed her actions of this whole debacle by the time they crossed the border and the forests gave way to wet tundra and muggy prairie. Hills dotted the horizon and viewing them gave Scorpia pause. She was being honest with herself, as best she could be. It was difficult. The loss of Dee (And she knew that the changeling was truly lost) and the various outcomes had truly shaken her. And the ease with which her words and her intent had been taken to excess. In truth, she wasn't even sure what she had wanted, what she had expected. Had she truly felt that her rival would have just been...paid off?

Deep down she knew she hadn't really cared. But the insanity of the actual plot, the idea of a coup? It felt bold and yet also, inane. Insane. And so utterly self defeating. This cold analysis crept into her other thoughts and she felt numb, lulled by the swaying of the rolling carriage.

She leaned from the conveyance and beckoned to a rider and sent him to the head of the column. Soon they drew to a halt in the middle of the warm plain and Scorpia dismounted. Rilka rode up and watched, confused. She cleared her throat and quirked an eyebrow from under her helm, "My lady?"

"A matter of courtly business. Won't be long," Scorpia smiled at the Commander, "And then we must discuss plans, commander. You will ride with me now."

"Yes ma'am." Rilka looked puzzled and a little pale at that announcement. Scorpia just smiled, then turned to the other riders who had gathered around. The rest of the column had drawn to a halt, but remained in their lines, the only sound being the jingle of harnesses and the distant groans of the wounded.

Scorpia looked up at a nervous Perfuma with a brittle smile, "Princess Perfuma. It is rude to look down upon your future Empress. And I know you don't like to be rude!" her tone was jovial, but clipped. Perfuma hastily slid from her saddle and approached Scorpia with a tentative smile, "And War-leader Huntara! Please dismount."

The Orc woman frowned, but did as she was bade. Perfuma paused as Scorpia took a slight step backwards, the Scorponi's tail raising ever so slightly. The flowery Princess' expression became stricken, "Scorpia, my love... um"…

"No, no need to lie, not for me," Scorpia went on, her voice pleasant, "I have been thinking and, well, this whole activity , the whole event, has given me a lot to work through. I took a lot for granted and I intend to be an Empress who rules *fairly* one day. Not through fear , or, well, blackmail. Or by holding people in bondage. You know, I think I know what I mean. Anyway," she smiled and clasped her pincers together, "I release you, Perfuma. You may return to your people."

Perfuma's face froze and she blinked a few times in shock, "W… what?

"I said I release you. And in turn, I release Plumeria from any bonds of fealty, beyond those of a vassal state. No preferential roles or worries. Truly a fair exchange. Your people will be secure. I will even request the removal of excess military stationed in the region."

"But…but you can't, Scorpia!" Perfuma cried. A few riders nearby adjusted and rested hands on pommels. Perfuma swallowed and knelt, "Your highness, please. I…I…"

Scorpia shrugged, though her face was tight, "I should have… should have noticed, shouldn't I? That you weren't happy. That it's all so…so…" she winced, "*Transactional.* You sacrificed yourself for your people. Catra said as much was expected of her and…and that feels wrong."

"No…it may have been that way at the start but I…"

"And now, well, you can have what you want!" Scorpia went on, her voice still pleasant. Her gaze flicked to Huntara, "I release you from your duty, War-leader. Along with your clansmen."

Huntara staggered, her face shocked, "My…my lady, you can't mean that. It…"

“And I will also release all the Orc from your tribe from expected Military service. As we will be withdrawing from Plumeria, I will encourage the Hegemony Territory Office to ensure that your clan is re-assigned territories within their borders, to ensure security. That way you can,” she waved a pincer , “be sure your impending relationship is secure.”

Huntara actually sagged to her knees, “The clan-leaders will... I'll be shunned! Please, your highness, just me, just banish me! I can handle the disgrace! But the clans, they'll... they'll rebel, I'll be a pariah! This is a mark on our honour as a whole, surely this is too much! And Perfuma...”

“Well, if the clans know their business, they will not blame Plumeria for any discomforts. As loyal servants of the Hegemony, I am sure they will see no harm comes to the Princess or her people. But I see we held your people hostage and forced you into roles you did not want, nor felt any real duty to uphold. This way they can decide to integrate fully, as individual citizens. Every decision has consequences, I've learned, and we must live with them.”

Huntara flinched and hung her head. Perfuma stared at Scorpia, “Your Highness, this... this is cruel.”

Scorpia cocked her head, “No... nope, it can't be. This is what you wanted, right? Freedom. Not yoke about your neck, a chance at a future with someone you... you care about. This is a gift,” The Scorponi Princess swallowed and shrugged, “I mean, turns out the idea of sharing is... hard. Catra made that point and, well, I never

realised how selfish I was being. A harem! And you had to put up with that, when you couldn't tolerate me. So, I absolve you of that."

"My... my people will be..." Perfuma faintly responded. They would be normal citizenry. Her place in the Harem had granted them a level of safety and superiority. And she felt dirty even thinking about *that* in that moment. Scorpia just breezed past it as she looked to Rilka.

"Please ensure all the Orc clan-folk are dismissed from the column and allowed to journey to their new clan-lands. And dispatch a messenger hawk with an update for the Ministries to update them on the nature of the dissolution of the treaty with Plumeria and a need to redraft a vassalage agreement with their representative. Perfuma will be returning home, no doubt."

Scorpia nodded to the dazed couple, then moved to the carriage once more. Perfuma whimpered and lunged forwards, "Scorpia! Please! I love you. Nothing... Nothing happened!"

The Scorponi princess paused and turned with a sad smile, "Yet."

She clambered back aboard, followed by Rilka, who had just finished discussing orders with a pair of other officers. With a whip crack, the carriage trundled on, along with the column, leaving behind a dazed Perfuma and a shocked Huntara.

Rilka stared at the Princess from her seat opposite her. There was a hardness to Scorpia now that hadn't been there before. She'd seen the woman as foppish, flighty, even a bit dimwitted. Now she looked at this Princess like she was a coiled snake. She coughed and tried to start a conversation, "That seemed extreme, ma'am. The Orcs won't respond well to being reassigned. They have a history of being difficult."

"It's one clan. The others will stay in line, as this has come from the Royal family," Scorpia replied, absently, her gaze melancholy as she stared out of the window.

"And the Plumerians? It is a bountiful land"…

"And so it will remain. Just not bought with whatever it was that Perfuma and I had." Scorpia sighed and closed her eyes. She smiled and shrugged, "No time for sadness. I am the strong one, the muscle. It is what is expected of the Royal family."

"As you say, your highness. Are we to make for the Capital?"

Scorpia mused, "Yes. But via a detour. Send messengers ahead. We need to call into Dryl first. I have a friend I wish to call upon."

Rilka's eyes widened, "As you command, my lady."

Scorpia settled back in her seat as Rilka leaned out of the carriage window to bark orders. She felt cold inside, but certain. There would be plans for the future when she returned to the city. She would ensure she was never again used as a catspaw for some scheme; not dragged into some pairing for someone else's goal.

No, Scorpio would act for herself now. But with clarity. Circumspection. And forethought.

Could she win Catra's heart? Perhaps. But she would be sure, first. As with all things ahead, she would now think, before she charged in. And having friends she could rely on would help. Friends with... connections.

Chapter End Notes

Yep, setting up some future craziness. Which way will Scorpia go, who will she be meeting with, what will be the political fallout from ALLLLL OF THIS?!

Stay tuned as we will get our third Act underway - a showdown with the Horde and a reckoning with the Hegemony

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